NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

Master Curriculum Comprehensive

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth, Virtual Assessments & Remote Coaching

NASM Virtual Coaching Specialization (VCS)

Official Curriculum and Practice Standards.

Chapter 1: Introduction to Virtual Coaching

Welcome to NASM Virtual Coaching

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingWelcome to NASM Virtual CoachingThe NASM Virtual Coaching course is an immersive online experience that equips fitness professionals with the skills, tools, and strategies to operate a virtual coaching business. Throughout this course, professionals will learn how to foster an engaging and effective online relationship with their clients, leveraging various technologies. This course uses the virtual environment to provide the skills and knowledge to address topics including scope of practice, business planning, technology requirements, communication strategies, conducting virtual fitness assessments, implementing virtual coaching sessions, and fundamental business operations.

NASM VCS Lecture CH1 Intro00:02:52

Programmatic Objectives

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingProgrammatic ObjectivesAt the end of this course, you will:

Develop the key components of a business plan required to launch a virtual coaching business.

Conduct and modify fitness assessments using the virtual environment with clients.

Coach and cue clients in a virtual environment.

Develop effective virtual coaching strategies for different client types and fitness goals.

Identify virtual services fitness professionals require to scale and sustain a virtual coaching business.

Differentiate virtual sales and marketing strategies used to grow a virtual coaching business.

Your CourseThe NASM Virtual Coaching course has been divided into 4 sections. Designed for the fitness professional looking to leverage the virtual environment, this course uses a step-by-step approach to address the skills and knowledge required to launch a successful virtual coaching business.

Table of ContentsSection 1: Introduction to NASM Virtual Coaching

1. Introduction to Virtual Coaching

Section 2: Building a Virtual Coaching Environment

2. Building a Business

3. Technology Considerations

Section 3: Virtual Coaching Strategies

4. Communication and Coaching Strategies

5. Administering Virtual Assessments

6. Implementing Coaching Sessions

7. Integrating Wearables into Virtual Coaching

Section 4: Promoting Virtual Services

8. Selling Virtual Coaching

9. Marketing Virtual Coaching

Course Contributors

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingCourse ContributorsAuthors and Reviewers

Andre Hicks, BS, CES, CSCS

Brad Dieter, MS, PhD

Corey Robb

Derek Saunders

Hannah Clausen, NASM-CPT

Javier Miller-Estrada

Jay Woith

Keridon McMahon, BS, CPT, WLS, FNS

Kevin Longoria, MSc, CEP

Scott Quill

Product Team

Brian Sutton, MS, MA, CNC, PES, CES, CSCS

Casey DeJong, M.Ed, MBA, MIS

Kara Hawking, BA

Tony Ambler-Wright, MS, LMT, CES, PES, NASM-CPT, CSCS

Special ThanksSpecial thanks to the instructional design professionals who provided their expertise and insight throughout the development of this course.

Paige Lunny, PMP

Sarah Celmer

Earning your Credential

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingEarning your CredentialTo earn your NASM Virtual Coaching Specialist designation, the only requirement is passing the Final Exam. Please be advised that you have 365 days from your date of purchase to pass your Final Exam.

Final Exam Information:

Passing Score: 70% or higher

Questions: 100 multiple-choice

Time Limit: 90 Minutes

Max Attempts: 3

Exam Expiration: 365 days from date of purchase

NASM CEUs: NASM 1.5

Let's Get StartedWe at the National Academy of Sports Medicine are here to support you, so do not hesitate to call on us if you need some help.

You can contact us at 1-800-460-6276, option 2 or nasmcares@nasm.org.

Hours: Monday-Friday 5 a.m.–5 p.m. PST

Saturday, Sunday 7 a.m.–4 p.m. PST

Access our FAQ page for more information.

It's time to get started. Are you ready?

Chapter 1: Introduction to Virtual Coaching

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingChapter 1: Introduction to Virtual CoachingVirtual coaching provides fitness professionals with the ability to train more clients, avoid geographical limitations, and increase revenue, but it comes with certain disadvantages. Without a physical training space and regular in-person sessions, fitness professionals often find it difficult differentiating themselves to attract new clients, developing or maintaining trust and communication, and monitoring compliance to avoid injuries and ensure outcomes. The NASM Virtual Coaching course provides fitness professionals with the necessary business, physical training, behavioral, and technological knowledge necessary to build a thriving virtual training business.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Define the role of a virtual coach.

Identify potential opportunities from offering coaching services within a virtual environment.

Determine the different client types who would benefit from virtual coaching services.

Summarize the professional qualifications of a virtual coach.

Explain professional scope of practice of a virtual coach.

Introduction

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingIntroductionNot long ago, the fitness industry was centered around locations that included a built-in client base for fitness professionals: the gym. The current landscape of the fitness industry looks much different, with demand at an all-time high. According to the 2019 IHRSA Health Club Consumer Report, more than 71 million people in the United States reported being a member of a fitness center, gym, or studio in 2018 (Rodriguez, 2019).

To accommodate such growth, the number of gyms, fitness centers, studios, and fitness professionals who run and staff these establishments has exploded. The Bureau of Labor Statistics (2020) projects 15% growth in employment for fitness trainers and instructors from 2019 to 2029 (Figure: Employment Growth Within the Fitness Industry), creating a level of competition that forces fitness professionals to become creative with strategies for setting their business apart.

FIGUREEmployment Growth Within the Fitness IndustryJacob Lund/Shutterstock.comFor fitness professionals looking to diversify, sustain, and grow their book of business (list of clients), offering virtual coaching services can help positively impact these efforts. Recent events have forced clients to seek at-home fitness solutions. Combined with the continuous rise of chronic health conditions like obesity, diabetes, heart disease, and other lifestyle-influenced conditions, this has created an environment in which the demand for adaptable fitness and nutrition coaching services is high.

With the ability to book any client, anywhere, at any time, virtual coaches can make a substantial impact on the health and wellness of clients at practically any fitness level. On any given day, a virtual coach can meet with a weight-loss client in California, train a youth athlete in Michigan, and a lead a group fitness class in Louisiana, all before lunch. There has never been a better or more exciting time for certified fitness professionals to build a virtual coaching business.

Coach's CornerOffering virtual coaching services may be incredibly overwhelming at first. However, fitness professionals should not let the fear of the unknown stop them from taking a positive step toward the game-changing world of virtual coaching. To avoid feeling overwhelmed about the requirements needed to transition the various services offered, the fitness professional should focus on immediate steps they can take to help facilitate this process. For example, before offering virtual coaching sessions with new or existing clients, they should begin by leveraging technology to track and communicate client progress.

Book of businessThe professional's list of clients.

The Virtual Coach

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingThe Virtual CoachVirtual coaches provide live, one-on-one programming through virtual means, such as video, chat, and livestreams, while integrating other communication technologies such as e-mail, file sharing, etc. Much like in-person fitness professionals, virtual coaches meet with clients on a set schedule, work together to set goals and milestones, and discuss progress and potential adjustments to programming.

Le Panda/Shutterstock.comWhile predesigned, one-size-fits-all workouts may be provided, this approach should complement the virtual experience not replace it. When executed effectively, the virtual coaching experience allows the client and virtual coach a more accessible way to work together to achieve goals in a healthy, attainable, realistic, and safe manner.

History of Virtual Coachinghafakot/Shutterstock.comWhile the concept of virtual coaching is relatively new, the use of technology to bring personalized and more private fitness solutions to the masses is not. Currently, virtual coaching is a natural evolution of the virtual training system, which used emerging technology to deliver personal trainer-like services to those who experienced barriers to frequenting a fitness center.

"With the advent of smartphones and affordable sensing technologies, the possibility to automate several of the functions of a personal trainer emerged… [allowing] a person to manage their own personal fitness program while integrating close monitoring, sports science knowledge, and motivational aspects (Lowe & ÓLaighin, 2012)."

Using a combination of smartphone apps, sensing technologies, and image processing devices to gather data before, during, and after workouts, virtual coaches can collect and use client data to coach their clients to success. However, while these technologies make it easy for individuals to track fitness data on their own, they lack the ability to address many of the unforeseen obstacles otherwise addressed by a virtual coach.

Monkey Business Images/Shutterstock.comVirtual coachA professional who provides live, one-on-one programming through virtual means such as video, chat, and livestreams while integrating other communication technologies such as e-mail, file sharing, etc.

Emerging technologyNew technologies currently developing that are expected to have a significant social and/or economic impact.

Sensing technologiesDevices that use sensors to detect and record physical or biological information and often are referred to as biometric wearables.

Trends in Virtual Coaching

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingTrends in Virtual CoachingThe limits to virtual coaching extend beyond personal training and nutrition coaching. Remote sessions are now considered a mainstream way of doing business and have become part of the service offerings provided by fitness professionals looking to grow and expand their reach in the industry. Because many technologies used to operate as a virtual coach are now user-friendly for both the client and coach, it is now common to see fitness professionals adopting and integrating virtual strategies within their current in-person training methods, thereby creating a hybrid approach to training and coaching their conventional client base. A virtual coach should assess trends and emerging technologies to determine if they are right for the services they offer and, most importantly, for their client. Included are a few trends in the fitness industry's virtual workspace that have helped define and differentiate the degrees of operating as a virtual coach.

Predesigned WorkoutsPredesigned workouts, sometimes called canned workouts, are already a part of the fitness professional's arsenal of tools used to train or coach clients. However, the strategies used to leverage these have drastically evolved in the virtual space. Whether provided as a free preview, included as part of a virtual coaching package, or available for purchase, the ability to provide predesigned workouts via e-mail, file sharing, or website is a great way to show prospective and current clients the fitness professional's ability to program for various fitness goals. Plus, predesigned workouts can also help virtual coaches expand their book of business or create supplemental income. And while convenient for coaches and clients alike, virtual coaches should avoid using predesigned workouts as a means to minimize or otherwise substitute for real-time interactions during a virtual coaching session with a client.

One-on-One Personal Training and Group FitnessIt has become increasingly easy for fitness professionals to acquire and/or transition many of their clients to virtual sessions with the availability of emerging technologies. Audio/video has become widely used to facilitate real-time communication, even for those who use Smartphones and computers to conduct business with clients who might not be as technologically savvy. Finding more efficient ways to coach more clients should be a goal for fitness professionals looking to grow their abilities while providing an array of service offerings to their clients. Virtual sessions provide fitness professionals with the ability to enjoy high-quality interactions with their clients regardless of location. Whether the need is to provide one-on-one training or instruct a group fitness session, fitness professionals are leveraging the virtual environment while upholding the benefits clients would otherwise have with them in person (Figure: Virtual Personal Training and Group Fitness Instruction).

FIGUREVirtual Personal Training and Group Fitness InstructionOne-on-one training, delivered virtually and in real time, provides clients with the freedom to access a coach that they know, like, and trust from the comfort and privacy of their own home, creating a client-coach relationship that supports successful, long-lasting change.

Virtual coaching for group fitness instruction provides flexibility for clients who cannot make it to an in-person class due to closures, proximity, or personal preference. Various methods of streaming will now accommodate numerous participants in one class, providing virtual coaches with the ability to encourage interaction, build community, and increase accountability.

Check-Ins

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingCheck-InsScheduling regular client check-ins is a crucial step to ensuring client engagement as they continue to work toward their fitness goals. However, it may become increasingly difficult to require clients to allocate the time required to have these check-in discussions with their coaches. For fitness professionals, integrating virtual technologies to help make it more feasible for their clients to check in, while remote, is an effective way to hold clients accountable to their fitness goals. In a 2017 study aimed at discovering how fitness technology impacts behavior change, researchers found that:

“Interventions that included established behavior change techniques were associated with greater increases in physical activity and subsequent weight loss than those that did not. Specifically, self-regulatory behavior change techniques such as goal setting, self-monitoring, and social support were associated with better outcomes (Sullivan & Lachman, 2017).”

Fitness professionals use goal setting as a tool to motivate clients, and the exercise is especially important in a virtual environment where another key factor for success, social support, is not physically present. Goals are often tracked in a health and fitness app, but virtual check-ins complement virtual coaching by adding accountability, consistency, and a sense of support to the client/coach relationship.

Nutrition CoachingVirtual nutrition coaching allows fitness professionals to connect with clients in new and useful ways. Using a virtual environment, a nutrition coach has the ability to take a virtual tour of a client’s kitchen to review pantry items, discuss food labels, check snack options on-hand, talk about using certain kitchen tools to maximize efficiency and meal prep, or to brainstorm alternatives based on what a client already has in the kitchen. Having the ability to leverage technology to get a peek at a client’s living space has become a powerful strategy to helping clients identify obstacles and barriers otherwise overlooked when trying to improve eating habits.

Try ThisNext time a client cannot make an in-person session work, reschedule with a virtual session instead of cancelling altogether. Having the ability to provide clients an alternative option can help address and overcome client objections.

Clients Seeking Virtual Coaching

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingClients Seeking Virtual CoachingVirtual coaching is a benefit for existing and prospective clients alike, but it will not be for every everyone. Fitness professionals looking to offer virtual coaching to new or existing clients will need to understand whether a client will be successful engaging with them in a virtual environment compared to traditional in-person training and/or coaching methods. During conversations with existing or prospective clients, it is important to ask them questions that will help determine their interest level in being trained or coached using a virtual environment and/or engaging with various virtual technologies. In most cases, the fitness professional may uncover clients who want virtual coaching services but lack the understanding and experience to determine whether it is an effective solution for their fitness goals. When identifying and discussing options with clients who may benefit from virtual coaching services, it is important to understand that offering virtual coaching services is not an all-or-nothing or one-size-fits-all approach. Instead, it can be used to help facilitate the fitness professional’s coach/client relationship, promoting goal attainment while minimizing sales objections.

goodluz/Shutterstock.comThe Client Who Prefers to Stay HomeIt is no surprise that there are clients who avoid the gym environment due to any number of reasons including long commutes, packed schedules, family commitments, and/or even lack of self-confidence. Regardless of why these individuals do not frequent the gym, it is the responsibility of the fitness professional to overcome these obstacles. The use of virtual coaching can help bridge the gap for individuals who are looking for change but may lack the desire to participate in training or coaching in a gym. No matter the reason, virtual coaching allows these clients to experience the benefits of health and fitness programming with live guidance from a fitness professional.

The Client Who Moved AwayTypically, when a client moves away it ends the client/trainer relationship. However, virtual coaching allows the fitness professional to leverage the virtual environment to continue their relationship through remote training and/or coaching. With a few adjustments to accommodate available space, access to equipment, and scheduling, clients who move away may find it easier to continue their current programming or coaching sessions versus finding another trainer or coach.

Clients Who Vacation Frequently

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual CoachingClients Who Vacation FrequentlyClients who skip training or nutrition coaching sessions on extended vacations often experience a momentum shift and risk derailing the efforts previously made to reach their goals. Virtual coaches can bridge that gap by suggesting live sessions that accommodate equipment and space changes or providing predesigned workouts while clients are on vacation. Depending on the client's goals, these sessions could be lighter than usual, incorporate local activities, and focus more on recovery than progression.

Clients With Demanding Work SchedulesClients whose professions require shift work or exhaustive work schedules that do not accommodate normal working hours often have difficulty sticking to a schedule, making it hard to provide consistent fitness solutions, whether in-person or virtual. According to the World Health Organization (2020), "adults aged 18-24 should do at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic physical activity throughout the week" no matter their work schedule. Because of this, virtual coaching is a great opportunity for those that may not have been able to make the traditional gym hours required for in-person training or coaching work. While working with such clients may require virtual coach to accommodate odd hours for training, the impact could be immense. A 2018 study found that "many shift workers fail to achieve the recommended physical activity guidelines and [,] consequently, the majority of shift workers are insufficiently active" (Flahr et al., 2018).

Global Pandemic Restrictions (COVID-19)When gyms and health clubs were forced to close due to COVD-19, virtual coaching allowed fitness professionals to quickly pivot to a safe and effective environment, while maintaining or even growing the business. While the fitness industry focused on keeping businesses afloat, health care providers emphasized the connection between physical fitness and recovery from the virus, noting that "exercise may reduce the risk of acute respiratory distress syndrome, a major cause of death in patients with coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19)" (Nyenhuis, et al., 2020). This connection reinforces the need for virtual coaching as a means of educating clients on the importance of physical fitness as a part of a comprehensive proactive health management program.

The potential client types and opportunities identified are merely examples of those who may benefit most from virtual coaching. By appropriately identifying and integrating various virtual technologies with specific needs, virtual coaching can benefit just about any client, solidifying the service as one of the most versatile and innovative ways to make an impact on the fitness industry as a professional.

Qualifications for Virtual Coaching

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 2Virtual Coaching ConsiderationsQualifications for Virtual CoachingThe qualifications of a virtual coach can be interpreted in many ways based on the professional's education and industry experience, as well as the character traits required to sustain success as a virtual coach. Aside from working with clients, it is imperative proper credentials have been obtained to safely and effectively coach clients with various health and fitness goals. Without the foundational knowledge and credentialing in either fitness training and/or nutrition coaching, the risk of client injury and liability is greatly increased. Becoming a virtual coach should help augment the professional's credentials recognized by the fitness industry and is not intended as a substitute.

Fitness CredentialsThe transition to virtual coaching should be relatively smooth for an experienced personal trainer or nutrition coach looking to broaden services offered to clients. Although not required, those new to the fitness industry should consider completing the NASM-CPT or NASM-CNC course before venturing into the virtual coaching environment.

Character Traits of a Successful Virtual CoachA fitness professional's passion for motivating and helping clients to learn, grow, and achieve goals should be evident through virtual coaching strategies. When transitioning or augmenting current services, fitness professionals may face communication challenges such as maintaining appropriate tone and cadence, building rapport, and maintaining a coach–client relationship that encourages accountability. When looking to overcome these challenges, consistency is key.

Having an entrepreneurial spirit is another essential attribute for virtual coaches who look to attract and retain clients while minimizing turnover. The virtual coach's proactive mindset keeps them seeking innovative ways to reach new clients and improve their ability to provide effective coaching. This entrepreneurial mindset can help drive the virtual coach to be creative with marketing, social media presence, networking, referral programs, innovative promotion ideas, and gated content to bring in new clients. Without this continuous drive for creativity and innovation, it becomes increasingly difficult to stand out in the virtual setting.

Scope of Practice

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 2Virtual Coaching ConsiderationsScope of PracticeVirtual coaches are expected to adhere to the scope of practice, which includes the procedures and processes fitness professionals follow in accordance with their fitness certification.

After evaluating a client's situation thoroughly, honestly, and independently, virtual coaches will be required to determine whether it is safe for the client to provide virtual coaching services or if a referral to an appropriate medical professional is needed. Whether the virtual coach is providing training or nutrition coaching, the scope of practice resides with the credentials carried by the professional. The limitations and boundaries of the coaching services a fitness professional is able to provide can be found within their credentials already obtained. While operating in a virtual environment does not change the scope of practice, it can provide some additional challenges.

Critical!When offering virtual coaching services to clients, fitness professionals should review the scope of practice limitations and boundaries identified by the credentials earned through the organization or certifying body from which they were obtained. Whether the professional is offering training services or nutrition coaching, offering these services in a virtual format does not change the scope of practice.

Certified Personal Training Personal trainers looking to use the virtual environment as an additional service for their clients will need to adhere to the scope of practice limitations and boundaries they operate with within their in-person training sessions. Because of the limits of operating virtually, the personal trainer will still be required to identify when it is appropriate to refer the client to a licensed professional.

Personal trainers do not diagnose injuries. If a client sustains an injury during a training session, the trainer should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional. This protocol is for physical and psychological diagnoses alike.

Personal trainers do not provide counseling services for past or present. If approached by a client seeking advice for a medical issue or injury, the trainer should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional.

Certified Nutrition Coaching Professionals with the opportunity to provide nutrition coaching services understand the potential impact on their client's health through their ability to provide education on making healthy choices and promoting positive behavior change. Like the certified personal training professional, nutrition coaches looking to offer virtual services will be required to adhere to their scope of practice and refer out to a licensed professional when necessary.

Nutrition coaches do not provide meal planning services. If approached by a client requesting meal planning, the nutrition coach should immediately refer the client to a registered dietitian.

Nutrition coaches do not provide nutritional therapy. If approached by a client seeking nutritional therapy, the nutrition coach should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional.

Scope of practiceThe actions that a professional is permitted to undertake in keeping with the terms of her or his license or certification.

Virtual Coaching Obstacles and Challenges

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 2Virtual Coaching ConsiderationsVirtual Coaching Obstacles and ChallengesWhile virtual coaching is a timely solution to an industry-wide problem, fitness professionals should understand and acknowledge the constraints that come with providing virtual services. Compared to in-person services, such as personal training or nutrition coaching, the fitness professional looking to augment their services by offering a virtual option will need to address additional obstacles and challenges faced in the virtual environment. Aside from the technical obstacles and challenges faced when offering virtual coaching, the virtual coach will need to identify and acknowledge that there are differences between interacting in-person versus virtually with the client.

insta_photos/Shutterstock.comClient EngagementA virtual environment makes it easier for clients to disengage, making client retention markedly more difficult for virtual coaches. Therefore, fitness professionals looking to offer virtual services will face new challenges with client engagement. Unlike in-person personal training or nutrition coaching, the virtual coach will need to seek creative solutions to ensure client engagement is upheld consistently throughout each virtual session, not to mention the required commitment for clients to complete offline activities such as forms, logs, etc. Understanding how to gauge and measure a client's engagement as a virtual coach is a crucial skill to providing effective virtual coaching. Because every client engages differently, the virtual coach will need to pay greater attention to how their client reacts to the virtual coaching they are provided.

Client Safety

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 2Virtual Coaching ConsiderationsClient SafetyLike with in-person personal training and nutrition coaching, the client's safety should remain a top priority. When offering virtual services, it is imperative that fitness professionals design programs that prioritize client safety while being conducive to the virtual environment. Because the virtual coach is unable to be with their client, they should continuously assess and address the client when risk of injury is identified during a live session.

When executing a virtual training session with a client, fitness professionals should keep the following in mind to help minimize injury risk:

Virtual coaches cannot see every angle of the client.

Virtual coaches cannot act as a spotter and should not provide programming that requires one.

Virtual coaches should be more diligent about monitoring and correcting form, demonstrating exercises, and watching for safety concerns such as abnormal discomfort.

Virtual coaches should never assume their clients' abilities.

Critical!In addition to programming considerations, virtual coaches must be prepared to react quickly, notifying the client's local authorities and/or an emergency contact should something go wrong during the virtual training session. For this reason, each client should provide a street address, emergency contact, and local police department phone number.

Professional BurnoutWorking remotely in any profession comes with the challenge of achieving a healthy work–life balance. For fitness professionals who are just beginning with virtual coaching, earning new clients can be exciting; however, packing a schedule with sessions every hour on the hour can quickly lead to burnout. Considering that work and life will probably never be balanced, a 2014 study on the work habits of surgeons suggests the concept of creating a work–life budget.

"Just as a budget is made at the beginning of each year for... the home, a budget should be made for work and life. And just as importantly, the budget for work–life balance needs to be individualized to best meet the needs of the individual (Raja & Stein, 2014)."

That being said, virtual coaches should set working hours while reserving time for personal and professional development. Setting these boundaries can help virtual coaches stay healthy while setting a positive example for clients.

Summary

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual CoachingLesson 2Virtual Coaching ConsiderationsSummaryVirtual coaching allows fitness professionals to serve clients that may have otherwise been out of reach due to their preference, proximity, or availability. On the surface, it seems like the logical next step for every fitness professional, but virtual coaching will not work for everyone. Just as a fitness professional examines a client's needs before assigning a training program, a similar assessment must be completed to determine if adding virtual training is a sound business decision. When determining whether to offer virtual services, fitness professionals should consider the following pros and cons of virtual coaching:

Twinsterphoto/Shutterstock.comPros

Allows any fitness professional to reach a global audience

Can be more affordable for clients than in-person training (especially without a gym membership and travel considerations), increasing the potential of acquiring new clients

More opportunities in geographical locations with few fitness facilities to work at

Same coach for clients no matter the location, providing the opportunity to build greater, longer lasting client–coach relationships

Cons

Clients lacking understanding for the value of virtual coaching and preferring in-person training or coaching, making it hard to sell the benefits of virtual services

Fitness goals requiring the fitness professional to be present with the client to minimize the risk of injury

Technology obstacles such as Internet connection, device requirements, and technical support sometimes making it difficult to ensure a seamless and effective virtual session

Allocating appropriate space for virtual sessions challenging for fitness professionals who do not or cannot stage a designated personal training or coaching space in their home

Successful fitness professionals are committed to helping their clients realize the benefits of achieving specific fitness and nutrition goals. When incorporating virtual services into their business model, the fitness professional has the potential of taking this client commitment one step further.

While it may seem that virtual training can take away from the personal and professional experience shared between a coach and client, one can also argue that it does just the opposite. Seeking additional ways to support clients' needs in this way will add to the level of care, understanding, and respect provided as virtual services to clients daily. In addition, there has never been a better (or more workable) time in history to augment the services offered by fitness professionals leveraging a virtual strategy. As technology and online business continues to grow, the normalcy of meeting and conducting business online has become commonplace. Having the knowledge and skills to offer virtual solutions at a global scale is not only lucrative and smart for the growing professional, but also incredibly beneficial for clients who otherwise would not have the opportunity to engage in traditional coaching.

Chapter 1 ReferencesBureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor. Occupational Outlook Handbook: Fitness Trainers and Instructors. Retrieved from https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/fitness-trainers-and-instructors.htm

Flahr, H., Brown, W. J., & Kolbe-Alexander, T. L. (2018, April). A systematic review of physical activity-based interventions in shift workers. Preventive Medicine Reports, 10: 323–331. doi: 10.1016/j.pmedr.2018.04.004

Lowe, S., & ÓLaighin, G. (2012, Dec.). The age of the virtual trainer. Procedia Engineering, 34: 242–247. doi: 10.1016/j.proeng.2012.04.042

Nyenhuis, S. M., Greiwe, J., Zeiger, J. S., Nanda, A., & Cooke, A. (2020, July–Aug.). Exercise and fitness in the age of social distancing during the COVID-19 pandemic. The Journal of Allergy and Clinical Immunology in Practice, 8(7): 2152–2155. doi: 10.1016/j.jaip.2020.04.039

Raja, S., & Stein, S. L. (2014, June). Work–life balance: history, costs, and budgeting for balance. Clinics in Colon and Rectal Surgery, 27(2): 71–74. doi: 10.1055/s-0034-1376172

Rodriguez, M. (2019, Sept.) Report: Health Club, Gym, & Studio Usage Reach All-Time High. Retrieved from https://www.ihrsa.org/about/media-center/press-releases/report-health-club-gym-studio-usage-reach-all-time-high/

Sullivan, A. N., & Lachman, M. E. (2017, Jan.). Behavior Change with Fitness Technology in Sedentary Adults: A Review of the Evidence for Increasing Physical Activity. Frontiers in Public Health, 4: 289. doi: 10.3389/fpubh.2016.00289

World Health Organization. (2020). Global Strategy on Diet, Physical Activity and Health. Retrieved from https://www.who.int/dietphysicalactivity/factsheet_adults/en/

Chapter 2: Building a Business

Chapter 2 - Building a Business

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 1The Virtual Coaching BusinessChapter 2 - Building a BusinessBuilding a successful virtual coaching business is not as simple as setting up a video conferencing account, launching a website, and being passionate about helping clients. A sustainable business requires strategic planning and considerations that extend beyond having knowledge of exercise science principles. This chapter will provide information related to financial forecasting, budgeting, bookkeeping, sales and marketing, and how to differentiate a virtual coaching business in a competitive marketplace.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Identify qualities of an entrepreneur.

Determine the key components in a business plan.

Write a virtual coaching business plan.

Introduction

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 1The Virtual Coaching BusinessIntroductionBuilding a successful business requires time, perseverance, hard work, and patience, but the rewards are limitless! When the fitness professional is able to build a business, they create an opportunity to provide a life and the freedom they desire. Building a business requires a different skill set from simply performing a job. It often requires a wide range of personal, technical, and financial skills as well as entrepreneurial spirit.

One key step to building a successful business is developing a carefully crafted business plan. A business plan can help provide a blueprint and a structured plan that will help the fitness professional build a successful, thriving business.

Have a nice day Photo/Shutterstock.comBusiness plans will be specific to each business and business owner as business owners will have many different goals—both personal and professional. For example, a business model for a company that will provide the owner and his family with a comfortable living for generations is different from a business plan that will provide the owner with the ability to work with flexible hours, an additional household income, and travel freely. Just as personal goals can change over time, a business's purpose and direction can change overtime as well. Developing a living business plan that is carefully thought out, well-crafted, and routinely updated will allow the fitness professional to build a business that fits their vision for both personal and professional success.

This chapter will provide an overview of the purpose of a virtual coaching business, the qualities of entrepreneurship, and how to build a business plan. The chapter will identify the mission of the business as well as address marketing the business, selling the business's services or products, and how to manage the financial aspects of the business.

Purpose of a Virtual Coaching Business

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 1The Virtual Coaching BusinessPurpose of a Virtual Coaching BusinessOnline businesses have been around for over 30 years and businesses of all sizes now operate solely online. Businesses that were once only found in brick-and-mortar locations are now becoming more popular in an online marketplace rather than in physical locations. Groceries, shoes, and even new film releases are all presented to consumers from the comfort of their home. The world has shifted to an acceptance of and reliance on virtual commerce.

In the current market, there are many unknowns that turn into high risks for a new business. The risk of an economic downturn is always on the mind of a successful entrepreneur. When sales slow down, a business still has employees and bills to pay. Building a successful business that is dependent on someone else (e.g., training clients at a gym someone else owns) does not provide the entrepreneur with complete control over their success. Similarly, building a business with large overhead not only requires massive amounts of startup capital, but also places the fitness professional under financial stress during periods of slow economic growth.

Food for ThoughtIn 2019, the virtual fitness coaching industry was valued at over $6 billion and is expected to reach almost $60 billion by 2027 (Rake & Gaikwad, 2020).

dmitriy-orlovskiy/Shutterstock.comVirtual coaching businesses have existed in various forms for many years but have recently seen substantial growth as more consumers are becoming comfortable with, and even preferring, online coaching. This industry is at a tipping point that is starting to disrupt the in-person training industry, which has dominated the personal training market since its inception. Fitness professionals are becoming more comfortable with virtual coaching, which provides more opportunities for them to start their own business. Virtual coaches can start with little overhead and still work as an in-person fitness professional while building up their virtual coaching startup to a self-sustaining, thriving online business.

As the world shifts to an ever-larger virtual presence, clients are looking for ways to integrate health and fitness into the virtual world. Fitness professionals must find a path to meet the demand for virtual services that not only provides the best training for clients, but also provides the same, or greater, job stability that in-person training offers.

Qualities of an Entrepreneur

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 1The Virtual Coaching BusinessQualities of an EntrepreneurThe Internet has made being an entrepreneur or business owner more accessible. The terms entrepreneur and business owner are often used interchangeably. However, there are differences between the two (Marks, 2012; Spring, 2014). In fact, over 18% of small businesses do not see themselves as entrepreneurs (Huefner & Hunt, 1998).

Small business owners are typically local businesses with one or a few physical locations within a small geographic area. They are often well-known throughout the community as a business owner and have deep personal connections with their customers. A business owner typically spends most of their time working in their business instead of on their business. Entrepreneurs are often small business owners as well; however, sometimes entrepreneurs may enter a new business but not own it. Other times, an entrepreneur may be in between businesses after selling theirs.

Food for ThoughtWorking in the business includes training clients, responding to customer service e-mails, and bookkeeping.

Working on the business includes developing training protocols, creating and testing marketing strategies, crafting customer service policies, structuring corporate guidelines, and building financial projections.

In the early stages of a business, the business owner will be focused primarily on working in the business. However, as a business grows, the entrepreneur will need to shift much of their focus to working on the business.

EntrepreneurA business owner who develops systematic, repeatable, scalable, and teachable processes to grow a business.

Business ownerAn individual or group who owns a business entity and has final decision-making authority as well as first right to profits

---

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 1The Virtual Coaching BusinessConsider the qualities of an entrepreneur:

Has a vision of the future: looking not just at the next week, but the next month, quarter, year, decade

Continues to test and modify their business until they achieve their vision

Understands how to share their vision with others

Wants full control over their destiny

Enjoys a challenge

Takes risk: Being able to take risks is the most important and common trait of entrepreneurs (Cramer et al., 2002). Taking calculated risk, but not unnecessary risk, can vastly improve the odds of becoming a successful entrepreneur.

Spends equal or more time working on their business versus working in their business

pathdoc/Shutterstock.com

Introduction to a Virtual Coaching Business Plan

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IIntroduction to a Virtual Coaching Business PlanA business plan is the instruction manual for how the business will grow, which outlines the path the fitness professional will follow to achieve their overall vision. As an instruction manual, a business plan is a living document that must be reviewed, updated, and rewritten as a business evolves and changes. Having a business plan gives the fitness professional a place to put their thoughts into words and gives them the ability to easily share their vision with others.

The length and detail of the fitness professional's business plan can and will vary depending on several factors. If the new entrepreneur is seeking to take out a bank loan or take on partners or investors, they will need to go into greater detail on financial information than they would if they were starting a business on their own. If the business owner is a solopreneur (an entrepreneur with no employees or partners), then the goal of the business plan is to have a guide to keep the fitness professional on course while building their business.

Please note: After each description of the different sections of the business plan are at least three Business Plan Questions to help the fitness professional develop their own well-thought-out and detailed business plan. These prompts will be followed by an example of properly developed answers that will be used to formulate a final business plan, which will be completed at the end of this chapter.

An example company, called Executive Fitness, will be created to demonstrate what well-thought-out answers to the business plan writing prompts should look like. The example company's goal is to provide online fitness coaching to busy office professionals who do not have time to visit a gym on a consistent basis. The example company will be expanded on as the business plan is developed further in this chapter.

The Business Plan Questions should be completed after reading the entire chapter because many of these questions and ideas work and build off of each other. In order to develop a complete picture of what the fitness professional's virtual coaching business will look like, the fitness professional must understand all of the concepts in this chapter first.

Food for ThoughtA business plan should be treated as a living document. It should be reviewed, referenced, and updated regularly.

Business planA document that outlines how a business will be structured, grow, and achieve goals that are set forth by the business owner or executive team.

SolopreneurAn entrepreneur who runs a business on their own.

Executive Summary

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IExecutive SummaryZurainy Zain/Shutterstock.comThe first section of a business plan is the executive summary. In the executive summary, the fitness professional will describe the purpose of the business. This part is the who, what, and why of the business.

Who are the founders and key people in the business? Who is the business targeting? What other stakeholders should be considered?

What makes this business different, more effective, and, most importantly, unique?

Why are clients going to come to this new, untested, and unproven business?

Each section of the executive summary can expand over time into their own sections of the business plan as the fitness professional develops more experience and a more detailed path for bringing their overall vision for the business to fruition.

Mission and Vision StatementsAs an entrepreneur, the fitness professional is the business's management team. The fitness professional is, essentially, the director of everything. This is where, as the company's chief visionary, they will lay the foundation for the future of the company for years to come. The fitness professional should discuss where they see the business in 1, 5, and 10 years along with the milestones of how they plan to get to each of those goals. They will discuss the driving force behind their business and their company's vision and mission statement.

Tang Yan Song/Shutterstock.comA mission statement is what drives the business's culture and progress over time. A mission statement is the entrepreneur's reason for wanting to start this business and should convey a meaning that resonates (and motivates) with the founder, employees, and clients (Bart, 1997).

A vision statement is what the business will look like in the long-term, over the next 5 to 10 years or more. If the overall goals of the business are met, the vision statement should describe an outside, broad view of the company.

Executive summaryA section of the business plan that provides an overview of what will be covered in the document.

Mission statementA mission statement is the entrepreneur's reason for wanting to start this business and should convey a meaning that resonates (and motivates) with the founder, employees, and clients.

Vision statementWhat the business will look like in the long-term, over the next 5 to 10 years or more.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IBusiness Plan Questions

Who is the target audience? What challenge does the target audience face that the business can help solve?

What is the fitness professional's personal connection and motivation to help solve this problem?

What does the business look like in 1, 5, and 10 years?

Executive Fitness Example1. Who is the target audience? What challenge does the target audience face that the business can help solve?

The target audience is busy business professionals who want to give their health, fitness, and nutrition a higher priority but have difficulty finding a sustainable path to achieve their goals.

2. What is the fitness professional's personal connection and motivation to help solve this problem?

This business is owned by someone who, prior to becoming a fitness professional, worked a corporate office job. Firsthand experience with the lack of personal health goals in accomplished individuals is vast. Balancing a 40+-hour work week with family life, being sedentary, lacking motivation to exercise, and not understanding there is a sustainable path to health are all common realities. This allows for empathy with clients and for developing a plan that will fit their aspirations.

3. What does the business look like in 1, 5, and 10 years?

During the first year, systems will be developed and refined while the company services the professional market the owner is most familiar with—those working larger corporate jobs in upper to middle management. After the first year, using feedback from clients combined with additional market research, the company will be able to evolve and expand the service to other professionals in different markets, such as teachers and educators of all levels. The company will also start to bring on employees at that time to ensure high quality of service is maintained. At the 5-year mark, the business will have started partnering with corporations to provide in-house wellness services to employees, as well as continuing to grow the direct-to-client coaching services. At the 10-year mark, the business will be a large company in the online training industry, generating millions of dollars of revenue annually. This growth will require an entire professional management team, along with a strong corporate structure and a constantly updated and refined business plan.

Company Description

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ICompany DescriptionA description of the company should be concise yet detailed. Simply stating that a business will conduct online personal training is too vague. Conversely, going into detail about what estimated customer acquisition cost (CAC) will be is too in-depth for the executive summary (this will be included in expanded sections of the business plan such as marketing or financial). A description of the business should discuss the purpose of the business and what makes it unique. The uniqueness is often described as the unique selling proposition (USP). This is the place that the fitness professional should explain why customers will choose their business over a competitor.

Highlight the true uniqueness of the business. Mentioning features of a business are simply not enough. There was a time when responding to an e-mail within 24 hours or offering text/messaging to a client was unique and rare. However, now that there are more online coaching businesses, these features have become the standard. The fitness professional needs a USP that only they bring to their clients.

niroworld/Shutterstock.comIt is also a good idea, and common practice, to include information on any of the company founders, along with their backgrounds. Even if the business owner is a solopreneur, they should be able to sell themselves and explain why their background and experience makes them the most suited to bring their USP to the market.

The company description should also include the management structure of the company. If the business will be starting with partners or employees, their roles and responsibilities should be clearly defined here. Highlight why these individuals will be vital to the business's initial success. If these employees are not included in the description and backgrounds of the company founders, then they should be included here.

Most entrepreneurs are solopreneurs at first. They are the only employee in the business. This means they are working both in and on the business. Take this opportunity to clarify what roles everyone involved will be taking on and what roles may be contracted out. For instance, most entrepreneurs will take on marketing, but few will do their own taxes.

Helpful HintThere are many gig services, companies that connect consumers or businesses with freelancers to perform various tasks or jobs, that can be found online for minimal cost. These can be utilized for things like creating infographics, editing blogs, and editing videos.

It is also possible to find reputable and affordable online services for things like accounting and legal advice.

Customer acquisition cost (CAC)How much a new customer costs a business – typically, the cost is determined through money spent on advertising.

Unique selling proposition (USP)The unique benefit or feature of a product or service that differentiates a business from other businesses offering a similar service or product.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IBusiness Plan Questions

What are the unique goals of the business?

What makes the company unique to clients? What single thing does the business perform or understand better than anyone else in the industry?

Who will the company consist of at inception? What roles will each person have?

Executive Fitness Example1. What are the short-term and long-term goals of the business?

The company's short-term goals include developing systems to provide customized, but repeatable client experiences. This will help to achieve the long-term goal of increasing coaches and to provide sustainable, high quality, and personalized online fitness coaching to a growing number of clients with a well-trained staff.

2. What makes the company unique for clients? What single thing does the business perform or understand better than anyone else in the industry?

As business owners that had executive careers prior to transitioning to a career in fitness, any future trainers brought on board will also have that experience of having found the balance between work, family, and health. That is an experience that cannot be taught but must be learned to be appreciated. This will allow the trainers to empathize with and understand the client's needs, wants, limitations, and goals better than anyone else in the industry.

3. Who will the company consist of at inception? What roles will each person have?

At inception, the company will consist of one owner-operator with goals to bring on up to four additional online trainers during a 2-year period. For the first year, the owner will balance their time between marketing, product development, sales, and servicing clients. At any time the owner feels overwhelmed in a specific area, help will be sought out in that specific area.

Identify Target Audience

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IIdentify Target AudienceThe final section of the Executive Summary in the business plan should identify who the clients will be. Most business owners already have some idea of who their target audience is. Having too wide a target audience, the business's message will get lost and not resonate with clients. A narrow target audience and will be too specific for anyone to hear the message. The target audience should be someone the fitness professional can relate to, that they know their USP will help, and that they feel will provide the business with enough clients to grow and expand.

Realize that every business will have clients who are outside of their target audience and their target audience will change over time, especially in the early stages of the business. For example, some fitness professionals may start out only wanting to work with competitive physique athletes, but quickly find out they prefer working with seniors who are trying to improve their quality of life.

Jirsack/Shutterstock.comBusiness Plan Questions

What is the ideal client's goal?

Where does the ideal client live?

How old is the ideal client?

How long is the average client enrolled in coaching for?

Are there any other specifics about the ideal client?

Executive Fitness Example1. What is the ideal client's goal?

The ideal client's goal is not just to lose weight or get into shape. The ideal client's goal is to find a balance between life, work, and physical health.

2. Where does the ideal client live?

In order to provide prompt service to clients and properly manage the limited time a small business owner or business professional has, the ideal client is located in North America. Exact geographical location outside of that does not matter, as this is a virtual coaching company.

3. How old is the ideal client?

The ideal client is between the ages of 30 and 45 and is most likely settling into their second job in the same profession.

4. How long is the average client enrolled in coaching for?

Based on previous experience with in-person training and nutrition clients, the average client will need to be enrolled in the coaching program for at least 3 months before achieving their goals and possessing the knowledge to manage their own nutrition and training.

5. Are there any other specifics about the ideal client?

Based on both personal and professional experiences, the ideal client has one to two children under the age of 10. Experience in finding ways to balance training with family life, in addition to work, allows the company to bring a unique and sought-after service to clients.

Products and Services

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IProducts and ServicesOnline Personal Training is not a product per se, but rather a service. The product description in the business plan must include detailed descriptions of what features will be brought to the market and what makes the product or service unique. Products and/or services should always be improving and changing. Offering the same service with no improvements is a quick way to become irrelevant in the highly competitive landscape of businesses, especially with online businesses. With that said, the downfall of many entrepreneurs is trying to perfect their product too much prior to actually having real-world feedback.

This section of the business plan should focus on the minimum viable product (MVP) that the business will be starting with. Remember the business plan is a living document that can be modified and updated as product offerings change. There are many approaches to developing an MVP. In this section, it will be broken down step-by-step to develop multiple product offerings that can get to market quickly and are easy to improve based on feedback from customers.

Helpful HintBefore starting to develop the MVP, do some simple market research and gain insight to what future competitors are doing. If the top competitors of the business are known, browse those companies' websites, e-mail the companies with questions, and read their content. If the business's competitors are unknown, search online for keywords that potential clients would most likely use to find services the business is going to offer. This is not to steal anything from competitors but, rather, to ensure the business is offering industry-standard items. The fitness professional may even find that what all competitor companies offer is not good enough for their clients and they will have the opportunity to build an industry-changing product.

Minimum viable product (MVP)A product that provides the bare minimum features to satisfy customer demand – this is the foundation for a product that will be developed and modified based on market feedback.

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IThe first step is to develop a base service. This base service forms the foundation for the USP and should be something the target market audience needs, as discussed in the previous section. Building on the example of offering online coaching to busy professionals, the base service will be set as Online Fitness Coaching.

Now that the product has been established, it is time to expand on what that product will actually include. These are the features and benefits. Benefits of a product will be discussed in the sales section of this chapter. For product development, the focus will be on features.

Features are the USP of a business's services—essentially, what the service is. This is when the fitness professional will use their creativity and passion to accurately describe their product. To illustrate this point, here is an example of some simple features of a common dry-erase marker:

Bright, vibrant colors

Ergonomic fit to left or right hand

Strong, durable casing

Ability to write on multiple surfaces

Easily erased

Secure cap to prevent accidental markings

Soft felt tip that does not require sharpening

Disposable, no messy ink to refill

Mtsaride/Shutterstock.comThese features are not unique; they are features shared by almost all dry-erase markers. However, the fitness professional should be able to emphasize not only the uniqueness of their product, but uniquely emphasize the common features of their product. Now, using this strategy to find the features of Online Fitness Coaching, it is possible to develop answers for the example company.

Please note: This is not meant to be an all-inclusive list of what online coaching is or should be but simply a list for the specific example company that is being built.

Features and benefitsFeatures are descriptions of what a product or service offers customers – Benefits are how those features help solve a customer's problem.

Features of Online Fitness Coaching Example

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IFeatures of Online Fitness Coaching Example

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable fitness

Custom training programs built around goals

24/7 e-mail access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based fitness practices

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

This simple list of only five features highlights common offerings in online fitness coaching. However, most online coaches do not promote their common features (1 to 4) and simply highlight their USP (5). A common example of this in other industries is the Schlitz Beer company, which took their product to the top selling beer in the world simply by highlighting how beer was made as their USP. Their technique was standard in the beer industry, but no companies had mentioned how beer was made before Schlitz (Harter, 2018).

Business Plan Questions

What are two common competitor features that the company might offer clients?

What are two standard features that other companies are not highlighting?

Describe the USP in 1 to 2 sentences.

The features have now been created for the product, Online Fitness Coaching. The example company officially has its first product. However, having one product is not good for the longer-term plan of gaining feedback and modifying the product. Therefore, a few offerings should be created based on the core product, Online Fitness Coaching.

Helpful HintFind balance when offering multiple products and services. Not only will the fitness professional put a lot of time and effort into developing products that may not be successful, it may actually hurt sales. Overchoice is when there are so many options in the marketplace that a buyer is overwhelmed and may choose to not purchase anything at all (Settle & Golden, 1974).

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IFirst, take the example company's base product of Online Fitness Coaching and expanding it into three distinct product offerings:

Online Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching (which contains both exercise and nutrition coaching)

The company will need to modify its USP or features from the original product to fit these expanded offerings. There will be some crossover and additional features. This is commonly seen in pricing charts, as seen in Table: Online Fitness Coaching Product Features Examples.

Online Fitness Coaching Product Features ExamplesOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable exercise habits

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable nutrition habits

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable exercise and nutrition habits

Custom exercise training programs built around goals and preferences

Custom nutrition program built around goals and preferences

Custom exercise and nutrition programs built around goals and preferences

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based exercise practices

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based nutrition practices

Access to the client only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based exercise and nutrition practices

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

With this update, there are now three products to offer clients and test in the marketplace. Because of this, there have also been simple upgrades and add-ons developed for clients, which will increase sales. For instance, if a client enrolls in Online Exercise Coaching, but after a consultation with the business owner feels they should also partake in nutrition coaching, it is a simple upsell offer to Complete Online Fitness Coaching. This will also work in reverse to increase customer's lifetime value (CLV). If a client is canceling their services at $150 per month for Complete Online Fitness Coaching, the fitness professional can offer to downgrade the client to either nutrition or exercise coaching at only $100 per month.

Customer lifetime value (CLV)The amount that a customer will spend with business over a lifetime.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IEach of these three offerings will be further developed to produce quality minimum viable products (MVPs) that will provide product add-ons, options, and a pricing structure that will be competitive in the marketplace.

Business Plan Questions

What is the core service?

What are two variations of that service and how do those variations relate to the core service?

What is one unique feature for each of those new variations?

Executive Fitness Example1. What is the core service?

The core service for Executive Fitness is Complete Online Fitness Coaching, which includes both exercise and nutrition coaching.

2. What are two variations of that service and how do those variations relate to the core service?

Two components of Complete Online Fitness Coaching will be exercise and nutrition coaching. These can each be turned into a standalone service and then offered as the original, combined service. Both exercise and nutrition coaching are components of the core service that can be broken down into separate services to meet the demands and goals of clients.

3. What is one unique feature for each of those new variations?

Clients now have programs that are customized to focus on areas of their health that they feel they need the most support from a trainer on, instead of a one-size-fits-all package.

Canned, Predesigned Programs

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ICanned, Predesigned ProgramsMany online personal trainers seek to write predesigned exercise and nutrition programs and sell them as one-off purchases. This approach may not be the most sustainable path for all businesses to take. Just like working with an in-person training client, training programs should be customized for each person. A training program that works for a 28-year-old former college athlete who wants to focus on muscle hypertrophy most likely will not work for a 65-year-old who wants to improve their ability to carry grocery bags up the stairs.

Figure Customize Predesigned Training TemplatesConsider the customer lifetime value (CLV). A customer who makes a recurring monthly payment for customized training at $100 per month for 4 months is worth 16 times more than someone who pays $25 for a one-time exercise program. They are also more likely to refer clients back to the business versus the templated training program that can be e-mailed to a friend.

This is not to say templates do not have a place in business. Templates can be massive time savers for the busy fitness professional and can make processes and work more efficient and consistent. Having pre-made training templates that are easy for the business owner to modify and customize for each client will save hours of work developing programming for each client (Figure: Customize Predesigned Training Templates). While similar, this differs from using a generic approach to programming for every client. For instance, developing five training templates with no specific exercises can save time having to recreate the same thing for every client.

Here are some template examples:

Template 1: A 2-day-per-week full-body program

Template 2: A 3-day-per-week program broken down into push/pull/legs

Template 3: A 5-day-per-week program consisting of back/biceps, shoulders/chest/triceps, and legs

Lastly, consider the customer acquisition cost (CAC). New customers are not free—they cost time, money, and energy. The business may not have a marketing budget, but the time that is spent making sales and creating content is time away from running the business and time away from providing services to clients. It is generally more cost effective to sell to someone who is already a customer than to try and acquire a new customer.

Live One-on-One Coaching

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ILive One-on-One CoachingNow that the three product offerings have been developed in nutrition, exercise/training, and nutrition and exercise coaching combined, it is time to build further on these products and provide some additional options to future clients. It is important to have valuable products for upsell to a client that they will benefit from. This will not only help clients increase their overall success but will also help boost the company's revenue as the CLV increases with each add-on. A simple option for this is to offer live video coaching for clients (Figure: Live Video Coaching). This is especially useful when the fitness professional is starting out and does not have a large client base. It enables the fitness professional to spend more time per client and obtain direct and instant feedback, and it provides more income per client for the business owner while they grow their business.

Continuing with the example company, three product offerings have been developed:

Online Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Complete Online Fitness Coaching

FigureLive Video CoachingA simple add-on for each of these products is a single-session video consultation. For a nutrition client, this could include a video call with the client while they go grocery shopping, being right there with them while they navigate the grocery store and work to make healthier food choices. For an exercise training client, this could include form checks or navigating the gym for a client who is nervous about going alone. Another option for add-ons is an in-person session. If the business owner has an online client who is local to their area, they could train with them at their gym, home, or outside (depending on their training/goals). For the nutrition client, they could actually go grocery shopping with them or help them learn how to meal prep. Adding these on to the product offerings, there is now a product line (Table: Upsell Options and Add-Ons).

Upsell Options and Add-OnsOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: Fitness and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: Fitness and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: N/A

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

With multiple coaching options, the chances have increased to upsell products to clients who will benefit from them, offer premium add-ons for existing clients, and keep the product overload to a minimum. The final step is pricing services and add-ons.

Hybrid Model

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IHybrid ModelThe fitness professional also has the opportunity to build out their virtual coaching business with in-person clients, as well. This can allow the fitness professional to retain clients longer, take on a greater client load, and build their own online business while still working as an in-person trainer.

Options for this include the following:

Working with nutrition clients online

Intermediate- to advanced-level training clients who may not need direct supervision of a personal trainer but would like accountability and program design

Utilizing client referrals for friends and family who may not be local to the training facility

Coach's CornerThe entrepreneur should keep their focus on their primary goal—their virtual coaching business. While the financial and employment stability that may come with an existing in-person training career is comfortable, the entrepreneur should ensure their attention is set on growing their online business. One of the many benefits of virtual coaching is the ability to take on more clients compared to in-person training. Spending valuable time with in-person training clients not only limits the personal trainer’s earning capability, but it can greatly slow down the rate of growth for the virtual business. The entrepreneur should find a balance between the two that steadily shifts focus toward the virtual coaching business.

Market and Competitive Analysis

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IMarket and Competitive AnalysisFitness is an extremely competitive space, with almost 650,000 Americans employed by fitness or recreation centers and an expected growth rate of approximately 15% between 2018 to 2028 (Torpey, 2020; U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2019). There is no difficulty in finding competitors in the fitness industry, no matter what niche a business targets. Analyzing the competitors in a market can be a daunting task; however, using a few key metrics (e.g., number of competitors in the market, average price of services, and the number of service variations offered) and incorporating a simplistic approach to designing pricing models and a target market, the fitness professional can save time and produce a quality business plan that will accelerate their growth by avoiding costly mistakes.

Rawpixel.com/Shutterstock.comWhen pricing any product, it is important to already know who the target market will be, what features will be offered with a well-defined product, and what variations of the product will be created. Once the fitness professional has these determined, they can take a look into the pricing of their competitors and accurately price themselves for the market. If the price is too low, there will not be enough revenue to pay the business owner a reasonable salary for work they have performed. If the price is too high, the business owner runs the risk of not having enough clients to pay themselves at all, or worse, they will have no clients. Many strategies exist for setting pricing for a new product. The most relevant and practical strategies will be broken down, including their benefits and downsides, and eventually one will be chosen for the example company. Before picking a pricing strategy, the fitness professional should conduct market research of future competitors in the area.

A simple online search for terms related to the target market and online coaching will produce ample results. Using the example company, a search for “online fitness coaching busy professionals” produced five quality results on the first page of the search engine. This provided pricing for five companies that offer online monthly coaching as follows in Table: Market Research Results Example.

Market Research Results ExampleCompany

1

2

3

4

5

Price

$199

$125

$595

$159

$139

The average price for monthly online coaching with these five companies is $243.

All of these companies offer similar services, each having their own unique USP. After this competitive analysis, it is known the average price in the market for online coaching is $243 per month and that the range in pricing for similar services is wide.

Pricing Strategies

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IPricing StrategiesThe following are four different pricing strategies that will help guide the entrepreneur pricing strategy in a simple way:

Economy Pricing: Low priced, affordable pricing for everyone – Profit margins in this pricing category are small. This pricing strategy is designed to target a mass, broad market. In a service industry, this pricing strategy is typically reserved for large corporations.

Skimming Pricing: This pricing strategy charges a higher price at the start of the company and eventually lowers the pricing as more competitors enter the market. This strategy is typically used for companies entering a new market or market segment that is not very competitive.

Penetration Pricing: This strategy sets pricing lower at the start of the company in order to gain a share of the market quickly. Once the business has met its market share goals, prices are raised to a higher level. This strategy also allows for feedback from customers and helps with the decision on where a valid price point should be set.

Premium Pricing: Setting a high price is used to define the product or brand as a luxury item. In the mind of the consumer, the high price must mean a high-quality product. This strategy is used by high-end brands in the automotive and luxury watch industries.

Quality of Product and PricingQuality of Product

Price

Low

High

Low

Economy

Penetration

High

Skimming

Premium

Note that the entrepreneur may pivot at different points in time to different pricing strategies based on sales and feedback from customers. However, ensure that the business plan is updated to consider the new pricing strategy.

Whichever pricing model is chosen, price according to the target market. If the target market is college students, the pricing will need to be at the lower end of the market. If the target market is celebrities, then pricing will need to be at the higher end of the market.

Business Plan Questions

Will the service best fit into an economy, penetration, skimming, or premium price strategy?

Will the company charge a one-time, pre-paid package fee or a recurring monthly subscription?

Will the company test other pricing strategies or price points?

Executive Fitness Example1. Will the service best fit into an economy, penetration, skimming, or premium price strategy?

The long-term goal of the service is to be priced as a premium service. To start the company and ensure that service quality commands a premium price point, services will be priced in the middle of the market, in a hybrid of penetration and premium pricing.

2. Will the company charge a one-time, pre-paid package fee or a recurring monthly subscription?

The product will be a recurring monthly subscription with a 3-month minimum subscription required. This will help to keep the cost lower, but still offer premium pricing. This will also allow the company to have a more predictable revenue stream.

3. Will the company test other pricing strategies or price points?

Utilizing feedback from clients and comparing that with projections and goals, the company will adjust pricing accordingly at 3-month intervals in the first year of business.

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IContinuing with the example company, because research showed there is a wide range of prices in the market, it is time to discover where the example company falls in the market. For this, a simple solution is to use a hybrid of the premium and penetration pricing models and be prepared to adjust based on feedback from clients. Setting a price around the average market price of $243 and deciding on $249 will put the business into a prime position for the average consumer. (Using an odd number for pricing is called psychological pricing—there is more resistance to $250 versus $249).

Helpful HintDo not change prices too often. Re-evaluate pricing every 3 months in the first year of business, every 6 months in the second year, and then yearly thereafter. Also, consider inflation in the economy. The average inflation rate is 3%, which means that prices will double about every 20 years. If prices are set at $100 for 10 years and that price is suddenly increased to $150 to offset inflation, many customers will be unhappy. However, a smart entrepreneur will plan for price increases. A good rule of thumb is a 5% price increase every other year or 10% every 3 years. This will help prevent a pricing shock to customers and a decline in purchasing power over time.

The example company now has a price of $249 for the coaching product, but still has three products. Pricing all three at the same rate would not give customers a price choice and makes it harder for the consumer to differentiate between products. $249 can be used for the base price or the upgrade price. The example company will use $249 as the upgrade and $199 for the base price, as a 25% upgrade price ($50 in this example) is a substantial revenue increase for the business, and a fair price for the client. Refer to Table: Base Price and Upgrade Price Example for the pricing options.

Base Price and Upgrade Price ExampleOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Complete Online Fitness Coaching

$199/month

$199/month

$249/month

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IThe company now has three products, each with their own pricing and the ability for clients to upgrade or downgrade. Downgrading is an important option to provide clients. It is better to have a client downgrade rather than leave altogether. Using these tools, the entrepreneur can create their own product lineup and pricing models that allow for products to be priced competitively in the market, upsell useful services to clients, and retain clients with different services that meet a client’s changing needs.

Helpful Hint

Add-ons can either cost more than the original product and require less sales or can cost less but will require more sales.

Cost more: less products that need to be created

Cost less: will need new products more often to keep small amounts of money coming in

After operating for 6 months, the entrepreneur should re-evaluate services that are selling and see if they can find where most of their revenue comes from.

For example, if a business has 80% of their sales coming from 20% of their products (referred to as the Pareto Principle or the 80/20 principle), drop products that do not sell and/or do not generate enough revenue to warrant continued development.

Food for ThoughtTwo common pricing options include having many clients who pay a little or a few clients who pay a lot. Having a few clients who pay more typically means there will be fewer daily headaches. It is easier to communicate with 10 people versus 100. The tradeoff for that is if two clients leave, the business will lose 20% of its income. One of the important factors of pricing is to find a balance between workload and revenue security.

Introduction to a Virtual Coaching Business Plan

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IIntroduction to a Virtual Coaching Business PlanA business plan is the instruction manual for how the business will grow, which outlines the path the fitness professional will follow to achieve their overall vision. As an instruction manual, a business plan is a living document that must be reviewed, updated, and rewritten as a business evolves and changes. Having a business plan gives the fitness professional a place to put their thoughts into words and gives them the ability to easily share their vision with others.

The length and detail of the fitness professional's business plan can and will vary depending on several factors. If the new entrepreneur is seeking to take out a bank loan or take on partners or investors, they will need to go into greater detail on financial information than they would if they were starting a business on their own. If the business owner is a solopreneur (an entrepreneur with no employees or partners), then the goal of the business plan is to have a guide to keep the fitness professional on course while building their business.

Please note: After each description of the different sections of the business plan are at least three Business Plan Questions to help the fitness professional develop their own well-thought-out and detailed business plan. These prompts will be followed by an example of properly developed answers that will be used to formulate a final business plan, which will be completed at the end of this chapter.

An example company, called Executive Fitness, will be created to demonstrate what well-thought-out answers to the business plan writing prompts should look like. The example company's goal is to provide online fitness coaching to busy office professionals who do not have time to visit a gym on a consistent basis. The example company will be expanded on as the business plan is developed further in this chapter.

The Business Plan Questions should be completed after reading the entire chapter because many of these questions and ideas work and build off of each other. In order to develop a complete picture of what the fitness professional's virtual coaching business will look like, the fitness professional must understand all of the concepts in this chapter first.

Food for ThoughtA business plan should be treated as a living document. It should be reviewed, referenced, and updated regularly.

Business planA document that outlines how a business will be structured, grow, and achieve goals that are set forth by the business owner or executive team.

SolopreneurAn entrepreneur who runs a business on their own.

Executive Summary

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IExecutive SummaryZurainy Zain/Shutterstock.comThe first section of a business plan is the executive summary. In the executive summary, the fitness professional will describe the purpose of the business. This part is the who, what, and why of the business.

Who are the founders and key people in the business? Who is the business targeting? What other stakeholders should be considered?

What makes this business different, more effective, and, most importantly, unique?

Why are clients going to come to this new, untested, and unproven business?

Each section of the executive summary can expand over time into their own sections of the business plan as the fitness professional develops more experience and a more detailed path for bringing their overall vision for the business to fruition.

Mission and Vision StatementsAs an entrepreneur, the fitness professional is the business's management team. The fitness professional is, essentially, the director of everything. This is where, as the company's chief visionary, they will lay the foundation for the future of the company for years to come. The fitness professional should discuss where they see the business in 1, 5, and 10 years along with the milestones of how they plan to get to each of those goals. They will discuss the driving force behind their business and their company's vision and mission statement.

Tang Yan Song/Shutterstock.comA mission statement is what drives the business's culture and progress over time. A mission statement is the entrepreneur's reason for wanting to start this business and should convey a meaning that resonates (and motivates) with the founder, employees, and clients (Bart, 1997).

A vision statement is what the business will look like in the long-term, over the next 5 to 10 years or more. If the overall goals of the business are met, the vision statement should describe an outside, broad view of the company.

Executive summaryA section of the business plan that provides an overview of what will be covered in the document.

Mission statementA mission statement is the entrepreneur's reason for wanting to start this business and should convey a meaning that resonates (and motivates) with the founder, employees, and clients.

Vision statementWhat the business will look like in the long-term, over the next 5 to 10 years or more.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IBusiness Plan Questions

Who is the target audience? What challenge does the target audience face that the business can help solve?

What is the fitness professional's personal connection and motivation to help solve this problem?

What does the business look like in 1, 5, and 10 years?

Executive Fitness Example1. Who is the target audience? What challenge does the target audience face that the business can help solve?

The target audience is busy business professionals who want to give their health, fitness, and nutrition a higher priority but have difficulty finding a sustainable path to achieve their goals.

2. What is the fitness professional's personal connection and motivation to help solve this problem?

This business is owned by someone who, prior to becoming a fitness professional, worked a corporate office job. Firsthand experience with the lack of personal health goals in accomplished individuals is vast. Balancing a 40+-hour work week with family life, being sedentary, lacking motivation to exercise, and not understanding there is a sustainable path to health are all common realities. This allows for empathy with clients and for developing a plan that will fit their aspirations.

3. What does the business look like in 1, 5, and 10 years?

During the first year, systems will be developed and refined while the company services the professional market the owner is most familiar with—those working larger corporate jobs in upper to middle management. After the first year, using feedback from clients combined with additional market research, the company will be able to evolve and expand the service to other professionals in different markets, such as teachers and educators of all levels. The company will also start to bring on employees at that time to ensure high quality of service is maintained. At the 5-year mark, the business will have started partnering with corporations to provide in-house wellness services to employees, as well as continuing to grow the direct-to-client coaching services. At the 10-year mark, the business will be a large company in the online training industry, generating millions of dollars of revenue annually. This growth will require an entire professional management team, along with a strong corporate structure and a constantly updated and refined business plan.

Company Description

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ICompany DescriptionA description of the company should be concise yet detailed. Simply stating that a business will conduct online personal training is too vague. Conversely, going into detail about what estimated customer acquisition cost (CAC) will be is too in-depth for the executive summary (this will be included in expanded sections of the business plan such as marketing or financial). A description of the business should discuss the purpose of the business and what makes it unique. The uniqueness is often described as the unique selling proposition (USP). This is the place that the fitness professional should explain why customers will choose their business over a competitor.

Highlight the true uniqueness of the business. Mentioning features of a business are simply not enough. There was a time when responding to an e-mail within 24 hours or offering text/messaging to a client was unique and rare. However, now that there are more online coaching businesses, these features have become the standard. The fitness professional needs a USP that only they bring to their clients.

niroworld/Shutterstock.comIt is also a good idea, and common practice, to include information on any of the company founders, along with their backgrounds. Even if the business owner is a solopreneur, they should be able to sell themselves and explain why their background and experience makes them the most suited to bring their USP to the market.

The company description should also include the management structure of the company. If the business will be starting with partners or employees, their roles and responsibilities should be clearly defined here. Highlight why these individuals will be vital to the business's initial success. If these employees are not included in the description and backgrounds of the company founders, then they should be included here.

Most entrepreneurs are solopreneurs at first. They are the only employee in the business. This means they are working both in and on the business. Take this opportunity to clarify what roles everyone involved will be taking on and what roles may be contracted out. For instance, most entrepreneurs will take on marketing, but few will do their own taxes.

Helpful HintThere are many gig services, companies that connect consumers or businesses with freelancers to perform various tasks or jobs, that can be found online for minimal cost. These can be utilized for things like creating infographics, editing blogs, and editing videos.

It is also possible to find reputable and affordable online services for things like accounting and legal advice.

Customer acquisition cost (CAC)How much a new customer costs a business – typically, the cost is determined through money spent on advertising.

Unique selling proposition (USP)The unique benefit or feature of a product or service that differentiates a business from other businesses offering a similar service or product.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IBusiness Plan Questions

What are the unique goals of the business?

What makes the company unique to clients? What single thing does the business perform or understand better than anyone else in the industry?

Who will the company consist of at inception? What roles will each person have?

Executive Fitness Example1. What are the short-term and long-term goals of the business?

The company's short-term goals include developing systems to provide customized, but repeatable client experiences. This will help to achieve the long-term goal of increasing coaches and to provide sustainable, high quality, and personalized online fitness coaching to a growing number of clients with a well-trained staff.

2. What makes the company unique for clients? What single thing does the business perform or understand better than anyone else in the industry?

As business owners that had executive careers prior to transitioning to a career in fitness, any future trainers brought on board will also have that experience of having found the balance between work, family, and health. That is an experience that cannot be taught but must be learned to be appreciated. This will allow the trainers to empathize with and understand the client's needs, wants, limitations, and goals better than anyone else in the industry.

3. Who will the company consist of at inception? What roles will each person have?

At inception, the company will consist of one owner-operator with goals to bring on up to four additional online trainers during a 2-year period. For the first year, the owner will balance their time between marketing, product development, sales, and servicing clients. At any time the owner feels overwhelmed in a specific area, help will be sought out in that specific area.

Identify Target Audience

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IIdentify Target AudienceThe final section of the Executive Summary in the business plan should identify who the clients will be. Most business owners already have some idea of who their target audience is. Having too wide a target audience, the business's message will get lost and not resonate with clients. A narrow target audience and will be too specific for anyone to hear the message. The target audience should be someone the fitness professional can relate to, that they know their USP will help, and that they feel will provide the business with enough clients to grow and expand.

Realize that every business will have clients who are outside of their target audience and their target audience will change over time, especially in the early stages of the business. For example, some fitness professionals may start out only wanting to work with competitive physique athletes, but quickly find out they prefer working with seniors who are trying to improve their quality of life.

Jirsack/Shutterstock.comBusiness Plan Questions

What is the ideal client's goal?

Where does the ideal client live?

How old is the ideal client?

How long is the average client enrolled in coaching for?

Are there any other specifics about the ideal client?

Executive Fitness Example1. What is the ideal client's goal?

The ideal client's goal is not just to lose weight or get into shape. The ideal client's goal is to find a balance between life, work, and physical health.

2. Where does the ideal client live?

In order to provide prompt service to clients and properly manage the limited time a small business owner or business professional has, the ideal client is located in North America. Exact geographical location outside of that does not matter, as this is a virtual coaching company.

3. How old is the ideal client?

The ideal client is between the ages of 30 and 45 and is most likely settling into their second job in the same profession.

4. How long is the average client enrolled in coaching for?

Based on previous experience with in-person training and nutrition clients, the average client will need to be enrolled in the coaching program for at least 3 months before achieving their goals and possessing the knowledge to manage their own nutrition and training.

5. Are there any other specifics about the ideal client?

Based on both personal and professional experiences, the ideal client has one to two children under the age of 10. Experience in finding ways to balance training with family life, in addition to work, allows the company to bring a unique and sought-after service to clients.

Products and Services

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IProducts and ServicesOnline Personal Training is not a product per se, but rather a service. The product description in the business plan must include detailed descriptions of what features will be brought to the market and what makes the product or service unique. Products and/or services should always be improving and changing. Offering the same service with no improvements is a quick way to become irrelevant in the highly competitive landscape of businesses, especially with online businesses. With that said, the downfall of many entrepreneurs is trying to perfect their product too much prior to actually having real-world feedback.

This section of the business plan should focus on the minimum viable product (MVP) that the business will be starting with. Remember the business plan is a living document that can be modified and updated as product offerings change. There are many approaches to developing an MVP. In this section, it will be broken down step-by-step to develop multiple product offerings that can get to market quickly and are easy to improve based on feedback from customers.

Helpful HintBefore starting to develop the MVP, do some simple market research and gain insight to what future competitors are doing. If the top competitors of the business are known, browse those companies' websites, e-mail the companies with questions, and read their content. If the business's competitors are unknown, search online for keywords that potential clients would most likely use to find services the business is going to offer. This is not to steal anything from competitors but, rather, to ensure the business is offering industry-standard items. The fitness professional may even find that what all competitor companies offer is not good enough for their clients and they will have the opportunity to build an industry-changing product.

Minimum viable product (MVP)A product that provides the bare minimum features to satisfy customer demand – this is the foundation for a product that will be developed and modified based on market feedback.

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IThe first step is to develop a base service. This base service forms the foundation for the USP and should be something the target market audience needs, as discussed in the previous section. Building on the example of offering online coaching to busy professionals, the base service will be set as Online Fitness Coaching.

Now that the product has been established, it is time to expand on what that product will actually include. These are the features and benefits. Benefits of a product will be discussed in the sales section of this chapter. For product development, the focus will be on features.

Features are the USP of a business's services—essentially, what the service is. This is when the fitness professional will use their creativity and passion to accurately describe their product. To illustrate this point, here is an example of some simple features of a common dry-erase marker:

Bright, vibrant colors

Ergonomic fit to left or right hand

Strong, durable casing

Ability to write on multiple surfaces

Easily erased

Secure cap to prevent accidental markings

Soft felt tip that does not require sharpening

Disposable, no messy ink to refill

Mtsaride/Shutterstock.comThese features are not unique; they are features shared by almost all dry-erase markers. However, the fitness professional should be able to emphasize not only the uniqueness of their product, but uniquely emphasize the common features of their product. Now, using this strategy to find the features of Online Fitness Coaching, it is possible to develop answers for the example company.

Please note: This is not meant to be an all-inclusive list of what online coaching is or should be but simply a list for the specific example company that is being built.

Features and benefitsFeatures are descriptions of what a product or service offers customers – Benefits are how those features help solve a customer's problem.

Features of Online Fitness Coaching Example

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IFeatures of Online Fitness Coaching Example

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable fitness

Custom training programs built around goals

24/7 e-mail access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based fitness practices

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

This simple list of only five features highlights common offerings in online fitness coaching. However, most online coaches do not promote their common features (1 to 4) and simply highlight their USP (5). A common example of this in other industries is the Schlitz Beer company, which took their product to the top selling beer in the world simply by highlighting how beer was made as their USP. Their technique was standard in the beer industry, but no companies had mentioned how beer was made before Schlitz (Harter, 2018).

Business Plan Questions

What are two common competitor features that the company might offer clients?

What are two standard features that other companies are not highlighting?

Describe the USP in 1 to 2 sentences.

The features have now been created for the product, Online Fitness Coaching. The example company officially has its first product. However, having one product is not good for the longer-term plan of gaining feedback and modifying the product. Therefore, a few offerings should be created based on the core product, Online Fitness Coaching.

Helpful HintFind balance when offering multiple products and services. Not only will the fitness professional put a lot of time and effort into developing products that may not be successful, it may actually hurt sales. Overchoice is when there are so many options in the marketplace that a buyer is overwhelmed and may choose to not purchase anything at all (Settle & Golden, 1974).

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IFirst, take the example company's base product of Online Fitness Coaching and expanding it into three distinct product offerings:

Online Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching (which contains both exercise and nutrition coaching)

The company will need to modify its USP or features from the original product to fit these expanded offerings. There will be some crossover and additional features. This is commonly seen in pricing charts, as seen in Table: Online Fitness Coaching Product Features Examples.

Online Fitness Coaching Product Features ExamplesOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable exercise habits

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable nutrition habits

Weekly check-ins with the coach that build toward sustainable exercise and nutrition habits

Custom exercise training programs built around goals and preferences

Custom nutrition program built around goals and preferences

Custom exercise and nutrition programs built around goals and preferences

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

24/7 email access to the coach with a guaranteed reply within 24 hours

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based exercise practices

Access to the client-only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based nutrition practices

Access to the client only newsletter, discussing the latest evidence-based exercise and nutrition practices

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

Coaching designed with flexibility in mind for individuals with busy schedules

With this update, there are now three products to offer clients and test in the marketplace. Because of this, there have also been simple upgrades and add-ons developed for clients, which will increase sales. For instance, if a client enrolls in Online Exercise Coaching, but after a consultation with the business owner feels they should also partake in nutrition coaching, it is a simple upsell offer to Complete Online Fitness Coaching. This will also work in reverse to increase customer's lifetime value (CLV). If a client is canceling their services at $150 per month for Complete Online Fitness Coaching, the fitness professional can offer to downgrade the client to either nutrition or exercise coaching at only $100 per month.

Customer lifetime value (CLV)The amount that a customer will spend with business over a lifetime.

Business Plan Questions

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IEach of these three offerings will be further developed to produce quality minimum viable products (MVPs) that will provide product add-ons, options, and a pricing structure that will be competitive in the marketplace.

Business Plan Questions

What is the core service?

What are two variations of that service and how do those variations relate to the core service?

What is one unique feature for each of those new variations?

Executive Fitness Example1. What is the core service?

The core service for Executive Fitness is Complete Online Fitness Coaching, which includes both exercise and nutrition coaching.

2. What are two variations of that service and how do those variations relate to the core service?

Two components of Complete Online Fitness Coaching will be exercise and nutrition coaching. These can each be turned into a standalone service and then offered as the original, combined service. Both exercise and nutrition coaching are components of the core service that can be broken down into separate services to meet the demands and goals of clients.

3. What is one unique feature for each of those new variations?

Clients now have programs that are customized to focus on areas of their health that they feel they need the most support from a trainer on, instead of a one-size-fits-all package.

Canned, Predesigned Programs

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ICanned, Predesigned ProgramsMany online personal trainers seek to write predesigned exercise and nutrition programs and sell them as one-off purchases. This approach may not be the most sustainable path for all businesses to take. Just like working with an in-person training client, training programs should be customized for each person. A training program that works for a 28-year-old former college athlete who wants to focus on muscle hypertrophy most likely will not work for a 65-year-old who wants to improve their ability to carry grocery bags up the stairs.

Figure Customize Predesigned Training TemplatesConsider the customer lifetime value (CLV). A customer who makes a recurring monthly payment for customized training at $100 per month for 4 months is worth 16 times more than someone who pays $25 for a one-time exercise program. They are also more likely to refer clients back to the business versus the templated training program that can be e-mailed to a friend.

This is not to say templates do not have a place in business. Templates can be massive time savers for the busy fitness professional and can make processes and work more efficient and consistent. Having pre-made training templates that are easy for the business owner to modify and customize for each client will save hours of work developing programming for each client (Figure: Customize Predesigned Training Templates). While similar, this differs from using a generic approach to programming for every client. For instance, developing five training templates with no specific exercises can save time having to recreate the same thing for every client.

Here are some template examples:

Template 1: A 2-day-per-week full-body program

Template 2: A 3-day-per-week program broken down into push/pull/legs

Template 3: A 5-day-per-week program consisting of back/biceps, shoulders/chest/triceps, and legs

Lastly, consider the customer acquisition cost (CAC). New customers are not free—they cost time, money, and energy. The business may not have a marketing budget, but the time that is spent making sales and creating content is time away from running the business and time away from providing services to clients. It is generally more cost effective to sell to someone who is already a customer than to try and acquire a new customer.

Live One-on-One Coaching

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part ILive One-on-One CoachingNow that the three product offerings have been developed in nutrition, exercise/training, and nutrition and exercise coaching combined, it is time to build further on these products and provide some additional options to future clients. It is important to have valuable products for upsell to a client that they will benefit from. This will not only help clients increase their overall success but will also help boost the company's revenue as the CLV increases with each add-on. A simple option for this is to offer live video coaching for clients (Figure: Live Video Coaching). This is especially useful when the fitness professional is starting out and does not have a large client base. It enables the fitness professional to spend more time per client and obtain direct and instant feedback, and it provides more income per client for the business owner while they grow their business.

Continuing with the example company, three product offerings have been developed:

Online Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Complete Online Fitness Coaching

FigureLive Video CoachingA simple add-on for each of these products is a single-session video consultation. For a nutrition client, this could include a video call with the client while they go grocery shopping, being right there with them while they navigate the grocery store and work to make healthier food choices. For an exercise training client, this could include form checks or navigating the gym for a client who is nervous about going alone. Another option for add-ons is an in-

person session. If the business owner has an online client who is local to their area, they could train with them at their gym, home, or outside (depending on their training/goals). For the nutrition client, they could actually go grocery shopping with them or help them learn how to meal prep. Adding these on to the product offerings, there is now a product line (Table: Upsell Options and Add-Ons).

Upsell Options and Add-OnsOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Online Exercise and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: Fitness and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: Fitness and Nutrition Coaching

Upsell option: N/A

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

Add-on option: Additional, 30-minute live video consult

With multiple coaching options, the chances have increased to upsell products to clients who will benefit from them, offer premium add-ons for existing clients, and keep the product overload to a minimum. The final step is pricing services and add-ons.

Hybrid Model

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IHybrid ModelThe fitness professional also has the opportunity to build out their virtual coaching business with in-person clients, as well. This can allow the fitness professional to retain clients longer, take on a greater client load, and build their own online business while still working as an in-person trainer.

Options for this include the following:

Working with nutrition clients online

Intermediate- to advanced-level training clients who may not need direct supervision of a personal trainer but would like accountability and program design

Utilizing client referrals for friends and family who may not be local to the training facility

Coach's CornerThe entrepreneur should keep their focus on their primary goal—their virtual coaching business. While the financial and employment stability that may come with an existing in-person training career is comfortable, the entrepreneur should ensure their attention is set on growing their online business. One of the many benefits of virtual coaching is the ability to take on more clients compared to in-person training. Spending valuable time with in-person training clients not only limits the personal trainer’s earning capability, but it can greatly slow down the rate of growth for the virtual business. The entrepreneur should find a balance between the two that steadily shifts focus toward the virtual coaching business.

Market and Competitive Analysis

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IMarket and Competitive AnalysisFitness is an extremely competitive space, with almost 650,000 Americans employed by fitness or recreation centers and an expected growth rate of approximately 15% between 2018 to 2028 (Torpey, 2020; U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2019). There is no difficulty in finding competitors in the fitness industry, no matter what niche a business targets. Analyzing the competitors in a market can be a daunting task; however, using a few key metrics (e.g., number of competitors in the market, average price of services, and the number of service variations offered) and incorporating a simplistic approach to designing pricing models and a target market, the fitness professional can save time and produce a quality business plan that will accelerate their growth by avoiding costly mistakes.

Rawpixel.com/Shutterstock.comWhen pricing any product, it is important to already know who the target market will be, what features will be offered with a well-defined product, and what variations of the product will be created. Once the fitness professional has these determined, they can take a look into the pricing of their competitors and accurately price themselves for the market. If the price is too low, there will not be enough revenue to pay the business owner a reasonable salary for work they have performed. If the price is too high, the business owner runs the risk of not having enough clients to pay themselves at all, or worse, they will have no clients. Many strategies exist for setting pricing for a new product. The most relevant and practical strategies will be broken down, including their benefits and downsides, and eventually one will be chosen for the example company. Before picking a pricing strategy, the fitness professional should conduct market research of future competitors in the area.

A simple online search for terms related to the target market and online coaching will produce ample results. Using the example company, a search for “online fitness coaching busy professionals” produced five quality results on the first page of the search engine. This provided pricing for five companies that offer online monthly coaching as follows in Table: Market Research Results Example.

Market Research Results ExampleCompany

1

2

3

4

5

Price

$199

$125

$595

$159

$139

The average price for monthly online coaching with these five companies is $243.

All of these companies offer similar services, each having their own unique USP. After this competitive analysis, it is known the average price in the market for online coaching is $243 per month and that the range in pricing for similar services is wide.

Pricing Strategies

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IPricing StrategiesThe following are four different pricing strategies that will help guide the entrepreneur pricing strategy in a simple way:

Economy Pricing: Low priced, affordable pricing for everyone – Profit margins in this pricing category are small. This pricing strategy is designed to target a mass, broad market. In a service industry, this pricing strategy is typically reserved for large corporations.

Skimming Pricing: This pricing strategy charges a higher price at the start of the company and eventually lowers the pricing as more competitors enter the market. This strategy is typically used for companies entering a new market or market segment that is not very competitive.

Penetration Pricing: This strategy sets pricing lower at the start of the company in order to gain a share of the market quickly. Once the business has met its market share goals, prices are raised to a higher level. This strategy also allows for feedback from customers and helps with the decision on where a valid price point should be set.

Premium Pricing: Setting a high price is used to define the product or brand as a luxury item. In the mind of the consumer, the high price must mean a high-quality product. This strategy is used by high-end brands in the automotive and luxury watch industries.

Quality of Product and PricingQuality of Product

Price

Low

High

Low

Economy

Penetration

High

Skimming

Premium

Note that the entrepreneur may pivot at different points in time to different pricing strategies based on sales and feedback from customers. However, ensure that the business plan is updated to consider the new pricing strategy.

Whichever pricing model is chosen, price according to the target market. If the target market is college students, the pricing will need to be at the lower end of the market. If the target market is celebrities, then pricing will need to be at the higher end of the market.

Business Plan Questions

Will the service best fit into an economy, penetration, skimming, or premium price strategy?

Will the company charge a one-time, pre-paid package fee or a recurring monthly subscription?

Will the company test other pricing strategies or price points?

Executive Fitness Example1. Will the service best fit into an economy, penetration, skimming, or premium price strategy?

The long-term goal of the service is to be priced as a premium service. To start the company and ensure that service quality commands a premium price point, services will be priced in the middle of the market, in a hybrid of penetration and premium pricing.

2. Will the company charge a one-time, pre-paid package fee or a recurring monthly subscription?

The product will be a recurring monthly subscription with a 3-month minimum subscription required. This will help to keep the cost lower, but still offer premium pricing. This will also allow the company to have a more predictable revenue stream.

3. Will the company test other pricing strategies or price points?

Utilizing feedback from clients and comparing that with projections and goals, the company will adjust pricing accordingly at 3-month intervals in the first year of business.

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IContinuing with the example company, because research showed there is a wide range of prices in the market, it is time to discover where the example company falls in the market. For this, a simple solution is to use a hybrid of the premium and penetration pricing models and be prepared to adjust based on feedback from clients. Setting a price around the average market price of $243 and deciding on $249 will put the business into a prime position for the average consumer. (Using an odd number for pricing is called psychological pricing—there is more resistance to $250 versus $249).

Helpful HintDo not change prices too often. Re-evaluate pricing every 3 months in the first year of business, every 6 months in the second year, and then yearly thereafter. Also, consider inflation in the economy. The average inflation rate is 3%, which means that prices will double about every 20 years. If prices are set at $100 for 10 years and that price is suddenly increased to $150 to offset inflation, many customers will be unhappy. However, a smart entrepreneur will plan for price increases. A good rule of thumb is a 5% price increase every other year or 10% every 3 years. This will help prevent a pricing shock to customers and a decline in purchasing power over time.

The example company now has a price of $249 for the coaching product, but still has three products. Pricing all three at the same rate would not give customers a price choice and makes it harder for the consumer to differentiate between products. $249 can be used for the base price or the upgrade price. The example company will use $249 as the upgrade and $199 for the base price, as a 25% upgrade price ($50 in this example) is a substantial revenue increase for the business, and a fair price for the client. Refer to Table: Base Price and Upgrade Price Example for the pricing options.

Base Price and Upgrade Price ExampleOnline Exercise Coaching

Online Nutrition Coaching

Complete Online Fitness Coaching

$199/month

$199/month

$249/month

Content

Chapter 2Building a BusinessLesson 2Building a Virtual Coaching Business Plan: Part IThe company now has three products, each with their own pricing and the ability for clients to upgrade or downgrade. Downgrading is an important option to provide clients. It is better to have a client downgrade rather than leave altogether. Using these tools, the entrepreneur can create their own product lineup and pricing models that allow for products to be priced competitively in the market, upsell useful services to clients, and retain clients with different services that meet a client's changing needs.

Helpful Hint

Add-ons can either cost more than the original product and require less sales or can cost less but will require more sales.

Cost more: less products that need to be created

Cost less: will need new products more often to keep small amounts of money coming in

After operating for 6 months, the entrepreneur should re-evaluate services that are selling and see if they can find where most of their revenue comes from.

For example, if a business has 80% of their sales coming from 20% of their products (referred to as the Pareto Principle or the 80/20 principle), drop products that do not sell and/or do not generate enough revenue to warrant continued development.

Food for ThoughtTwo common pricing options include having many clients who pay a little or a few clients who pay a lot. Having a few clients who pay more typically means there will be fewer daily headaches. It is easier to communicate with 10 people versus 100. The tradeoff for that is if two clients leave, the business will lose 20% of its income. One of the important factors of pricing is to find a balance between workload and revenue security.

Chapter 3: Technology Considerations

Chapter 3: Technology Considerations

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsChapter 3: Technology Considerations Virtual training relies heavily on technology, which, when utilized properly, can improve training efficiency and outcomes, facilitate better communication and client relationships, and improve the ability to effectively manage more clients. From filming high-quality videos to choosing the correct video conferencing software, this chapter will review the necessary and ancillary technologies that will help fitness professionals develop, run, and scale a successful virtual training business.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Determine hardware, software, and operating system requirements needed to operate a virtual coaching business.

Select an appropriate internet service and computer peripherals to suit the needs of a virtual coaching business.

Identify fitness programming software to help manage and assess client progress.

Introduction

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsIntroductionFitness professionals have an opportunity to use technology to develop, operate, and scale successful virtual training businesses. Clients are increasingly utilizing non-traditional, technologically driven fitness solutions, including mobile workout and food logging apps, wearable fitness technology, and virtual training programming. Accordingly, fitness professionals who are proficient in computer, mobile, and wearable technology can offer viable fitness solutions and meet the rapidly evolving needs of consumers within the digital market. This digital market expands the reach of a fitness professional from what was once just a local impact to now a global one.

Within the fitness industry, fitness professionals might find technology to be a major disruptor to the traditional approaches and methods in the delivery of services and client management. However, as technology continues to advance, fitness professionals have an opportunity to adopt new approaches to engage clients, deliver a quality service, and compete effectively in a demanding market. This chapter will explore the technological infrastructure, including hardware, software, peripherals, Internet service requirements, and wearable fitness technology considerations that are necessary to operate a successful virtual training business.

Viktoria Kazakova/Shutterstock.comTechnology Considerations Checklist A Technology Considerations Checklist is provided for the fitness professional to use throughout the chapter to track technology considerations, notate inventory the fitness professional may already own, and to suggest future technology purchases.

Technology Considerations Checklist

Hardware Requirements

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsHardware Requirements Hardware includes the physical components that are required for a computer system to function. These physical components include a mouse or trackpad, keyboard, screen or monitor, and speakers. In addition, the physical components of processing hardware, which can be thought of like puzzle pieces (Figure: Physical Components of Processing Hardware), include the following:

FigurePhysical Components of Processing Hardware

Computer Processing

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsComputer Processing The first puzzle piece of a computer's hardware requirements is computer processing. When choosing a computer, it is important to ensure the processing capability aligns with the intended use of the machine. A personal home computer used for basic computing, some streaming, and Internet access will have significantly different processing needs than a computer intended for small business use. In order to make the best purchase for building a virtual coaching business, the fitness professional should understand what components and requirements are needed to operate effectively, efficiently, and productively.

The central processing unit, or CPU, is the brain of a computer (Figure: CPU Chip). It carries out and directs all tasks being performed. The faster a CPU is, the faster and more efficiently the computer will run. A fitness professional may be using Excel spreadsheets for exercise programming and have a video being uploaded to their workout directory for clients, while also using instant communication applications on their computer—all of which can consume processing power.

Weera.otp/Shutterstock.comFigureCPU ChipHaving enough processing capacity to keep a computer running at optimal pace, while multiple programs are running, can ensure productive workflow.

CPU speed is currently measured in gigahertz (GHz), but, historically, when processing power was lower, they were in megahertz (MHz). A gigahertz is also known as "Clock Speed." At 2.5 GHz, it is like a clock that ticks 2.5 billion times in a second. Each tick is an opportunity for the CPU to move and modify the smallest fragments of data called bits. The higher the GHz classification for a processor, the quicker a processor can process data and make decisions. Modern computers typically range from 2.0 GHz through to 5 GHz or more as technology advances. While top-of-the-line processor speeds are not needed for virtual coaching, the fitness professional should ensure the machine being purchased has between 2.4 and 4.0 GHz of processing speed.

Getting TechnicalAnother component of CPU technology to consider is how many cores the processor has. Each core can work on a single task. The more cores a processor has, the more tasks a CPU can process. An average computer may come with a dual core processor but can contain more. Ideally, aiming to purchase a machine with four cores or more will help with multitasking and running multiple programs without slowing the computer down.

Central processing unit (CPU)A CPU is the brain of a computer. It carries out and directs all tasks being performed.

GigahertzThe measurement of how fast a computer processor can manage bits of data – a 1.0 GHz processor can process 1 million bits of data per second; a 2.4 GHz processor can process 2.4 million bits of data per second.

BitsThe smallest fragments of computer data.

RAM

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsRAMRAM stands for Random Access Memory and is another piece of the puzzle that makes up a computer system (Figure: RAM). RAM is essentially a computer's short-term memory.

daniiD/Shutterstock.comFigureRAMRAM temporarily stores the information that the computer needs to access immediately or in the near future.

RAM keeps track of everything that is being processed by the computer such as open web browser tabs, a training spreadsheet being edited, or a video being rendered. Instead of the computer going into a hard drive storage device to pull the data it requires, RAM knows what the computer will need next and keeps that information at hand, ready to be used.

For example, RAM is like having a grocery shopping list in hand at the store. Having this list shortens the shopping trip; without it, the shopper would walk aimlessly up and down the aisle trying to remember what is needed for groceries and extend the time spent shopping!

Getting TechnicalRAM is short-term memory, whereas a hard drive is used for long-term storage. In fact, RAM does not actually store anything. RAM is what is considered volatile memory, meaning it loses its data as soon as the power is shut off. The data and information are only housed temporarily, as needed. Hard drives are considered non-volatile memory, meaning the data is stored even when the power is turned off.

RAMRandom Access Memory – A computer's short-term memory for processing immediate and upcoming tasks.

How Much RAM is Needed?

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsHow Much RAM is Needed? RAM is currently measured in Gigabytes (GB). How many GB of RAM a computer has will determine how much data it can temporarily store for instant access as the computer is operating. The amount of RAM needed will depend mainly on what the computer is being used for and the complexity of the program. The more complicated a program becomes the more RAM will be required. A simple program, such as a basic notepad, will not take up much RAM, if any. Complex programs like Excel, Photoshop, or a video-editing software may use gigabytes of RAM by themselves.

With virtual coaching requiring programs like Excel spreadsheets, video editing software, or video conferencing programs that can consume a large amount of RAM by themselves, it is a good idea to ensure you have enough RAM rather than not enough (Table: RAM Recommendations). This can also minimize expensive RAM add-on kits or having to purchase a new computer if there is no option to expand RAM capabilities. It saves money in the long-term and minimizes frustrations with a slow operating computer system.

RAM Recommendations<4 GB

Minimum requirements for operating systems and basic function.

4 GB to 8 GB

Minimum requirements for typical computer use.

8 GB to 16 GB

Provides enough RAM to support most or all tasks except high-end video editing or game rendering.

16 GB or more

Professional-grade editing software, gaming, and content rendering.

Coach’s CornerIn most cases, 8 to 16 GB of RAM will be enough to effectively and efficiently run a virtual coaching business. When purchasing a laptop or desktop, ensuring it has a minimum of 8 GB of RAM, is a great starting point. 16 GB of RAM would be enough for the majority of the process and software requirements for running a virtual coaching business.

Food for ThoughtMore RAM is not always better. While it is a good idea to get more than needed, rather than not enough, getting 32 GB of RAM when the max operating requirements are less than 16 GB may be wasteful. It costs more money and does not make the computer faster unless the software programs actually need 16 GB+ of RAM.

Storage

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsStorageA third piece of the computer hardware requirements puzzle is storage. With virtual coaching, the fitness professional is responsible for not only handling and organizing client information, but also managing and storing business documents such as a business plan, workout demonstration videos, and any of created social media content. From liability and sign up forms, to progress photos, workout plans, and private client information, being able to safely store this data as well as quickly access it as needed is key to running a successful virtual coaching business. There are two main options for data storage (Table: Types of Storage):

Local Data Storage

Cloud or Online Storage

Types of StorageLocal Data Storage

Cloud or Online Storage

What it is

Hard copy of the information or data

Examples include the following:

USB flash drives

Internal hard drives

External hard drives

Information stored on the Internet, on a server

Examples include the following:

Google Drive

Dropbox

iCloud

Accessibility

Harder to access on the go, must carry a physical hard drive

Easy to access on the go from smartphone or laptop

Security

Increased risk of physical drives being stolen, lost, or damaged

Added security because the fitness professional controls who has access to storage devices

No risk of data loss due to mishandling, damage, or loss of a device

Increased risk of data-hacking or online data theft due to third-party servers hosting data

Scalability

Expensive to scale due to needing to use physical hard drives

Physical hard drives take up more physical space

Added cloud storage costs minimal compared to physical hard drives

Speed of Use

Faster than downloading or uploading files from cloud-based storage

Large files can be time consuming to upload or download

Local Storage

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsLocal StorageLocal storage has the benefit of instant access and is typically faster than uploading and downloading information from the cloud. Plus, if an Internet connection goes offline temporarily, a virtual coaching business can still operate because of the data being accessible on demand, as needed. Local storage devices such as thumb drives, the physical storage device on the computer, or an external drive (Figure: Local Storage) are also more secure than cloud storage because information can only be physically accessed with those storage devices in hand. However, if those drives become lost, stolen, or crash, there is a risk of data loss.

There are two main types of hard drives to consider for local storage:

Hard Disk Drive or HDD: A physical disk that spins inside a case where the data is written and erased. They are typically cheaper but also larger and slower than other types of hard drives.

Solid-State Drive or SSD: A solid-state storage device is similar to a thumb drive. It has no moving parts and is faster than a standard HDD but also comes at a higher cost.

Anton Marchenkov/Shutterstock.comFigureLocal StorageFood for ThoughtConsider getting an external hard drive that is kept at home, which regularly backs up all the vital information for running a virtual coaching business. If a computer or phone is lost, or something gets damaged, that external drive will safely store all that data and it is easily accessible.

Hard disk drive (HDD)A data-storage device, which has a physical spinning disk where information or data is stored, written, or deleted.

Solid-state drive (SSD)A data-storage device that uses no physical spinning or moving parts to store, write, or delete data.

Cloud Storage

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsCloud StorageChristian Horz/Shutterstock.comCloud storage has the advantage of being accessed on the go with most cloud services being accessible from a phone or laptop. This means a virtual coaching business can be easily conducted from a smartphone or laptop and a Wi-Fi signal. However, there may be higher security risks with cloud-based storage. Because the data is stored in a third-party system, there may be some added risk of attackers hacking into the system and gaining access to the data (Tujilio et al., 2016). Alongside added security risks, large file uploads and downloads may be more time consuming than transferring between a computer and a physical external hard drive.

When picking a cloud storage service, be mindful of scaling a virtual coaching business. Dropbox and Google Drive both come with word processing and spreadsheet capabilities and a large amount of initial free storage. Google Drive has some added benefits such as integrated e-mail and business services and other professional software such as Google Sheets (spreadsheets), Google Docs (word processing software), and the ability to create forms for collecting client information and sign ups.

Both local storage and cloud storage have their pros and cons, and using a mixed approach of both cloud storage and local storage will be most effective for managing and running a virtual coaching business.

Video Card

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsVideo CardThe final piece, a video card, or graphics card, is hardware that takes all the data from across a computer system and generates it into a visible image on the computer monitor or laptop screen (Figure: Video Card). Most video cards include a stand-alone processing unit, built-in memory that is similar to RAM, and sometimes a cooling fan to help manage temperatures. It is essentially another computer in itself. Just like RAM, a video card is designed to take added stress off the CPU to more efficiently process images and transfer them to the monitor or screen.

teh_z1b/Shutterstock.comFigureVideo CardMany graphics cards will also have additional outputs such as an HDMI connection or VGA connection. HDMI connections transmit both audio and video data, whereas a VGA connection only transmits video data. Some graphics cards will also include an S-video display and USB port, which can connect to digital cameras, webcams, and other peripherals like microphones.

For doing high-quality exercise videos, filming and editing social media content, or creating PowerPoint presentations, the built-in video card that comes with any mid-range desktop or laptop will meet the needs of a virtual coaching business. Upgrading video cards might be considered if the machine being purchased will be used for high-definition video editing, gaming, or other professional editing software uses.

Video cardA video card or graphics card is a piece of hardware that takes all the data from across a computer system and generates it into a visible image on the computer monitor or laptop screen.

Desktop or Laptop?

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 1Hardware RequirementsDesktop or Laptop? A fitness professional should consider whether a desktop computer or laptop computer will be needed to build a virtual coaching business. There is more available processing power in a typical desktop computer than in a laptop computer when looking at a comparable price range. While a laptop has all of the hardware requirements built into it as a complete package, a desktop computer will have an added cost of the wires, monitor, speakers, mouse, and keyboard. Once these pieces are factored in, a high-quality laptop can be purchased for a similar price with more than enough processing capabilities for a virtual coaching business.

If building a virtual coaching business with a home base in mind and mobility is not a primary consideration, a desktop computer will give the most capability to the end user. However, the mobility of a laptop often outweighs the benefits of a desktop computer when it comes to running a virtual coaching business. A laptop can be used in a variety of spaces such as a coffee shop, throughout a home, and when travelling. All that is needed is a stable Internet connection.

Africa Studio/Shuttershock.com

Software Requirements

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsSoftware Requirements Software components are the actual programs running on a computer system to make it function and operate. Software is strings of programming code that are run and processed by the hardware components of the computer system. For example, software is found in the form of operating systems themselves such as Windows Operating System from Microsoft or iOS from Apple, to programs such as the Word processor, Excel, video games, and even just music players. This topic will cover operating systems, video conferencing systems, and other software recommendations to help the fitness professional operate in the virtual coaching space effectively and efficiently.

Operating Software There are currently three major operating systems dominating the market in computer technology. Microsoft with their Windows Operating System, Apple with their iOS and OS-X operating systems, and Linux, which is used as a baseline in many systems like Roku TVs, social media feeds, and smart technology integrated into the automotive industry. In 2019, Microsoft dominated the software industry with a worldwide market share of 77% with Windows and Apple Inc. with OS-X around 17% (Statcounter GlobalStats, 2020). Both Microsoft and Apple operating systems have their own unique pros and cons.

The primary consideration for purchasing a computer system and for which operating system to use will always be governed by the fitness professional's budget. Apple products have always carried a higher price tag when compared to similar performing Windows-based computers.

Aa Amie/Shutterstock.comFood for ThoughtThe 2019 baseline MacBook Air was priced at $1,199 USD in 2019. A similarly performing Windows-based laptop was priced around $200 cheaper. Higher-performing Apple computers can be even more expensive, ranging upward of $2,500 dollars.

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsApple operating systems do come with some extra software and programming that may need to be purchased on a Windows-based operating system. With iMovie, which can be used to edit videos, merge sound clips, and add subtitles, for example, purchasing third-party video editing software may not be needed. However, Windows third-party software compatibility shadows the Apple operating system.

The notable difference between the Windows and Apple operating systems will be in the user experience and interface. For example, the OS-X system from Apple uses a pop-up app dock for favorite apps, whereas Windows OS has a taskbar and a start menu. Windows has a more versatile file management system, whereas OS-X offers a higher degree of integration with other Apple products. While the brands themselves and loyal fans may proclaim that one operating system is better, preference becomes the main determining factor of how to choose which OS to use.

Overall, the main determining factors when choosing an operating system to fit the needs of a virtual coaching business should be the following:

Budget

Intended use, such as added video editing

Ease of use, with peripherals like tablets or wearable fitness trackers

Preference, user experience, and interface

Hardware

Critical!The fitness professional does not need to purchase a new computer or components. Purchasing a preowned computer can save money when on a tighter budget.

Video Conferencing Software

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsVideo Conferencing Software FigureVisual ConnectionsVideo conferencing technology is a critical channel of communication for virtual training. Not only does video conferencing eliminate the barriers of geographical location, it allows fitness professionals to engage and connect with clients in a more meaningful manner.

In a study on processing information, humans process visual information more quickly and capably than through audible or written information (Cohen et al., 2009). This transfers to improved engagement and also client understanding, which are crucial components of successful client outcomes. Regular eye contact throughout video calls may result in higher perceived friendliness and improved information recall. A pleasant, smiling facial expression can indicate openness and positively strengthen the interaction between the fitness professional and the client (Park & Park, 2018) (Figure: Visual Connections).

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsIn addition, studies have shown that body language and tone of voice contribute to 55% and 38%, respectively, of effective communication; while words, such as a phone call or written message, only account for around 7% (Park & Park, 2018). Video conferencing allows the fitness professional, and the client, to convey emotion and tonality in a conversation or virtual training session that may otherwise get lost through other forms of communication. Some examples might include the following:

The fitness professional can sense if the client has encountered some obstacles if the tone of the conversation shifts.

The fitness professional can share in a client's excitement if they hit a personal record in one of their exercises.

The fitness professional can explain and demonstrate proper exercise form.

When having difficult conversations, the client can hear the fitness professional and see if they are paying full attention, helping the client find solutions.

There is no shortage of options when it comes to video conferencing. When choosing a video conferencing software, the user should consider factors such as price, participant and meeting time thresholds, mobile app accompaniment, and other features such as meeting recording. While many video conferencing applications are available for free, it is not uncommon for them to have restrictions on the number of attendees and meeting runtimes. Several software vendors offer the user the ability to upgrade to a paid version, which removes the aforementioned restrictions. The following table outlines some of the more popular options currently available; however, these metrics are subject to change (Table: Comparing Video Conferencing Software). Before choosing a video conferencing service, investigate if the company has changed their terms and conditions.

Comparing Video Conferencing SoftwareSoftware

Paid/Free

Maximum No. of Participants

Maximum Meeting Runtime

Mobile App

Includes Recording Cloud Storage?

Zoom

Free

100

40 min

Y

N

Zoom

Paid

100+

24 hrs

Y

Up to 4 Gb

Web-Ex

Free

100

50 min

Y

N

Web-Ex

Paid

200+

24 hrs

Y

Up to 10 Gb

Google Meet

Free

150

60 min

Y

N

Google Meet

Paid

100+

300 hrs

Y

Y, Varies

Microsoft Teams

Free

50

24 hrs

Y

N

Microsoft Teams

Paid

250+

24 hrs

Y

Varies, paid add-on

Word Processing Software

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsWord Processing SoftwareWord processing software is another common communication tool used in virtual coaching. Word processing software is essential to the development of coaching plans and other personalized content intended for sharing with a client. It can also be used for record keeping and business administration activities such as scheduling and invoicing. Most computers are equipped with a trial version word processing software as a standard feature.

The standard software will vary depending on the operating system. For example, the Windows operating system is commonly equipped with Microsoft Word, whereas the Apple OS-X operating system is commonly equipped with Pages. Most trial version word processing software is restrictive in the features necessary to create, edit, save, and share content, which means the fitness professional may need to purchase additional software.

In addition to standard equipped software or purchased software, a user may choose to use a cloud-based word processing program. While standard equipped word processing software does not vary remarkably between programs, there are considerable differences between a cloud-based and non-cloud-based word processing software, specifically in the ability to collaborate in real time.

When choosing a word processing software, the user should consider cost, compatibility with the operating system, and features. Cloud-based versions of commonly recognized software, such as Microsoft Word or Google Docs, are often seen as advantageous due to the collaboration functionality. This allows multiple users to view and edit documents in real time with 24/7 access by both client and coach and saved version history. This functionality could be viewed as beneficial and more efficient in providing client feedback than a non-cloud-based software.

Spreadsheets

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsSpreadsheetsThe fitness professional would benefit from spreadsheet software. This software can allow the fitness professional to create workout programs, invoice clients, or build client metric monitoring sheets, among many other uses (Figure: Example Spreadsheet). Google Sheets, Numbers from Apple Inc., or Excel from Microsoft are all examples of spreadsheet programs.

This program, alongside a word processing application, may be all a fitness professional needs to operate their business. One consideration, however, if business begins to scale, is that there are apps and coaching software programs that can improve time management and may be easier for the client to use.

PixieMe/Shuttershock.comFigureExample Spreadsheet

Internet Service Requirements

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsInternet Service Requirements The nature of virtual coaching relies on the ability to access the Internet with a reliable connection. Slow or inconsistent connections lead to frustrations for both the client and the fitness professional and can impact quality of service. With many Internet service providers available and variables in delivery of Internet service (fiber optic, cable, or satellite), it can be difficult to choose what is most effective for running a reliable virtual coaching business. The largest determining factor will be what is available in the area where the virtual coaching business is located and how it operates. If the fitness professional lives in a rural area, there might be limits to Internet services such as satellite or dial-up. If the fitness professional is in an urban area, likely there will be access to high-speed cable or fiber optic Internet services with high rates of bandwidth.

Bandwidth is the maximum data transfer rate of a network or Internet connection, in a specific amount of time, or how fast a person can download or upload information to and from the Internet. Bandwidth is measured in megabytes per second or Mbps. A Megabyte (Mb) is broken up into smaller units known as Kilobytes (kbit) and there are 1,000 Kilobytes in each Megabyte of data. Kilobytes are broken up into bits and there are 1000 bits per kilobyte. There is also a Gigabyte, which is 1,000 megabytes (Mb).

BandwidthThe maximum data transfer rate of a network or Internet connection, in a specific amount of time, or how fast Information can be downloaded or uploaded to and from the Internet.

MegabyteA measurement of data, 1,000 kilobytes.

KilobyteA measurement of data, 1,000 bits.

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsThere are some basic considerations for how much bandwidth is needed to operate a virtual coaching business. If providing online group training via a video conferencing platform where most of the data transfer comes from, slower Internet speeds may be utilized without an effect on the user experience. For example, Zoom, Skype, and Google Meet require as little as 1.5 Mbps for voice or low-definition video calls and up to 8 Mbps for large group video conferencing or HD video calling. A 25 Mbps Internet speed may be enough in this case.

If creating video content, performing large live stream feeds, or regularly downloading and uploading large files is integral to how the virtual coaching business is run, getting a higher bandwidth connection can increase productivity. For live-feed video conferencing, a slower Internet speed may impact the video feed quality and end-user experience (Table: Comparing Bandwidth Speed and Download Times).

Comparing Bandwidth Speed and Download TimesLength and Type of Media

Average Size

1 Mbps Connection Speed

5 Mbps Connection Speed

10 Mbps Connection Speed

20 Mbps Connection Speed

100 Mbps Connection Speed

1,000 Mbps Connection Speed

4-min song

4 Mb

30 s

5 s

3 s

1.5 s

0.3 s

0.03 s

10-minute client catch-up video call

30 Mb

3 m

40 s

26 s

13 s

2.5 s

0.2 s

9-hr audiobook

110 Mb

10 m

2 m

1.5 m

46 s

9.2 s

0.9 s

60-min Zoom live workout

200 Mb

20 m

5 m

3 m

1.5 m

16 s

1.7 s

45-min TV show

600 Mb

1 h

15 m

8.5 m

4 m

50 s

5 s

2-hr movie

1.0 to 1.5 Gb

2 h

24 m

21.6 m

10.5 m

1.5 m

8 s

10-minute HD 1080p workout video

4.0 Gb

6 h

72 m

60 m

32 m

4.4 m

25 s

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 2Software RequirementsDial-up will have the slowest rates of bandwidth at just 56 kbits or 0.056 Mbps. When compared to the U.S. average broadband speed of around 135 Mbps, dial up is over 2,000 times slower. Just 0.3% of the U.S. is still using dial-up Internet. This is just enough to do basic tasks like answer e-mails and read webpages on the Internet at a slow pace. While dial-up is still available in some rural places, this Internet connection would not be suitable for running a virtual coaching business.

Satellite Internet is used by 6.9% of the U.S. population (Clement, 2019) and has a limitation of around 100 Mbps, with most services capping around 25Mbps. While this is enough to run a virtual coaching business, satellite Internet may be more expensive and less reliable than a cable or fiber Internet connection. Satellite Internet also operates on the line-of-sight principle. Meaning the satellites must be able to physically see each other to form a connection. A simple storm with poor weather conditions can knock out the Internet connection due to the satellites not being able to connect. This can make running a business a hassle if the connection to the Internet is unreliable. Additionally, satellite Internet tends to be more expensive.

Broadband Internet connections such as DSL, fiber optics, and cable Internet will be the fastest, most reliable, and often cheapest Internet connections to choose from. With bandwidth speeds from 25 Mbps to 1,000+ Mbps and reliable connections that do not rely on line-of-sight, a virtual coaching business can operate efficiently and reliably.

In order to be effective, efficient, and productive, consider signing up with an Internet service provider that can provide 25 to 75 Mbps of bandwidth. This will ensure smooth operation when uploading training videos, administering virtual coaching sessions, or performing video consultations.

Try ThisTry searching for “Internet Speed Test,” and then test your current Internet speed. If it is running less than 25 Mbps, it may be time for you to upgrade your Internet package or Internet service provider.

Computer Peripheral Requirements

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsComputer Peripheral Requirements Andrii Zastrozhnov/Shutterstock.comBy now, the fitness professional should be able to determine what hardware and software requirements are needed, how much bandwidth is needed to run a business, and what operating systems are preferred when purchasing a computer. One last consideration is computer peripherals, which may help with producing and delivering quality content to the client. The fitness professional should remember that these additional peripherals are not requirements but, rather, components that contribute to producing and delivering higher-quality content. A fitness professional may be able to start and operate a virtual coaching business solely using a smartphone and then upgrade as their budget allows.

Computer peripherals include the following:

Lighting

Cameras

Microphones

LightingA major consideration for creating high-quality, deliverable digital content is lighting. Lighting may impact overall content quality, considering that not all training facilities or office spaces will have adequate lighting. A lack of bright natural light when filming technique videos, live workouts, or virtual coaching sessions can be a major distraction. The fitness professional should mitigate this with a well-lit environment.

The main factors to consider when purchasing lighting peripherals are:

Lighting Spectrum

Budget and Portability

Lighting Spectrum

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsLighting Spectrum Lighting spectrum or color temperature is what hue of color is being provided by a light source. Degrees of Kelvin (K) is how the appearance of light is measured. Kelvin is measured from 1,000 K up to 10,000 K. The lower end of the Kelvin spectrum has a far-red tinge to it. The high end of the Kelvin spectrum has a blue overtone.

The typical lighting spectrums used in video content is between 3,200 K and 5,500 K. The 3,200 K lighting spectrum is typically associated with indoor lighting and indoor scenes; it will be warmer in color with a higher degree of orange or yellow. The 5,500 K spectrum is a cooler light that is mostly bluish-white and is representative of midday daylight. Too low of a lighting spectrum will produce more flat colors and may create unnatural skin tone, while too high of a lighting spectrum will lack warmth and be harsh to look at.

The 5,600 K spectrum may be more optimal for use where there is a lower level of light or in indoor settings where incandescent bulbs or soft, warm lighting may be used. The midday lighting spectrum will help produce a brighter, more natural and balanced feel. The warmer 3,200 K spectrum may be more optimal for use where there is harsh white light such as under fluorescent bulbs or when filming in brightly lit locations. The warmer spectrum may reduce the harsh look that higher spectrum lighting may produce.

Many of the available lighting options will have adjustability from 3,200 K to 5,600 K, which means the fitness professional will be able to adjust the lighting spectrum accordingly for where they will be filming the majority of their content. Having this adjustability can minimize purchasing extra equipment or lighting options.

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsTable: Light Source Examples and Color Temperature compares light sources and their color temperature, whereas Figure: Color Temperature in Kelvin shows a visual representation of the color change through the Kelvin (K) scale.

Light Source Examples and Color TemperatureLight Source Example

Color Temperature in Kelvin (K)

Blue Sky

10,000 K

Shade on Sunny Day

8,000 K

Overcast Sky

6,000 K

Natural Daylight

5,500 K

Incandescent Bulb

3,400 K

Sunrise and Sunset

3,200 K

Candle

1,500 K

FigureColor Temperature in KelvinGetting TechnicalLighting spectrum also interacts with camera settings and can help improve the end product. There are several online resources available that provide in-depth discussions and tutorials regarding this topic.

Budget and Portability

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsBudget and PortabilityProducing high-quality content that is valuable to the client does not require purchasing high-end equipment. While there is studio quality lighting available at a steep price, a fitness professional just starting out who is looking to film training videos and perform virtual coaching sessions will not need such high-end equipment. Building a virtual coaching business also means building a business that is portable. With much of the technology to run a business being available on a smartphone, tablet, or laptop, working on the go will present some added challenges if it means having to carry around bulky equipment.

With budget and portability in mind, the fitness professional may find appropriate solutions in portable ring lights or clip-on smartphone lights that are both compact and effective in meeting lighting requirements and lighting spectrum applications. The ring lights are typically adjustable (Figure: Ring Light), while the clip-on lights may not be (Figure: Clip-On Light). However, these lights can work in the gym when filming training content, at home when performing video consultation calls, or when administering virtual coaching sessions to the client.

Some free or low-budget solutions to lighting might be as simple as opting to film content in a(n):

Brighter location on sunny days

Office that has a large amount of natural daylight

Room utilizing a lamp fixture with a cool white bulb installed and the lampshade removed

While these options may be less-optimal, they can help the fitness professional create higher-quality content without investing too much into equipment.

Genzi/Shutterstock.comFigureRing LightVetertravel/Shutterstock.comFigureClip-On Light

Camera

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsCameraOne struggle that the fitness professional may encounter when building a virtual coaching business is that it lacks the same face-to-face contact as in-person fitness coaching. With over 50% of human communication conveyed through body language (Park & Park, 2018), being able to film quality workout videos, take photos for demonstrations, perform video consultation calls, and have regular video check-ins may provide higher client engagement.

The considerations when looking for a camera include the following:

Megapixel (MP) rating of the camera

Video recording resolution

Budget

Megapixel Rating While a bit of data is the smallest portion of data that a computer processes, a pixel is the smallest portion of an image. They are tiny little dots or squares of color that, when put together, make up an image. A digital image may look similar to a regular image but when zoomed in close enough, a digital image is made up of millions of these tiny squares. A megapixel is 1 million pixels, and the more megapixels in an image, the more detail and clarity an image will have. Notice that in Figure: Close-Up of Pixels, each little dot is actually a little square of color.

Pikepicture/Shutterstock.comFigureClose-Up of PixelsThe megapixel rating of a camera will have a determinant effect on the quality of the photos being taken. While there is no set recommendation for how many megapixels are needed for creating content, generally speaking, a camera with a higher number of megapixels will take higher-quality photos than a camera with a lower megapixel rating. The fitness professional should consider purchasing a camera with the highest megapixel rating that is within their budget.

PixelThe smallest portion of an image. They are tiny little dots or squares of color that, when put together, make up an image.

Megapixel1 million pixels put together, a measure of image resolution or graphic resolution.

Video Resolution

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsVideo ResolutionVideo resolution is another representation of image quality. The higher the video resolution, the higher the video quality. Much like an image is made from pixels, video resolution relates to how many pixels the video image has both in horizontal count and vertical count. 720p, 1080p, and 4K ultra HD are the most common resolutions for video content. Most modern digital cameras will have at minimum 1080p full HD video resolution capabilities and that is really all that would be needed for filming video content, conducting virtual coaching sessions, or performing video consultation calls. Table: Comparing Different Video Resolutions explains these different video resolutions.

Comparing Different Video ResolutionsResolution

Horizontal Pixels x Vertical Pixels

Total Number of Pixels

Other names

720p

1,280 x 720 pixels

921,600 pixels

High-Definition

1080p

1,920 x 1,080 pixels

2,073,600 pixels

Full High-Definition

4K

3,840 x 2,160 pixels

8,294,400 pixels

Ultra High-Definition

Budget and Peripherals

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsBudget and Peripherals Budget is the final consideration when purchasing a camera for a virtual coaching business. There are a few camera styles to look at and the fitness professional should do their own research to determine what is best for their needs and what is available within their price range.

DSLR camera: Professional quality photos, typically films video in HD, higher price point, and may need to buy attachments

Hand-held digital camera: Lower-quality but hand-held, no additional lenses needed, and reasonably priced

Smartphone camera: Newer phones will have all of the features needed to produce high-quality video and images

Getting TechnicalThe iPhone has had HD 1,080 p recording capabilities since the iPhone 5 was released in late 2012, and Samsung, with their S4 in spring of 2013, also has 1,080 p HD recording capabilities. Earlier phones still had a respectable 8-megapixel rating and 13-megapixel rating for the S4. However, these earlier smartphones may not have some functionality like changing specific settings or auto-focus that newer smartphones may have. While there is no standard recommendation for megapixel requirements for high-quality photos, most smartphones will have a 10+ megapixel camera. If the fitness professional has a relatively new smartphone, they will be able to shoot, record, edit, and upload much of their content right from the smartphone itself.

One upgrade to consider when using a camera for recording content or even taking photographs is to purchase a quality tripod. Options vary on this due to the variety of brands and models of cameras and smartphones. It will be up to the fitness professional to research what will work best with their camera or smartphone.

In addition to capturing quality content, most laptops will have a built-in webcam. Most newer computers will have a webcam with at least 720p HD resolution for filming. While 720p is considered a lower-quality resolution for filming, a camera with a 720p resolution is still usable to get started with filming content for a virtual coaching business. There are also a multitude of USB webcam options available that will plug into the fitness professional's computer system and may have higher resolution ratings. A webcam is a lower-budget option that can easily improve content quality without a large initial expense.

Audio

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsAudioWhen filming or recording high-quality content for a virtual coaching business, fitness professionals should ensure that the sound quality of the content being produced is considered. Poor audio quality or videos with excessive background noise may lead to the client retaining less of the information and impair learning and communication (Klatte et al., 2013). This may lead to added struggles and create a discord between the client and the fitness professional. Purchasing a microphone can help create a quality audio feed when recording content such as podcasts, training videos, and voice-overs, and when performing virtual coaching sessions.

There are two main types of microphones to consider:

Dynamic Microphones

Condenser Microphones

Dynamic microphones are the types of microphones one might see being used by a singer or comedian performing on stage (Figure: Dynamic Microphone). These microphones tend to do better than condenser microphones in environments that have a higher level of background noises. That is why dynamic microphones are used in concerts, during stand-up shows, or interviewing somebody on the street. They contain a coil and magnet inside that are sensitive to sound vibrations.

Dynamic microphones are also more rugged than condenser microphones, so, if the microphone gets dropped, there may be less worry of damage and having to replace an expensive peripheral. These microphones are relatively cheap compared to condenser microphones and require no extra equipment. They can sit at a desk in the quiet to be used for podcast recordings or used in a noisy environment such as filming workout videos.

Soonios Pro/Stuttershock.comFigureDynamic MicrophoneKrakenimages.com/Shutterstock.comFigureCondenser MicrophoneCondenser microphones work slightly differently than their dynamic counterpart (Figure: Condenser Microphone). Condenser microphones do not contain a coil and magnet and instead use capacitor plates, which are more sensitive to the smaller sound vibrations than a dynamic microphone. This can help pick up the subtle differences in a voice and may be better for recording a podcast in a quiet area. Condenser microphones are also not as durable as a dynamic microphone due to their construction using capacitor plates. Condenser microphones may also need an external power source or internal battery to operate. Depending on the type of microphone purchased may mean hidden equipment costs such as extra audio equipment. However, condenser microphones that are powered by battery or USB plug-in are becoming more available making these microphones a viable option for fitness professionals without added costs.

Content

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 3Computer Peripheral RequirementsThe next consideration for microphones is whether to choose a USB microphone or an XLR microphone. Simply put, a USB microphone will plug right into the computer, an XLR microphone will need an audio interface between the computer and the microphone (Figure: USB Microphone). A USB microphone is simple and considered plug and play, with no additional software, drivers, or expensive audio interface systems. XLR microphones can become more expensive due to both initial purchase of the microphone and required add-ons needed to operate (Figure: XLR Microphone). However, XLR microphones (dynamic or condenser) will produce a higher-quality sound than a USB microphone.

Random Photo Gallery/Shutterstock.comFigureUSB MicrophoneSockagphoto/Shutterstock.comFigureXLR MicrophoneOne final option is to simply use a smartphone with a voice recording app. Fitness professionals should be mindful that this option will not produce the highest-quality audio recordings. Most smartphones come with a voice recording app that may have adjustable settings. There are also third-party apps that may increase recording sound quality. The fitness professional should research what may be best for this option.

If the fitness professional is also filming live workouts or doing large group instruction over video conference software, purchasing an additional wearable microphone may be needed and can improve audio quality and engagement with the clients (Figure: Wearable Microphone).

The Table: Dynamic Microphone Versus Condenser Microphone compares and contrasts the pros and cons of microphones. The fitness professional can use this as a guide before purchasing a microphone.

Di Studio/Shutterstock.comFigureWearable MicrophoneDynamic Microphone Versus Condenser MicrophoneDynamic Microphone

Condenser Microphone

Budget: When considering budget, how the microphone connects is important. USB will be plug and play, whereas XLR microphones need an interface to record.

A dynamic microphone will typically be cheaper than a condenser microphone. Using a dynamic microphone with a USB connection will be budget friendly and plug and play with no audio interface needed.

Condenser microphones are generally more expensive than a dynamic microphone. A condenser microphone that uses an XLR connection may be expensive due to initial costs because of the added audio interface that is required for XLR microphones.

Environment Considerations: Where is the audio being recorded?

A dynamic microphone will be better suited for noisy environments.

A condenser microphone will be better suited for quiet environments.

Durability: Will the fitness professional be travelling around?

A dynamic microphone is more rugged than a condenser microphone and may be better suited to the more-mobile fitness professional.

A condenser is well-suited for the less-mobile fitness professional.

Fitness Programming Software Options

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsFitness Programming Software Options There are a multitude of fitness, nutrition, and workout apps available for both the client and the fitness professional to utilize in reaching their health and fitness goals. Studies have shown that people may have greater adherence to their health goals when using mobile health apps to self-monitor and stay accountable (Voth et al., 2016). While no single app, no matter how good it is, can replace a qualified and effective fitness professional, using these apps may increase a client's engagement and adherence to their program.

ZinetroN/Shutterstock.comNutrition Apps While tracking nutritional intake has numerous benefits, many of the new apps do much more than simply count calories. This can be especially important for those who are trying to lose weight, build muscle, or improve athletic performance. Nutritional apps are beneficial for the following reasons:

Meal planning

Understanding and counting calories

Reading and understanding food labels

Tracking macronutrient intake (protein, carbohydrates, and fat)

Tracking nutritional content (vitamins, minerals, and fiber)

Making healthier food choices

Fueling workouts

Finding recipes

Forming positive eating habits

Coach's CornerThe fitness professional should remember that when recommending that clients track or monitor meals away from home or at restaurants, there can be an 8 to 18% difference in what is indicated on the label versus the actual calories being eaten, and, in some cases, there can be up to 200% more calories. (Urban et al., 2010) All it takes is a heavy-handed chef to add a little extra oil or sauce to a dish to increase the calorie value of a meal. It may be a good idea to have the client over-estimate meals out by 30% and also account for an additional 100 to 200 calories worth of fat from oil or butters being used. The fitness professional and client should work together to help estimate the calorie content of food.

Fitness Apps

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsFitness Apps Fitness apps are downloadable applications that can be used on nearly any mobile device and are designed to help users obtain certain fitness goals. A fitness app is an inexpensive and convenient way for fitness enthusiasts to take their workouts with them and include a variety of exercise formats, including high-intensity interval training (HIIT), strength training, yoga, and Pilates.

The benefits of fitness apps include the following:

Access to exercise routines anytime or anywhere with a computer, tablet, or smartphone

Personalized fitness programs based on the user's goals and exercise preferences

Access to exercise programs that do not require equipment

Tracking completed workouts and time spent exercising

Daily/weekly/monthly reminders to complete workout routines

Simulation of one-on-one or group training

Tracking steps taken each day

Tracking calories expended from physical activity

Tracking fitness achievements like miles run or weight lifted

Instructing proper exercise technique

There are several fitness apps on the market today and many have free trial periods. Individuals can test several applications to determine which app best fits their needs. Remember that individuals with chronic disease may need medical clearance before starting a new exercise routine. In addition, performing exercise routines without supervision can be dangerous, especially for those new to exercise.

NASM EDGE App NASM has their own app for fitness professionals called NASM EDGE (Figure: NASM EDGE 1 & 2).

The NASM EDGE app has the following features:

Exercise Video Library: Assess and share the hundreds of NASM expert-approved exercises.

Calorie and Macronutrient Calculator: Give clients confidence with nutrition advice that aligns with their goals.

Workout Builder: Create customized workouts or use ready-to-go training sessions designed by NASM experts.

Integrated Client Dashboard: Keep track of clients and monitor their real-time performance, compare dynamic assessments, and send clients workouts.

Assessment Wizard: Remove any uncertainty out of client assessments while performing them quickly and effectively.

The app also has a built-in Certified Personal Trainer (CPT) prep tool for those studying for their NASM-CPT examination. The prep tool includes over 600 practice questions, over 500 flash cards, and an unlimited number of attempts on the NASM practice exam.

FigureNASM EDGE 1FigureNASM EDGE 2

Wearables

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsWearables Wearable fitness technology has been around as early as 1981, when Olympic medalists were using wearable heart rate monitors. Commercial gyms started seeing wireless heart rate monitors in the early 2000s being integrated into group workout classes. Since 2010, when Fitbit released the first clip-on pedometer, technology has gone from basic step counting to tracking heart rate, sleep, energy expenditure, and even GPS tracking.

Clients can track virtually every meaningful data point about themselves, which can be helpful but can also provide additional confusion in an already overwhelming abundance of information. Keep in mind, the current body of evidence is mixed regarding the weight-loss and health benefits from wearable fitness technology (Jo et al., 2019). While the direct benefits for the client may still be in question from a research perspective, there are valuable metrics that can be tracked such as heart rate, sleep, and energy expenditure. The fitness professional can use this information to help customize and evaluate exercise programs. When considering what is best for a client, note that some of the metrics being tracked by wearable technology will be more accurate than others.

Heart Rate wavebreakmedia/Shutterstock.comThere are multiple studies showing that heart rate monitoring will be most accurate at rest or at moderate activity levels, with accuracy decreasing as exercise intensity increases (Khushhal et al., 2017). If a client is doing higher-intensity or long-duration cardiovascular training such as cycling or running, a better option to recommend is a fitness tracker that comes with a wearable heart rate chest strap (Reddy et al., 2018). If a client is looking for general heart rate monitoring, a wristband style fitness tracker will suffice.

Energy Expenditure Many fitness trackers will estimate total daily energy expenditure (TDEE) and provide the end user with a calorie burn count at the end of each day. How accurate is this measure of TDEE? Studies show that most wearable fitness trackers have a range of accuracy and, much like heart rate, as exercise intensity increases, measured energy expenditure accuracy may decrease (Kendall et al., 2019). When compared to research-grade fitness trackers, resting calorie expenditure may be close. However, these devices tend to overestimate time spent in higher-intensity activities, which leads to higher-than-actual energy expenditures being reported by the wearables (Feehan et al., 2018). This simply means that current wearables may do well at calculating energy expenditure at rest, but the level of accuracy decreases as exercise intensity increases. One study showed a 20 to 50% difference in actual calories expended versus what the wearables listed when recording energy expenditure during resistance training (Bai et al., 2016). However, it is important to note that the quality of the device's electronics and algorithms have a fundamental influence on the accuracy of the device. In other words, some wearables are more accurate than others. Due to the high degree of inconsistency across wearable fitness trackers, fitness professionals should use caution when relying on this information.

Energy expenditureThe number of calories burned over a specified period of time at a given intensity of movement.

Total daily energy expenditure (TDEE)The number of calories a person burns over a 24-hr period.

Step Counters/Pedometers

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsStep Counters/Pedometers Most step counters are fairly accurate when it comes to measuring stride length and accurately representing step counts, with an average error of 3 to 6% on some brands (Feehan et al., 2018). There are also multiple studies that show an improvement in all-cause mortality that is associated with higher step counts (Dwyer et al., 2015). In addition to the health benefits of a higher step count, monitoring step counts can help a fitness professional monitor for a subconscious decrease in Non-Exercise Activity Thermogenesis (NEAT) that is often associated with weight-loss-based goals among clients (Trexler et al., 2014).

Kaspars Grinvalds/Shutterstock.comNEAT includes all movements and activities of daily living that are not structured exercise such as fidgeting, performing household chores, grooming, and pacing. If a client starts out at a 10,000-per-day step count average at the start of a weight-loss program and through their program ends up subconsciously reducing step counts to 7,000 per day, there may be a notable difference in TDEE. By monitoring step counts, clients can be encouraged to move more and avoid this downward metabolic adaptation that occurs while working to achieve a fat-loss-related goal. This is where wearable fitness technology excels in terms of accuracy, alongside being the most usable data for the fitness professional.

Coach's CornerThe fitness professional should always try to meet the client where they are at when it comes to step counts. Assigning a 10,000-per-day step count to a client who is only achieving 2,000 steps per day may feel overwhelming to the client. Try to encourage the client to move more where they can while helping them understand NEAT can impact daily energy expenditure. Set small goals, even just 5 to 10 minutes of extra movement a day may contribute greatly to overall step counts over a week.

SleepOne very popular function of many fitness trackers that has evolved over time is the ability to monitor sleep. Sleep impacts appetite (Brondel et al., 2010) and hunger and can affect the client's rate of recovery from their training sessions. Most fitness trackers have sleep monitors that are shown to be relatively accurate when compared to self-reported sleep time (Lee et al., 2018).

Andrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comWhile the sleep trackers on wearable fitness technology may not be on par with the technology used to monitor sleep in clinical research studies, for the client and the fitness professional, the accuracy of sleep tracking in wearable fitness technology will suffice in assessing sleep hygiene. Monitoring a client's sleeping patterns may help the client to improve sleep hygiene and overall sleep quality.

Food for Thought6 hours and 40 minutes is the average amount of sleep an American gets (Sleep Foundation, 2014).

Non-exercise activity thermogenesis (NEAT)The measurement of energy expenditure from all other movements outside of intentional exercise activity.

Integrating Apps and Wearables Into Business

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsIntegrating Apps and Wearables Into Business Whether using the NASM Edge App, third-party client management software, or any of the other apps listed, it is important for the fitness professional to understand how to best use these integrations when operating a business. Remember that apps and software programs have their advantages and disadvantages and there is no one correct approach for building a virtual coaching business. Budget, business scaling, client population, and ease of client use all play a role in determining which programs and apps to use. For example, when getting started, a fitness professional may choose to simply use spreadsheets for workouts and nutrition tracking. This simple system can be a low-cost solution for the fitness professional and can help their clients build effective health habits. Over time, integrating wearables such as a pedometer or activity tracker can help the client more accurately track their physical activity and will add additional value.

If a fitness professional is working with a higher client load or scaling a business and building a team of coaches, using an all-in-one client management software program may lead to a more scalable and productive approach. All-in-one client management software systems may incorporate the functions a fitness professional may need:

Billing and invoicing systems

Client reminder and check-in systems

Brand customization

Nutrition tracking

Syncing with wearable fitness to track activity

Workout videos and exercise programming tools

Even if the fitness professional is not operating with a high volume of clients, many of the benefits that client management software systems offer will help a small-scale online business run smoothly and productively.

The software and app options are major considerations for creating the foundations of client management and a professionally delivered coaching experience in a virtual coaching business. Each client management software system has their own unique features; therefore, it is important to conduct further research and consider all aspects that will be needed for operating a virtual coaching business.

While these options and recommendations have the fitness professional in mind, it is also important to consider the client when using these different approaches. The less-complicated the system being used, the lower the barrier of effort it will be for the client. This lower barrier of effort for coaching interaction means a client can focus on the coaching itself rather than learning a complicated system. For some, filling out spreadsheets may be an effortless portion of their check-ins, but for others it may be a barrier of effort that causes additional struggles in adherence to the coaching program. Using a simple system such as a client management software program may allow the fitness professional to reduce time spent performing other tasks and give their clients a higher level of service. It also may reduce these critical barriers of effort for the client.

Summary

Chapter 3Technology Considerations Lesson 4Fitness Programming Software OptionsSummaryThis chapter outlined what hardware, software, and peripherals are needed to deliver a highly professional and individualized coaching experience to the client.

Fitness professionals who offer virtual coaching must become knowledgeable about computer hardware and software systems. These systems include computer processing and storage, operating software, lighting, and cameras.

Fitness professionals must also acquire basic knowledge of fitness programming software, including nutrition and fitness apps and wearable technology.

Technology considerations when building a virtual coaching business are an important part of delivering a high-quality and personalized service to a client. With technology becoming more prevalent within the fitness industry, the fitness professional who can adapt and grow with these ever-changing technologies can build a successful and sustainable virtual coaching business. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH300:06:00Chapter 3 ReferencesBai, Y., Welk, G. J., Nam, Y. H., Lee, J. A., Lee, J.-M., Kim, Y., Meier, N.F. & Dixon, P. M. (2016). Comparison of Consumer and Research Monitors under Semistructured Settings. Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise, 48(1): 151–158. https://doi.org/10.1249/MSS.0000000000000727

Brondel, L., Romer, M. A., Nougues, P. M., Touyarou, P., & Davenne, D. (2010). Acute partial sleep deprivation increases food intake in healthy men. The American Journal of Clinical Nutrition, 91(6): 1550–1559. https://doi.org/10.3945/ajcn.2009.28523

Clement, J. (2019, Dec.). U.S. household internet subscription types 2017. Retrieved from https://www.statista.com/statistics/185602/broadband-and-dial-up-internet-connection-usage-in-the-us/

Cohen, M. A., Horowitz, T. S., & Wolfe, J. M. (2009). Auditory recognition memory is inferior to visual recognition memory. Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America, 106(14): 6008–6010. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.0811884106

Dwyer, T., Pezic, A., Sun, C., Cochrane, J., Venn, A., Srikanth, V., Jones, G., Shook, R., Sui, X., Ortaglia, A., Blair, S., & Ponsonby, A.-L. (2015). Objectively Measured Daily Steps and Subsequent Long-Term All-Cause Mortality: The Tasped Prospective Cohort Study. PloS One, 10(11): e0141274. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0141274

Feehan, L. M., Geldman, J., Sayre, E. C., Park, C., Ezzat, A. M., Yoo, J. Y., Hamilton, C. B., & Li, L. C. (2018). Accuracy of Fitbit Devices: Systematic Review and Narrative Syntheses of Quantitative Data. JMIR mHealth and uHealth, 6(8): e10527. https://doi.org/10.2196/10527

Jo, A., Coronel, B. D., Coakes, C. E., & Mainous, A. G., III. (2019). Is There a Benefit to Patients Using Wearable Devices Such as Fitbit or Health Apps on Mobiles? A Systematic Review. The American Journal of Medicine, 132(12): 1394–1400. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.amjmed.2019.06.018

Kendall, B., Bellovary, B., & Gothe, N. P. (2019). Validity of wearable activity monitors for tracking steps and estimating energy expenditure during a graded maximal treadmill test. Journal of Sports Sciences, 37(1): 42–49. https://doi.org/10.1080/02640414.2018.1481723

Khushhal, A., Nichols, S., Evans, W., Gleadall-Siddall, D. O., Page, R., O'Doherty, A. F., Carroll, S., Ingle, L., & Abt, G. (2017). Validity and Reliability of the Apple Watch for Measuring Heart Rate During Exercise. Sports Medicine International Open, 1(6): E206–E211. https://doi.org/10.1055/s-0043-120195

Klatte, M., Bergström, K., & Lachmann, T. (2013). Does noise affect learning? A short review on noise effects on cognitive performance in children. Frontiers in Psychology, 4: 578. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00578

O'Dea, S. (2020). Average internet connection speed in the U.S. 2007–2017. Retrieved from https://www.statista.com/statistics/616210/average-internet-connection-speed-in-the-us/

Park, S. G., & Park, K. H. (2018). Correlation between nonverbal communication and objective structured clinical examination score in medical students. Korean Journal of Medical Education, 30(3): 199–208. https://doi.org/10.3946/kjme.2018.94

Reddy, R. K., Pooni, R., Zaharieva, D. P., Senf, B., El Youssef, J., Dassau, E., Doyle Iii, F. J., Clements, M. A., Rickels, M. R., Patton, S. R., Castle, J. R., Riddell, M. C., & Jacobs, P. G.. (2018). Accuracy of Wrist-Worn Activity Monitors During Common Daily Physical Activities and Types of Structured Exercise: Evaluation Study. JMIR mHealth and uHealth, 6(12): e10338. https://doi.org/0.2196/10338

Statcounter GlobalStats (2020). Desktop Operating System Market Share Worldwide. Retrieved from https://gs.statcounter.com/os-market-share/desktop/worldwide

Trexler, E. T., Smith-Ryan, A. E. & Norton, L. E. (2014). Metabolic adaptation to weight loss: implications for the athlete. Journal of the International Society of Sports Nutrition, 11(7). https://doi.org/10.1186/1550-2783-11-7

Urban, L. E., Dallal, G. E., Robinson, L. M., Ausman, L. M., Saltzman, E., & Roberts, S. B. (2010). The accuracy of stated energy contents of reduced-energy, commercially prepared foods. Journal of the American Diet Association, 110(1): 116–123. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jada.2009.10.003

Voth, E. C., Oelke, N. D., & Jung, M. E. (2016). A Theory-Based Exercise App to Enhance Exercise Adherence: A Pilot Study. JMIR mHealth and uHealth, 4(2): e62. https://doi.org/10.2196/mhealth.4997

Chapter 4: Communication and Coaching Strategies

Chapter 4: Communication and Coaching Strategies

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Chapter 4: Communication and Coaching StrategiesCommunication is necessary to establish and maintain a trusting fitness professional–client relationship. The convenience and efficiency associated with online communication are equally matched by the difficulties of establishing credibility, building client relationships, and motivational coaching. This chapter will review best practices for virtual communication from the initial visit to explaining programs and maintaining compliance.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Determine how to use virtual communication platforms to establish the fitness professional-client relationship.

Discover ways to build rapport, motivate, and set goals virtually with a client.

Analyze client accountability in a virtual environment.

Introduction

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101IntroductionCommunication plays a tremendous role in the relationship fitness professionals have with their clients. With in-person training, fitness professionals often rely on a combination of non-verbal and verbal communication strategies to relay instructions, cues, incentives, and enthusiasm. However, there has been a shift in fitness service offerings due to advances in technology and alterations in lifestyle factors. In-person training environments are now also offered in hybrid or fully virtual, online training formats. Therefore, fitness professionals should be familiar with various forms of communication and learn how to tailor different technologies and methods of communicating to achieve greater success for their clients.

Online platforms have opened more environments and increased opportunities to cultivate client relationships to help clients reach their goals. The fitness professional should work at not only developing the technical skills to navigate online training, but also how to interview, build rapport, and set goals with clients. While there are many common elements between in-person and online training, there are distinct differences as well—requiring fitness professionals who train clients virtually to place greater focus on developing skills to combat distraction and maintain excellent client connection.

This chapter will address core principles of virtual communications. The fitness professional will be able to use this information to guide interactions with clients from consultation to regular check-ins. While the technical aspects of training, like data collection and sheet creation, are important to working and tracking progress with clients, ultimately, it all comes down to the relationship the fitness professional is able to build and maintain with the client.

Virtual Communication 101

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Virtual Communication 101Any method where individuals use technology to communicate with each other without meeting face-to-face is considered a virtual environment. These environments will vary based on services provided and the technology available for the fitness professional and potential clients. It is estimated that roughly 81% of Americans go online daily with upwards of 43% going multiple times per day (Perrin et al., 2018). Fitness professionals have the ability to reach millions of people online and to help them shape their goals using a wide variety of communication platforms.

Advantages and DisadvantagesFitness professionals who offer, or plan to offer, virtual programming and coaching services must understand the advantages and disadvantages of virtual communication. There can be misconceptions regarding working with clients online, from a distance (i.e., thinking it is easier due to the ability for fitness professionals to stay in their home or gym while working with the client). However, for every advantage virtual training may afford, there may be an equal number of disadvantages (Table: Virtual Communication Advantages and Disadvantages). The fitness professional should take stock of the range of potential issues they will face using a distance coaching platform.

Virtual Communication Advantages and DisadvantagesAdvantages

Disadvantages

Clients can reread instructions and guidelines.

Can lack in-person connection and interpretation of body language.

Clients can provide in-depth details regarding their needs or questions.

Can lack immediate feedback depending on communication format.

Fitness professionals can provide in-depth details regarding their plans and instructions.

Some clients or fitness professionals may find lack of in-person communication more challenging.

Materials and records are easily stored.

Some clients may not take a virtual commitment as seriously as an in-person commitment.

Both the client and fitness professional have time and opportunity to collect and articulate their thoughts.

Tonality may be lost or misconstrued in text-based communication.

Fitness professionals can reach a wider audience. Clients have vast resources and have the ability to stay in their own environment (Khorzoghi et al., 2018).

Some less technologically savvy clients may struggle with navigation of online platforms.

Virtual environmentA method where individuals use technology to communicate with each other without meeting face-to-face.

Communication Platforms

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Communication PlatformsThe method the fitness professional uses to connect with a client will depend on the technical aspects of their online setup and if they work for themselves or with a company. There are a variety of communication platforms the fitness professional can use; in fact, it is not uncommon to use more than one to service clients. It is important to understand how each platform works in order to assess which one will work best for the fitness professional and their clients depending on the situation and program needs.

For example, one type of communication platform is a mobile app. NASM's EDGE app allows fitness professionals to access client information, use and perform assessments, and tailor workouts all from one platform interface. While this app services a certain set of needs and requirements, each fitness professional will want to determine the right system and communication platform from which to deliver their programs and services (Table: Communication Platforms).

Communication Platforms

Email is the most common application for communicating with online clients. In 2018, over 281 billion emails were sent and received each day (Clement, 2019). It is also the most personal form of virtual communication and often easy to use. In its most simple use, an online fitness professional needs only an email address to start working with clients virtually. Using email for client communication comes with many benefits, including accessibility. For instance, when people go online, they often start with e-mail.

Email also decreases the chance of technology fumbles and errors or the need for third-party communication systems. Email provides a clear one-on-one platform for talking between clients and fitness professionals and builds a foundation for confidentiality and trust in the relationship.

Online communities or apps can include private company memberships or social media platforms like Facebook. With private company membership, a fitness professional can have their own membership site or app where individuals can access their information and update and share results with their fitness professional and often other members. With certain apps and membership groups, fitness professionals have the capability of delivering programs, exercise videos, and nutritional information and to track their client's data while also allowing the client to see and track the data themselves.

With social media supported groups like Facebook, individuals can receive support, links, and updates just as with the private community; however, the fitness professional and company leader do not control the design or updates of the space. There are also few ways to track data or performance. Fitness professionals may be limited based on what they want to execute and how much they can achieve. There is also an increased possibility of distraction or disruption in goals due to the other elements that exist with and comprise social media. That being said, the collective community provided with social media can be inspiring and unifying.

Text messaging (texting) is a form of communicating with the client directly via the messaging application on mobile devices, which essentially bypasses e-mail. It gives direct written messages to the client, usually instantly. Fitness professionals can use texting to provide or receive immediate answers to questions or for reminding clients of goals they need to achieve for the day. Reminders are a particularly interesting point of focus for fitness professionals as some studies show that texting or mobile app messaging may help increase attention toward health goals (Schwebel & Larimer, 2018).

A growing technology trend in client communication is video calls and video conferencing between fitness professionals and clients. Smartphone applications like FaceTime or WhatsApp or online conferencing services like Google Hangouts or Zoom means fitness professionals can interact with and watch their clients perform workouts and then relay comments or advice based on body language and non-verbal cues. Moreover, fitness professionals can visually demonstrate, just as they can in-person, how to perform exercises and movements correctly.

These applications will often have recording options, which can allow the fitness professional to replay calls and take more time to analyze and dissect assessments. Furthermore, fitness professionals can use these videos as "before" examples to measure and track client results against, allowing them to show progress to the client as time goes on.

The phone is still a solid standby for quick, easy, and instantaneous communication. While not all client populations may have access or the technological ability to use video or application services, a large majority do have telephone access. Fitness professionals and clients can communicate their needs and instructions and provide instant responses.

Synchronous and Asynchronous Communication

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Synchronous and Asynchronous CommunicationFitness professionals should consider which environment and type of communication is the right fit for their clients. Specifically, what form of and how much synchronous and/or asynchronous communication will be most effective for the fitness professional and client relationship, as well as intended goals and outcomes of the program.

Synchronous communication occurs at the same time (or of the moment) between more than one individual. An example of virtual synchronous communication would be a live video training session with a fitness professional (Figure: Synchronous Communication Example). The client, in this instance, would be receiving live (or of the moment) cues about how to move or adjust their form or rep counts and how to best proceed to the next exercise.

FigureSynchronous Communication ExampleSynchronous communication is closest to the traditional personal training environment. If live video streams are used between a client and their fitness professional, many of the same benefits of in-person training can exist. Fitness professionals can comment immediately and directly and clients can pose questions about their program in real-time. Clients can also see the body language and physical responses of their fitness

professional. Smiling, eye contact, and gestures can all relay enthusiasm and encouragement for positive reinforcement. Communication platforms that are synchronous include video calls and video conferencing and the phone.

Asynchronous communication is communication that occurs on delay (or at a later time) between more than one individual. E-mail is one form of asynchronous communication. For example, a fitness professional sends an instructional email to a client for that week's exercise program and then the client responds back at a later time with questions or comments (Figure: Asynchronous Communication Example). Other communication platforms that are asynchronous include online communities, certain apps, and texting.

FigureAsynchronous Communication ExampleSynchronous communicationCommunication occurring at the same time (or of the moment) between more than one individual.

Asynchronous communicationCommunication occurring on a delay (or at a later time) between more than one individual.

When to Use Which Communication Method

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101When to Use Which Communication MethodBeyond understanding the concepts of asynchronous and synchronous communication is learning when to make the best use of each. Both forms of communications have advantages and disadvantages. The style of communication and when it is used is a skill as much as training itself. For example, too many reminders or interrupting messages from apps or online communities can end up creating a haze or ignoring effect (Kushlev et al., 2016). However, if a client needs time-sensitive assistance, they may benefit more from synchronous communication. For example, if a client needs multiple answers on how to handle a nutritional strategy problem, it might benefit both the fitness professional and client timewise to opt for a quick phone call and have a back-and-forth conversation.

Creating office hours and boundaries for synchronous communication is important for both the fitness professional and the client. Mobile app messaging, for example, can be a form of both asynchronous and synchronous communication, depending on the parameters. In some instances, the messaging is set during predetermined hours and a client can receive instant messaging or communication from the fitness professional. For example, if a client is in the middle of a training session and does not understand what level of fatigue in training they should achieve during their exercise sets, they can instant message their fitness professional and receive an immediate answer.

Other texting and messaging can be asynchronous, such as reminders or encouragements sent on schedules or not in real-time. Clients can find these messages useful, but a fitness professional needs to be careful to not constantly send reminders, updates, and messages to their client if the trigger effect is not needed. If a fitness professional does not respect the client's boundaries, it could lead to the client consciously or subconsciously viewing the messages as ineffective or irrelevant. These clients would need less-frequent and more specifically targeted, asynchronous communication, such as email.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Fitness professionals should develop a system that works specifically for their targeted and continuous communication style and should ask themselves if they are someone who enjoys constant and instant interaction or less-frequent interaction. For example, some fitness professionals feed off the energy clients give them and need daily and consistent visual interaction. Such professionals would likely benefit from daily online classes or video conferencing with their clients. To the contrary, some fitness professionals may be more introverted and less comfortable with daily verbal or video conferencing communication and may enjoy less-frequent asynchronous interactions with their clients.

Additionally, one should determine the frequency and style of the client's check-ins. Fitness professionals need to have a consistent and predictable system in place that covers when the client checks in, how frequently, and which communication platform they use. Fitness professionals can use the exact same system and applications for all clients or vary them based on the various types of clients they work with.

There are a wide variety of communication forms and methods available for fitness professionals and clients to use. The type of platform used, the frequency, or how many of each platform used will vary based on the specific client and the programs and services being offered. Determining which platform is best for a given client can be achieved through gaining an understanding of the client's preferences, needs, and available resources. Is there a client who is overwhelmed by technology but is comfortable with email? Perhaps their preferred style of training is best suited to a particular app where everything is stored and accessible in one place. As the traditional fitness professional develops as a virtual coach, make note and keep a collection of which communication styles and platforms work best for given programs, scenarios, and client-types in order to put the client in the best position to achieve results.

Helpful HintUsing a format that is convenient and comfortable for the fitness professional is just as important as one that is convenient and comfortable for the client.

Communicating Online: Asking Questions

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Communicating Online: Asking QuestionsOnce the fitness professional determines which communication type and platforms they will be using, the next crucial phase is understanding how to communicate with potential clients. Assuming clients have gone through the qualifying process and ultimately signed on to work with a fitness professional or company, the next interactions with a client are the most important a fitness professional can have. The manner in which fitness professionals talk to clients, how they ask and respond to questions, and the plans they make for the future together pave the road for their relationship.

Collecting Client Information: Open-Ended and Closed-Ended QuestionsCommunicating virtually requires fitness professionals to effectively collect the information needed from the client to guide them in their journey while simultaneously using a client-centered approach and fostering personal autonomy. An effective way of achieving this is to allow the client to speak for themselves by using the right style of interviewing to evoke detailed and thoughtful responses. This style of

interviewing revolves around open-ended questions.

Open-ended questions are questions worded in a manner that evokes thoughtfulness and reflection in the individual who is being asked. They cannot be answered by a simple “yes” or “no” response. These types of questions can help clients to explore deeper into their desires, goals, and emotional positions, while helping fitness professionals find out what motivates them and where their values lie and further understand their thought processes.

Most often, open-ended questions begin with “Why,” “What,” “How,” or “Tell me” and allow the client to speak freely. For example, “Why are you looking to start an exercise program at this time?

Using open-ended questions in interviews and interactions can help fitness professionals better understand their client’s motives, goals, and potential obstacles, which can help them find unique solutions to various circumstances. Often, this can lead to the client finding answers on their own by giving them the chance to voice their thoughts and connect different experiences together. Additionally, open-ended questions encourage the client to elaborate and give more nuanced explanations. At first, certain details may not seem relevant or important, but these can be the very details fitness professionals need most in order to tailor a program for success.

Open-ended questionsQuestions worded in a manner that evokes thoughtfulness and reflection in the individual who is being asked.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Despite their many benefits, caution should be used with open-ended questions. They can and often do move into deeper personal spaces. It is pertinent to remain within the scope of the fitness professional and refer out to other appropriate providers when necessary.

Fitness professionals should seek permission with moving forward, and, when given, move slowly. Professionals should not rush the client or make them feel that any particular response is needed or that lack of response is brought with disappointment. Figure: Seek Permission is an example of appropriate dialogue:

Helpful Hint Remember, open means it can go anywhere and closed is locked in place.

FigureSeek PermissionThis example can be used in written or verbal form. Notice the professional is asking permission, providing the client with power, and allowing them to choose their own pace in responding. Fitness professionals should also keep in mind that the ability and benefits of seeing body language and hearing vocal inflection are lacking with written and certain virtual platforms. Written questions need to be carefully worded to ensure the tone is conveying an articulate message that is taken as intended. Framing things in an inclusive manner such as “we” or “us” can make the difference when delivering sensitive critique by reminding them it’s a team effort and that comments are not being made in judgement but rather in support. When communicating these messages vocally, fitness professionals should make sure to add reassuring phrases and check in on their client’s comfort while discussing potentially sensitive subjects.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 1Virtual Coaching 101Closed-ended questions are questions that are worded in a way that does not give opportunity to elaborate and typically can only be answered in a distinct and predetermined way. They leave no room for ambivalence or uncertainty and are most often used to ask permission or to obtain quantitative data. Some examples are “Are you comfortable taking daily body weight?” or “Can you please fill out this weekly check-in form?” or “Do you mind if we discuss this further?”

Closed-ended questions are questions with a “Yes” or “No” answer, and, although they are limiting in nature, they are sometimes required and can be very helpful. They are less explorative and more about finding specific answers to specific questions. They typically begin with, “Have you,” “Do you,” “Will you,” “Are you,” “Can you,” “Is it,” etc.

For the most part, open-ended questions should be the primary interviewing tool fitness professionals use with potential or current clients. Refer to Table: Examples of Open and Closed-Ended Questions for a list of examples of open- and closed-ended questions.

Examples of Open and Closed-Ended QuestionsOpen-Ended Questions

Closed-Ended Questions

What are your current goals?

Do you feel comfortable sharing measurements and data?

What are you looking to achieve with training?

Will you have 30 minutes each day to exercise?

What are your exercise experiences?

Do you have access to a gym?

Tell me what you know about nutrition intake?

Is it okay if I ask you questions about your nutrition?

What are specific things you want to achieve in the next year?

Is it okay if I ask you questions about your physical history?

What do you feel are some of your strengths?

Do you have adequate time to focus on these goals right now?

Closed-ended questionsQuestions worded in a way that does not give opportunity to elaborate and typically can only be answered in a distinct and predetermined way.

Virtual Goal Setting

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesVirtual Goal SettingOnce the fitness professional has asked open- and closed-ended questions in order to build rapport with the client, the next step is to set goals for their program using a framework or system like SMART goals. In the questionnaire or consultation process, a fitness professional should ask the client what their current short-term and long-term goals are, what they want to achieve, and by when they want to achieve it. From there, using SMART as a guideline, the fitness professional will have the ability to work with the client and determine the pace and appropriate method for achieving those goals.

SMART GoalsGoals are actions or results an individual wants to achieve, generally within a specified timeframe. Fitness professionals will encounter clients who have a variety of goals ranging from increasing strength, daily mobility, muscle growth, and cardiovascular improvements. Each client will have different goals and different timelines and expectations for their goals. One of the roles of a fitness professional is to be the manager and facilitator of their client's goals. One way a fitness professional can do this is by following a researched and tested formula of goal setting called SMART goals. SMART is an acronym that stands for Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. The concept of SMART originated in the 1950s in management and company improvement research (Day & Tosey, 2011). Since that time, SMART goals have been found useful as a framework for a wide variety of goal setting circumstances.

SMART Goals - Definition and ExamplesDefining a SMART Goal

Application

Specific

Is the goal specific?

The goal should not be vague or unclear. It should be targeted, purposeful, and specific in nature. The more narrowed the focus on the goal, the more likely the things needed to be done to achieve the goal will be as well.

Example of a non-specific goal: I want to exercise more.

Example of a specific goal: I will follow a strength building program and exercise 4 days every week.

Measurable

How will the goal be measured?

The goal should have metrics and references of measure. The fitness professional should be able to trend and study the progress of the client's success toward their goal.

Example of non-measured goal: The client updates you every few weeks saying they have completed (and sometimes not completed) their goals with very little charting or records.

Example of a measured goal: Once a week, the client updates a premade form covering the exercise, reps, sets, and intensity required to gauge their program results and direct any changes.

Achievable

Is the goal one that can be completed?

The goal should be achievable. It should be technically possible to accomplish.

Example of non-achievable goal: A middle-aged client wants a training program to increase their height by 5 inches.

Example of an achievable goal: A middle-aged client wants a training program to help improve their standing posture.

Relevant

Is the goal realistically achievable for that person?

Is the goal personally meaningful?

While similar to an attainable goal, this goal needs to be relevant and realistically possible for the specific client. Simply because a goal is technically attainable does not mean the goal itself is realistic for that particular individual.

Example of non-realistic goal: A client wants to lose 20 lbs of pure fat in 1 month.

Example of an achievable goal: A client wants to lose 2 lbs of pure fat in 1 month.

Time-Bound

Is there a definite timeline for completion of the goal?

The goal should have a start date and a termination date. If multiple goals are being selected, each of them should move in unison with the other and have time-specific dates for reassessment.

Example of non-time-bound goal: A client wants to gain muscle at some point.

Example of a time-bound goal: A client wants to gain 2 lbs of muscle in a 3-month time period.

SMART goalsAn acronym that stands for specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound goals.

Outcome and Process Goals

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesOutcome and Process GoalsAn outcome goal is defined as the target or definitive end point of the set goal. For example, if the goal is to gain 2 pounds of muscle by the client's birthday, that is the outcome. Outcome goals are also synonymous with concepts like short-term and long-term goals.

A process goal is the method or alteration of habit used to achieve that goal. For example, to gain 2 pounds of muscle by their birthday, the client will need to take part in a nutrition and specific exercise training program to support that outcome.

In process goals, there can also be performance goals. Performance goals are defined by setting a new achievement(s) within the performance being measured. For example, if the process goal is to perform three sets of 10 deadlifts in the workout, the performance goal could be to track the ability to increase weight when doing a deadlift.

Generally speaking, time is typically best spent working on process goals. While it is important to have a larger focus on the end direction or outcome, the short-term process completion can help a client build momentum and self-efficacy toward achieving continued success with their goals. Research suggests that short-term goals can be defined as any goal attempted to be completed in less than 12 months (Ogbeiwi, 2017). Most literature agrees that 3 months is a good starting point for short-term goal achievement; however, individuals can focus efforts of smaller periods of time and interweave process goals alongside their outcome goals. For example, it can be more rewarding to an individual to set a process goal of training 4 days each week as they work toward achieving their 3-month goal. Each training session completed is another notch toward completion of the overall process and achievement of the goal.

Outcome goalA goal defined as the target or definitive end point of the set goal.

Process goalA goal defined as the method or alteration of habits used to achieve that goal.

Performance goalsA goal defined by setting a new achievement within the performance being measured.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesIn the end, when looking at goal completion, key takeaways are ensuring goal output is achievable and supplies momentum to the client. One of the primary underlying themes of the SMART goals framework is to leverage accomplishment of smaller, realistic goals to ultimately achieve success.

Collecting client information and goal setting is critical in making a great first impression. The fitness professional will do this with a series of questions during assessment and then follow-up with back-and-forth dialogue until the outcome and process goals are established. The manner in which a fitness professional speaks with their client during this process will set the tone for the rest of their relationship. Here is an example (Figure: Setting the Tone):

FigureSetting the Tone

Virtual Accountability and Check-Ins

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesThe client should feel comfortable with the questions being asked, feel they are able to speak freely and provide their own input and desires, and should never feel uneasy during the consultation experience. The client should be in charge of their own goals at all times during this process and the goals should be of their choosing. The client should have autonomy and feel in control of their future with an increasing sense of confidence in their ability to succeed. Goals should be specific and targeted, yet realistically achievable, and have the ability to be measured. They should, ultimately, be realistic and achievable. Ultimately, a fitness professional's job is to foster client self-confidence as they help guide them toward achievement of their goals.

Virtual Accountability and Check-InsAccountability is being held responsible to an organization or another individual to achieve a desired outcome. Fitness professionals are the accountability agent for their clients. Due to the transactional nature of the relationship, fitness professionals are there to not only provide educated and carefully considered programming, they are also there to help the client achieve execution of the programming and outcomes. In the beginning, a fitness professional will collect and gather their client's information during a data collection phase. Then, together with the client, they will each determine outcome goals. After that, the client will progress to completing their goals with the fitness professional there for support and accountability throughout the process.

FigureCycle of AccountabilityAccountabilityBeing held responsible to an organization or another individual to achieve a desired outcome.

Measures of Accountability and Data Collection

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesMeasures of Accountability and Data CollectionThe fitness professional and the client should come together on their ideal accountability parameters. There should be enough data collection to allow the fitness professional to have an educated understanding of the client's progress toward their goals, but not so much information that the client is uncomfortable, it becomes unmanageable, or it is un-actionable. Autonomy in the check-in and data collection process is crucial to building a long-term relationship with the client. For example, some clients may

find themselves negatively stimulated by daily weigh-ins while other clients find it motivating. This may also change through the course of working with the client and may need to be adjusted along the way. Clients should look forward to the weekly process of goal competition and data-collection. They should not have negative emotions attached to the process; otherwise, it is likely that compliance and dedication will wane.

Once the parameters have been established, a fitness professional needs to have some form of data collection available in order to track client progress. Fitness professionals can use applications in which the client inputs the data on their side and the fitness professional has visibility to see it, or they can receive the data from the client and input it themselves. Budget and technology capabilities will determine applications used. For example, Google Sheets™ is a spreadsheet application that is free with a Google account and allows both the fitness professional and the client to review, edit, and update the same document.

When a fitness professional has selected the best platform for communication and data collection and the client understands the purpose of each when working together, the next step is to actually start collecting data. In fact, data collection starts the moment a fitness professional begins interacting with a client. Every aspect of a fitness professional's working relationship with clients involves important information that can be used to help clients achieve their goals. Fitness professionals learn most of this when initially evaluating and assessing their client; however, a certain amount of that information will need to be carried over from week-to-week in order to measure results and progress.

Physical DataPhysical data is comprised of an individual's current makeup, such as age and anthropometric measurements like height, weight, body circumference, and body fat percentage. Depending on the client's goals, these physical data measurements may be essential to tracking their progress toward physical goals.

Pictures can also be used to track physical data and for pre- or post-comparison photos. This is especially useful for clients who want to achieve changes in body composition, like fat loss or muscle gain, in which the scale or other measurements may not give the clearest or most accurate indication of progress toward the goal. However, remember, not all clients are comfortable sharing photos. It is incredibly important to provide a safe as well as secure space for clients to provide and store their progress photos.

Physical dataData comprised of an individual's current makeup, such as age, height, weight, and measurements, including inches and body-fat percentage.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesThe following is an example of how collecting the combination of weight and physical data can help troubleshoot what seems like a fat-loss plateau (Figure: Troubleshooting Physical Data). Remember, this conversation can happen through email or video conferencing. Be mindful of tone and execution in conversation. Without physical data, a client could likely become discouraged and may veer off the course set for them to achieve their goals. Fitness professionals should always use the data to encourage clients and highlight successful efforts.

FigureTroubleshooting Physical Data

Performance Data

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesPerformance DataPerformance data includes alterations in any marker in which improvement or maintenance is looking to be achieved. Heart rate, for example, can be a great indicator of improved cardiovascular health in clients. Decreases in resting heart rate over time or alterations in heart rate variability (HRV) can be a sign of improved overall health (Kim et al., 2018). One-repetition maximum (1RM) testing (or other variants of repetition maximum testing), as well as some of the other objective assessments highlighted in the assessments chapter, are other reliable indicators of performance improvement (Levinger et al., 2009). By consistently collecting and tracking this data, even from a distance, fitness professionals can continue to monitor and track progress and guide their client in the pursuit and achievement of their goals.

Most performance data, as related to the previous examples, is fairly straightforward to collect, monitor, and track:

Did the client lift heavier weights for a given exercise? Did they achieve more volume in their program?

Has the client's resting heart rate decreased over time? Has their HRV increased over time?

Did their muscular endurance increase?

Did they run farther, faster, or both?

These objective physical indicators of performance are generally easy to relay, read, and track over time.

Another performance parameter that can be used to measure progress is compliance ratings. Compliance ratings are how well a client felt they did in achieving that day's process or goal. If a client has a goal of training 4 days a week, fitness professionals can provide them with a yes–no response section in their check-in. If they have achieved four "Yes" responses to the question "Did you train today?" then they have achieved a week of compliance.

Performance dataData including alterations in any marker in which improvement or maintenance is looking to be achieved.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesCompliance ratings can be helpful to see overall trends in performance and for troubleshooting changes in or lack of progress. If there is a challenge improving in particular physical performance parameters or goal-achievement, the first place to look is compliance. If a client is not gaining in strength at a rate they desire but is not hitting their compliance rating, fitness professionals can help explain their lack of results as a possibility of missed sessions. Here is a conversational example (Figure: Discussing Results) where the fitness professional could be discussing their results via a video conferencing call:

FigureDiscussing Results

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesThis fitness professional could schedule an additional video conference call to help the client maintain compliance during that following week. Compliance ratings are not about judging the client; they are about using the data to determine if that is contributing to the observed issue or concerns shared by the client. The same approach can be used for clients who tend to put in too much work (Figure: Discussing Compliance Data).

FigureDiscussing Compliance DataSuccess toward any goal is about maintaining the balance in the work-to-rest ratio. The data fitness professionals regularly collect from clients helps determine if that balance is on or off target.

Lifestyle Data

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesLifestyle Data Lifestyle data is made up of variables that can affect the success of outcome and process goals. For example, a client who is attempting to lose body fat and/or regulate their food intake may struggle in their ability to comply with their program goals due to consecutive nights of poor sleep (Landis et al., 2009). For athletes, inability to maintain adequate water intake throughout the day could decrease performance capabilities (Casa et al., 2019). These data markers can give clues and insight into potential program adjustments a fitness professional or client can make or areas where they might benefit from some additional focus.

Lifestyle data is also important in helping identify and empathize with struggles and difficulties clients face. If a client is reporting excessive fatigue, work stress, and poor sleep, it may become clear to the fitness professional that achieving established goals may be difficult and may not necessarily be the top priority for the client at the present time. It is the fitness professional's responsibility to evaluate the data and the client's status and to work with them to modify or adjust program priorities—and possibly goals—to reflect their current situation. A strategy to implement this using data would be scale ratings. For example, clients can be asked to rate how much fatigue or stress they feel on a scale of 1-10, 10 being the most fatigued or stressed and 1 being the least.

Lifestyle dataData made up of variables that can affect the success of outcome and process goals.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesIt is not uncommon for clients to experience challenges along the way to improved health, fitness, and performance. Fitness professionals should strive to help clients work through both good and tough times as a part of their support system. Here is an example of using lifestyle data during an email check-in with a client who is struggling to maintain consistency with their training (Figure: Lifestyle Data):

FigureLifestyle DataCritical!A fitness professional's role is never to judge or criticize the pace of a client's progression. It is up to the client to determine the speed at which they want to move forward.

Client Comments

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesClient CommentsWhen working with a client, fitness professionals should provide a space for comments outside of data collection. Comments are critical in communication between a fitness professional and their client. There are many times clients may have information or comments about their day or week that may not fit perfectly into a particular column or category within a data collection survey. Sometimes, a client simply needs to vent and discuss their feelings about the week or make additional comments regarding their training sessions. These conversations can often offer insight into potential roadblocks that may impact their training or nutrition as well as building further trust in the working relationship.

Commentary should always be encouraged, and it is often beneficial to query further when opportunities arise. It is a fitness professional's responsibility to ask questions if there is something in a client program that needs addressing. Here is an example of encouraging a client to comment, if desired, while respecting their boundaries (Figure: Encouraging a Client to Comment):

FigureEncouraging a Client to Comment

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesNote, it is not a fitness professional's place to dictate to a client; however, if the client has set a goal and asked for accountability for that goal, it is okay to engage and ask them questions regarding their actions if they do not match up to what they committed to (Table: Examples of Accountability Data to Collect).

Examples of Accountability Data to CollectPhysical

Performance

Lifestyle

Comments

Age

Heart Rate

Sleep Hygiene (Quality and/or Quantity)

(Provide a space for clients to provide general comments.)

Height

HRV

Hydration

Weight

Strength Increases

Fatigue Score

Circumference Measurements

Volume (Reps/Sets) Increases

Mediation

Body Fat %

ROM/Mobility Improvement

Supplement Tracking

Progress Pictures

Jump Measures (Height, Distance, Repetitions, etc.) Increase

Alcohol/Drug Use

Balance Measures Improvements

Stress Score

Running Metrics (Distance, Time, Pace, etc.)

Compliance Ratings

Client Check-In Questions and Data Collection

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesClient Check-In Questions and Data CollectionDepending on the system a fitness professional uses and the programs and services offered, the client can check-in with them daily, weekly, or monthly. The process should be simple and easy for the client to complete. The client should have a sheet, form, or application to fill out the selected, predetermined criteria based on their goals. The client should have a clear understanding before going into a check-in what data they are expected to provide, the date and time it needs to be provided by, and what protocol to follow if they are unable to complete their check-ins on time. With the right check-in structure, documentation, and system, clients should find the technical aspect of checking-in relatively simple and easy.

The fitness professional should select and provide a form or questionnaire for their client to complete during the check-in process. Always remember, the amount and type of data and process to collect it should only be as intensive and involved as the client needs it to be in order to accomplish their goals—nothing more. Fitness professionals should take care and caution not to overwhelm clients with too much information or too complicated a process to collect it. Often, less is more.

Here is an example of a spreadsheet structure for a client who is looking to alter body composition and train four times a week (Table: Spreadsheet Structure for Altering Body Composition).

Spreadsheet Structure for Altering Body CompositionDate

Training Session

A.M. Weight

Caloric Intake Estimate

Protein

Carbs

Fat

Sleep

Water Intake

Fatigue Score 1–10

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesData reporting specific to training is generally best done in a separate spreadsheet from the compliance and physical data forms. Clients should be encouraged to track their training session data if they are serious about goal and performance progression.

Table: Spreadsheet Structure for Training Session Tracking is an example of a spreadsheet structure for training session and progression tracking.

Spreadsheet Structure for Training Session TrackingDate:

Fatigue Score:

Sleep:

Exercise Description

Reps

Sets

Intensity/Load

Rest Time

Notes/Comments

Fitness professionals should not only provide a structure for clients to record their exercise movements, but also a place to comment or relay notes regarding how the movements felt, if they were having an off day, or if an exercise did not feel right or good. If a client repeatedly experiences and shares a particular problem with a certain exercise, that should prompt the fitness professional to modify the movement or exercise or change it altogether. It is also important to take note of a client's fatigue score or sleep prior to training to see if other factors are influencing their training session experience and results.

Before the Check-In

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesBefore the Check-InCommunication and organization are important elements for fitness professionals to maximize success in helping clients achieve their goals. As previously discussed, the rapport and manner in which a fitness professional speaks to their client is critical to fostering the relationship and building trust. Moreover, staying organized and incorporating good data collection habits into the routine will allow fitness professionals to identify trends, positive or negative, in order to best assist and serve their client.

On receipt of the first check-in, the fitness professional should already have a process and structure in place to keep clients' data organized and easily accessible for review. Even if client data is stored in an application or software system, fitness professionals should take the extra step and establish best practices for keeping their own records, notes, and thoughts for each client. While this may seem redundant, excessive, or too clinical, it allows the fitness professional to troubleshoot problems almost instantly as they arise, encourage the client when needed, and offer protection from liability, should something unfortunate occur.

For example, not all data can be simply categorized. There are times when clients are simply human, experiencing certain emotions that need to be noted. This is especially true if a fitness professional is working with a higher volume of clients. Relying on memory alone or raw data without context can allow for gaps, which may limit or undermine the effectiveness of the fitness professional's rapport with a client. Fitness professionals should have their own notes, reminders, and comments regarding their clients saved and stored somewhere secure, even if they are relying on an external or app-driven system.

Mindset During the Check-InThe fitness professional's role is not to determine, dictate, or judge client goals, but rather to help their client achieve the goals they desire while respecting their boundaries. Fitness professionals often tend to take the results and success of their clients personally; nothing could do more to harm the relationship between them. It is vital to recognize that a client's goals and wishes are separate from those of a fitness professional. Fitness professionals should always resist the urge or desire to put any of their own wishes, desires, or expectations onto the client.

The check-in process should be a positive experience for the client every time. They should feel free to ask questions without worry or ridicule. They should also never be afraid or anxious to report results, regardless of how close (or far) they are from achieving their goals.

Feedback to Client

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesFeedback to ClientWhen a fitness professional receives their check-in from the client, he/she should have notes or spreadsheet systems open and ready to document thoughts or important markers of interest during the check-in. Fitness professionals should then review the answers and data in response to the predetermined questions and begin to organize and arrange their comments.

Table: Example of Client Looking to Alter Body Composition is an example of a completed spreadsheet from a client looking to alter their body composition through losing fat and maintaining muscle by training 4 times a week.

Example of Client Looking to Alter Body Composition Date

Training Session

A.M. Weight

Caloric Intake

Protein

Carbs

Fat

Sleep

Water Intake

Fatigue Score 1–10

8/06

Yes

65 kgs

2000

140 g

250 g

75 g

7.5 hrs

70 oz

2

8/07

No

64.4 kgs

2000

180 g

195 g

55 g

7.0 hrs

70 oz

2

8/08

Yes

64.8 kgs

2000

160 g

190 g

68 g

6.5 hrs

70 oz

4

8/09

No

64.8 kgs

2500

120 g

300 g

90 g

7.5 hrs

70 oz

3

8/10

No

65.6 kgs

?

?

?

?

6.0 hrs

?

6

8/11

No

65.4 kgs

3000

160 g

?

?

8.5 hrs

70 oz

5

8/12

No

66.4 kgs

?

?

?

?

7.5 hrs

?

3

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesWithout any other comments from the client, a fitness professional should be able to look at the data to determine possible questions to ask and topics to discuss with their client (Table: Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to Discuss).

Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to DiscussDate

Training Session

A.M. Weight

Caloric Intake

Protein

Carbs

Fat

Sleep

Water Intake

Fatigue Score 1–10

8/06

Yes

65 kgs

2200

140 g

250 g

75 g

7.5 hrs

70 oz

2

8/07

No

64.4 kgs

2000

180 g

195 g

55 g

7.0 hrs

70 oz

2

8/08

Yes

64.8 kgs

2000

160 g

190 g

68 g

5.5 hrs

70 oz

4

8/09

No

64.8 kgs

2500

120 g

300 g

90 g

7.5 hrs

70 oz

3

8/10

No

65.6 kgs

?

?

?

?

6.0 hrs

?

6

8/11

No

65.4 kgs

3000

160 g

?

?

8.5 hrs

70 oz

5

8/12

No

66.4 kgs

?

?

?

?

7.5 hrs

?

3

Based on the highlighted data in the spreadsheet (Table: Determining Questions to Ask and Topics to Discuss) the fitness professional should consider the following:

Ask their client the reason for lack of training toward the end of the week.

Make a note that body weight has trended upward toward the end of the week.

Discuss possible setbacks toward achieving outcome results from a lack of tracking data.

Ask their client about their inconsistent sleep and if good sleep hygiene is being practiced. Or perhaps send them some literature on the topic to enhance their understanding of how important sleep quality and consistency is to achieving their goals.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesNext, fitness professionals should look at any comments or notes left by the client. In this example, the client included the following feedback and comments (Figure: Client Comments).

FigureClient Comments

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesFitness professionals should use the client's feedback and comments as well as all the data to form an articulate and helpful response. Between the client feedback and spreadsheet data, focus on as many of the positive attributes as possible when formulating the response (Figure: Fitness Professional Response).

FigureFitness Professional Response

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesThe feedback from the fitness professional is littered with tips and pointers on client etiquette. The following in Table: Analyzing Fitness Professional Feedback are a few selected quotes and comments about the written approach.

Analyzing Fitness Professional Feedback Quotes

Comments

Based on your comments, I could sense you were not very happy with your check-in this week. To me, the most encouraging part was you writing “I’ll try better next week.”

One should always strive to find the most positive attributes in the client's comments. In this instance, the client expressed desire to want to do better. Fitness professionals should always start an email on a clear and positive note.

It’s always hard to say exactly what helps or hinders achieving a goal, but we do know from research a lack of sleep can change hunger levels—leading to overeating of high-calorie, low-nutrient foods. By the way, if you’d like to see some of that research, feel free to ask.

Fitness professionals should do the best they can to stay up-to-date on current research to be better able to answer clients’ questions. Clients do not always want to read the research themselves and that is okay. However, fitness professionals should be willing and able to back up their programs, strategies, feedback, and suggestions with research that supports them.

Again, it’s typical and normal, but if you know or are aware you do it, you can practice more mindfulness to avoid it if the situation comes up again.

Clients can often feel alone and nervous when trying to achieve their goals. Discourage feelings of failure and inadequacy.

Keep up the effort and don’t let this week discourage you!

Fitness professionals should strive to keep an energetic and upbeat disposition and always end their communication on an encouraging, positive note.

Ultimately, accountability is about being a source of assistance to the client both in education and consistency. The role of a fitness professional is to help clients achieve their goals by collecting and analyzing data and then leveraging it to assist and guide them through the process of change. Professionals should select the type and amount of data they need based on the client’s individual goals and circumstances—taking care not to overwhelm clients with unnecessary requirements or data tracking.

Additionally, fitness professionals should have an organized and consistent process and system of data collection. When collecting and analyzing data, fitness professionals should organize their thoughts and take relevant notes so they can prepare and communicate constructive feedback to help their client.

Lastly, fitness professionals should remain neutral and be present in the client’s goals alongside them. They should always be prepared for shifts in goals or altered outcomes. At no time should a fitness professional feel personally affected or attached to the specific goals or outcomes a client seeks to achieve.

Communicating Online: Building Rapport

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesCommunicating Online: Building Rapport Every interaction a fitness professional has with a client is a chance to strengthen or to weaken the relationship if they are not sensitive and thoughtful with their communication. To strengthen relationships, fitness professionals use rapport. Rapport is a relationship built on an agreement of mutual respect and understanding of the respective roles and empathy that allows for clear and effective communication. Building rapport is an ongoing process of active listening, shared experiences, and empathy. Rapport is practically impossible to build or establish under disingenuous circumstances. Choosing to care about clients is an investment worth putting time and effort into and can result in a gratifying career and an emotionally fulfilled client roster.

For success, patience and consideration is needed equally by both parties. Taking time to communicate with consideration and thought rather than rushing the process is likely to produce happy clients who feel looked after and valued. Alternatively, snappy, short, or truncated responses, can result in clients who become closed off, ashamed to ask questions, or feel as though they are not cared for. The right delivery can help assure that even challenging messages and more difficult conversations are perceived respectfully. Clients should feel trust in the professional and that they have their best intentions at heart.

For example, if a fitness professional encounters a situation where they are unable to respond immediately to a client because they need to carefully construct their thoughts, any potential tension can be mitigated by being honest and telling the truth (Figure: Thoughtful Response).

Simply relaying a time frame for response reduces potential anxiety for a client. If a fitness professional can respond faster, great. However, the client knows not to be concerned or worried by a lack of response until 48 hours have passed. It can mean the difference between a client feeling like they are the only client, are cared for and thought of as an individual, rather than feeling like they are just another number in the business roster.

FigureThoughtful ResponseRapportA relationship built on an agreement of mutual respect and understanding of the respective roles and empathy that allows for clear and effective communication.

Positive Affirmations

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesPositive Affirmations Affirmations are another important piece of the fitness coaching communication toolbox. An affirmation is a positive statement highlighting traits, characteristics, actions, behaviors, etc.

Ultimately, the fitness professional wants clients to recognize these in themselves, but at the start of the relationship, it may require the fitness professional to highlight them. Fitness professionals can help clients reflect on themselves and see not just what they want to improve but also what they currently do well. In time, the objective is for clients to begin to adopt this positive mindset, observe their own victories, and begin to exhibit more confidence and self-compassion. When these personal skills grow, it can improve a client's ability to move forward with consistency rather than being anchored in place by negative thinking.

Additionally, fitness professionals should balance constructive feedback with positive affirmations as much as possible, and clients should hopefully leave each interaction feeling better than before and as though they are on the right track. Fitness professionals should empower the client while decreasing negativity. Improving exercise and nutrition habits are staples in individuals who embark on a journey toward self-improvement. That journey should always come from a positive place. For example, many individuals who seek out weight-loss programs who are met with stark opposition and shaming will actually gain weight (Sutin & Terracciano, 2013). Research has consistently shown negative emotions hinder success for individuals looking to improve.

In practice, weekly check-ins are one of the most important places to use positive affirmations. Specifically, in the beginning of the fitness professional–client relationship, it is important to foster an unconditionally positive and supportive environment. These early stages help clients hear and realize the things they are doing right, building their confidence as well as strengthening the bond with their fitness professional. Fitness professionals need to promote an open and honest relationship in which the client is unafraid to share their struggles and stumbles because they know they will not be met with judgment or shame but, instead, guidance and understanding. Through the fitness professional's continued positive affirmation, clients will often start to develop their own positive self-affirmations and observations, which will shape their future behaviors and decisions.

AffirmationsA positive statement highlighting traits, characteristics, actions, behaviors, etc.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesHere is an example of a fitness professional using affirmations to reveal the positive actions taken by a client in a challenging situation (Figure: Affirmations).

In this explanation, one should see the goal is to encourage rather than discourage the client from attending social gatherings and avoiding "tasty" food. The fitness professional is framing social events as opportunities to learn and test new skills and also provides an opportunity to reflect further with an open-ended question at the end of the interaction. A fitness professional should help reduce fears and anxieties and encourage enjoyment, inclusivity, and, above all, autonomy in their clients. Were the fitness professional to shame this individual instead of using affirmation or to cast doubt in the client's mind regarding their ability to attend such an event and make sound choices, then this could potentially reinforce the client's fears and promote reclusiveness, anxiety, and shame—the opposite of what fitness professionals want to achieve with clients.

Poor affirmation building can also close off further communication with the fitness professional. Clients could become fearful of the fitness professional's response in situations where they perceive to have performed poorly. It is not realistic for a fitness professional given their responsibility or role to expect perfection from a client. Through affirmation, fitness professionals have the potential to teach clients about learning points and opportunities, even within uncomfortable situations. Through self-reflection and a positive outlook, clients can derive valuable lessons from these situations and utilize them in the future to improve downstream outcomes.

FigureAffirmations

Empathetic Approach

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesEmpathetic ApproachEmpathy is the ability to imagine oneself in the position of another and to relate to a person from this frame of reference while trying to understand why they think and feel the way they do when viewed from their standpoint and experiences.

The ability of a fitness professional to empathize with their client can have a profound effect on the client—fitness professional relationship. A client's perception of a fitness professional's empathy may be a better predictor of positive client outcomes than how knowledgeable the fitness professional is in their respective field (Watson et al., 2014). Empathy should be used selectively and with careful reserve.

arloo/Shutterstock.comProfessionals should not presume to know exactly what a client feels or has experienced, as it is impossible to truly experience life through anyone else's eyes. Through the cultivation of great interpersonal communication skills, reflection, and visualization, a fitness professional can try to piece together the life and experiences of their client.

Fitness professionals often attempt to draw on their own experiences, knowledge, and education to try and find solutions to the unique problems each client faces. Taking the time and care to try to understand a client from a more holistic point-of-view can help fitness professionals guide clients through their journey to improved health more effectively. It is true the most theoretically sound fitness and nutrition plan will be useless if it cannot be applied and executed by the individual for whom it was programmed. In this instance, the client is the confounding variable. The capacity for empathy coupled with the discerning ability to apply it and when can determine the spectrum of individuals with whom fitness professionals can achieve results.

Food for Thought While it might seem relating to a client is the best thing to do, it is often better to simply listen.

EmpathyThe ability to imagine oneself in the position of another and to relate to a person from this frame of reference while trying to understand why they think and feel the way they do when viewed from their standpoint and experiences.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching StrategiesLesson 2Virtual Accountability StrategiesA key component to being able to empathize with clients is the ability to remove biases. Professionals all have biases, and no matter how unbiased one believes themselves to be, situations will arise where personal beliefs and values will be an impediment. As practitioners, it is important to be as aware of pre-held bias as possible.

For example, say a fitness professional has a history of exercise disordered behavior. In their own experience, they used exercise in an unhealthy manner to control and attempt to solve problems. That fitness professional needs to be careful to not project their own tendencies onto their client. A client may enjoy a higher threshold of training, but, for them, it is not being expressed out of a negative circumstance. The fitness professional needs to critically evaluate their position and ensure they are not involving their own past experiences or misplacing empathy in the situation—constructing a problem where one does not actually exist. Professionals need to remember in all dealings with clients that it is not about their preferences, abilities, or values; it is about the client. It is about assessing the client's values, goals, and growth and helping them align their behaviors with their goals. This is a continually evolving process and one that requires frequent reassessment and reevaluation. Clients goals and desires are not static; over time, they may change, as can circumstances. As they do, so must the approach a fitness professional takes into the interaction.

Furthermore, an empathetic approach includes always keeping in mind that a client does not know the mind of the fitness professional. To assume they do is a disservice to them. Professionals are teachers of the specific skills for which they are hired. Clients do not have the professional's knowledge, so much patience is needed. Empathy from the fitness professional should be expressed from the place in which they were once the student of an unknown skill. Fitness professionals may have to reiterate the same information many times and in many ways before finding a method of communication that speaks to the individual.

Individuals do not assimilate and process information in the same way. The fitness professional must find a strategy to communicate with their client so that they understand, grow, and learn and always do so with respect and professionalism. Fitness professionals do not define where the client starts; they must work to understand where their client has been and take on the sum of their client's experiences up to the point the relationship begins—and let that define where things start.

Virtual Motivational Interviewing

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingVirtual Motivational Interviewing Motivational interviewing is an empathetic, collaborative, and client-centered approach to communication. It is designed to help direct clients through ambivalence and support positive change. In these instances, ambivalence may be expressed in intermittent indifference to the client's own goals or changing of focus. Motivational interviewing helps shift the focus by asking questions in such a way as to evoke thoughtfulness and reflection from clients to help them find their own reasons for change and motivation, in a non-judgmental, compassionate manner.

Motivational interviewing has been found to be especially effective in helping clients achieve change through health and fitness (Armstrong et al., 2011) Virtual motivational interviewing is similar to the in-person experience. The greatest obstacle to overcome in virtual communications is the preservation of clarity and tone in translation. The manner in which professionals speak in-person may not always transfer to the written word, and, without the benefit of non-verbal cues, interactions need to be more conscientiously crafted. When creating any response, careful consideration should be taken to how it will be interpreted and received. Prior to sending, fitness professionals should reread responses to ensure they are concise, professional, relevant, empathetic, and compassionate. It may take extra time to do so, but those details can create a vastly different experience for both the client and the fitness professional and, often, can lead to a more meaningful, successful, and longer-term working relationship.

Motivational interviewingAn empathetic, collaborative, and client-centered approach to communication designed to help counsel clients through ambivalence and support positive change.

Behavioral Change

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingBehavioral ChangeChanging behaviors is difficult. Many barriers to change exist in both physical and mental paths. All individuals have their own composition of fear, education, environment, social settings, and time constraints that create different outcomes and building blocks for the same problems. To help clients find what approach will work for them, fitness professionals first need to help them find the root of these issues so the proper maps can be created to alter the course and path of their future. As presented by the Stages of Change Model or Transtheoretical Model of Change (Figure: Stages of Change), developed in the 1970's by Prochaska and DiClemente, there are five stages of change:

FigureStages of Change

Precontemplation – At this stage, an individual is not yet aware or is unwilling to accept that a change is needed. They are likely hanging on to their current behaviors and have not yet found intrinsic motivation to change but may have pressure from other sources to make change.

Contemplation – The client has started to become aware that a change is needed, but they are struggling with the pros and cons of doing so, the amount of effort that may be required of them, or what they may have to sacrifice to see change.

Preparation – This is the stage where serious consideration starts to take place and even a desire to begin taking steps to make change. At this point, they are starting to think about what they can do to bring about change but may still be struggling with knowing where to begin. The desire for change is there.

Action – Here they start taking physical action, moving beyond the stages of mental effort to actually taking steps to implement the changes that, until this point, have only been considerations. For many, this will be the most difficult stage as it is the "first step," so to speak, and where they will have to put forth the greatest commitment to keep momentum.

Maintenance – At this point, the client has been consistent with their new behaviors for at least 6 months (Rubak et al., 2005) and it is becoming an integrated part of their lifestyle. Getting here does not mean they will stay here, though, and, if they have not been focused on a sustainable approach, they are still at risk of relapse to old behaviors.

In reality, individuals will often shift back and forth between various stages of change as they encounter new obstacles or things in their lives change, and, although they can progress through the stages in a linear fashion, that may not be typical.

Client Ambivalence

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingClient AmbivalenceIt is also common throughout the coaching process to encounter client ambivalence, where the client has reservations about certain changes, which will vary in reason from person to person. Ambivalence is a state of mind where an individual may have conflict, disinterest, or resistance regarding an outcome or individual.

For example, ambivalence can present, at times, revolving around nutrition where the client is overwhelmed at the notion of learning to eat by hunger cues or perhaps eating at set mealtimes. Altering habits are not easy and resistance is part of change. In another example, if a client wants to participate in a specific training program but cannot due to time constraints, their enthusiasm may decrease while ambivalence increases because their “perfect” schedule cannot be achieved. If they have the perception they are unable to get results on one program, they may choose to do no program at all.

Often, a major point of friction and cause for ambivalence from clients comes from the desire to see results while maintaining their current lifestyles. Individuals want fast results, change, and instant fixes rather than the uncomfortable process of self-evaluation and exploration. It can be difficult for them to accept their current state due to past and current choices, beliefs, and behaviors. Acceptance can be overwhelming at times, but it is imperative to achieve long-term change. By altering and redirecting focus, the client may get to a place they might not have reached previously.

AmbivalenceA state of mind in which an individual may have conflict, disinterest, or resistance regarding an outcome or individual.

Change Talk Versus Sustain Talk

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingChange Talk Versus Sustain TalkChange talk is language that supports behavior change. As much as possible, fitness professionals want to promote change talk with their clients (Apodaca et al., 2016). Fitness professionals should encourage client autonomy while staying true to their core values and facilitating positive changes to assist them in reaching their goals. An example of change talk may sound like this (Figure: Change Talk):

Try ThisWhenever a client expresses negatives, fitness professionals should do what they can to find the positives.

FigureChange TalkHere the client is giving a smoke signal call of change and the underlying theme is achievement.

Change talkLanguage that supports behavior change.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingConversely, researchers also discuss sustain talk. Sustain talk is any language that is in support of avoiding change. This style of talk often signals, consciously or not, a desire to resist change and keep to previous or current paths, which do not put the individual on course for their goals. Sustain talk may sound like this (Figure: Sustain Talk):

FigureSustain TalkChange Talk Versus Sustain TalkChange Talk

Sustain Talk

I’m struggling with finding the perfect balance, but I know it’s something I’ll do.

Maybe this isn’t for me?

I get tired and this is hard, but I think this is worth doing.

I’ve accepted I’m not young anymore and I have to let go of a lot of dreams.

I guess learning new things is part of this process, right?

I just want to live a normal life again!

There are moments of sacrifice, but I know the results are worth it.

I’m not sure why I’m even doing this.

Both styles of talk may come up as professionals try to help clients through ambivalence. There are times clients find difficulty letting go of the opposition to their goals.

Sustain talkLanguage that supports the avoidance of change.

Motivational Interviewing in Practice

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingMotivational Interviewing in Practice With motivational interviewing, fitness professionals want to create an environment where clients feel unconditionally supported and safe to express their feelings. If they feel the fitness professional lacks empathy or is judgmental, they may become closed off and less motivated to share or continue. These can result in what is known as discord. Discord is a breach in the fitness professional–client relationship, which can pull attention away from the original relationship intention.

Discord can decrease willingness to change, and, if a client is already prone to sustain talk, it can increase the perception that change is simply too hard. This is the opposite of what professionals want. When clients express sustain talk, they need to feel heard. The fitness professional should use open-ended questions and empathizing to redirect the conversation back toward change talk. Using the previous example for a client engaging in sustain talk, here is a fitness professional's response in that situation that could cause discord (Figure: Discord):

FigureDiscordDiscordA breach in the fitness professional–client relationship that can pull attention away from the original relationship intention.

Content

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingIt is easy to see how this response can evoke discord and more ambivalence in a client. Here is a response to the same question that acknowledges the client's dislikes and preferences and promotes change talk (Figure: Promoting Change Talk):

This response clearly states the client is being heard. The professional is respecting their individuality and attempting to help develop a flexible approach and find an amicable solution. This can be the difference between a client continuing to move forward or regressing and giving up altogether.

FigurePromoting Change Talk

Summary

Chapter 4Communication and Coaching Strategies Lesson 3Virtual Motivational InterviewingAs much as possible, fitness professionals want the relationship between them and their clients to be a collaborative one. Professionals should help clients explore the deeper reasoning behind their obstacles, find a lifestyle that supports their values and goals in balance, and develop the tools to self-evaluate, self-monitor, reflect, and adapt. This is precisely why motivational interviewing, empathy, and great communication are crucial skills to develop as fitness professionals. If the fitness professional and client work together to develop bespoke approaches to goal achievement, it is likely that the client can sustain for the long-term. It is up to fitness professionals to help clients navigate and invest in their current and future health, rather than find a temporary goal and regress back to their old habits. The goal must be realistically attainable as well as sustainable.

Whatever the reasons for using motivational interviewing, it can help clients move past ambivalence to change talk by allowing them to explore their reasoning in an environment that is safe from judgement and encourages them to align their behaviors to their values.

Summary Virtual communication is a relatively new platform and environment for fitness professionals and clients all over the world to come together and interact. More recently and more frequently, there are an abundance of opportunities for fitness professionals to work with and help clients from a distance, regardless of physical proximity. Fitness professionals have a variety of options for working with clients virtually, from email to web and mobile-based software applications and asynchronous or synchronous communication strategies—enabling them to find the right fit for clients and themselves. Fitness professionals help their clients through the process of planning and setting goals and then achieving those goals through an individualized, tailored, and achievable process. Through an organized process of data collection and analysis, and consistency in communication, fitness professionals can use their knowledge, skills, abilities, and talents to keep clients accountable and work through periods of issues of ambivalence and hardship. Ultimately, fitness professionals will use empathy and evidence-based methods to help clients realize and achieve their own goals and dreams, all while building an unshakable relationship, which can influence and enhance the lives of the client and fitness professional for a lifetime. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH400:08:15Chapter 4 ReferencesApodaca, T. R., Jackson, K. M., Borsari, B., Magill, M., Longabaugh, R., Mastroleo, N. R., & Barnett, N. P. (2016, Feb.). Which Individual Therapist Behaviors Elicit Client Change Talk and Sustain Talk in Motivational Interviewing? Journal of Substance Abuse Treatment, 61: 60–65. https://doi.org/:10.1016/j.jsat.2015.09.001

Armstrong, M. J., Mottershead, T. A., Ronksley, P. E., Sigal, R. J., Campbell, T. S., & Hemmelgarn, B. R. (2011, Sept.). Motivational interviewing to improve weight loss in overweight and/or obese patients: a systematic review and meta-analysis of randomized controlled trials. Obesity Reviews, 12(9): 709–723. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-789X.2011.00892.x

Casa, D. J., Cheuvront, S. N., Galloway, S. D., & Shirreffs, S. M. (2019). Fluid Needs for Training, Competition, and Recovery in Track-and-Field Athletes. International Journal of Sport Nutrition and Exercise Metabolism, 29(2): 175–180. https://doi.org/10.1123/ijsnem.2018-0374

Clement, J. (2019, Aug.). Daily number of e-mails worldwide 2023. Statista. Retrieved from https://www.statista.com/statistics/456500/daily-number-of-e-mails-worldwide/

Day, T., & Tosey, P. (2011, Dec.). Beyond SMART? A new framework for goal setting. The Curriculum Journal, 22(4): 515–534. https://doi.org/10.1080/09585176.2011.627213

Kim, H. -G., Cheon, E. -J., Bai, D. -S., Lee, Y. H., & Koo, B. -H. (2018, March). Stress and Heart Rate Variability: A Meta-Analysis and Review of the Literature. Psychiatry Investigation, 15(3): 235–245. https://doi.org/doi:10.30773/pi.2017.08.17

Khorzoghi, M. B., Sahebozamani, M., & Karimi, M. T. (2018, Oct.). Comparison of the Effectiveness of 8-Week Ultimate-fit Combined Field exercise and Tele-Exercise Program on Static and Dynamic Balance Parameters of the Elderly Man. Journal of Gerontology, 3(1): 35–47. https://doi.org/10.29252/joge.3.1.35

Kushlev, K., Proulx, J., & Dunn, E. W. (2016, May). "Silence Your Phones": Smartphone Notifications Increase Inattention and Hyperactivity Symptoms. Proceedings of the 2016 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 1011–1020. https://doi.org/10.1145/2858036.2858359

Landis, A. M., Parker, K. P., & Dunbar, S. B. (2009). Sleep, hunger, satiety, food cravings, and caloric intake in adolescents. Journal of Nursing Scholarship, 41(2): 115–123. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1547-5069.2009.01262.x

Levinger, I., Goodman, C., Hare, D. L., Jerums, G., Toia, D., & Selig, S. (2009, March) The reliability of the 1RM strength test for untrained middle-aged individuals. Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport, 12(2): 310–316. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jsams.2007.10.007

Ogbeiwi, O. (2017, July). Why written objectives need to be really SMART. British Journal of Healthcare Management, 23(7): 324–336. https://doi.org/10.12968/bjhc.2017.23.7.324

Perrin, A., & Kumar, M. (2019, July). About three-in-ten U.S. adults say they are 'almost constantly' online. Pew Research Center. Retrieved from https://pewrsr.ch/2Y5pwdX

Rubak, S., Sandbaek, A., Lauritzen, T., & Christensen, B. (2005, April). Motivational interviewing: a systematic review and meta-analysis. The British Journal of General Practice, 55(513): 305–312.

Schwebel, F. J., & Larimer, M. E. (2018, June). Using text message reminders in health care services: A narrative literature review. Internet Interventions, 13: 82–104. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.invent.2018.06.002

Sutin, A. R., & Terracciano, A. (2013, July). Perceived weight discrimination and obesity. PloS One, 8(7): e70048. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0070048

Watson, J. C., Steckley, P. L., & McMullen, E. J. (2014). The role of empathy in promoting change. Psychotherapy Research, 24(3): 286–298. https://doi.org/10.1080/10503307.2013.802823

Chapter 5: Administering Virtual Assessments

Chapter 5: Administering Virtual Assessments

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningChapter 5: Administering Virtual Assessments Developing and executing individualized training programs begins with assessing clients. Based on the client's goal, sport, current conditioning, or previous injuries, it is important to develop a baseline with ongoing assessments to achieve outcomes in the safest and most efficient manner possible. This chapter will review how to develop and execute comprehensive assessments in a remote capacity by utilizing technology and other resources available.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Develop a virtual assessment toolkit.

Identify safe and effective methods for administering remote assessments.

Determine how to modify remote assessments based on client type or physical readiness.

Use technology to assist in reliable data collection.

Introduction

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningIntroductionThe role of a fitness professional is to support clients in achieving their health and fitness goals in the safest, most efficient manner possible. Assessments—and subsequently, reassessments—are integral components to this process. Fitness professionals will administer a variety of assessments with clients to establish a starting point for their program and a baseline from which to measure and track progress toward goals over time. With some modifications and additional resources, these assessments can be conducted virtually without compromising safety, utility, and effectiveness.

Le Panda/Shutterstock.comWhile clients are typically able to define their own health and fitness goals, they often lack an objective understanding of their baseline starting point. Considering this, in order to develop an effective, individualized program, fitness professionals must utilize both objective and subjective assessment tools to gain a better understanding of a client's baseline strengths and areas of opportunity with respect to their goal/s, medical history, exercise history, current levels of fitness and conditioning, recreational or sport activities, and/or previous injuries. Following a phase of analysis, this assessment and reassessment data can be utilized to develop and modify individualized programs, monitor progress toward goals and objectives, and be leveraged to provide reinforcement for adherence and retention.

Administering assessments is common practice for the trained fitness professional. When performed remotely, there are considerations and modifications necessary to maintain safety and reliability, which will be discussed in this chapter. Fitness professionals should rely on additional resources and technologies, when applicable, for administering virtual assessments.

Helpful Hint Navigating a Client's Health and Fitness Journey:

To develop the most efficient route (program), a client must define the intended destination (goal) but also have a precise understanding of the starting location (baseline). As the client is en route to their destination, navigation may recommend a slight detour (program modification made based on reassessment) with the ultimate goal of reaching the destination in the safest and most efficient manner possible.

ObjectiveAn assessment based on facts or direct measurement, such as a quantitative measurement.

SubjectiveAn assessment based on individual opinion or perception, which lacks the ability to directly measure.

ReliabilityThe accuracy of a measurement or the degree to which the measurement can be relied upon.

Virtual Assessment Toolkit

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningVirtual Assessment ToolkitFitness professionals should develop a categorized list of assessments that are feasible, within their credentials and expertise, and can be reliably performed virtually, without physical contact. After developing a comprehensive, categorized assessment list, considerations of application to client type and relevance, access to specific equipment and/or technology, and modifications based on previous injuries or physical limitations will help organize and standardize the assessment process.

While not exhaustive, Table: Virtual Assessments lists common assessments that can be administered virtually. A fitness professional should assess their own skills, expertise, resources, and feasibility/practicality when developing an assessment list for their own coaching business.

Ilin Sergey/Shutterstock.comVirtual AssessmentsAssessment Type

Description

Examples

Questionnaire/Survey

A specific set of questions to assess an individual's goals, health status, or lifestyle habits

PAR-Q+

Health History Questionnaire

Dietary Assessment Forms

Physiological

An evaluation of certain physical and physiological characteristics

Heart rate

Blood pressure

Cardiorespiratory Fitness

Anthropometric

Posture, Movement, and Mobility

An evaluation of an individual’s movement pattern quality, neuromuscular control, and/or range of motion

Static Posture

Apley scratch test

Overhead squat

Single-leg squat

Pushing/pulling

Muscular Endurance

An evaluation of muscular strength with respect to time or repetitions until fatigue or compensation

Push-up

Plank test

Wall sit test

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningFitness professionals should then develop a general schedule of assessment frequency (Table: General Schedule of Assessment Frequency), which may vary based on the client type or perceived progress. Reassessment provides the opportunity to show objective and quantifiable progress to maintain client adherence and motivation, but reassessing too frequently can also lead to discouragement if progress is not evident. For example, a weight-loss client may reassess scale weight on a weekly or biweekly basis but perhaps only take circumference measurements once per month.

General Schedule of Assessment Frequency Assessment Type

Description

Resources (Required and Recommended)

Frequency of Reassessment

Scale weight

Assessment of physical body weight, measured in lbs

Digital or manual (analog) scale

Determined on client-by-client basis

Resting heart rate

Assessment of heart rate at rest, measured in beats per minute (bpm)

Instructions

Clock or stopwatch

Bi-weekly

Continuous if wearable device available

Overhead squat

Functional assessment of kinetic chain neuromuscular control and compensatory mechanisms

Instructions

Video: live stream and/or recorded

Monthly

As needed to assess progress and modify program

Push-up test

Assessment of upper body strength and endurance

Instructions

Video: live stream and/or recorded

Monthly

As needed to assess progress and modify program

General Schedule of Assessment Frequency

Technology and Resources

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningTechnology and ResourcesAccording to the Pew Research Center (2019), approximately 96% of Americans own a cell phone and nearly three-quarters of U.S. adults own a personal computer. These devices are often equipped with valuable technology for facilitating remote assessments, including high-resolution cameras, video conferencing applications, a timer, stopwatch, and email access.

While a fitness professional should not rely on a client having access to such technology, the ability to use these resources when available can significantly expedite and expand the range of assessments conducted while improving interpretation of the data. See Table: Types of Technology for types of technology the fitness professional might use.

Types of TechnologyTechnology

Technology Description

Conducting movement assessments via a video conferencing session may allow for better communication of instructions, improve client comfort, and be recorded for interpretation or side-by-side comparison.

Using email or text messaging for daily communication, or in addition to a twice-a-week training session, may help build and maintain a trusting client–trainer relationship while improving a fitness professional's ability to manage more clients.

Android and Apple cell phones often come pre-equipped with health applications (Samsung Health or Apple Health) with features that allow clients to measure, track, and even share their data, including workouts, caloric intake, weight, and heart rate. Cell phones can also be used to facilitate more personal communication with clients.

Cell phones, computers, or standalone cameras provide the ability to record physiological assessments for later interpretation so fitness professionals can dedicate real-time efforts toward motivating, coaching, and facilitating a safe and reliable virtual assessment.

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningIn addition to the connected devices, there are many software platforms available for fitness professionals. These include but are not limited to survey, nutrition, and all-in-one training applications that can aggregate, analyze, and trend assessment data over time while improving the efficiency and individualization of program development. A spreadsheet is an alternative option in addition to software platforms to log client data and stay organized.

Table: Example Applications and Platforms provides a few examples of highly rated applications and platforms used by fitness professionals but it should not be considered a comprehensive or exhaustive list. Fitness professionals should do their own research to determine the best platform solution with regard to client type, usability, and cost.

Example Applications and PlatformsSurvey Tools

Nutrition Tracking

All-in-One

Typeform

MyFitnessPal

NASM Edge

Google Forms

MyNetDiary

TrueCoach

SurveyMonkey

MyPlate Calorie Counter

My PT Hub

Administering Pre-Participation Health Screening

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningAdministering Pre-Participation Health ScreeningImportant components of program development include safety and sustainability. In order to develop individualized programs that address these components, fitness professionals should always administer some type of pre-participation health screening as a portion of the intake process. There are various types of health screening tools available, which can be efficiently conducted via email, phone call, or video conferencing. Fitness professionals may standardize the pre-participation health screening process or determine which tools to use on a client-by-client basis.

To begin the intake process, the fitness professional should do the following:

Assess his/her client's experience, comfort, and access to technology, or ask directly which method they would prefer.

Administer the pre-participation health screening. In general, some form of pre-participation health screening is recommended for all fitness professionals, but it may not be necessary to perform all of the listed pre-health screening tools.

Organize the pre-participation health screening information for future access with consideration to client privacy. Instead of saving client files on a desktop, fitness professionals may consider a cloud storage account. Not only do these platforms require a password and additional security, but they also provide accessibility from any connected device.

In addition, there are many online tools and websites that allow professionals to build custom surveys, automatically share by e-mail at a predefined frequency, and produce summary reports.

Coach's CornerWhile saving client information online, be sure to keep this information secure and consistent with HIPAA (1996) policies.

Physical Activity Readiness Questionnaire for Everyone (PAR-Q+)

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningPhysical Activity Readiness Questionnaire for Everyone (PAR-Q+)The Physical Activity Readiness Questionnaire for Everyone (PAR-Q+) is a standardized assessment of a client's readiness to engage in physical activity. Fitness professionals should avoid making assumptions or relying on aesthetic characteristics alone when determining physical readiness for any type of program or intervention. Due to the personal and sensitive nature of the questions, the PAR-Q+ is generally self-administered with minimal guidance. Instructions are included in the PAR-Q+, but a fitness professional should consider providing a brief overview and instructions.

The PAR-Q+ consists entirely of yes or no answers, with instructions to complete additional sections based on responses. In order to be considered valid, the PAR-Q+ does require a participant signature. For this reason, clients may consider printing and scanning the completed document, which may be done with a scanner or personal camera and sent via email or text message (Figure: Technology for PAR-Q+).

FigureTechnology for PAR-Q+Food for ThoughtPAR-Q Versus PAR-Q+

Among the most accepted and widely used health screening surveys is the PAR-Q+. The original PAR-Q, created by the British Columbia Ministry of Health and the Multidisciplinary Board on Exercise, was developed as a standardized assessment to gauge an individual's readiness to perform physical activity. Based on feedback from individuals engaging in physical activity, fitness professionals, and medical physicians, researchers found that the original PAR-Q had limitations in terms of utility and effectiveness across the broad population, citing that the established health benefits of participation far outweigh the risks (Bredin, Gledhill, Jamnik & Warburton, 2013).

Whereas the PAR-Q unnecessarily restricted exercise for populations who would benefit from physical activity, the revised PAR-Q+ was developed to be more inclusive, with the + indicating "For Everyone."

2020 PAR-Q+ Template

Lifestyle and Health History Questionnaire

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningLifestyle and Health History QuestionnaireThe Lifestyle and Health History Questionnaire is intended to assess a client's baseline habits, goals, and readiness to safely engage in physical activity. Fitness professionals should provide a brief overview and instructions, if self-administered, or consider guiding the client through each category and section via video conference or phone (Figure: Technology for Questionnaire).

FigureTechnology for QuestionnaireThe Lifestyle and Health History Questionnaire is separated into six distinct categories:

Exercise

Diet

Lifestyle

Occupation

Recreation

Medical

It may not be necessary to use this entire questionnaire if the PAR-Q+ has been completed; however, fitness professionals should use some alternative methods to obtain user-defined goals and lifestyle habits that may impact program outcomes. Additionally, fitness professionals should consider asking further questions based on the client's lifestyle, occupation, or goals. For example, if the client rates a particularly high level of work-related stress, questions related to an average work week may provide deeper transparency into how to develop an effective program with realistic expectations.

Lifestyle and Health History Questionnaire

Dietary Assessment Forms

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningDietary Assessment FormsDietary assessment forms are utilized to identify and monitor nutritional patterns, including consumption of all food, beverages, and supplementation. The purpose of nutritional assessments is not to discourage a client but, rather, help bring attention to nutritional habits that might discourage progress. Fitness professionals may decide to use all, some, or none of these dietary assessment forms based on their qualifications and expertise.

24-Hour RecallThe 24-hour recall is intended to rapidly assess a client's perception and memory of nutritional intake of the previous 24 hours, including all food, beverages, and supplements. The fitness professional should prompt client reporting of the following:

Food Item Description

Type of food or beverage

Method of preparation (home cooked, leftovers, pre-made, restaurant, etc.)

Brand name or restaurant

Serving Size/Amount/Portion Description

Time Consumed

Location Consumed and Occasion

i.e., kitchen table, living room, restaurant, etc.

Why? i.e., hungry, bored, post-exercise fueling, etc.

Rawpixel.com/Shutterstock.comNormally performed as an in-person interview, it is recommended that fitness professionals conduct the 24-hour recall via phone call or video conference (Figure: Technology for 24-Hour Recall). Because this assessment should be based on the client's memory, communications methods such as text messaging or email should be avoided.

FigureTechnology for 24-Hour RecallCritical! Understanding Limitations of 24-Hour Recall:

Self-administered nutrition assessments, including the 24-hour recall, may be subject to underreporting of energy intake, particularly in certain subgroups of the population including those with a high BMI (Johansson et al., 2001). In general, fitness professionals should use this assessment tool to improve client self-awareness and to improve nutritional habits through comparison of 24-hour recall logs over time.

24-Hour Recall Worksheet

Usual Intake Worksheet

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningUsual Intake WorksheetThe usual intake worksheet is intended to gain a broad overview of nutritional habits in general, not limited to just the previous 24-hours. As opposed to unstructured recall, the fitness professional should ask specific questions related to the consumption frequency of various food and beverage categories. A common assessment method includes structured question and response choices as follows:

FigureTechnology for Usual Intake Worksheet

Over the previous year, how often did you consume alcohol?

Never

1 time per month or less

2–3 times per month

1–2 times per week

3–4 times per week

5–6 times per week

Daily

Multiple times per day

Important intake categories to assess include but may not be limited to water, caffeine, foods and beverages containing a significant amount of sugar, and specific questions to gauge intake of specific micro- and macronutrients. Another method is to provide a list of time segments throughout the day (early morning, morning, midday, etc.) and have a client describe their normal intake in their own words.

The usual intake assessments can be performed via phone call, video conference, or email (Figure: Technology for Usual Intake Worksheet).

Usual Intake Worksheet

Interpreting Results

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 1Virtual Pre-Participation Health ScreeningInterpreting ResultsFitness professionals should thoroughly analyze clients' nutritional habits to gauge caloric intake and potential macro- and micronutrient deficiencies. Manually calculating all of these foods can be a tedious task; therefore, it is recommended that fitness professionals use a nutritional tracking software to analyze and interpret the nutritional assessment forms. The NASM Edge app (Figure: NASM Edge app) also offers a macronutrient calculator. The purpose is to understand individual caloric requirements and nutritional habits that may limit program efficacy and to develop meaningful and sustainable interventions for long-term success.

FigureNASM Edge app

Administering Physiological Assessments Virtually

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsAdministering Physiological Assessments VirtuallyIn addition to survey information, an effective program should be developed based on individualized physiological data. Physiological measurements are those that objectively quantify certain characteristics, including body weight, circumference measurements, and vital signs. Fitness professionals should focus on education and committable habits to help clients understand the importance of accurately measuring physiological data. Leveraging cost-effective and readily available technology will improve data reliability and avoid human error in data collection and/or reporting.

Physiological AssessmentsIt is important to understand that physiological assessments are sensitive to the external environment, influenced by physical exertion, and may fluctuate significantly throughout the day. Fitness professionals should consciously avoid confounds during physiological assessments. As a general rule, physiological assessments should be performed in the following ways:

First thing in the morning, ideally at the same time each day, in the same outfit

In the same position each time – Results can be significantly different in a seated versus standing position.

No earlier than 2 hours following exercise or a stressful event

No earlier than 1 hour after consuming caffeine

Using the same data collection method, instructions, and equipment

Fitness professionals should leverage technology and resources to expedite and improve the reliability of virtual physiological assessments. In addition to comprehensive—yet simple and easy-to-understand—written instructions provided via e-mail or text message, fitness professionals may consider pre-recording instructional videos or dedicating time to walk clients through these assessments with live video conferencing, coaching, and demonstration (Figure: Technology for Physiological Assessments).

FigureTechnology for Physiological Assessments

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsOnce prepared, these instructional videos can be shared via e-mail or a preferred communication strategy to improve the efficiency of conducting virtual physiological assessments.

Fitness professionals should avoid generic e-mails and pre-recorded videos by taking the time to customize the e-mail and video introductions, directly referencing the client's name, program goal, and/or modifications that were made based on injury history or health conditions (Figure: Customized Video Introduction).

FigureCustomized Video IntroductionTo facilitate the communication and monitoring of assessment results, fitness professionals should create a standardized process based on the resources available. For example, providing a template in Google Sheets or another spreadsheet program offers a secure and efficient method compared to manual reporting of results by text or e-mail. Based on the assessment frequency, fitness professionals can organize these sheets and schedule automated reminders to keep clients accountable and prompt and monitor compliance. When applications such as Samsung Health or Apple Health are available, clients have the ability to manually enter results, including heart rate, blood pressure, measurements, and scale weight and, with a single click, they can share their results with friends, family members, and/or health and fitness professionals.

Resting Heart Rate

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological Assessments Resting Heart RateResting heart rate, measured in beats per minute, is a common physiological assessment to non-invasively gauge an individual's health and fitness. According to a study of nearly 3,000 male subjects followed over 16 years, researchers concluded that elevated resting heart rate is a risk factor for mortality independent of physical fitness and other major cardiovascular risk factors (Jensen et al. 2013). For this reason, fitness professionals should consistently assess resting heart rate to monitor progress or changes in health status.

Fitness professionals should take the time to guide their clients through a baseline resting heart rate assessment through visual demonstration when possible, which can be accomplished through pre-recorded instructional videos sent by e-mail or a live video conference (Figure: Technology for Resting Heart Rate).

FigureTechnology for Resting Heart Rate

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsTo measure RHR via manual palpation (Figure: Measuring Palpation), consider the following:

Have the individual sit or lie comfortably for several minutes prior to testing.

The RHR is measured via fingertip palpation – Use the index and middle fingertips rather than the thumb, as it has its own pulse.

The fingertips are placed directly over the artery and with lightly applied pressure.

Once a pulse is identified, count the pulses for 60 seconds.

Note that there is no universal consensus on whether the first beat measured should commence with ‘0’ rather than the number ‘1' because cardiac cycles are being counted. Whichever is decided on, do it consistently.

When measuring exercise heart rate, this count can be measured over a 10-second interval and then multiplied by six.

FigureMeasuring PalpationAndrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comAnother method for regularly assessing a client’s resting heart rate, when applicable, is through a wearable device or fitness tracker. These devices often collect heart rate data while the client is sleeping to accurately assess and trend an individual’s resting heart rate over time. Additionally, many cell phones have the ability to reliably measure heart rate using the camera light. Access to these heart rate measuring tools can often be determined by visiting the pre-installed health app (Apple Health or Samsung Health) on most newer devices.

Heart Rate Recovery

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsHeart Rate RecoveryHeart Rate Recovery (HRR) is a measurement of a client’s heart rate after a defined period of time following intense exercise. For example, if a client were to perform an exercise until they achieve an active heart rate of 160 beats per minute, and then, after 1 minute of no exercise, their heart rate returns to 145 beats per minute, this client would have a heart rate recovery of 15 beats per minute. In general, a higher value for heart rate recovery is preferred, as this is correlated with improved fitness and overall cardiovascular health (Dimkpa, 2009).

The method for assessing heart rate recovery should be determined based on the client’s baseline physical fitness and activity level and should always be performed under the guidance of a trained fitness professional. For example, a less-active or older client may be guided through an incremental walk test, where the intensity or speed is gradually increased and the rate of perceived exertion is consistently assessed by the fitness professional. To ensure safety, it is recommended that the fitness professional perform this assessment via video conference or phone call to guide the user through the protocol and assist with recording the heart rate measurements (Figure: Technology for Heart Rate Recovery).

If the client is a well-trained athlete, a fitness professional may consider a more rigorous protocol, such as a functional threshold power assessment. In this population, the client may be more likely to have a heart rate monitor and can accurately and safely perform this assessment without much guidance, although it is still recommended that this be conducted via video conference.

In both cases, the method for assessing heart rate recovery should be standardized. Following exercise, the client may stand up or sit down during the recovery period, but the fitness professional should document this and ensure that future reassessments are performed under the same conditions as this may have an effect on the results.

FigureTechnology for Heart Rate Recovery

Blood Pressure

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsBlood PressureBased on the results of the PAR-Q+ and Health History Questionnaire, it may be necessary to prompt clients to regularly assess their blood pressure. There are many affordable over-the-counter blood pressure devices available, including cuff-based devices worn at the wrist or upper arm. While wrist devices have advantages in terms of size, cost, and fitting, it is important to consider data integrity of such an important physiological assessment. In a population-based study, researchers found that “use of wrist devices for home self-measurement leads to frequent detection of falsely elevated blood pressure values” (Casiglia et al.2016). For this reason, fitness professionals are encouraged to recommend traditional upper-arm monitors.

Prior to assessing blood pressure, clients should be instructed to sit at rest for a minimum of 5 minutes. The following steps are important to reliably measure blood pressure, regardless of the device manufacturer:

Andrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comFIGURETechnology for Blood Pressure

Remove clothing or anything preventing direct contact between the cuff and skin.

Apply the cuff, making sure that the indicator line is placed directly over the artery.

Ensure that the elbow is placed comfortably on a stationary object (such as a desk) with the forearm horizontal across the body. The wrist bone should be at heart level.

Avoid excessive movement during the blood pressure measurement.

Fitness professionals should take the time to guide their clients through baseline blood pressure monitoring via video conferencing or pre-recorded instructional videos to ensure instructions are closely followed to optimize data reliability (Figure: Technology for Blood Pressure). If abnormal values are reported, fitness professionals should consider the live video conference method with step-by-step instructions and feedback to ensure reliable values are obtained.

Anthropometric Assessments

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsAnthropometric AssessmentsAnthropometric assessments are quantitative measurements of the physical body with commonly assessed components, including height, weight, body mass index (BMI), and body circumference (Casadei & Kiel, 2020). These measurements are generally simple to obtain and can be used as a tool to monitor progress, provide reinforcement and motivation, and dynamically adjust programs.

Scale WeightScale weight is among the most common assessment tools available. While it may be simple to instruct a client to step on a scale and write down a number, there are many considerations that impact the reliability of scale weight measurements. The most important consideration for scale weight is consistency.

Due to daily fluctuations in weight throughout the day based on drinking fluids, consuming food, and using the restroom, that simple number on the scale can quickly turn into a less-meaningful tool to assess progress and may lead to discouragement. Fitness professionals may consider averaging client weight over 2 to 4 weeks to account for these normal fluctuations and for a more reliable measurement of change in scale weight over time, particularly in women who may experience weight gain during the menstrual cycle. To facilitate the communication and monitoring of scale weight results, fitness professionals may create a Google Sheet or use another spreadsheet program for immediate manual entry following measurement. Additionally, fitness professionals can instruct clients to immediately report results via e-mail or text message (Figure: Technology for Scale Weight).

9dream studio/Shutterstock.comFIGURETechnology for Scale WeightIn general, a fitness professional should instruct their client to weigh themselves first thing in the morning, prior to the first meal, wearing minimal clothing or the same outfit. Fitness professionals should consider placing less emphasis on scale weight and shifting validation of program success to other assessments that accurately reflect progress, such as photos and circumference measurements.

Critical! Placing too much emphasis on scale weight can be counterproductive. According to Dionne & Yeudall (2005),

Attention focused on one’s current, and presumably undesirable, body size can be motivating to those who want to modify a pattern of unhealthy behavior. For others, this feedback may result in psychological distress and could lead to outcomes that are, in fact, counter to a weight loss strategy, such as attrition from programs, misreporting of dietary intake, and emotional states associated with binge eating.

A fitness professional should consider the client type and program goal to determine how often measurements such as scale weight should be recorded as well as the value to the functional goal of the client in general.

Body Mass Index

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsBody Mass IndexBody mass index (BMI) is a standardized classification tool for indirectly assessing body fat based on a client’s height and weight. BMI classification categories include underweight, healthy weight, overweight, and obese with correlations related to an individual’s risk of heart disease, high blood pressure, Type II diabetes, and other health conditions (National Institute of Health). For this calculation, it is important to input accurate values for height and weight.

To measure height, a client should be instructed to do the following:

Stand flat with heels, back, buttocks, and shoulders against a wall.

Keep the head straight and chin level to the ground.

Mark a line on the wall directly at the top of the head, not including the hair.

Step away from the wall and then use a tape measure to precisely measure the distance from the ground to the drawn line.

LiveVector/Shutterstock.com

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsBMI can be determined using several methods, including mathematical formulas available in both metric and imperial units and various online calculators. There are two formulas to calculate BMI. It is calculated by either dividing a person’s weight in kilograms by the square of their height in meters or dividing their body weight in pounds by the square of their height in inches and multiplying by 703.

Metric Formula: BMI = weight (kg) ÷ [height (m)]2

Imperial Formula: BMI = 703 x weight (lbs.) ÷ [height (in)]2

To avoid errors in calculation fitness professionals should find a reliable BMI calculator app or online tool, such as the Adult BMI Calculator (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2020), which automatically classifies the client’s BMI. If the client does not have a scale, purchasing one that reports BMI may be encouraged. Similarly, these tools require accurate inputs of height and weight.

To facilitate the communication and monitoring of BMI results, many smart scales offer the ability to manually share the results and trend graphs with a single click. If this resource is not available, fitness professionals should add a column for BMI input into a prepared Google Sheet or other spreadsheet program or provide instructions to e-mail and/or text results immediately following measurement.

Coach's CornerIt is important to note that BMI has limitations in certain populations, including individuals and athletes with higher bone density and muscle mass.

Waist-to-Hip Ratio

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsWaist-to-Hip RatioMeasuring waist-to-hip ratio (WHR) is another cost-effective and simple way to perform an assessment that provides insight into a client's body composition and the ability to show progress over time through scheduled reassessment. In a study published by the Annals of Internal Medicine, researchers found that obesity defined by WHR was associated with higher mortality rate than body mass index (Sahakyan et al., 2015).

The only equipment required to assess waist and hip circumference is a measuring tape, which is typically found at local general merchandise, pharmacy, or online retailers. A measuring tape should not be confused with a tape measure, which is more rigid and will not snugly wrap around the body.

To measure waist and hip circumference, it is important to provide guidance or instructional images to the client to ensure these areas are accurately and precisely measured. For initial baseline measurements, anthropometric assessments should be conducted via video conferencing to ensure the appropriate physical landmarks are adhered to. Follow-up assessments may be conducted via phone call or self-administered, but fitness professionals should assess for abnormal values and revert to video conferencing as needed.

To accurately measure waist circumference, do the following:

Identify the narrowest point of the torso below the rib cage and above the iliac crest (top portion of the hip bone) at the hips.

Take this measurement as close to the skin as possible.

Be sure the tape runs horizontally around the entire body circumference.

Keep the tape flat and avoid any twisting.

The tape should be pulled snugly but not to the point of causing an indentation in the skin.

Take the waist measurement at end-tidal volume, following normal expiration.

Record scores to nearest millimeter or 1/16″.

Prostock-studio/Shutterstock.com

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsTo accurately measure hip circumference, do the following:

Stand straight with feet together and locate the widest portion of the hips, often at the level of the mid-buttocks.

Wrap the measuring tape snugly around this area, ensuring that the measuring tape is level and not angled. The measuring tape should not be pulled so tight as to compress the skin.

Record the hip measurement.

Take the measurement at least twice to ensure accuracy. If the values do not match, perform until repeatable measurements are obtained.

To calculate waist-to-hip ratio, simply convert the measurements to centimeters (cm) and divide the waist measurement by the hip measurement. The World Health Organization (WHO, 2008) defines abdominal obesity as a WHR above 0.90 in males and above 0.85 in females (2008) (Figure: Hip Circumference).

FigureHip CircumferenceTo personalize and optimize the efficiency of these assessments, consider filming a short instructional video of how to properly take waist and hip circumference measurements. These pre-recorded instructional videos can be shared with virtual training clients via e-mail or text message to expedite the assessment process. To facilitate the communication and monitoring of results, fitness professionals may create an additional column in Google Sheets or another spreadsheet program for manual input or prompt clients to immediately send results via e-mail or text message following measurement.

Circumference Measurements

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsCircumference MeasurementsDepending on the client type and program goal, a fitness professional may consider a more comprehensive assessment of circumference measurements. Once again, it is important to provide guidance and instructional images or videos to ensure the measurements are accurately obtained at the correct physical location. Circumference measurements should not be utilized to assess fatness but, rather, to identify progress or changes in overall girth. The placement of the measuring tape for each circumference measurement is as follows:

Circumference Measurement Sites Site

Description of Location

Placement of Measuring Tape

Neck

Measure just below the larynx (across the Adam's apple for men).

Chest

Measure across the fullest part of chest.

Waist

Measure at the narrowest point of the waist, below the rib cage and just above the top of the hipbones. If there is no apparent narrowing of the waist, measure at the navel.

Hips

With feet together, measure circumference at the widest portion of the buttocks.

Thigh

While standing, legs 10 cm (4″) apart, measure the largest circumference immediately below the gluteal fold.

Calves

Measure the calf at its fullest part, taken between the ankle and the knee.

Arm

Measure the upper arm at its fullest part, taken at midpoint between the shoulder and elbow.

In general, all circumference measurements should be recorded at least twice to ensure accuracy. If the two measurements are not identical, continue to assess until repeatable measurements are obtained. For circumference measurements including the thighs, calves and biceps, a fitness professional should determine if measurements will be taken on both sides or limited to one side only. If circumference measurements are taken on only one side, it is important to document this to ensure consistency when performing reassessments.

As with the waist and hip measurements, it is recommended that the fitness professional takes the time to create personalized demonstration videos for the client on how to properly record circumference measurements. Clients can document and share these results in a standardized template provided by the fitness professional or immediately share results by e-mail or text message following measurements.

Bioelectrical Impedance Analysis (BIA)

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsBioelectrical Impedance Analysis (BIA)Bioelectrical Impedance Analysis (BIA) is a reliable measurement tool for assessing additional anthropometric measurements, including fat mass, skeletal muscle mass, total body water, and protein and mineral content. Obtaining these additional measurements will allow fitness professionals to go beyond simple scale weight monitoring to objectively assess changes in body fat and muscle to show meaningful progress and optimize client adherence and retention.

BIA works by passing a small and precise frequency of electricity through the body and measuring the impedance or resistance caused by specific types of body composition. For example, this electricity will flow smoothly through water, but will have higher levels of resistance when passing through fat tissue. This assessment requires physical contact on electrode sites, most commonly both feet (two contact points) when using a scale incorporating BIA technology, but often includes the hands (four contact points) in more advanced devices as well.

Koldunov Alexey/Shutterstock.comFIGURETechnology for BIADepending on the program goal, a fitness professional may consider recommending that their client visit a location that offers BIA testing or purchase an at home BIA scale for regular assessment of body composition. In both instances, the results of single or multiple assessments may be shared as a PDF via e-mail or directly through a reporting software (Figure: Technology for BIA). While BIA is considered a generally safe assessment, it is important to note that there are contraindications, including pacemakers, metal implants, and pregnancy. In addition, BIA assessment should be done under similar circumstances, if possible, as they are easily manipulated by hydration status, proximity to the last workout, and even digestive content.

Before/After Photos

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsBefore/After PhotosBeyond showing quantitative progress, clients are often reinforced by actually visualizing their progress. Instructing clients to take photos of their body over time is simple and readily obtainable with only the need of a basic camera. However, this should be performed with consideration of consistency in conditions, angles, outfit, and lighting.

Conditions refers to taking body images at the same time and under the same conditions each time. For example, if a client takes baseline images first thing in the morning, after skipping dinner the evening before, but then takes the follow-up images on a full stomach or after drinking a lot of water, these follow up images can lead to a perceived lack of results when meaningful progress has been made. If a client wants to flex for baseline body images, they should be instructed to do the same for all follow-up photos.

Obtaining images at the wrong or inconsistent angle can misrepresent the actual appearance of the human body and limit the ability to effectively show progress. In general, clients should be recommended to use the following angles for body progress photos (Figure: Body Progress Photos Angles):

Frontal: Directly facing the camera, standing with normal, relaxed posture

Side: Facing perpendicular to the camera, standing with normal, relaxed posture

Back: Facing away from the camera, with normal, relaxed posture

FigureBody Progress Photos AnglesCoach's CornerClients can also take a video with the held poses and then screenshot the image if they are having difficulty with timed photos.

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 2Virtual Physiological AssessmentsConsistency in lighting is also important to obtaining a high-quality photo. In general, natural lighting is preferred but it is more important to maintain consistency. If a client feels more comfortable taking body images in the privacy of their bathroom, a fitness professional should recommend follow-up images in the same location and lighting conditions. Clients should be instructed to avoid any shadows across the body for all images.

Clients may share the body image results via e-mail or text message or upload into a secure shared folder set up by the fitness professional. Fitness professionals should organize client folders for secure photo storage, titled by date. To optimize the ability to show consistent progress, a regular schedule, such as taking body images on the first of each month, should be maintained. As significant progress is shown, putting together a quick collage of photos over time can be an invaluable tool for providing reinforcement and maintaining client motivation. Photos and measurements can also be more telling of body composition changes at a time when weight is stable or being influenced by outside forces (i.e., stress, fluid retention, etc.).

Coach's CornerGetting consent from a client is important if the fitness professional wants to use client images for other reasons besides training.

Administering Movement and Mobility Assessments Virtually

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 3Virtual Movement and Mobility AssessmentsAdministering Movement and Mobility Assessments Virtually In addition to quantitative assessments including range of motion, fitness professionals should also prompt the client to report any specific or broad areas of pain or discomfort experienced during movement and mobility assessments. Many clients may not have knowledge of physiological landmarks. Therefore, it may be best to have them point to the area of discomfort and rate their pain on a standardized scale (such as 0–10) and refer them to the appropriate practitioner (doctor or physical therapist) on a case-dependent basis, making sure to operate within the fitness professional's scope of certification. Certain applications may have a survey capability or self-administered assessment where clients can indicate the areas and associated levels of pain/soreness/discomfort. Such tools/functionality can be leveraged to monitor and track changes in body discomfort and soreness over time, which may be particularly useful to adjust and modify programming, if necessary, as well as provide reinforcement for clients who are looking to feel better as a program goal.

Apley Scratch TestThe Apley Scratch Test is a valuable assessment of upper extremity mobility limitations for consideration when developing a safe and effective exercise program. This assessment should only be performed under the live guidance of a qualified fitness professional using video conferencing. Fitness professionals should record this assessment for later interpretation to focus real-time efforts on guiding the client through a safe and effective assessment.

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 3Virtual Movement and Mobility AssessmentsTo perform a remote Apley Scratch Test (Figure: Apley Scratch Test Technique), consider the following:

The client may be seated or standing to perform this assessment.

The client should ask for help from a friend or set up their camera to ensure stability. The camera (phone, computer camera, or dedicated camera) should be level, and the client should be close enough to clearly visualize the area between the top of the head and lower back.

Using the right arm, the client is instructed to touch their opposite shoulder blade with the arm behind the head and neck.

The client is instructed to place the left arm behind the back and slowly reach upwards as far as possible with the goal of touching or even interlocking the fingers of both hands, if possible.

The test is then repeated performing the opposite motions with each arm to assess and compare mobility in each arm/shoulder and between sides.

FigureApley Scratch Test Technique

Overhead Squat Assessment

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 3Virtual Movement and Mobility AssessmentsOverhead Squat AssessmentThe overhead squat assessment is a reliable functional evaluation of kinetic chain movement quality, neuromuscular control, and compensatory mechanisms that can be safely performed in a remote capacity with most client types. This assessment should only be performed under the live guidance of a qualified fitness professional using video conferencing or if the instructions are explicit and clear. It may be recorded by the client and sent to the fitness professional for observation and analysis. Fitness professionals should record this assessment for later interpretation and comparison to focus real-time efforts on guiding the client through the process safely and effectively.

While the overhead squat assessment may be used—and useful—for all client types, research has shown that it may provide more information in less-experienced clients and athletes who are still learning to control complex movement patterns (Bishop et al., 2016).

To perform an overhead squat assessment remotely (Figure: Overhead Squat Technique), consider the following:

The client should ask for help from a friend or set up their camera to ensure stability. The camera should be level, and the client should be framed to capture the top of the fingertips down to a clear visual of both feet and ankles. Excess dead space above or below these physical landmarks should be avoided.

Ideally, the client should wear form-fitting clothing within their level of comfort that does not match or blend into their background. A solid color and complete background (a wall) is preferable for observation and interpretation.

Clients should be instructed to remove their socks and shoes for a clear visual of the feet and ankles.

With the feet positioned shoulder-width apart and feet pointed directly forward, the client should raise both arms completely overhead with the elbows fully extended.

Instruct the client to maintain arms in this overhead position, to the best of their ability, while squatting to a depth that brings their upper legs parallel to the ground (roughly to the height of a typical chair) or as deeply as possible without significant discomfort for a total of five repetitions.

The assessment should be repeated with identical instructions from anterior, posterior, and lateral vantage points. To standardize the assessment, the camera should be left in the same place and the client instructed to simply rotate their body in relation to the camera to change angles.

FigureOverhead Squat TechniqueNASM provides a comprehensive checkpoint table to assist fitness professionals in the standardized interpretation of movement compensations during the OHS, overactive, and underactive musculature and corrective program development.

Single-Leg Squat Assessment

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 3Virtual Movement and Mobility AssessmentsSingle-Leg Squat AssessmentThe single-leg squat (SLS) is a simple, reliable, and relatively easy to administer assessment of stability, strength, balance, and motor control of the lower extremity, and Lumbo-Pelvic-Hip complex regions. Due to the complexity, strength, and balance requirements to perform an SLS assessment, it has been shown that physically active individuals with greater hip and knee flexion seem to be at lower risk to perform the SLS than non-physically active individuals (Gianola et al., 2017). The SLS assessment should be performed at the fitness professional's discretion based on the physical activity levels and injury history of the client. Similarly to the OHS, this assessment should be conducted during a live video conference and recorded for later interpretation in order to focus real-time efforts on guiding the client through the assessment safely and effectively. Conversely, if the instructions are explicit and clear, it may be recorded by the client and sent to the fitness professional for observation and analysis.

To perform an SLS assessment remotely, Livengood, Dimattia & Uhl (2004) recommends the following (Figure: Single-leg Squat Technique):

The client should ask for help from a friend or set up their camera with live video conferencing to ensure stability. The camera should be level, and the client should be framed to capture the top of the head down to a clear visual of both feet and ankles. Excess dead space above or below these physical landmarks should be avoided.

Ideally the client should wear form-fitting clothing, within their level of comfort, that provides visualization of both knees during all portions of the SLS assessment and that does not match or blend into their background. A solid color and complete background (a wall) is preferable for observation and interpretation.

Clients should be instructed to remove their socks and shoes for a clear visual of the feet and ankles.

Instruct the client to place their hands on their hips and to stand on a single leg with the other leg lifted off the ground, hip and knee flexed at a 45- and 90-degree angle, respectively. The foot of the non-stance leg should remain directly beside the stance leg/foot without touching it.

While maintaining hands on hips, the client should squat to approximately 60 degrees of knee flexion or as deeply as possible without losing balance before returning to the start position in less than 6 seconds.

Perform up to five repetitions before switching sides.

Repeat identical assessment protocol on the other leg to assess for compensations and differences bilaterally.

FigureSingle-Leg Squat TechniqueFitness professionals should consider a modified single-leg balance assessment for clients who are not confident in their abilities, pregnant, obese, or exhibit any other contraindications to performing an SLS assessment.

NASM provides a comprehensive checkpoint table to assist fitness professionals in the standardized interpretation of movement compensations during the SLS, overactive, and underactive musculature and corrective program development.

Pushing/Pulling Assessments

Chapter 5Administering Virtual AssessmentsLesson 3Virtual Movement and Mobility AssessmentsPushing/Pulling AssessmentsPushing and pulling assessments are a noninvasive method for assessing movement efficiency, mechanics, and muscle imbalances of the scapulae and shoulders and stability of the lumbo-pelvic-hip complex, cervical spine, and head. These assessments often require access to training equipment, such as free weights, a pulley system, or resistance bands, and may not be applicable or available for all remote-training clients. Ideally, the assessment should be performed live using video conferencing and recorded for later analysis and interpretation in order to focus real-time efforts on guiding the client through a safe and effective assessment. However, if the instructions are explicit and clear, and/or a video example with instructions is provided to the client, it may be a viable option for the client to record themselves performing the movements and send the recording to the fitness professional for observation and analysis. For the purposes of virtual assessments, variations utilizing a resistance exercise band are as follows.

To perform remote pushing and pulling assessments (Figure: Pushing/Pulling Techniques), consider the following:

The client should ask for help from a friend or set up their camera (with live video conferencing) to ensure stability. The camera should be level, and the client should be framed to capture the top of the head down to a clear visual of both feet and ankles. Excess dead space above or below these physical landmarks should be avoided.

It is important that the client wear form-fitting clothing within their level of comfort that does not match or blend into their background. A solid color and complete background (a wall) is preferable for interpretation.

Choose a resistance band that allows for a minimum of 20 repetitions in each assessment. These assessments are not meant to assess muscular strength or cause significant fatigue.

The client should be instructed to find a stationary object, such as a pole, to anchor the resistance band around ensuring equal length and tension on each side of the band. If the client has a door anchor specifically for use with resistance bands, they can certainly use that placed between the closed door and door jamb. Do not use an object that may move or fall over during this assessment.

FigurePushing/Pulling Techniques

Holding a handle in each hand at the level of the mid-chest, the client should stand with feet shoulder-width apart, body centered to the stationary object, and toes pointing directly forward.

For the pushing assessment, the client should be facing away from the stationary object.

For the pulling assessment, the client should be facing toward the stationary object.

While maintaining a controlled tempo throughout, the client should slowly push (or pull) handles away from (or toward) the body and return to the starting position. Approximately 10 to 20 repetitions should be completed for each pattern.

The pushing assessment is similar to a standing chest press.

The pulling assessment is similar to a standing row.

Note any flaws in technique and movement compensations that should be addressed in the client's program.

Fitness professionals should use their judgement when deciding whether to perform pushing or pulling assessments with their virtual/remote clients.

Administering Muscular Endurance Assessments Virtually

Chapter 5Administering Virtual Assessments Lesson 4Virtual Muscular Endurance AssessmentsAdministering Muscular Endurance Assessments Virtually Muscular endurance assessments are simple and generally safe due to the use of body weight alone and do not require additional equipment to perform. While it may still be preferable to perform muscular endurance assessments via video conference for accountability, instruction, and monitoring, these can generally be performed with basic instructional videos or e-mailed PDF guides and client reporting. Fitness professionals should consider running clients through a low-intensity, dynamic warm-up prior to conducting muscular endurance assessments.

Push-Up TestsPush-up tests provide a strength and endurance assessment of the upper body musculature during a pushing pattern. While there are multiple variations available, the most common include maximal and modified push-up tests, which may be preferable for apparently healthy populations, including women, youth, obese, or older clients.

Lucky Business/Shutterstock.com

Content

Chapter 5Administering Virtual Assessments Lesson 4Virtual Muscular Endurance AssessmentsTo perform a virtual maximal push-up test, consider the following:

Instruct the individual to assume a push-up position with hands slightly outside of shoulder-width apart, elbows and knees fully extended, and the spine in a neutral position. If the client is not able to perform a standard push-up, the client can perform push-ups from a kneeling position as outlined below.

The client lowers their body until the elbows reach approximately 90 degrees of flexion or the chest makes contact with the ground.

With no rest in between, return to the starting position with the arms fully extended.

Continue until the client is no longer able to complete a repetition to the appropriate depth or fails to perform repetitions without compensation or any additional part of the body makes contact with the ground.

Record the total number of repetitions completed.

The client should be reassessed at regular intervals (e.g., 4 to 6 weeks) to evaluate progress.

To perform a virtual modified push-up test, consider the following:

Instruct the individual to assume a push-up position with hands slightly outside of shoulder-width apart, elbows fully extended, knees on the ground hip-width apart, and the spine in a neutral position, with hips in line with the knees and shoulders.

The client lowers their body until the elbows reach approximately 90 degrees of flexion or the chest makes contact with the ground.

With no rest in between, return to the starting position with the arms fully extended.

Continue until the client is no longer able to complete a repetition to the appropriate depth or fails to perform repetitions without compensation or any additional part of the body makes contact with the ground.

Record the total number of repetitions completed.

Pressmaster/Shutterstock.comWhile clients may perform this on their own and self-report results or record their performance for the fitness professional to view later, ideally, this assessment should be performed live using video conferencing and recorded for later analysis and interpretation in order to focus real-time efforts on guiding the client through the assessment safely and effectively. The client should be reassessed at regular intervals (e.g., 4 to 6 weeks) to evaluate

progress.

Plank Test

Chapter 5Administering Virtual Assessments Lesson 4Virtual Muscular Endurance AssessmentsPlank TestThe plank test provides insight into a client's core and upper extremity strength, stability, and endurance. This timed assessment requires a stopwatch, which comes pre-installed on most connected devices and computers in the clock application.

To perform a virtual plank test, consider the following:

The client should begin in a prone position on a level surface with the elbows and forearms placed on the ground. The elbows should be placed directly under the shoulders, level and in-line with mid-sternum to lower pectorals, with the toes pointing downward toward the ground.

Instruct the client to begin the stopwatch and then lift the hips until their lower back and pelvis is parallel with the ground. Encourage the client to maintain a neutral head and neck alignment with the eyes focused down toward the floor between the hands.

Instruct the client to hold this position for as long as possible but stop if pain or severe discomfort arises.

The timer should be stopped when the client reaches failure, which is defined as inability to keep the hips off the ground, or form and technique are compromised in an attempt to maintain the required position—evidenced by compensations such as consistent arching or slouching of the lower back, excessive rounding or drooping of the upper back, and dropping or extending of the head and neck.

Prostock-studio/Shutterstock.comWhile this assessment is valuable, it may be difficult to standardize the results due to the subjectivity of failure. For this reason, a fitness professional may consider performing the plank test during a recorded video conferencing session for post-analysis to determine the actual duration achieved.

Wall Sit Test

Chapter 5Administering Virtual Assessments Lesson 4Virtual Muscular Endurance AssessmentsWall Sit TestThe wall sit test is a simple assessment of lower-body strength endurance, primarily of the quadriceps, hamstrings, and glute musculature. This timed assessment requires a stopwatch, which comes pre-installed on most connected devices and computers in the clock application.

To perform a virtual wall sit test, consider the following:

Instruct the client to locate a flat, non-slippery surface next to a sturdy wall.

With their back against the wall, have the client slowly slide down into a seated position, moving the feet away from the wall until a comfortable position is found with the knees and hips bent at 90 degrees. Ensure the knees are positioned directly above the feet and the thighs are parallel to the ground. Mark or make note of this position and have them stand back up.

With the feet shoulder-width apart, instruct the client to move the feet out to this measured or marked distance—keeping the feet flat on the ground. Arms should be crossed on the chest or extended straight out to the front of the body, parallel to the ground.

Upon achieving this position, start the timer.

The client should hold this position for as long as possible but stop if pain or severe discomfort arises.

The timer should be stopped when the client reaches failure, which is defined as an inability to maintain the 90-degree hip and knee angle.

rock-the-stock/Shutterstock.comFitness professionals should use their judgement when determining whether to perform the wall sit test. It may not be suitable for certain individuals, particularly those with a history of knee pain or lower-body injury.

While clients may perform this on their own and self-report results or record their performance for the fitness professional to view later, ideally, this assessment should be performed live using video conferencing and recorded for later analysis and interpretation in order to focus real-time efforts on guiding and motivating the client through the assessment safely and effectively.

Summary

Chapter 5Administering Virtual Assessments Lesson 4Virtual Muscular Endurance AssessmentsSummaryAdministering virtual assessments may be a new concept to some fitness professionals. However, with proper planning; careful consideration toward assessment choices, standardized processes, and the use of readily available technology and resources; fitness professionals can build out their own comprehensive virtual assessment toolkit. This will streamline the assessment workflow while ensuring client comfort and safety, optimizing data collection and reliability, and, through regularly scheduled reassessments, allow for continued measurement and tracking of progress toward desired goals and outcomes. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH500:06:19Chapter 5 ReferencesBishop, C., Edwards, M., & Turner, A. N. (2016, Oct.). Screening movement dysfunctions using the overhead squat. Professional Strength & Conditioning Journal, (42): 22–30.

Bredin, S., Gledhill, N., Jamnik, V. K., & Warburton, D. E. R. (2013, March). PAR-Q+ and ePARmed-X+: new risk stratification and physical activity clearance strategy for physicians and patients alike. Canadian Family Physician, 59(3): 273–277.

Casadei, K., & Kiel, J. (2020). Anthropometric Measurement. Treasure Island, FL: StatPearls.

Casiglia, E., Tikhonoff, V., Albertini, F., & Palatini, P. (2016, Oct.). Poor Reliability of Wrist Blood Pressure Self-Measurement at Home. Hypertension, 68(4): 896–903. https://doi.org/:10.1161/hypertensionaha.116.07961

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2020). What Is My BMI? Retrieved from https://www.cdc.gov/healthyweight/assessing/bmi/adult_bmi/english_bmi_calculator/bmi_calculator.html

Dimkpa, U. (2009). Post-exercise heart rate recovery: An index of cardiovascular fitness. Journal of Exercise Physiology Online, 12(1): 10–22.

Dionne, M. M., & Yeudall, F. (2005). Monitoring of Weight in Weight Loss Programs: A Double-Edged Sword? Journal of Nutrition Education and Behavior, 37(6): 315–318. https://doi.org/10.1016/s1499-4046(06)60162-0

Gianola, S., Castellini, G., Stucovitz, E., Nardo, A., & Banfi, G. (2017, July). Single leg squat performance in physically and non-physically active individuals: a cross-sectional study. BMC Musculoskeletal Disorders, 18(1): 299. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12891-017-1660-8

Jensen, M. T., Suadicani, P., Hein, H. O., & Gyntelberg, F. (2013, June). Elevated resting heart rate, physical fitness and all-cause mortality: a 16-year follow-up in the Copenhagen Male Study. Heart, 99(12): 882–887. https://doi.org/10.1136/heartjnl-2012-303375

Johansson, G., Wikman, A., Ahrén, A. M., Hallmans, G., & Johansson, I. (2001, Aug.). Underreporting of energy intake in repeated 24-hour recalls related to gender, age, weight status, day of interview, educational level, reported food intake, smoking habits and area of living. Public Health Nutrition, 4(4): 919–927. https://doi.org/10.1079/phn2001124

Livengood, A. L., DiMattia, M. A., & Uhl, T. L. (2004). "Dynamic Trendelenburg": Single-Leg-Squat Test for Gluteus Medius Strength. Athletic Therapy Today, 9(1): 24–25. https://doi.org/10.1123/att.9.1.24

Pew Research Center (2019, June). Mobile Fact Sheet. Retrieved from https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/fact-sheet/mobile/

Sahakyan, K. R., Somers, V. K., Rodriguez-Escudero, J. P., Hodge, D. O., Carter, R. E., Sochor, O., ... Lopez-Jimenez, F. (2015, Dec.). Normal-Weight Central Obesity: Implications for Total and Cardiovascular Mortality. Annals of Internal Medicine, 163(11): 827. https://doi.org/10.7326/m14-2525

World Health Organization (2008, Dec.). Waist Circumference and Waist-Hip Ratio: Report of a WHO Expert Consultation. Geneva, Switzerland.

Chapter 6: Implementing Coaching Sessions

Chapter 6: Implementing Coaching Sessions

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationChapter 6: Implementing Coaching Sessions Implementing virtual training sessions requires organization and development of a proper training environment, exercise equipment, instructional components, and compliance monitoring. Recommendations and guidance for appropriate spacing, flooring, lighting, camera angles, equipment, and coaching cues will all be provided in this chapter.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Summarize different methods for configuring a virtual training environment.

Identify appropriate training equipment for clients.

Summarize best practices for presenting in the virtual training space.

Compare ways to instruct individual, small, and large group fitness classes virtually.

Explain ways to implement safety protocols in a virtual training session.

Describe ways to provide nutritional guidance virtually.

Introduction

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationIntroductionNew technologies are constantly changing the way people live across generations. Advancements, such as smartphones and personal computers, are revolutionizing how people interact with both their physical and virtual worlds and the health and fitness industry is no exception (Banos & Nugent, 2018). The job outlook for fitness professionals is expected to increase by 15% in the next decade (Figure: Employment Projections) and, with the surge in demand for online delivery of fitness programs, much of this could be composed of fitness professionals operating virtually (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2020).

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2020FigureEmployment ProjectionsFitness professionals engaging in virtual training have a variety of methods from which they can conduct their business. For example, they may choose to provide live or prerecorded training sessions, one-on-one training, or virtual group fitness classes. The attributes required to run a virtual training business are not unlike those required for in-person training. Professionalism, coaching competency, fitness knowledge, and communication skills play vital roles on both ends of the fitness coaching spectrum.

However, there are several components that require additional consideration in virtual coaching sessions when compared with traditional in-person fitness training. Fitness professionals implementing virtual coaching sessions will need to ensure they have all of the necessary equipment and recording and scheduling tools to effectively conduct their business and training sessions online.

In the online training space, clients only have access to the fitness professional through video conferencing, voice calls, or messaging tools. Through these mediums, the client is peering into the fitness professional's "virtual world;" therefore, the fitness professional must understand how to effectively create, manage, and adjust each component of their virtual world to provide the best training experience for their clients.

Syda Productions/Shutterstock.com

Session Preparation

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationSession PreparationOperating in the virtual fitness space allows a fitness professional to interact with more clients than they would have been able to while doing in-person training. The time gaps between appointments are typically much smaller than in a typical face-to-face environment, and the fitness professional or nutrition coach can remain in the same location from session to session. Clients also benefit from the convenience of virtual training as they can access their coach from the comfort of their own homes and even on the go. Due to this increased accessibility, it is vital that the fitness professional be well-prepared and organized in their virtual training business. The quality of the fitness professional's preparation may dictate the success of the session. Selecting appropriate video conferencing tools, scheduling and confirming appointments, and preparing workouts are the foundational requirements of a virtual training business.

Video RecordingAnton Kor/Shutterstock.comCoaching clients virtually requires some form of video recording and conferencing software. Both video calls and pre-recorded workouts or instructions require access to a quality camera, a computer or smartphone, high-speed Internet connections, and a method to efficiently share the videos with clients. Virtual storage space, upload bandwidth, download capacity, and ease of access will need to be considered by both the client and fitness professional. Using applications that provide large storage space (e.g., Vimeo, Dropbox, or YouTube) is recommended for professionals sharing prerecorded workouts with their clients. For live, 1-to-1 or group virtual coaching sessions, video conferencing applications are recommended (e.g., Zoom, Skype, WebEx, Google Meets, etc.). Advancements in video conferencing technologies have made them considerably useful, essentially indispensable, tools for fitness professionals operating virtually. Appointments can be scheduled, confirmed, and conducted all from a single application.

Helpful HintBeginner Tips for Recording Great Videos on a Smartphone

- ❏ Record in landscape mode (horizontally).
- ❏ Check phone settings.

Video resolution refers to the size of the video file. The most commonly used video resolutions are 1080 HD and 4K, with the latter being the larger of the two. The higher the video resolution, the clearer the video will be. However, higher resolution also means a much larger file size. Video resolution should be considered in conjunction with file storage options.

Frame rate is measured in frames per second (fps). The phone should be set at either 30 fps or 60 fps. The higher the fps, the smoother the video will look.

- ❏ Clean the camera lens with a microfiber cloth before each recording.
- ❏ Use both hands to hold the phone or invest in a tripod mount.
- ❏ Avoid using the camera flash. Instead, use other available light sources to light the subject.
- ❏ Avoid backlit settings.
- ❏ Experiment with slow-motion and time-lapse effects for variety.
- ❏ Take advantage of basic editing features on a mobile device, such as trimming, transitioning, and other effects.

Scheduling Appointments

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationScheduling AppointmentsAs with in-person training, virtual training requires scheduling and organization. The fitness professional should determine availability, session length/duration, and hours of operation and clearly communicate these to clients. To maintain organization and avoid overbooking appointments, the fitness professional will need to choose a scheduling system suitable for their business format.

Scheduling via virtual technologies (e.g., Calendly, Vocus.io, ScheduleOnce, Zoom, etc.) are efficient ways for both the fitness professional and client to communicate and confirm appointments. These technologies have made scheduling intuitive, accounting for time-zone differences, providing reminders and notifications of upcoming appointments, as well as allowing for multiple app integrations and customizations. Utilizing these tools certainly enhances the organization of a virtual coaching business, but their use is not mandatory. If the fitness professional decides to use a traditional analog scheduling system, it is imperative they stay on top of appointment confirmations, time-zone differences, appointment records, and session tracking. Great communication and organizational skills are a must for fitness professionals that choose to rely on traditional scheduling tools (e.g., pen and paper, calendar, phone calls, etc.).

Scheduling OptionsScheduling Modality

Pros

Cons

Online Scheduling Technology

(e.g., Calendly, MeetFox, or SimplyBook.me)

Fast

Efficient

Provides notifications and reminders

Accurate record-keeping

Typically requires a fee

E-mails, Text Messages, and Phone Calls

Cost-effective

Ease of use

No notifications

Manual process

Increased likelihood of scheduling errors

Analog Calendar or Pen and Paper

Cost-effective

Ease of use

No notifications

Manual process

Increased likelihood of errors and miscommunication

Still requires the use of another modality to communicate schedule with the client

---

Confirming Appointments

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationConfirming AppointmentsOnce a scheduling system is chosen, the fitness professional will need to determine which appointment confirmation system will best complement their business. Confirming appointments maximizes a fitness professional's time, minimizes missed appointments, and provides appointment reminders to clients. Using a virtual scheduling tool is an efficient method for managing appointments as these tools can be programmed to provide reminders at specific times prior to an appointment. An efficient confirmation system should notify a client about an upcoming appointment 12 to 24 hours prior to its start. This time frame provides the fitness professional with enough notice to adjust their schedule and the client with enough notice to reschedule without penalty. If the fitness professional chooses not to use a scheduling tool it is imperative that they keep track of upcoming appointments and confirm them with their clients via e-mail, text message, or phone call.

Rawpixel.com/Shutterstock.comThe scheduling and confirming of appointments organizes and optimizes a virtual training business, but without accountability structures such as policies and signed agreements, issues of adherence may still come up. Designing and communicating a cancellation policy may aid in keeping clients and professionals accountable for their scheduled appointments.

A cancellation policy is a statement of the course of action to occur if an agreed-on meeting is not upheld in a predetermined manner or time frame. Cancellation policies are put in place to hold the client accountable to the agreed-on times of confirmed appointments. Additionally, a cancellation policy should allow the fitness professional enough time to fill the session should a client cancel. The penalty for failing to appear for a confirmed appointment could be as severe as a complete loss of a paid session, as mild as a small penalty fee, or a verbal warning. The cancellation policy must be determined by the fitness professional and should be clearly communicated to the client prior to engaging in the virtual training program. Cancellation policies are not intended to punish clients for mishaps. Rather, they are designed to encourage schedule integrity by providing appointment confirmation time constraints (e.g., 12 to 24 hours prior to the session or a 10-minute grace period). These confirmations not only hold participants accountable; they also act as helpful reminders and allow penalty-free margins for rescheduling.

Cancellation Policy ExamplesExample Cancellation Policies

A client can cancel or reschedule an appointment 12 hours prior to the session, penalty-free.

A client can cancel or reschedule an appointment 24 hours prior to a session, penalty-free, and is allotted two no-shows prior to penalization.

A client who fails to appear for a confirmed appointment will be penalized 100% of their session cost.

A client who fails to appear for a confirmed appointment will be penalized 50% of their session cost.

A client is allotted two no-shows prior to penalization. Once the client exceeds two no-shows, they will be penalized 100% of their session cost for any further missed appointments.

A client is granted a 15-minute grace period at the beginning of each session. This means a client has a 15-minute window to appear for a session before being penalized.

Accountability structuresA framework outlining the terms or conditions of an agreement between two parties.

Cancellation policyA statement or course of action to occur if an agreed-on meeting is not upheld in a predetermined manner or time frame.

Equipment Set-Up

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationEquipment Set-UpFailing to check and prepare vital equipment prior to an appointment can drastically affect a virtual training business. If the fitness professional has a full week of scheduled appointments and their computer crashes, their audio or video system fails, or there is a loss of Internet connection, they will not only have a host of frustrated clients, but they may also lose future business. Fitness professionals should create an equipment checklist and go through the list at least 1 hour prior to the first appointment of each training day. Incorporating a daily equipment check routine will help mitigate any sudden or unexpected equipment breakdowns, allow time to rectify any issues that arise, and, if necessary, provide notice to scheduled clients.

wavebreakmedia/Shutterstock.comOnce the fitness professional has completed their equipment check, they will need to set up all equipment required for their upcoming virtual coaching sessions. This includes but is not limited to computer and recording systems being fully charged and in place, having appropriate lighting set up, ensuring all required training equipment is accessible, and that training programs are completed and accessible. It is also best practice for the fitness professional to perform an end-of-day checklist to account for any equipment that will need to be fully charged, cleaned, or turned off after each day of appointments.

Equipment Preparation Checklist❏ Camera and audio recording system functioning properly

❏ Computer connected and functioning as expected

❏ All battery-powered peripherals fully charged

❏ Lighting systems on and functioning

❏ All required training equipment accessible

❏ Client workout program(s) complete and ready to access

End-of-Day Checklist❏ Electronic equipment that requires a charge (e.g., computers, cameras, or batteries) set to charge before the next day of appointments

❏ Electronic equipment that does not require a charge (e.g. external lighting) unplugged from the power source until the next day of appointments

❏ Training equipment and environment cleaned and arranged in an appropriate location for the next day of appointments

Program and Session Preparation

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 1Session PreparationProgram and Session PreparationTo maintain a successful virtual training business, the fitness professional should be prepared prior to the start of each and every session. A training session that is void of a predetermined training program or structure can lead to a multitude of complications. The fitness professional might forget what the client's workout is on a particular day or accidentally confuse one client's program for another's. By completing the design and planning of each client's program and having it accessible prior to their session, the fitness professional can mitigate the likelihood of these complications. The saying, "failing to plan is planning to fail," is a good reminder for fitness professionals engaging with clients in the virtual environment. Preparing training programs prior to a session provides a foundation and structure from which the fitness professional can make intelligent and effective alterations when necessary (Figure: Preparation).

FigurePreparationOnce the information is gathered from initial assessments, such as health and injury history, client limitations and preference, and physical assessments, the fitness professional will construct a training program for their client based on their individual goals. The fitness professional can utilize a variety of online training program builders, such as NASM EDGE, or choose to use something as simple as a spreadsheet program (e.g., Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets, etc.) or even pen and paper. Once developed, the training programs should be organized in such a way that they will be easy to track, record, and adjust when necessary.

Africa Studio/Shutterstock.comRegardless of which program development tool the fitness professional chooses to use, it is vital they have easy access to the programs prior to each virtual training session. Having training programs completed and accessible prior to appointments will mitigate complications and ensure program integrity during training sessions. As mentioned previously, a client's program may need to be adjusted or altered at times, but having everything prepared and accessible will help the fitness professional make the most effective adjustments.

Training Environment

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentTraining EnvironmentBAZA Production/Shutterstock.comTo effectively implement virtual training sessions, the fitness professional will need an appropriate amount of space and a suitable environment. Virtual training clients watch and listen to movements and exercise cues as their only source of coaching. So, having adequate space and the environment to perform and instruct exercise movements is paramount. The client does not want to see their trainer struggling to direct the session due to a lack of organization or space.

Critical!Fitness professionals engaging in virtual training should make the following training environment considerations:

Does the space have enough room to not only demonstrate exercises but also include enough space for the filming system to capture the entire body and movement demonstration in the frame?

What camera angle is most suitable for the training session or exercise selection?

What external sounds could the space be exposed to? Is the appropriate equipment available to mitigate any potential sound interruptions?

What kind of lighting (fluorescent, skylight, natural light, etc.) does the space have? Is there a skylight or natural light? Will the time of day a session is conducted be a factor? Will the fitness professional need extra lighting equipment?

What kind of flooring does the space have? Carpet? Hardwood? Tile? Gym flooring? Will the flooring be a hindrance to the style of the training session?

Does the space have enough room for all the necessary training equipment?

SpacingThe fitness professional should first consider what style of movements they will be consistently demonstrating in their sessions. Perhaps the movements will be primarily dynamic, high-intensity exercises like plyometrics, or maybe the exercises will consist mostly of easy, restorative movements that are performed in a single location. Once the fitness professional has determined the training style to use, they should perform a practice run of a few of the primary exercises. The practice run is intended to ensure there is ample space for safe demonstration of the exercises, void of obstacles. If space limitations do exist, the fitness professional will need to make alterations to either the movement and exercise selection or the training space itself (e.g., not jumping as high or moving a coffee table).

Filming

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentFilmingOnce the practice run is complete and the training space is adjusted to complete all movement, the fitness professional should film some of the primary exercises and ensure that the chosen camera or filming system is able to capture each movement in its entirety. Optimal placement for a filming system is 6 to 8 feet from the camera. Depending on the filming method (phone, computer, external camera), this distance may have to be adjusted.

Another vital aspect of camera placement is the camera angle. The camera angle must provide the most optimal viewing experience to the client. Determining which perspective will allow the viewer to see the most important aspects of exercise form is an effective way to choose a camera angle. The camera angle not only shapes a client's viewing experience but may even mold client perceptions of their instructor. Camera angles have even been suggested to affect viewer perception of trustworthiness.

ORION PRODUCTION/Shutterstock.comIn a 2017 study, camera angles positioned at eye-level (Figure: Camera Angles) were shown to have positive effects on viewer perceptions of trustworthiness, in comparison to upward or downward camera angles (Baranowski & Hecht, 2017).

FigureCamera Angles

Content

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentThe fitness professional may choose to demonstrate exercises facing the camera, positioned perpendicularly to the camera, or from multiple positions. By filming a few of the primary exercises from the chosen angle and reviewing the footage, the fitness professional will be able to assess whether the viewer will be able to determine and replicate the exercises demonstrated (Figure: Straight-On and Downward Camera Angles). Exercises that are stationary or that occur in the sagittal/frontal plane will benefit from a straight-on or balanced camera view with no angle. Dynamic, non-conventional, or transverse plane exercises will benefit from a slightly angled (up or down) camera position to provide a more comprehensive view of the movements. Once the fitness professional has filmed a few of their primary exercises and reviewed the footage, they will be able to make necessary adjustments to their camera angle and spacing.

FigureStraight-On and Downward Camera Angles

Sound and Audio

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentSound and AudioScarc/Shutterstock.comAdministering virtual training is highly reliant on verbal cues and coaching. The fitness professional will not physically be with the client to spot them or make form adjustments. So, the client's ability to clearly hear and understand the coach becomes vital. The fitness professional should consider investing in a shotgun or lavalier mic to achieve quality audio. While setting up the training environment, the fitness professional should assess potential external sounds that might disrupt a training session. If the training space is in an apartment, adjacent to a noisy freeway, or exposed to children or pets, precautions need to be taken to mitigate the likelihood of those sounds impacting the training session.

Soundproofing supplies such as foam soundproofing panels, blackout or noise reduction curtains, and carpets/rugs are cost-effective methods for absorbing unwanted external noise vibrations.

Investing in soundproofing materials can transform an unsuitable training environment into a calm, quiet space perfect for virtual training implementation. If the fitness professional has children, pets, or roommates, they should make necessary arrangements and schedule specific times to do their filming and training sessions.

LightingLighting in a virtual training environment can make the difference between an enjoyable, effortless viewing experience or a frustrating viewing experience. Poor lighting conditions might complicate a client's view and make it difficult to comprehend exercises and instructions. The fitness professional should assess the lighting in their training space prior to filming and make all necessary adjustments until they are certain the viewer has no trouble seeing the instructor in the frame. Lighting in a building can vary greatly. Some rooms are lit through natural light by way of windows, some from skylights, and some from various artificial lights at different angles.

If natural light beaming through windows or skylights is the primary light source of the space, the fitness professional will need to evaluate the times of day they will be filming or performing training sessions. Filming exercise videos or performing training sessions as the sun sets may provide a poor experience for the client.

Dmytro Zinkevych/Shutterstock.comThe time of day the filming will be performed (e.g., sunrise, midday, or sunset) will also need to be considered. Ideally, the fitness professional should pick times when it is brightest in the room to be filming or administering training sessions. Filming a practice video or performing a mock training session can help the fitness professional determine if natural lighting is adequate for their needs. When evaluating lighting, the main goal is to ensure that the fitness professional and the exercises being performed can be properly viewed and are undistorted to the camera. If the lighting is such that it casts a shadow on the fitness professional or over-illuminates them, adjustments will need to be made to the camera position or the time of day the filming is performed, or artificial lighting equipment may be needed.

Content

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentIf artificial lighting is required, the fitness professional will need to consider both the lighting angle and power (wattage). The lights will need to be positioned so that they do not complicate camera function or instructor visibility. Lights that are aimed directly at a camera or shining from the opposing side of the camera and instructor can distort the client's view. Artificial lights will also need to be powerful or bright enough to illuminate the entire body of the fitness professional. Purchasing dimmable lights will give the fitness professional more adjustability for setting up their environment. Lighting that shines from behind or to one side of the camera onto the instructor is not optimal, so additional lights may need to be acquired (Figure: Example Lighting and Camera Set-Up). Lighting systems designed for photoshoots are recommended for additional artificial lighting. Ring lights, clip-on phone lights, or even a house-hold lamp with the shade removed can provide adequate lighting for those with a lower-budget.

FigureExample Lighting and Camera Set-Up

Exercise Area

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentExercise Areafaboi/Shutterstock.comThe style of flooring in a virtual training environment will affect the exercise and footwear selection for the fitness professional. Flooring surfaces can vary from hardwood and tile to carpet and rugs. If the training space contains slick flooring, such as tile, linoleum, or hardwood, the fitness professional will need to make sure they wear appropriate footwear during their sessions. Conducting sessions in shoes with worn soles or while in socks is ill-advised on slick surfaces as accidents and movement complications may be more

likely to occur. If the space contains rugs or has a carpeted surface, the fitness professional may need to put less thought into footwear. Some longer carpets like shag-style carpet can be slick. Slick carpeting may cause trouble gaining traction and increase injury risk while in footwear with worn soles or insufficient ankle support. The fitness professional should test the movements being performed beforehand and determine footwear requirements.

Another aspect of flooring that warrants consideration is visibility. If the flooring is distracting or complicates the client's ability to see the instructor's extremities or equipment placement, adjustments will need to be made. These might include adjustments to the exercise selection or flooring type to provide an optimal viewing experience for the client. Additional flooring adjustments that can be made to optimize the client's experience include laying down solid-colored, low-profile rugs, using foam or rubberized mats, and coaching on flooring void of shag-style carpeting and potentially distracting graphics or patterns. Adjustments to exercise selection are dependent on the flooring available. If the flooring is hard (e.g., hardwood, tile, or linoleum) the viewer is not likely to have trouble seeing the placement of extremities (e.g. hand placement or foot placement), whereas, thick rugs and shag-style carpeting may complicate a viewer's understanding of proper placement of extremities (e.g., foot placement in a squatting exercise) and exercise selection will need to be adjusted.

Once the flooring in the space has been assessed and adjusted for functionality, the fitness professional will need to ensure that their training equipment will not affect or be affected by the flooring material. Heavier training equipment such as dumbbells, kettlebells, or any weighted object will not distort the viewer's experience, but they may have an impact on the flooring in the space. Hardwood, linoleum, and tile surfaces can be damaged and cause the camera to shake if a piece of equipment is dropped. If the flooring surface is at risk of damage or rattles the camera when it hits the floor, the fitness professional should place a suitable floor covering such as a rug or rubber mat over the area where training sessions will occur. Rubber training mats and thick rugs are sufficient for absorbing vibration and protecting flooring from damage.

If the fitness professional is choosing exercises that involve equipment such as foam rollers, exercise sliders, or an exercise ball, they must test the flooring surface to ensure the exercise movement is not restricted. For example, utilizing an exercise ball on a carpeted area may increase the risk of the ball sliding out.

Environment Safety ConsiderationsFitness professionals should also inform clients about best practices regarding flooring safety when exercising. Slick flooring, such as hardwood, tile, and linoleum floors, can be dangerous surfaces to perform lateral, jumping, or explosive movements on, especially in improper footwear. If the client is wearing footwear with minimal traction (for example, socks), slick floors are appropriate for performing gliding or sliding movements such as a mountain climber exercise. However, if the client were to attempt a plyometric or explosive lateral movement in just their socks, there would be a higher risk for the client slipping and getting injured. The fitness professional should educate their clients on appropriate footwear and adjust the exercise selections when their flooring poses a potential injury risk.

Presentation

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentPresentationThe cleanliness and appearance of the training environment may not seem important in a virtual setting, but it can have a significant impact on the fitness professional's business. Additionally, the way in which professionals present themselves, whether it be online or in-person, speaks volumes about their competence and professionalism. If a client were to book an online appointment with a telehealth provider, an attorney, or even just engage in a business meeting, they would expect a professional environment and presentation. If the professional were to conduct their session in a space with dirty laundry on the floor, empty pizza boxes on the table, and trash cans piled to the top, the client would likely form unwanted opinions about their professionalism.

Presenting to clients in a clean, clutter-free, and organized space goes a long way in demonstrating competence. This also displays a courtesy to clients and conveys that the professional takes their business and the client's time seriously.

Virtual training may require relocation to a new space, whether it be due to traveling or renting a new training space. Regardless of where a fitness professional is conducting their training sessions, they should make their best effort to keep the space as clean and organized as possible. This is not to suggest that remodeling and reconstruction are necessary. The primary objective of the fitness professional should be to do their best to keep the space they operate in as orderly and clean as possible. Fitness professionals may consider completing a cleaning checklist prior to filming or video conferencing.

Vadym Pastukh/Shutterstock.comHelpful HintTraining Environment Cleaning Checklist

❏ Walls/Curtains: Remove any posters, art, or markings on the wall that could be distracting or potentially offensive. Ensure walls and curtains are free of holes.

❏ Windows: Any windows that are visible to the client should be clean and streak-free.

❏ Floor: The floors should be clean and free of dirt, debris, garbage, or clothing.

❏ Furniture: If there is any furniture in the space (e.g., couch, coffee table, or chairs), it should be free of any garbage or unnecessary items. Furniture should be kept in an organized and orderly fashion when possible.

❏ Garbage: All garbage and garbage bins should be completely removed and out of view while filming exercise videos, performing virtual coaching sessions, or during video calls.

Professional Appearance and Attire

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentProfessional Appearance and AttireIn the same way that a virtual training environment demonstrates professionalism, so does personal presentation. A 2018 study on the effect's appearance had on professionalism showed that health care professionals who took the time to improve their appearance were perceived as more professional and trustworthy (Wills et al., 2018). The fitness professional will not need to conduct virtual training sessions in dress attire but presenting in clean and appropriate clothing displays professionalism and competence. Basic training attire is all that is necessary for a fitness professional operating in a virtual training environment. Ensuring the attire is free of stains, holes, wrinkles, and offensive or distracting graphics will strengthen the professional's presentation.

Helpful HintRecommended Virtual Training Attire

Solid color t-shirts or tank tops

Solid color shorts or training pants

Comfortable, appropriate (based on session type and flooring) athletic shoes

(See Figures Below: Recommended Virtual Training Attire)

Olga Gutyria/Shutterstock.com Paul Michael Hughes/Shutterstock.com

Virtual Training Attire to Avoid

Potentially offensive graphic t-shirts or pants

Clothes with noticeable holes or stains

Distracting accessories (e.g., large bracelets, necklaces, or earrings)

(See Figures Below: Virtual Training Attire to Avoid)

Yuliya Alekseeva/Shutterstock.com Africa Studio/Shutterstock.com

Virtual training environment and physical appearance are the components that shape the professional's virtual presence. Taking the time to go through each aspect of the training environment will not only ensure the professional conducts safe and efficient virtual training sessions, but it will also convey a message of courtesy, professionalism, knowledge, and competence.

Equipment Access for the Fitness Professional

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentEquipment Access for the Fitness ProfessionalMaridav/Shutterstock.comEquipment access is a primary limitation of virtual when compared to in-person training. When a fitness professional works at a gym, they may have unlimited access to workout equipment, whereas, when at home or running a smaller virtual coaching business, equipment access may be limited. When considering workout programming, the exercises chosen for the client are more dependent on what type of equipment the client has versus what equipment the trainer has on hand. This is because the trainer can still demonstrate many movements without specifically having those machines or extra equipment available. This is also where filming exercise videos to use as demonstrations when writing client programming can help minimize the equipment needed when performing the virtual coaching sessions themselves. Ideally, the fitness professional should have some basic equipment available to demonstrate movements and show proper form. Dumbbells or resistance bands generally suffice; the fitness professional does not need a full gym worth of equipment to administer a quality training session.

Client Equipment Purchasing

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentClient Equipment PurchasingClient equipment access will be the primary consideration when selecting appropriate exercises. Programming should consider what equipment the client has available so that the fitness professional is prepared with an appropriate exercise program design. The client and fitness professional do not need to have matching equipment. For instance, the client may use a dumbbell for a goblet squat, while the trainer uses a kettlebell. Small changeups like this mid-session will be easily managed. Client equipment requirements may also be dependent on goals. If a client is trying to build as much strength as possible, or maximize muscle growth, working out at home with a set of 5-pound dumbbells and resistance bands may not provide the adequate loading required for those goals. If the client is looking to move better and feel better and does not have specific performance goals, a small selection of bands or dumbbells will suffice.

The most efficient way to determine what equipment will be needed for a training session is for the fitness professional to ask their client what their goals are, where the client will be training (at home or at a gym), and what equipment they will have access to. It is up to the fitness professional to educate the client on equipment requirements. To make the best use of virtual coaching sessions, Table: Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations highlights some basic equipment recommendations.

Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations

A range of kettlebells from 3 to 30 lbs depending on skill levels

A range of dumbbells from 3 to 40 lbs, or adjustable dumbbells such as PowerBlocks or SelectTechs – This will vary based on skill and budget

A workout bench that adjusts from flat to incline or decline

An exercise/stability ball will also suffice for many exercises performed on a bench

A high-quality set of resistance bands of varying resistance-levels, with a door anchor kit

Some extra equipment to consider:

A variety of medicine balls

Foam roller or lacrosse ball for mobility work

A pull-up bar

Suspension training

Stretching/exercise mat

The equipment listed in Table: Basic Virtual Training Equipment Recommendations represents basic training equipment recommendations, not mandatory equipment requirements. Clients may have access to a wider variety of equipment (e.g., barbells or treadmills) or they may have access to only a few select pieces of equipment. There are many factors that may affect a client's training equipment access, from budget to physical capacity. There may be scenarios in which a client does not have access to any training equipment at all. They may not currently have a budget for purchasing new equipment or they may be traveling and lack access to equipment. In these scenarios, the fitness professional may need to adjust their training programs to best suit clients' needs and given equipment. Bands can be easily packed in a suitcase or carry-on bags for clients on the go.

Content

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 2Training EnvironmentLjupco Smokovski/Shutterstock.comWhen equipment is lacking, the fitness professional can utilize objects in the client's surroundings to modify exercises and training sessions. Integrating a client's surroundings into their training session can make up for the lack of equipment by substituting gravity and the client's own body weight for resistance. Objects such as stairs, chairs, a sturdy table, canned goods, or water or milk jugs can turn a space void of equipment into a miniature gym. Developing creative ways to safely integrate a client's surroundings can not only make up for an equipment deficiency but also make workouts fun and engaging.

Critical!Because the virtual fitness professional is most likely instructing their clients to perform exercises in their own home environment, it is imperative that the fitness professional do so safely and rationally. Exercises that place a client in a dangerous position, near a potentially unsafe object, or on a questionable surface should be avoided at all costs (e.g., pull-ups from a high elevation or exercises on glass tables or near sharp objects). The fitness professional should learn about the client's fitness environment and prescribe exercises using rational thinking and with safety in mind.

Try ThisPractice using these household objects and surroundings to perform safer, less-risky exercise variations.

Couch: Box Squat, Rear Foot Elevated Split Squat, and Decline Push-Up

Chairs: Tricep Dip, Deficit Push-Up, and Chair-Supported Single-Leg Squat

Slick Flooring (hardwood, tile, or linoleum): Mountain Climbers, Pike-Up, and Ab Roll Out

Stairs: Toe Taps, Step-Ups, Calf Raise, and Conditioning

Lizardflms/Shutterstock.com

woodpencil/Shutterstock.com

Gorodenkoff/Shutterstock.com

Olga Miltsova/Shutterstock.com

Client Instruction and Virtual Communication Strategies

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesClient Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesEffective communication is an important aspect of a successful virtual training session. Clients engaging in a virtual training program will be relying on the communication and instructional skills of the fitness professional conducting their session. Fitness professionals need to be able to effectively instruct, coach, and motivate clients with little more than their voice and movement. Virtual clients will be able to see and hear their instructor performing exercises, but effective training sessions also require detailed coaching, demonstration, and preparation. The ability to prepare for, communicate with, and instruct clients whom the professional may never be in the same room with is what sets great virtual fitness professionals apart from mediocre ones.

Workout and Session StructureWhen designing a training program for a client, outlining and organizing the training sessions creates a road map the fitness professional will use to help their clients get to their destination. In the virtual training environment, clients will be faced with multiple variables that could alter their training programs. Equipment access, training frequency, training duration, and missed appointments are all aspects that will alter the structure of a training program from client to client. The objective is to get the client from Point A to Point B in the safest, most effective, and efficient manner possible. Many obstacles may arise along the way, but as mentioned previously, designing a plan prior to starting will help to mitigate complications during the journey. This may mean the fitness professional must adapt quickly to a busy client's changing needs.

The organization of workouts may be dictated by several factors such as equipment availability, training intensity, and training frequency. Whatever the case may be, the fitness professional should organize workouts based on the needs of their clients and utilize a system to keep track of which workouts will be scheduled and when. Organizing and keeping track of workouts will aid in keeping clients on track to obtain their goals and increase training program efficacy.

Program Planning

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesProgram PlanningAndrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comOrganizing workouts for virtual training clients could be as simple as determining what style of training they will do throughout the week (Figure: Sample Training Program). For example, if training 3 days per week on a Monday, Wednesday, and Friday, the structure could be Monday: Resistance Training, Wednesday: Aerobic Conditioning, and Friday: HIIT. Program planning could also be more involved where periodization strategies are used to achieve specific monthly training goals in order to obtain peak physical condition by a specific date (e.g., Month 1: Hypertrophy, Month 2: Strength, and Month 3: Power). The primary goal of planning and organizing client programs should be to allow the fitness professional to keep track of workouts and alter them over time. Altering workouts each session, even slightly, can help improve client adherence. Engaging in the same workouts every session can lead to client boredom. When clients perform new or different workouts in each session, they are more likely to enjoy their training and adhere to the program. The organization

of workouts may be dictated by several factors such as equipment availability, training intensity, and training frequency. Whatever the case may be, the fitness professional should organize workouts based on the needs of their clients and utilize a system to keep track of which workouts will be scheduled and when. Organizing and keeping track of workouts will aid in keeping clients on track to obtain their goals and increase training program efficacy.

FigureSample Training Program

Visual and Verbal Instruction

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesVisual and Verbal InstructionThe most vital aspect of virtual training is effective instruction. Without the luxury of in-person communication, where a trainer and client can clearly see and hear each other, it is imperative for the fitness professional to execute clear and concise visual and verbal instruction to their clients.

As mentioned earlier in this chapter, sound checks and camera positioning will need to be tested and adjusted to ensure all demonstrations are visible and instructions audible for the chosen recording device. Anything in the space that is obstructing or distorting the view or audio of the instruction will need to be removed or adjusted. Once a thorough sound and camera check have been completed, the fitness professional can then focus on the delivery of their instructions.

Verbal instructions should be clear and easy to understand. The fitness professional should speak at an appropriate volume and enunciate as they speak.

Drazen Zigic/Shutterstock.comIt is also best to limit fitness jargon and complex instructions that could potentially confuse a client. For example, while describing a squatting exercise, the fitness professional would clearly and concisely verbalize the most important aspects of the exercise and avoid describing the exercise in complex or confusing language.

Visual instructions should be provided using proper form, a demonstrative pace, and by performing multiple repetitions of the exercise being shown. For example, while demonstrating a push-up for a client, the instructor will slowly perform multiple repetitions using proper form. By speaking clearly in a language and tone the client can easily interpret and by demonstrating in such a way that the client can easily determine what they should be doing, the fitness professional will be providing their clients with the best opportunity to understand the instruction.

Coach's CornerExample verbal Instructions for a squat exercise:

Clear and Concise: “Squat down like you are sitting into a chair and put your weight through the center of your feet as you stand back up.”

Complex and Confusing: “Squat down until your hips reach parallel while maintaining thoracic extension. Once parallel has been reached, press through your heels, squeeze your glutes, and bring yourself into hip extension.”

Try ThisThe fitness professional may consider the following example of instruction

“If you watch my elbows, they aren’t flaring out and making me shaped like a T, but, rather, they are tucked back slightly as if I’m trying to hold a tennis ball in my armpit.”

Pre-, Intra-, and Post-Session Instruction

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesPre-, Intra-, and Post-Session InstructionBefore conducting a training session, the fitness professional should determine which style of instruction is best suited for the specific workout and/or their specific style of training. There are a few ways to effectively instruct a virtual training session: pre-, intra-, and post-session instruction.

Pre-Session InstructionPre-session instruction is the act of demonstrating or describing the components of an individual workout session or exercise routine prior to beginning the session. This may include demonstrating each individual exercise in the routine, going over all important details, or describing duration, intervals, and intensity levels. Pre-session instruction is best used for fast-paced, high-intensity style training routines. During fast-paced routines, there is not much time available for detailed instruction during the workout itself. By providing instruction or demonstration prior to this type of workout, the instructor allows the client to perform the routine without interruption and allows the fitness professional to have the opportunity to coach, motivate, and make minor corrections.

Helpful HintPre-session instruction is best suited for the following activities:

Pre-recorded workouts

Group fitness settings

Circuits

HIIT training

Time-based intervals

Girts Ragelis/Shutterstock.comCoach’s CornerThe following is an example of pre-session instructions:

Session Information: A fitness professional has designed a Tabata/interval-inspired workout for their client to complete. The client is to perform 20 seconds of high-intensity work followed by 10 seconds of rest using four different exercises:

Squat Jump

Push-Up

Lunge Jump

Dumbbell Squat to Overhead Press

Pre-Session Instructions: Prior to starting the workout, the fitness professional takes time to explain the circuit, demonstrates each exercise, has the client perform each exercise, and provides them with exercise cues. If the instructor were to provide instructions during the routine or in the 10-second rest period, they understand that they would likely disrupt the training intensity, work intervals, and even the client's focus.

Pre-session instructionThe act of demonstrating or describing the components of an individual workout session or exercise routine prior to beginning the session.

Intra- and Post-Session Instruction

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesIntra- and Post-Session InstructionIntra- and/or post-session instruction is a form of instruction that consists of a demonstration or correction of training variables during and/or after a training session or exercise bout. This form of instruction is useful when time or exercise complexity is not a limiting factor. This form of instruction may be most effective when a client is not performing a complex routine or has plenty of time to perform the reps and sets of their session.

Helpful HintIntra- and/or post-session instruction are best suited for the following activities:

Low-intensity workouts

Low-complexity workouts

Familiar workouts

Long-duration sets and workouts

If a client is performing an exercise for a long and continuous duration, for example, a 15-rep set of goblet squats, there is plenty of time for the fitness professional to coach the client and make form corrections along the way. A brief pre-session instruction could be utilized in conjunction with intra-/post-session instruction, but taking time to provide pre-session instruction could potentially take away from the time spent engaging in the actual session in a continuous, long-duration routine.

Coach's CornerThe following is an example of intra-/post-session instructions.

A client is scheduled to perform a simple exercise in which technique is not a major concern such as goblet squats. The client is going to do the exercise for three sets of 12 to 15 reps. Goblet squats are a simple exercise that may not require much coaching or form correction. Rather than taking time away from the session by demonstrating and explaining the exercise in detail, the fitness professional can have the client perform the squats. If any necessary corrections are needed, the fitness professional understands there will be plenty of time to correct them during those sets without impacting the training session.

Intra-session instructionA form of instruction that consists of demonstration or correction of training variables during a training session or exercise bout.

Post-session instructionA form of instruction that consists of demonstration or correction of training variables after a training session or exercise bout.

Cueing Exercise Techniques

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesCueing Exercise TechniquesAn exercise cue is a condensed or simplified version of instructions used to help clients more easily understand or achieve a training or exercise objective. Providing exercise cues to a client during a training session is an effective coaching tactic. Cues can be as simple as instructing a client to drive their hips back or as creative as telling them to try to spread the floor with their feet. In the virtual training environment, because efficiency is of the essence, cues serve as a fantastic coaching tool. Simply instructing a client to squat may not be a sufficient form of instruction and going into great detail about each aspect of an exercise may cause frustration and confusion for clients.

Exercise cues bridge the gap between understanding and implementation. A training client will need to understand the primary components of an exercise in a time-efficient and easy-to-comprehend manner. The fitness professional will not need an exhaustive list of cues for every exercise, but it is beneficial to develop some cues for the exercises that are utilized in programs. These cues can also be used to help clients gauge exercise or training difficulty. Providing a cue or scale for intensity to help guide and quantify client training intensity can serve as a more effective method than using more complex instructions such as "74% of 1RM" (Sweet et al., 2004).

A rating of perceived exertion (RPE) scale is a number-based scale used to gauge the level of exertion or difficulty of an act or event (Figure: RPE Scale). An RPE scale can be used by a fitness professional to easily prescribe an intensity level to perform an exercise at and by a client to comprehend and communicate difficulty levels.

FigureRPE ScaleExercise cueA condensed or simplified version of instruction used to help an individual more easily understand or achieve a training or exercise objective.

Rating of perceived exertion (RPE)A number-based scale used to gauge the level of exertion or difficulty of an act or event.

Content

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesCueing for exercises should highlight the most important or difficult-to-comprehend aspects of an exercise. The fitness professional should consider how they might explain the exercise to a child (Figure: Cueing). For instance, while coaching a child to squat, a person would not say, "Keep the torso erect, press the hips back while bending at the knees, track the

knees over the midfoot, and, once 90 degrees of depth is achieved, press through your heels, squeeze the glutes, and return to the start position." A child is more likely to comprehend a short, simple instruction that accomplishes a similar goal such as, "Keep the chest up proud, push the rear back like you're sitting into a chair, and stand back up." While simple and concise language is needed, talking down to a client should also be avoided.

Corrections will always need to be made by the fitness professional, but using simple, effective cues will save time, effort, and frustration for both the professional trainer and client.

FigureCueingCoach's CornerThe following are examples of exercise cues for primary movements:

Bodyweight Squat:

- "Drive your butt back like you are sitting into a chair."
- "Lift your chest up tall and proud."
- "Drive your knees away from each other."
- "Screw your feet into the floor."
- "Press the floor away from you."

Push-Up:

- "Pull your belly button back to your spine."
- "Imagine you are a stiff board from head to heel."
- "Push the floor away from you."

Bent Over Row:

- "Unlock your knees and hinge at the waist."
- "Imagine a string is pulling your elbows straight up toward the ceiling."
- "Keep your back flat; imagine your spine is a stiff pole."

Exercise Selection

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 3Client Instruction and Virtual Communication StrategiesExercise SelectionProper exercise selection is not exclusive to virtual training, but it warrants consideration due to potential equipment barriers. Preparing exercise programs and selecting exercises based on a client's equipment and space allows for quicker, more efficient adjustments to be made when needed. If the fitness professional does not know what equipment their client will have access to, they should incorporate movement patterns that could easily be performed both weighted or unweighted, with only minor alterations. By choosing exercises in this fashion, the fitness professional will avoid having to make drastic training program changes in real time if their client lacks the necessary equipment. Variables such as sets, reps, tempo, and rest periods can always be adjusted to increase training difficulty when an exercise that is intended to be performed with external resistance now has to be performed with just bodyweight.

DC Studio/Shutterstock.comFood for ThoughtHere are some considerations for adjusting training difficulty and intensity:

Repetitions: Goal dependence – Increase the number of repetitions in each set.

Sets: Increase the total number of sets being performed of a specific movement.

Antagonistic Supersets: Complete sets of antagonistic exercises back to back with minimal to no rest in between sets. For example, performing a lat-pull down followed by a chest fly. The pull-down is a pulling exercise and the chest fly is a pushing exercise.

Agonistic Supersets (Compound Sets): Performing similar movements for the same muscle group(s) back to back to create additional stimulus or stress – For example, performing a chest fly and then doing push-ups right after

Tempo or Time Under Tension: Increase time under tension or increase the tempo of sets and repetitions. An example of this is the 2-1-2 model outline in Table: Loaded Versus Unloaded Exercise Adjustment Examples: 2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or lifting phase.

Rest Periods: Decrease rest time between sets or include an active rest period in which the client is instructed to perform a low-intensity activity during prescribed rest times.

Loaded Versus Unloaded Exercise Adjustment ExamplesSquat Exercise

Loaded: Dumbbell Squat – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds

Unloaded: Tempo Squat (2-0-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-0-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 0 seconds in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)

Horizontal Pressing Exercise

Loaded: Dumbbell Bench Press – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds

Unloaded: Tempo Push-Up (2-1-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)

Lunge Exercise

Loaded: Dumbbell Forward Lunge – 3 x 10, Rest Period: 60 seconds

Unloaded: Tempo Rear Foot Elevated Split Squat (2-1-2) – 4 x 8, Rest Period: 45 seconds

(2-1-2 = 2 seconds in the eccentric or lowering phase, 1 second in the isometric or static phase, and 2 seconds in the concentric or upward phase.)

NASM VCS Lecture CH600:05:26

Small or Large Group Training

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingSmall or Large Group TrainingJacob Lund/Shuttershock.comVirtual training may take place in a small (2 to 10 individuals) or large (10 or more individuals) group setting. Clients will be engaged in a class receiving live instruction from a fitness professional, watching a prerecorded video of a fitness professional conducting a training session, or following along to a live stream group workout. In the group fitness setting, the fitness professional will often lack the resources to focus on minor details and the sessions will tend to be more of a one-size-fits-all general fitness workout. The fitness professional should consider how each movement may be modified and regressed to suit a variety of skill levels and physical abilities among clients. During group training, the fitness professional should focus on the tone, delivery, and style of instruction provided.

Group CommunicationThe way in which the fitness professional communicates with and instructs clients in the group fitness setting directly affects the outcome of the class. Online group fitness classes may consist of multiple clients relying on just one or many fitness professionals for instruction. The classes may either be pre-recorded, live-interactive, or live-non-interactive (Figure: Group Fitness). In pre-recorded classes the fitness professional films a workout that is to be watched and completed by a class at a later date. In this virtual format, the class participants will have no access to the fitness professional during the class.

FigureGroup FitnessEnsuring regressions and progressions of each movement being performed is key to engage clients of all fitness levels. A live-interactive group fitness class will consist of the fitness professional coaching a small or large group class in real time while watching and interacting with the participants. A live-non-interactive class (e.g., live-streaming) is similar to a prerecorded class, only the fitness professional conducts the training session live, at the same time as their class, but without visual access to the class.

Pre-Recorded Group Fitness Coaching

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingPre-Recorded Group Fitness CoachingPre-recorded group fitness classes require the fitness professional to be clear and concise with instructions as there will be no opportunity for correction or adjustments. Providing instruction on exercise technique and workout objectives multiple times during a pre-recorded group fitness class will help alleviate confusion and difficulties for the class. Providing detailed instruction on objectives, tempo, and exercise form prior to beginning the class is the most effective method for mitigating obstacles for participants in pre-recorded group fitness classes.

Helpful HintKey Components: Pre-Recorded and Group Fitness Coaching Key

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Repeat instructions multiple times.
- Provide instruction often, prior to and during the class.

Live Group Fitness Coaching

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingLive Group Fitness CoachingIn live group fitness classes, fitness professionals should communicate clearly and concisely. If the fitness professional is coaching a live class in which they will be interacting with clients, they should avoid coaching in a way that purposefully singles out or isolates any participants. The coaching should be catered to the group and void of any form of favoritism or divisive language. All individual corrections and coaching provided should be for the sole purpose of motivation, education, and safety. Live-stream group classes, in which the fitness professional cannot interact with or see clients. should include multiple instructions provided often during the class, similar to pre-recorded group fitness classes.

Helpful HintKey Components: Live-Non-Interactive Group Fitness Coaching

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Repeat instructions multiple times.
- Provide instruction often, prior to and during the class.

Interactive live group fitness classes allow the fitness professional to make adjustments and corrections in real time, but class size may limit the amount of individual attention given to each participant. While coaching a small group fitness class, the instructor will be able to make regular adjustments without affecting class flow and effectiveness. However, this may not be the case in larger class sizes. Large group fitness classes may contain too many clients for the fitness professional to make consistent and individualized corrections. Coaching large group fitness classes in real time should be aimed at guiding the class as a group using outcome goals and generalized themes and should limit detailed corrections.

Helpful HintKey Components: Live-Interactive Group Fitness Coaching

- Provide clear, concise instructions.
- Limit frequency of detailed corrections.
- Keep coaching themes general and goal-oriented (avoid singling out clients).

Communication Tone

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingCommunication ToneThe tone and delivery of the instruction should reflect the intent or purpose of a group fitness class. The tone of the fitness professional should be uplifting, motivational, and function-focused. A 2018 study found that function-focused coaching had more positive effects on client body-satisfaction than appearance-focused coaching (Engeln et al., 2018). Appearance-focused coaching emphasizes physical appearance as the coaching objective of the class, whereas function-focused coaching emphasizes physical effort and outcomes (Figure: Communication Tone).

FigureCommunication ToneOnline fitness classes range from restorative to high-intensity. If the class is high-intensity and difficult, the fitness professional will need to motivate, encourage, and maintain appropriate tempo in the class. Motivating clients in a high-intensity class setting will include consistent upbeat and energetic encouragement. A class that is designed to be restorative or low-intensity, such as a yoga class, will require the fitness professional to present with a softer, more mellow tone. The fitness professional is responsible for recognizing the objective of the class and choosing a suitable tone and delivery to correlate with that objective.

Function-focused coachingFitness coaching emphasizing physical effort and outcomes.

Appearance-focused coachingFitness coaching geared toward improvements to physical appearance.

Safety Considerations

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingSafety ConsiderationsIt can be challenging to ensure client safety in a virtual training environment. Fitness professionals cannot spot a client in a virtual training session as they can in-person, they cannot help them into and out of positions, or even help them if they happen to get injured. Certain precautions need to be taken in virtual training to promote safety and mitigate the risk of injury.

Helpful HintHere are some helpful ways for fitness professionals to improve safety in the virtual training environment.

Collection and understanding of client injury history, PAR-Q+, and physical capacity

Demonstration of proper use of training equipment and exercise form

Consistent focus, attention, and awareness on client

Have the client show them the whole workout area on camera or with pictures to determine if any safety concerns exist.

Select exercises and movements that are suitable for the client’s workout environment.

Physical Readiness and Injury History

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingPhysical Readiness and Injury HistoryFitness professionals should never attempt to diagnose or treat any form of illness; however, they should develop an understanding of the physical readiness of their clients. By providing clients with readiness questionnaires and reviewing their injury history, the fitness professional will have a better understanding of any limitations a client may have. Developing programs and awareness around a client’s physical readiness will help the fitness professional maintain a safe virtual training program and environment for their clients.

Previous injuries, health conditions, lifestyle habits, and work environment all provide vital information used for shaping individual programs. However, if a client presents with a serious medical or health condition, the fitness professional should refer them to an appropriate medical professional for clearance before participating in training or physical activity.

Critical!Fitness professionals, who are not licensed medical professionals, should never attempt to diagnose, treat or prescribe for any form of disease, illness, or medical condition.

Equipment SafetyEquipment safety is a byproduct of proper fitness professional demonstration and exercise selection. Fitness professionals should demonstrate exercises that require equipment and request that their clients demonstrate competency before progressing with more complexity, intensity, or increased weight. This demonstration can be completed through video calls or through form videos sent via e-mail or direct message. Demonstration of competency is needed, especially when a client has never used a particular piece of equipment or done a specific exercise movement.

Aligning exercise selection with client needs and capabilities mitigates equipment-related injury risk. If selected exercises are safe and the client has demonstrated competency, progressing the client to more challenging movements, incorporating added equipment, increasing difficulty, or adding more resistance to the movements can be done safely. If the client has not shown proficiency in performing an exercise safely, keeping the client at a regressed version of the exercise may increase exercise safety overall and minimize the potential risk of equipment-related injuries.

Attention and Awareness

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingAttention and AwarenessThe last, but certainly not least, safety consideration is the fitness professional's level of focus, attention, and awareness. All other safety precautions taken may fall short if the professional lacks awareness and focus on their clients during virtual training sessions. This simple yet important component is the foundation for safety in virtual training. Fitness professionals should maintain complete focus on their clients for the duration of their training session. They should refrain from checking their phone, leaving the room, or having external conversations or activities during appointments. This is not only a major component of safety but of professionalism, as well.

Antonio Guillem/Shuttershock.comCritical!Fitness Professionals should avoid the following during a virtual training session:

- Being on the phone
- Checking e-mails
- Leaving the room
- Engaging in external conversations or activities

Virtual Nutrition Coaching

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingVirtual Nutrition Coaching Dean Drobot/Shuttershock.comOnline nutrition coaching is an emerging industry. For the client, having a virtual nutrition coach will mean they have more access to their nutrition coach via e-mail, messaging, or client management software. Virtual nutrition coaching may have higher weight loss and more favorable health outcomes than in-person coaching (Johnson et al., 2019) (Figure: Nutrition Coaching). Professionals may find virtual nutrition coaching to be more desirable than in-person services due to its ease of access, the ability for the business to be mobile, and low overhead operating costs.

Virtual nutrition coaches can operate a successful coaching business with nothing more than a smartphone, a food tracking app, and some spreadsheets for keeping track of client data. These are the minimum tools required to deliver a virtual nutrition coaching service. Designing a scalable business that runs smoothly will require some added software, hardware, and peripheral equipment considerations, all of which are covered in Chapter 3: Technology Considerations.

FigureNutrition Coaching

Nutrition Program Development and Delivery

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingNutrition Program Development and DeliveryNutrition program delivery is much like delivering virtual training sessions. The fitness professional will need to utilize a scheduling system just as they would with virtual fitness coaching. (e.g., Calendly, Vocus.io, ScheduleOnce, Zoom, etc.). They will also need to choose how to communicate with and manage clients. For example, they may use a simple system like a text message or e-mail or video calling services like Skype or WhatsApp. They may also choose to use an integrated client management software that not only allows tracking desired client metrics but also enables communication and messaging between the coach and client.

There are a variety of tools the fitness professional or nutrition coach can utilize to develop nutrition plans for clients. The options for nutrition program development range from tools like spreadsheets and Word documents, to easy-to-use apps (e.g., MyFitnessPal, Eat This Much, etc.), all the way through to full client management software systems and integrative technology. Examples of integrated technologies include the NASM Edge App, Trainerize, TrueCoach, My PT Hub, Apotheo, etc. These third-party software systems offer a host of benefits such as tracking desired client metrics (calories, hunger, energy, steps, food logs, etc.), integrated messaging and e-mail systems, scheduling integration, nutrition app integration, billing and payment systems, and so on. There is an array of client management systems and the fitness professional should do their research to consider which option will work best for both the client and coach. Professionals can choose to utilize one or a combination of all these tools as long as they are able to effectively produce, provide, and discuss nutrition plans with their clients.

asiandelight/Shuttershock.comThe professional will not only need to determine the best platform to develop and deliver their nutrition programs, but also the most suitable platform for them to engage with their clients on the other components of nutrition coaching. Whether via cell phone or video, the professional should schedule appointments with their clients to evaluate nutrition goals, discuss progress and setbacks, discuss daily eating habits, and encourage self-monitoring. The professional should also consider how frequently they will be providing check-ins for accountability and progress review, what communication boundaries may look like, and how frequently video catch-up calls are provided. These factors will be individual to each coach and what services are being provided.

Progress Communication

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingProgress CommunicationWeekly or bi-weekly check-ins should be scheduled to touch-base with each client. These can be done through the integrated client management programs that have built-in check-in systems or, alternatively, done manually with e-mails or direct messaging. There is merit in performing video calls to discuss and perform check-ins with clients. With over 55% of communication being non-verbal (body language) and 38% of communication being determined by the tone of voice (Park & Park, 2018), there may be some benefits to performing video calls versus just written reviews each week.

If the professional is performing video calls to go through weekly or bi-weekly progress reports with clients, they should exercise the same principles of preparation, communication, and environment as mentioned for fitness professionals conducting virtual training sessions. These include the following:

Confirming scheduled appointments

Setting up computer or video conferencing equipment (lighting, microphones, etc.)

Being prepared for the video call: having all documentation, client metrics, and data at hand

Being well-groomed, professional, and courteous

Coach's CornerNutrition Coaching Options

- One-on-one nutrition coaching via video conferencing applications (e.g., Zoom or Skype)
- One-on-one nutrition coaching via virtual tools (e.g., e-mail, cell phone, or diet and nutrition apps)
- Predesigned nutrition program sales
- Combination of two or more coaching options

Summary

Chapter 6Implementing Coaching SessionsLesson 4Conducting Small or Large Group TrainingSummaryThe fitness professional or nutrition coach sets the stage for the client's virtual experience. The environment they construct, the way they present themselves, and the coaching they provide all dictate the experience the client will have in their virtual space. A successful virtual fitness professional understands and applies the principles of environment, presentation, and effective communication to implement great training sessions and provide excellent nutrition coaching that can rival in-person coaching.

By using the guidelines mentioned in this chapter, the fitness professional will be able to effectively adjust and configure a virtual training environment, schedule and organize training and coaching sessions, determine appropriate training equipment, and instruct a variety of clients virtually.

Chapter 6 ReferencesBanos, O., & Nugent, C. (2018). M-Coaching: Towards the Next Generation of Mobile-Driven Healthcare Support Services. Computer, 51(8): 14–17. https://doi.org/10.1109/MC.2018.3191267

Baranowski, A. M., & Hecht, H. (2017). Effect of camera angle on perception of trust and attractiveness. Empirical Studies of the Arts, 36(1). https://doi.org/10.1177/0276237417710762

Engeln, R., Shavlik, M., & Daly, C. (2018). Tone it down: How fitness instructors' motivational comments shape women's body satisfaction. Journal of Clinical Sport Psychology, 12(4): 508–524. https://doi.org/10.1123/jcsp.2017-0047

Johnson, K. E., Alencar, M. K., Coakley, K. E., Swift, D. L., Cole, N. H., Mermier, C. M., Kravitz, L., Amorim, F. T., & Gibson, A. L. (2019). Telemedicine-based health coaching Is effective for inducing weight loss and improving metabolic markers. Telemedicine Journal and E-Health, 25(2): 85–92. https://doi.org/10.1089/tmj.2018.0002

Park, S. G., & Park, K. H. (2018). Correlation between nonverbal communication and objective structured clinical examination score in medical students. Korean Journal of Medical Education, 30(3): 199–208. https://doi.org/10.3946/kjme.2018.94

Sweet, T. W., Foster, C., McGuigan, M. R., & Brice, G. (2004). Quantitation of resistance training using the session rating of perceived exertion method. Journal of Strength & Conditioning Research, 18(4): 796–802. https://doi.org/10.1519/14153.1

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. (2020). Fitness Trainers and Instructors: Occupational Outlook. Retrieved from https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/fitness-trainers-and-instructors.htm#tab-6

Wills, N. L., Wilson, B., Woodcock, E. B., Abraham, S. P., & Gillum, D. R. (2018). Appearance of nurses and perceived professionalism. International Journal of Studies in Nursing, 3(3): 30. https://doi.org/10.20849/ijsn.v3i3.466

Chapter 7: Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching

Chapter 7: Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesChapter 7: Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Wearable technology unlocks the ability to incorporate objective biometrics related to daily activity, sleep, recovery, and health parameters to develop and dynamically adjust integrative training programs. This chapter will focus on education and validation of health and performance for common wearable biometrics, the development of data-driven programs, and how to leverage wearable data for compliance monitoring and client reinforcement to maintain motivation and retention.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Develop an understanding of wearable technology and its limitations in virtual training.

Summarize the potential value of integrating wearable devices for virtual training.

Describe the primary biometrics collected by commercial wearable devices.

Determine ways to use biometric data to develop individualized programs.

Define ways to make data-driven adjustments to optimize safety, outcomes, and compliance.

Introduction

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesIntroduction According to Vogels (2020), “Roughly one-in-five U.S. adults (21%) say they regularly wear a smartwatch or wearable fitness tracker” (Figure: One-In-Five). When available, wearable technology provides fitness professionals with the ability to improve the reliability of data collection and continuously monitor clients’ health and fitness biometrics in a virtual training environment. The data from wearable devices can be utilized for assessing client risk and readiness for physical activity, developing individualized programs, monitoring progress, and even as a reinforcement tool to optimize adherence and retention.

ra2 studio/Shutterstock.comFigureOne-In-FiveBiometricsMeasurements of the human body or characteristics, including those obtained from smartwatches and wearable devices.

Defining Wearables

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesDefining WearablesWith the use of wearables, the virtual coaching experience does not have to be limited to an initial assessment, intermittent communication, and subjective reporting. When integrated properly, wearable technology helps to facilitate a 24/7 monitoring approach. This approach can improve client outcomes while also optimizing a fitness professional’s ability to scale his or her virtual coaching business.

While the perception of wearable technology is often limited to wrist-worn devices, this industry includes any type of electronic device worn on the body. Other common wearable devices include smart jewelry, tech-enabled clothing, and eyewear. For the purposes of virtual coaching, this chapter will limit its focus to commercially available smartwatches and fitness trackers that collect and track applicable biometrics including the following:

Heart rate

Heart rate variability

Respiratory rate

Oxygen saturation

Physical activity

Sleep parameters

To collect physiological data, smartwatches and fitness trackers often come equipped with sensors, including an electrocardiogram (ECG) or photoplethysmogram (PPG), gyroscope, and accelerometer.

Description of Wearable SensorsSensor Type

Description

Electrocardiogram (ECG)

Direct measurement of the heart’s electrical activity

Photoplethysmogram (PPG)

Optical measurement of blood circulation obtained by illuminating the skin and measuring changes in light absorption

Gyroscope

Measurement of orientation in space

Accelerometer

Measurement of three-axis movement and acceleration

WearableAny type of electronic technology worn on the device, including smartwatches, fitness trackers, smart jewelry and tech-enabled clothing.

Differences in Wearable Devices

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesDifferences in Wearable DevicesPeter Kotoff/Shutterstock.comWearable technologies have many differences, including the type of embedded sensors, method of data collection, what they measure, advanced features, and the quality and reliability of the data. When integrating wearable devices into a virtual coaching business, fitness professionals should be able to adapt and work with a device already owned by a client, but also be prepared to make suggestions based on the most suitable option for their needs.

Getting TechnicalElectrocardiography (ECG) Versus Photoplethysmography (PPG) in Wearable Technology

Electrocardiography (ECG) is a measurement of electrical activity at the heart that controls the expansion and contraction of the heart chambers, often using multiple electrodes. ECG is the gold standard measurement used in hospitals and healthcare settings to monitor heart rate and heart rate variability.

Photoplethysmography (PPG) uses light-based technology to measure the rate of blood flow as controlled by the heart's pumping action. In addition to measurements of heart rate, analysis of the PPG waveform can provide an accurate estimation of additional biometrics, depending on the wavelength or color of light utilized.

FIGURE: ECG vs. PPG

FigureECG vs. PPG

Green Versus Red Light PPG

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesGreen Versus Red Light PPG Most wearable devices utilize green light PPG. Measurements done on light-skinned individuals at normal temperature have shown that green light has desired properties for data collection, particularly during motion (Maeda et al., 2011). Green light PPG has been shown to be more readily absorbed by individuals with higher melanin levels (Shcherbina et al., 2017), including those with darker skin tones, which can often lead to inaccuracies in data collection.

Red and infrared (IR) light PPG sensors, while less reliable during physical activity, have various benefits related to deeper penetration in the skin (Figure: Green/Red Light PPG) and typically provide more reliable data regardless of skin tone (Spigulis, Gailite, Lihachev, & Erts, 2007). To correct for inaccuracies caused by motion in red light PPG sensors, many wearable technology companies have created algorithms that utilize the accelerometer to produce high-quality PPG signals. For these adaptive filters, the accelerometer movement data is used to detect and subtract motion from the PPG signal or to exclude the data completely if an accuracy threshold cannot be obtained.

FigureGreen/Red Light PPGAdvanced FeaturesThe features and biometric data collected from wearable devices will vary by manufacturer and even by device offered by the same wearable manufacturer. The number of advanced features often increases with the cost of the device, including color screens, onboard GPS, and waterproofing. More expensive is not always better, as many features may be unnecessary or lead to additional confusion for the client. Fitness professionals must understand what each device offers. They must know how the device relates to their ability to develop and execute effective virtual coaching and consider the balance between cost, features, and ease of use for the client.

Data Reliability

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesData ReliabilityAndrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comWhen relied on for risk stratification, program development, and client monitoring, the accuracy of data collected is of the utmost importance. In a comparative study of six mainstream wearable fitness trackers, researchers found that "Fitness trackers of different brands vary with regard to the measurement of indicators and are all affected by the activity state" (Xie et al., 2018).

All wearable technologies will have some margin of error relative to costly and bulky medical equipment. However, using the same device consistently will allow the client to establish a baseline activity level and show the fitness professional a developing trend to support improvements and adjustments. In general, fitness professionals should select a reliable device, avoid switching between different devices, and focus on establishing and monitoring data trends over time.

Coach's CornerSelecting a Reliable Wearable Technology

When determining which wearable technology to integrate into a virtual coaching business, fitness professionals should research which devices have been clinically validated versus gold standard medical equipment. For example, heart rate and/or oxygen saturation should be validated against a hospital-grade electrocardiogram or pulse oximeter and not against other commercial devices lacking validation.

Most commercial wearable technologies do not have the approval of the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA approval) but may have a research section available on their company website. Additionally, fitness professionals may search for scholarly articles on Google Scholar, JSTOR, or a comparable resource for information about data reliability of certain devices.

Risk stratificationAssessment of risk based on qualifying information, such as vitals or health history – Risk stratification can include the potential for training-related injury, the likelihood of a health event, or developing a health condition.

Pros and Cons

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Fitness WearablesPros and ConsPros and Cons of Wearable DevicesCategory

Pros

Cons

Electrocardiography (ECG)

Clinical gold standard

Require multiple electrodes; diminished accuracy when measured at the wrist alone

Photoplethysmography (PPG)

Cost-effective; less invasive; provides an estimation of additional biometrics

Less motion-tolerant

Green Light PPG

More motion-tolerant

Limitations for certain client populations

Red Light PPG

Deeper penetration; reliable for broad client populations

Less motion-tolerant

Advanced Features

May increase value for certain client types

Complexity of use; more expensive

Data Reliability

Confidence in program development and decision making

N/A

While wearable technology presents the opportunity to improve a virtual coaching experience, fitness professionals should not rely solely on biometric data. The trainer–client connection should include communication and consideration of subjective feelings and opinions, in addition to objective data obtained from wearable devices.

Biometric Education

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationBiometric EducationBiometrics are measurements of the human body or characteristics. These measurements range from fingerprint recognition to more readily available measurements obtained from smartwatches and fitness trackers. To understand how to integrate biometric data into a virtual coaching business, fitness professionals should first have an in-depth understanding of that data by considering these questions (Figure: Evaluating Biometrics).

FigureEvaluating Biometrics

Heart Rate

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationHeart RateBreslavtsev Oleg/Shutterstock.comHeart rate, measured in beats per minute (bpm), is the number of times the heart beats per minute. Heart rate is most commonly assessed at rest and during physical activity, both of which should be considered independently. According to the American Heart Association (2016), the following factors may influence heart rate:

Fitness Level

Room Temperature

Body Position

Emotional Stress

Body Size or Composition

Use of Medications

Critical!The Role of a Fitness Professional

A fitness professional is not credentialed to diagnose, treat, or prevent any specific medical conditions. While many of these biometrics may provide insight into potential health issues, the role of wearable technology in virtual coaching is to provide reliable data for program development. Fitness professionals should not provide medical advice but, rather, recommend that clients seek medical attention from a qualified health professional if alarming biometric values or trends are

recognized, especially if accompanied by symptoms including chest pain, shortness of breath, dizziness, or fatigue.

Resting Heart Rate

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationResting Heart RateResting heart rate (RHR) is the number of beats per minute obtained during rest. A normal resting heart rate can vary widely from person to person, but the accepted range for adults is 60 to 100 bpm (American Heart Association, 2015) (Figure: Resting Heart Rate).

FigureResting Heart RateHowever, individuals with higher resting heart rate values within this range may still be at increased risk of cardiovascular, non-cardiovascular, and all-cause mortality (Seccareccia et al., 2001). An elevated resting heart rate above 100 bpm, referred to as tachycardia, can be indicative of an underlying health condition that should be addressed by a trained healthcare professional.

In general, a lower resting heart rate is related to improved heart function and cardiovascular fitness (Nauman et al., 2012). A well-trained individual may maintain a resting heart rate well below 60 bpm, referred to as bradycardia, due to positive cardiovascular adaptations from training. For clients who are not physically active but still maintain a heart rate below 60 bpm, fitness professionals should prompt the client to seek approval from a doctor prior to engaging in physical activity, as this can be a sign of an underlying heart condition (American Heart Association, 2016).

When assessed properly, resting heart rate should be relatively stable for all populations with minimal day-to-day changes. Over time, positive or negative lifestyle interventions may lead to a steady change in resting heart rate values. In a meta-analysis, Reimers et al. (2018) found that all types of exercise, especially endurance training and yoga, decreased resting heart rate in healthy subjects, which may contribute to a reduction in all-cause mortality.

Resting heart rate (RHR)The number of times the heart beats per minute while at complete rest.

Active Heart Rate

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationActive Heart RateActive heart rate is the number of beats per minute obtained during physical activity. In general, active heart rate is correlated with relative output and can be utilized to gauge the intensity of an exercise effort (Figure: Target Heart Rate). Fitness professionals may utilize active heart rate monitoring as a method to assess compliance for exercise prescription, particularly when target heart rate zones are recommended (Polar, 2020).

FigureTarget Heart RateMany wearable devices rely on active heart rate measurements, in addition to demographic information, including gender and age, to estimate activity-related caloric expenditure.

Active heart rateThe number of times the heart beats per minute during physical activity.

Heart Rate Variability

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationHeart Rate Variability Heart rate variability (HRV) is the measurement of variation in time intervals between heartbeats, most commonly reported in milliseconds (ms). Wearable devices are frequently limited to time-domain measurements of HRV and report values as the standard deviation of N-N intervals (SDNN) or root mean squared standard deviation (RMSSD). Additional measures of HRV include nonlinear or frequency-domain analysis, which is beyond the scope of this discussion.

Time-Domain Measurements of HRVIndex

Units

Description

SDNN

ms

Total variability between heartbeats, considered the gold standard when measured over a 24-hour period to predict morbidity and mortality (Task Force of the European Society of Cardiology and the North American Society of Pacing and Electrophysiology, 1996)

RMSSD

ms

Beat-to-beat variance in heart rate to estimate parasympathetic influences (Shaffer et al., 2014)

HRV provides quantifiable and non-invasive insight into the current state of a client's autonomic nervous system, which is involved in the regulation of autonomic or involuntary processes. The autonomic nervous system consists of two primary branches, sympathetic (fight-or-flight) and parasympathetic (rest, digest, and relax). HRV is a measurement of the ongoing contention between these two branches to regulate physiological processes without conscious thought. For example, an individual does not have to actively think about breathing, their heart beating, or maintaining blood pressure due to autonomic control of these processes. More importantly, though, recent research has shown that changes in HRV may be related to inflammatory processes, hormone regulation, and immune system function (Liu et al., 2017).

VectorMine/Shutterstock.comHeart rate variability (HRV)The measurement of variation in time intervals between heartbeats, most commonly reported in milliseconds (ms).

Autonomic nervous systemThe division of the peripheral nervous system responsible for regulation of involuntary processes that do not require conscious control, such as heart rate or respiratory rate.

Content

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationCritical!Heart Rate Variability and Health

Due to its relation to physical and mental health outcomes, HRV is among the most meaningful biometrics that fitness professionals should consider when developing and measuring the success of a lifestyle intervention program. There is growing evidence that various diseases are accompanied by reduced HRV values including, but not limited to, the following (Young & Benton, 2018):

Diabetes

Cardiovascular disease

Psychiatric disorders

All-cause mortality

In a meta-analysis, researchers found that individuals with lower HRV values compared to their cohort had a 112% higher risk of all-cause death and a 46% increased incidence of cardiovascular events (Fang et al., 2019).

Heart rate variability is a highly individualized biometric and should not be utilized to compare different clients but, instead, assessed for positive or negative change at the individual level. While HRV has been shown to decrease predictably with age (Jandackova et al., 2016) and various health-related conditions, the value of monitoring HRV in a virtual coaching program is to determine an individual's recovery, daily training readiness, and monitor progress over time. In general, HRV values should be relatively stable from day to day but may increase gradually over time with positive lifestyle interventions, including improved sleep, exercise activity, and nutritional habits. Higher HRV values have been positively associated with improved cardiovascular fitness and stress resilience (Dong, 2016) and decreased risk of training-related injuries (Williams et al., 2017). Additional studies have shown that decreased heart rate variability is an effective tool for measuring cumulative physical fatigue in overtrained athletes (Pichot et al., 2000), which may offer insight into programming periods of lower intensity to prioritize recovery (Figure: Heart Rate Variability).

FigureHeart Rate VariabilityCoach's CornerGuiding Training With HRV

HRV represents the current state of the individual's autonomic nervous system and its ability to make a positive adaptation. By assessing an individual's HRV trend and adjusting daily training efforts accordingly, fitness professionals can help clients train smarter while also improving overall outcomes.

Training Prescription Guided by HRV in Cycling (Javaloyes et al. 2018)

In a study of elite cyclists, researchers divided participants into two groups: an HRV-guided training group and a traditional periodization group. The HRV-guided training group had their daily output dynamically adjusted based on daily HRV values, whereas the traditional periodization group followed a structured protocol. Following an 8-week training intervention, researchers found that HRV-guided training led to greater increases in the following:

Peak power (5%)

Power at second ventilatory threshold (VT2) (14%)

Power over a 40-minute time trial (7%)

Oxygen Saturation

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationOxygen Saturation When an individual breathes, oxygen is attached to and distributed throughout the body by a protein molecule called hemoglobin in the red blood cells. Oxygen saturation, often referred to as SpO2 and reported as a percentage (%) value, is the fraction of oxygenated hemoglobin relative to the total amount of hemoglobin. The normal range for oxygen saturation in healthy adults is 95 to 100 percent at rest (Figure: Normal Oxygen Saturation) but can be as low as 88 to 92 percent in clients with known conditions such as Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease or other lung diseases (Holland, 2019). Lifestyle habits such as smoking may also reduce oxygen saturation (Ozdal et al., 2017).

FigureNormal Oxygen SaturationMonitoring oxygen saturation is important because low blood oxygen (hypoxemia) can lead to adverse effects on important organ systems, including the brain, heart, and kidneys (Hafen & Sharma, 2020). In general, clients with normal oxygen saturation should not recognize significant day-to-day changes or overtime with program interventions. If a significant decrease in oxygen saturation is recognized, particularly if it is accompanied by symptoms, fitness professionals should urge clients to seek medical attention.

HemoglobinA red protein responsible for transporting oxygen in the blood of vertebrates.

Oxygen saturationOften referred to as SpO2 and reported as a percentage (%) value, the fraction of oxygenated hemoglobin relative to the total amount of hemoglobin.

Respiratory Rate

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationRespiratory RateRespiratory rate, measured in breaths per minute (bpm), is the number of breaths an individual takes in 1 minute at rest. Respiration is measured as one complete inhale and exhale, which represents the cycle of respiratory gas exchange of oxygen and carbon dioxide. Normal ranges for respiratory rates vary throughout the life cycle (Figure: Respiratory Rates by Age), with newborns

breathing at a rate of up to 60 breaths per minute but leveling out at a steady rate of 12 to 20 breaths per minute in adulthood (Nall, 2017). For adults, respiratory rates below 12 or over 25 are considered abnormal and may be indicative of an underlying condition such as asthma, anxiety, pneumonia, heart, or lung disease (Cleveland Clinic, 2019). Respiratory rate may also be influenced by posture or mechanical restrictions of the diaphragm (Zafar et al., 2018).

FigureRespiratory Rates by AgeBased on physical activity and other stressors, respiratory rate can vary significantly throughout the day. Fitness professionals should focus on nocturnal measurements of the respiratory rate due to the relatively controlled environment. In general, the nocturnal respiratory rate should be steady from day to day with minimal change over time. Minor changes in nocturnal respiratory rate may be indicative of recent alcohol consumption (Izumi et al., 2005), whereas rapid and significant changes may be indicative of illness requiring medical attention (Cretikos et al., 2008).

Coach's CornerAssessing Respiratory Rate During Activity

In response to physical activity, the autonomic nervous system will increase the respiratory rate to account for increased oxygen demand and a change in blood pH due to the increased concentration of carbon dioxide. Changes in respiratory rate measured during physical activity have been shown to be a valid and reliable marker for assessing cardiorespiratory fitness and anaerobic threshold during a graded exercise test (Carey et al., 2005), which may be valuable for program development. Unfortunately, most wearable devices are intolerant to motion and do not provide a reliable measurement of respiratory rate during physical activity.

Respiratory rateThe number of breaths an individual takes in 1 minute at rest, typically measured in breaths per minute (bpm).

Sleep Parameters

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationSleep Parameterssolar22/Shutterstock.comAdequate, quality sleep is an important yet overlooked aspect of health and physical performance. According to the Centers for Disease Control (Colton & Altevogt, 2006), one-third of adults in the United States have insufficient sleep. This correlates to wide-ranging effects on the cardiovascular, endocrine, immune, and nervous systems, leading to an increased risk of health conditions, including the following (Center for Disease Control, 2020):

Obesity

Type II diabetes

Hypertension

Cardiovascular disease

Anxiety and depression

Decreased testosterone

General sleep recommendations will vary by age group but may not be appropriate for all client populations depending on health status and level of physical activity. Fitness professionals should monitor the client's sleep duration in relation to other biometric parameters, including sleep quality and heart rate variability to determine more precise sleep recommendations within the appropriate guidelines (Figure: Sleep Recommendations).

FigureSleep Recommendations

Content

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationGetting TechnicalSleep, Recovery, and Adaptation

While sleep seems like a time to finally let the brain "shut off," research has revealed the brain works even harder during sleep. During sleep, the brain works to restore and repair cells, process information for long-term memory, and perform important processes related to health and performance (Dattilo et al., 2011).

Fitness professionals should emphasize the importance of proper sleep for recovery and dynamically modify programs to optimize client outcomes and decrease the risk of injury.

Wearable devices provide fitness professionals with the ability to consistently monitor clients' sleep habits to determine deficiencies and develop data-driven programs for improvement. Wearable devices auto-capture meaningful sleep parameters and often provide an overall sleep score for rapid interpretation of change over time.

Andrey_Popov/Shutterstock.comCommon Wearable Device Sleep ParametersSleep Parameter

Description

Time in Bed

Total time spent in bed, which may include time spent watching television or on waking before getting prepared for the day

Sleep Duration

Total time spent asleep – sleep duration relative to the time in bed can be utilized to assess sleep efficiency

Onset and Wake Time

Time of sleep onset and wake up time – these values can be utilized to assess consistency in sleep schedule or adherence to a circadian rhythm

Sleep Stages

Analysis of time or percentage of time spent in each distinct sleep stage – sleep stages vary by wearable device but often include light sleep, deep sleep, and REM sleep

Latency

The amount of time to fall asleep

Awakenings/Disruptions

The number of awakenings, which may include voluntary awakenings such as using the restroom or involuntary, including a sleep disruption

---

Content

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationAdditional valuable sleep parameters provided by certain wearable devices include movement, snoring levels, circadian rhythm scores, sleep accounting, and overall sleep scores ranging from 0 to 100 for simple interpretation. Each reported sleep metric provides a fitness professional with the opportunity to develop an individualized and data-driven program to improve sleep quality for overall program success.

FigureOverview of Sleep StagesGetting TechnicalIntroduction to Sleep Stages

There are four distinct stages of sleep each with the purpose of restoring or improving specific physiological processes. In general, the body will cycle through all of these stages several times throughout a single night, but various lifestyle factors, ages, and health conditions can impact the amount of time spent in each sleep stage.

FIGURE: Overview of Sleep Stages

Critical!Circadian Rhythm

One of the most meaningful, simple, and cost-effective (free) interventions that a fitness professional can recommend is adherence to a consistent sleep cycle. The human body has evolved to follow a natural and internal 24-hour clock, or circadian rhythm, which impacts body temperature, metabolism, and hormonal processes (National Institute of General Medical Sciences, 2020). Physiological processes are optimized when factors such as sleep and wake up times are consistently maintained. Consistency in sleep patterns has been correlated with improved cognitive function and memory, whereas inconsistent circadian patterns have shown to increase the incidence of illness, cardiovascular disease, and cancer (Scheiermann et al., 2013). The human body's natural circadian rhythm can be disrupted by external factors, including temperature and light.

Fitness professionals may consider circadian rhythm interventions or recommendations to maintain consistent sleep onset and wake up times to improve an individual's overall sleep quality and performance.

Recovery and Readiness

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationRecovery and ReadinessRecovery and readiness to engage in physical activity are relative concepts that require access to consistent and reliable biometric data. For example, a fitness professional cannot compare two individuals side-by-side and determine who is more recovered based on a heart rate variability value. Instead, it requires an understanding of an individual's baseline values over the previous days or months to determine the current state of their body. Regarding the common biometrics provided by wearable devices, fitness professionals should assess recovery and readiness based on the biometrics that have been clinically validated to predict the risk of injury, daily readiness to perform, or change in health status. These biometrics are resting heart rate, heart rate variability, and sleep parameters (Figure: Assessing Recovery and Readiness).

Parilov/Shutterstock.comFigureAssessing Recovery and Readiness

---

Content

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Biometric EducationExample of Adequate Recovery – READYBiometric

30 Day Average

Today

Interpretation

Resting Heart Rate

72 bpm

72 bpm

Normal

Heart Rate Variability

54 ms

58 ms

Above Average

Sleep Duration

7 hours 48 mins

8 hours 10 mins

Adequate Sleep

In the example provided in Table: Example of Adequate Recovery – READY the client appears to have had a restful night's sleep and made a full recovery from the previous day. The client may engage in physical activity as planned.

Example of Inadequate Recovery – RECOVERBiometric

30 Day Average

Today

Interpretation

Resting Heart Rate

72 bpm

74 bpm

Elevated HR (within normal range)

Heart Rate Variability

54 ms

40 ms

Below Average

Sleep Duration

7 hours 48 mins

5 hours 10 mins

Inadequate Sleep

In the example provided in Table: Example of Inadequate Recovery – RECOVER, the client did not achieve adequate sleep and biometrics have not fully recovered, indicating a potential increased risk of injury or poor performance (Williams et al., 2017; Buchheit et al., 2009). The fitness professional should consider modifying the program to focus on active or passive recovery and recommend that the client get a restful night's sleep.

For the purposes and simplicity of these examples, sleep duration was utilized as a primary biometric to assess recovery and readiness. Note that sleep duration alone should not be relied on to determine sleep quality and readiness. Additional parameters, including sleep stages and disruptions, should be included in the determination of sleep quality.

Following a defined baseline stage, many wearable applications apply unique algorithms to provide a recovery score ranging from 0 to 100 for rapid interpretation and simple understanding. These often include basic instructions to rest and recover, take it easy, or engage in light physical activity or indicates readiness to engage in rigorous physical activity based on full recovery.

Recovery Template

Building a Program

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramBuilding a ProgramThe value of integrating wearable technology into virtual coaching is not from the data collection itself but the insight this data provides to the fitness professional for individualized and data-driven program development. When used properly, wearable technology and the data it provides can be utilized to develop programs and make data-driven adjustments that optimize outcomes and safety. Wearable technology data can also provide a behavioral reinforcement tool for ongoing motivation, adherence, and retention.

Milles Studio/Shutterstock.com

Process Overview

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramProcess OverviewTo optimize the efficiency and value of integrating wearable technology into virtual coaching, the fitness professional should develop a consistent and repeatable process (Figure: Program Design).

FigureProgram DesignIntegrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingPhase

Overview/Description

1 – Baseline

Establish a minimum of a 3- to 5-day baseline to obtain objective insight into a client's biometric strengths and deficiencies. During the baseline phase, the client should be instructed to continue with normal lifestyle behaviors and not adjust nutritional or exercise habits.

2 – Analysis and Initial Program Development

Following the baseline phase, fitness professionals should perform a comprehensive analysis of a client's strengths and deficiencies in relation to their goals. Programs should be developed to address deficiencies that may limit program success while ensuring that strengths are not sacrificed. A comprehensive program is developed and provided to the client with an explanation of WHY specific interventions were chosen.

3 – Ongoing Monitoring

Fitness professionals should develop a consistent schedule for monitoring client data. While it may not be feasible to assess data every day, it is important to check in on days that rigorous training is scheduled to assess readiness and, if necessary, adjust program recommendations. Some wearable platforms provide automated alerts of significant change to streamline the monitoring process.

4 – Adjust & Consult

Utilize biometric data to dynamically adjust program recommendations based on client recovery and readiness to safely and effectively perform the recommended program for the day. Over time, fitness professionals may be able to create a more effective program schedule based on recovery trends from previous exercise interventions.

If a program adjustment is required, fitness professionals should attempt to understand the unexpected change in biometric data. For example, poor sleep quality and decreased HRV may be explained if the client consumed alcohol the evening prior. This represents an opportunity to show the client how this behavior impacted their biometrics to create awareness and avoid future deviations from the program.

In the case that positive biometric trends are recognized, this represents an opportunity to provide positive reinforcement to maintain program adherence.

Intervention Toolkit

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramIntervention ToolkitFitness professionals should have a comprehensive understanding of the biometrics provided by wearable technologies and develop an intervention toolkit based on their skills and qualifications. This may be organized based on which biometric it is validated to address and then selected on a client-by-client basis based on analysis of additional assessments, cost, and time commitment. Over time, the toolkit will be enhanced and refined based on personal experiences and program outcomes.

Coach's CornerProgram Development – Practical Example

Client A is a 45-year-old male with a desk job and a high-level of work-related stress. After a check-up from his doctor, Client A was diagnosed as pre-diabetic and obese. Client A's physician cleared him for exercise but emphasized the importance of lifestyle changes. Client A has tried to exercise and improve his nutritional habits but gives up because the scale weight does not improve.

Following a comprehensive assessment and establishing a 5-day biometric baseline, the fitness professional identified the following deficiencies:

2400 steps/day

Sleep latency over 30 minutes

Lack of consistency in sleep times

Elevated resting heart rate (88 bpm)

Reduced HRV (28 ms)

Based on the fitness professional's qualifications, it is determined that a minimally invasive and phase-based program will be the most effective and sustainable for Client A:

Daily step count goal of 5000 steps, increased by 500 steps per week: To emphasize consistency of movement throughout the day, Client A is instructed to set an alarm and take at least 500 steps every hour during the workday.

Exercise program (based on other assessments)

Nutritional counseling (based on nutritional assessment forms)

Sleep recommendations and Circadian Rhythm Intervention: Avoid use of technology for 1 hour prior to bed, create a bedtime routine, and set consistent sleep and wake times each day.

Education: Why these biometrics are important, expected improvements, and the significance to Client A's health and goals

The fitness professional will monitor Client A's biometric data for compliance and consistently provide positive reinforcement based on improvements in sleep quality, daily physical activity, and other applicable biometrics.

Data-Driven Adjustments

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramData-Driven AdjustmentsHuman physiology is complex and adaptable. This requires fitness professionals to consistently monitor and dynamically adjust programs to minimize the risk of training-related accidents, avoid injuries, and optimize client outcomes. The use of wearable technology provides fitness professionals with the unprecedented ability to objectively quantify and track the

efficacy of any type or combination of interventions. For example, a fitness professional with the proper qualifications may develop a similar nutrition program for two individuals who present with similar backgrounds and biometrics but recognize the high probability of significantly different health and body composition outcomes.

goodluz/Shutterstock.comThe following are examples of various data-driven adjustments:

Adjusting the type or intensity of a single exercise session based on recovery data

Adjusting a portion of an intervention to test if outcomes can be improved, such as modifying macronutrient recommendations

Removing an intervention that does not seem to be yielding outcomes

Removing an intervention that is negatively affecting biometric data

Adding an intervention based on changes in biometric data over time

Dynamic modification of a program to avoid plateaus

For example, a previously sedentary client following an exercise intervention may require additional sleep to facilitate adequate recovery.

Behavioral Considerations

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramBehavioral ConsiderationsThe basic principles of human behavior state that behaviors that are reinforced tend to be maintained. Clients have likely attempted lifestyle modification on their own prior to seeking help from a fitness professional but failed because they did not recognize improvements and could not maintain intrinsic motivation. Utilizing biometric data from wearable devices provides fitness professionals with the ability to consistently monitor compliance, which is a notable limitation of virtual coaching, and provides a source of positive reinforcement to optimize ongoing momentum for improvement (Figure: Reinforcement Theory of Motivation). Fitness professionals should actively pursue any opportunity to make a client feel good about their progress, whether it be based on compliance to a program or positive biometric trends related to overall health and performance (Expert Program Management, 2018).

FigureReinforcement Theory of MotivationAdditionally, biometric data can be utilized to bring attention to the negative impact of certain behaviors. For example, a decrease in sleep quality and heart rate variability following a night of heavy alcohol consumption may decrease the likelihood of the individual deviating from the program in the future.

Lastly, clients want to know that they are being supported and monitored by a fitness professional they can trust. By integrating wearable technology into virtual coaching, fitness professionals have the ability to further individualize recommendations and continuity of care with 24/7 monitoring beyond what can be offered in a training facility.

Positive reinforcementA stimulus following a behavior that increases the likelihood of an individual continuing that behavior – For example, improvements in scale weight due to nutritional intervention increase the likelihood of an individual continuing to adhere to the nutrition program.

Summary

Chapter 7Integrating Wearables Into Virtual CoachingLesson 3Building a ProgramSummaryBiometric data provided by wearable technologies provides fitness professionals with reliable data to assist in developing, modifying, and continuously monitoring virtual programs for client compliance and outcomes. Many of these biometrics, including sleep and heart rate variability, may be applied to support a better-quality program for all client types based on their relationship with physical health, mental health, risk of injury, and athletic performance. When integrated properly, wearable technology provides the fitness professional with the ability to facilitate a 24/7 monitoring approach to improve client outcomes while also optimizing their ability to scale their virtual coaching business. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH700:04:44Chapter 7 ReferencesAmerican Heart Association. (2015). All About Heart Rate (Pulse). Retrieved from https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure/the-facts-about-high-blood-pressure/all-about-heart-rate-pulse

American Heart Association. (2016). Bradycardia: Slow Heart Rate. Retrieved from https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/arrhythmia/about-arrhythmia/bradycardia--slow-heart-rate#:%7E:text=Bradycardia%20is%20a%20heart%20rate,(BPM)%20qualifies%20as%20bradycardia

Buchheit, M., Chivot, A., Parouty, J., Mercier, D., Al Haddad, H., Laursen, P. B., & Ahmaidi, S. (2009). Monitoring endurance running performance using cardiac parasympathetic function. European Journal of Applied Physiology, 108(6): 1153–1167. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00421-009-1317-x

Carey, D. G., Schwarz, L. A., Pliego, G. J., & Raymond, R. L. (2005). Respiratory Rate is a Valid and Reliable Marker for the Anaerobic Threshold: Implications for Measuring Change in Fitness. Journal of Sports Science & Medicine, 4(4): 482–488. https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3899665/

Centers for Disease Control. (2020). Sleep and Sleep Disorders. Retrieved from https://www.cdc.gov/sleep/index.html

Cleveland Clinic. (2019). Vital Signs. Retrieved from https://my.clevelandclinic.org/health/articles/10881-vital-signs

Colton, H. R., & Altevogt, B. M. (Eds.). (2006). Sleep disorders and sleep deprivation: An unmet public health problem. Washington, DC: National Academies Press.

Cretikos, M. A., Bellomo, R., Hillman, K., Chen, J., Finfer, S., & Flabouris, A. (2008). Respiratory rate: the neglected vital sign. Medical Journal of Australia, 188(11): 657–659. https://doi.org/10.5694/j.1326-5377.2008.tb01825.x

Dattilo, M., Antunes, H. K. M., Medeiros, A., Mônico Neto, M., Souza, H. S., Tufik, S., & de Mello, M. T. (2011). Sleep and muscle recovery: Endocrinological and molecular basis for a new and promising hypothesis. Medical Hypotheses, 77(2): 220–222. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.mehy.2011.04.017

Dong, J.-G. (2016). The role of heart rate variability in sports physiology. Experimental and Therapeutic Medicine, 11(5): 1531–1536. https://doi.org/10.3892/etm.2016.3104

Expert Program Management. (2018). Reinforcement Theory of Motivation. Retrieved from https://expertprogrammanagement.com/2018/10/reinforcement-theory-of-motivation/

Fang, S.-C., Wu, Y.-L., & Tsai, P.-S. (2019). Heart Rate Variability and Risk of All-Cause Death and Cardiovascular Events in Patients With Cardiovascular Disease: A Meta-Analysis of Cohort Studies. Biological Research for Nursing, 22(1): 45–56. https://doi.org/10.1177/1099800419877442

Hafen, B. B., & Sharma, S. (2020). Oxygen saturation. Treasure Island, Fl: StatPearls.

Holland, K. (2019). Is My Blood Oxygen Level Normal? Retrieved from https://www.healthline.com/health/normal-blood-oxygen-level#:%7E:text=Normal%3A%20A%20normal%20ABG%20oxygen,these%20ranges%20may%20not%20apply

Izumi, I., Nasermoaddeli, A., Sekine, M., & Kagamimori, S. (2005.). Effect of moderate alcohol intake on nocturnal sleep respiratory parameters in healthy middle-aged men. Environmental Health and Preventive Medicine, 10(1): 16–20. https://doi.org/10.1265/ehpm.10.16

Jandackova, V. K., Scholes, S., Britton, A., & Steptoe, A. (2016). Are Changes in Heart Rate Variability in Middle-Aged and Older People Normative or Caused by Pathological Conditions? Findings From a Large Population-Based Longitudinal Cohort Study. Journal of the American Heart Association, 5(2): e002365. https://doi.org/10.1161/jaha.115.002365

Javaloyes, A., Sarabia, J. M., Lamberts, R. P., & Moya-Ramon, M. (2019). Training Prescription Guided by Heart-Rate Variability in Cycling. International Journal of Sports Physiology and Performance, 14(1): 23–32. https://doi.org/10.1123/ijspp.2018-0122

Liu, Y.-Z., Wang, Y.-X., & Jiang, C.-L. (2017). Inflammation: The Common Pathway of Stress-Related Diseases. Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 11: 316. https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2017.00316

Maeda, Y., Sekine, M., & Tamura, T. (2011). The Advantages of Wearable Green Reflected Photoplethysmography. Journal of Medical Systems, 35(5): 829–834. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10916-010-9506-z

Nall, R. (2017). A Mom's Guide to Pediatric Vital Signs. Retrieved from https://www.healthline.com/health/pediatric-vital-signs

National Institute of General Medical Sciences. (2020). Circadian Rhythms. Retrieved from https://www.nigms.nih.gov/education/fact-sheets/Pages/circadian-rhythms.aspx#:%7E:text=Circadian%20rhythms%20are%20physical%2C%20mental,a%20light%2Drelated%20circadian%20rhythm

National Institute of Neurological Disorders and Stroke. (2019). Brain Basics: Understanding Sleep. Retrieved from https://www.ninds.nih.gov/disorders/patient-caregiver-education/understanding-sleep

National Sleep Foundation. (2015). National Sleep Foundation Recommends New Sleep Times. Retrieved from https://www.sleepfoundation.org/press-release/national-sleep-foundation-recommends-new-sleep-times

Nauman, J., Aspenes, S. T., Nilsen, T. I. L., Vatten, L. J., & Wisløff, U. (2012). A Prospective Population Study of Resting Heart Rate and Peak Oxygen Uptake (the HUNT Study, Norway). PLoS ONE, 7(9): e45021. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0045021

Ozdal, M., Pancar, Z., Çinar, V., & Bilgiç, M. (2017). Effect of Smoking on Oxygen Saturation in Healthy Sedentary Men and Women. EC Pulmonology and Respiratory Medicine, 4(6): 178–182.

Pichot, V., Roche, F., Gaspoz, J. M., Enjolras, F., Antoniadis, A., Minini, P., Barthélémy, J. C. (2000). Relation between heart rate variability and training load in middle-distance runners. Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise, 32(10): 1729–1736. https://doi.org/10.1097/00005768-200010000-00011

Polar. (2020). Running heart rate zones: The basics. Retrieved from https://www.polar.com/blog/running-heart-rate-zones-basics/

Reimers, A. K., Knapp, G., & Reimers, C.-D. (2018). Effects of Exercise on the Resting Heart Rate: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis of Interventional Studies. Journal of Clinical Medicine, 7(12): 503. https://doi.org/10.3390/jcm7120503

Scheiermann, C., Kunisaki, Y., & Frenette, P. S. (2013). Circadian control of the immune system. Nature Reviews Immunology, 13(3): 190–198. https://doi.org/10.1038/nri3386

Seccareccia, F., Pannozzo, F., Dima, F., Minoprio, A., Menditto, A., Lo Noce, C., & Giampaoli, S. (2001). Heart Rate as a Predictor of Mortality: The MATISS Project. American Journal of Public Health, 91(8): 1258–1263. https://doi.org/10.2105/ajph.91.8.1258

Shaffer, F., McCraty, R., & Zerr, C. L. (2014). A healthy heart is not a metronome: an integrative review of the heart's anatomy and heart rate variability. Frontiers in Psychology, 5: 1040. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2014.01040

Shcherbina, A., Mattsson, C. M., Waggott, D., Salisbury, H., Christle, J. W., Hastie, T., Wheeler, M. T., & Ashley, E. A. (2017). Accuracy in Wrist-Worn, Sensor-Based Measurements of Heart Rate and Energy Expenditure in a Diverse Cohort. Journal of Personalized Medicine, 7(2): 3. https://doi.org/10.3390/jpm7020003

Spigulis, J., Gailite, L., Lihachev, A., & Erts, R. (2007). Simultaneous recording of skin blood pulsations at different vascular depths by multiwavelength photoplethysmography. Applied Optics, 46(10): 1754–1759. https://doi.org/10.1364/ao.46.001754

Task Force of the European Society of Cardiology and the North American Society of Pacing and Electrophysiology (1996). Heart Rate Variability. Circulation, 93(5): 1043–1065. https://doi.org/10.1161/01.cir.93.5.1043

Vogels, E. A. (2020. About one-in-five Americans use a smart watch or fitness tracker. Retrieved from https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2020/01/09/about-one-in-five-americans-use-a-smart-watch-or-fitness-tracker/

Williams, S., Booton, T., Watson, M., Rowland, D., & Altini, M. (2017). Heart Rate Variability is a Moderating Factor in the Workload-Injury Relationship of Competitive CrossFit Athletes. Journal of Sports Science & Medicine, 16(4): 443–448. https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5721172/

Xie, J., Wen, D., Liang, L., Jia, Y., Gao, L., & Lei, J. (2018). Evaluating the Validity of Current Mainstream Wearable Devices in Fitness Tracking Under Various Physical Activities: Comparative Study. JMIR mHealth and uHealth, 6(4): e94. https://doi.org/10.2196/mhealth.9754

Young, H. A., & Benton, D. (2018). Heart-rate variability: a biomarker to study the influence of nutrition on physiological and psychological health? Behavioural Pharmacology, 29:9(2): 140–151. https://doi.org/10.1097/fbp.0000000000000383

Zafar, H., Albarrati, A., Alghadir, A. H., & Iqbal, Z. A. (2018). Effect of Different Head-Neck Postures on the Respiratory Function in Healthy Males. BioMed Research International, 2018(5): 1–4. https://doi.org/10.1155/2018/4518269

Chapter 8: Selling Virtual Coaching

Chapter 8: Selling Virtual Coaching

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingChapter 8: Selling Virtual CoachingIt may seem counterintuitive, but many companies lose sales because they try to provide solutions for everyone instead of focusing on a smaller, yet profitable market. Understanding individual expertise and personal goals will help fitness professionals develop a niche, unique selling proposition, and pricing model to differentiate from the competition and drive sales.

Learning ObjectivesAfter completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

Identify customer problems to develop sales strategy.

Summarize how to develop and customize sales goals.

Describe the sales process.

Summarize the customer journey process.

Create a prospecting strategy.

Introduction

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingIntroductionWithout sales, any business will cease to exist. A fitness professional who owns their own business must give careful thought and consideration to the best methods to sell virtual coaching. Sales can be intimidating and can even sometimes have a negative connotation, but it does not have to be this way. Many new business owners assume that sales will come naturally; however, this is rarely the case. Much like helping clients achieve goals, sales require training, systems, processes, and consistent practice to yield results for the business. Sales are an outcome of a repeatable and scalable process. Without a well-developed sales process, sales will likely never come. A virtual fitness professional must develop scalable, teachable, and repeatable processes to help their businesses grow to become a successful entrepreneur (Figure: Fitness Professional Entrepreneur).

FigureFitness Professional EntrepreneurWhen starting a traditional or virtual business, the fitness professional is typically not only a business owner but also a business operator, spending their hours and efforts working both in the business and working on the business. However, being a business owner-operator should not be the end goal, as this model is likely not sustainable. The end goal of the business-owning fitness professional should be to become a true entrepreneur. An entrepreneur does not simply own or operate a business, they run a business. The entrepreneur works diligently to create clear and efficient business and sales processes. They utilize and leverage automation so they can focus on other aspects of their business. They value positive and negative feedback. Entrepreneurs strive for not only improving their business but improving themselves.

This chapter will provide the fitness business entrepreneur with tools necessary to build a successful sales program that will be repeatable, largely automated, and will scale with their business as it grows. When applicable, each section will contain a writing prompt with at least three questions to help the entrepreneur develop a reliable sales strategy for their business.

Coach's CornerPlease note: At the end of each section there are three or more writing prompts to help the fitness professional develop their own well-thought-out and detailed sales plan. The sales plan prompts should be completed after reading the entire chapter, as many of these questions and ideas work off each other. To develop a complete picture of what the fitness professional's sales plan will look like, it is important to understand all of the concepts presented in this chapter first.

Business ownerAn individual or group who owns a business entity and has final decision-making authority as well as first right to profits.

Business operatorThe individual running the day-to-day operations of a business.

Defining Sales

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingDefining SalesPurchasing is a solution to a problem. When consumers have an issue or unmet need, they typically purchase a product or service they feel will solve that specific problem or meet that specific need. As soon as the transaction is complete, the company this product or service was purchased from has made a sale. Selling a product or service is problem solving. Consequently, sales are the process of truthfully and successfully conveying that a company's product or service offering truly solves the consumer's problem.

Fitness business entrepreneurs take on many different duties, especially when starting and growing their business. One of the most important tasks a virtual fitness business entrepreneur will have is that of a salesperson. As previously mentioned, without sales, a company will cease to exist. Many business owners, and people in general, have an aversion to sales. Salespeople are sometimes viewed as manipulative and willing to do whatever it takes to make a sale—even at the customer's expense. The stereotypical salesperson shows little regard for the interest of the customer and cares more about getting money in their pocket. In contrast, the fitness business entrepreneur is not a stereotypical salesperson and will not be viewed as such, provided they have a long-term mindset about their business and emphasize putting their customers' interests first. Fitness business entrepreneurs generally are passionate about the product or service they offer and believe it will make a significant impact on their client's life. By putting ethics and clients' interests first, there is no need to worry about coming across as a manipulative or unethical salesperson. While it probably does not need to be stated, manipulation and poor ethics do not produce results in the long run.

As many retail and financial transactions now take place via e-commerce web and mobile applications, prospective clients will also likely expect a virtual coaching business to conduct its sales online. Leveraging the familiarity that potential clients already have with e-commerce, automated sales processes can be developed by the fitness professional that will turn their business into a smooth-running sales machine.

Inbound and Outbound SalesSales can be divided into two categories: inbound sales and outbound sales. Outbound sales are sales initiated by the business—in other words, the business contacted the client first to attempt a sale. Outbound sales are associated with techniques such as cold calling, where the business contacts prospective clients unsolicited.

Antonov Maxim/Shutterstock.comConversely, inbound sales are sales initiated by the client—in other words, the client contacted the business looking to purchase a particular product or service.

The virtual fitness professional's customer acquisition strategy should be built around an inbound sales approach. Inbound prospective clients include those who have found the business via content-driven platforms like social media channels, blogs, videos, podcasts, etc. Inbound strategies are centered on establishing trust and building rapport with prospective customers. Successful inbound methods help establish the brand as a trusted advisor through high-quality content. By earning prospective clients' trust and interest they will be more receptive to sales tools the fitness professional entrepreneur will utilize to generate business, such as automated e-mail marketing. With that in mind, this chapter will focus primarily on inbound sales processes.

ConsumerIndividuals in the target audience who are not yet aware of the business or its products and services.

Outbound salesSales that are initiated by the business; the business contacted the consumer first.

Inbound salesSales that are initiated by the consumer; the consumer contacted the business first.

Why People Make Purchases

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingWhy People Make PurchasesConsumers purchase products or services to solve a problem. When clients and potential clients are not satisfied with their current health and fitness or are not attaining their desired fitness and health goals, they typically seek out goods and services to help fulfill that desire. For the virtual fitness professional, most of their clients will have similar goals, including weight loss, building muscle, obtaining better overall health, improving performance, etc. The fitness professional's mission is to identify the problems their clients are facing, inform the client how their programs and services can help solve their problem, and ethically guide the future client in their purchase of the business's services (Figure: Fitness Professional's Mission).

FigureFitness Professional's MissionIdentify the ProblemUtilizing the target market identified in their business plan, the fitness professional has a well-defined market audience. Correctly identifying the specific problems clients are seeking to solve is key to developing a successful sales funnel. Note that a client's problem or problems may change over time. It is always important to obtain feedback on how the goods and services are meeting the needs of the target market, not only from clients but also from potential clients who do not currently purchase the service.

When starting a business, the fitness professional does not always have enough, or any, feedback from their potential market. To solve this, the fitness professional must conduct market research to understand the most common challenges prospective clients are facing. At this stage, the fitness professional may not have clients or even potential clients whom they can contact for useful feedback, but they can still develop an idea based on their own knowledge and experience about what problems and challenges the market needs to solve and overcome. The focus of the initial sales strategy should be the problems that currently exist in the market that inspired the fitness professional to develop their own virtual fitness business.

Sales Strategy Questions for Identifying the ProblemA useful exercise is to ask a series of questions to progressively narrow down the focus and help identify the primary problem future programs and services will solve.

What are three problems that everyone, not just the target customer, faces that makes them seek out the expertise and guidance of a fitness professional?

What are two problems (same as above or otherwise) that virtual coaching solves for clients compared to traditional in-person training?

What is one problem that is unique to your target market that you feel you can solve better than anyone else?

Sales funnelAn organized, repeatable process that a prospective customer follows to become a paid customer.

Solve the Problem

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingSolve the ProblemWith the problem identified, and the fitness professional already having established that they can solve the problem with their service, the next step is to understand how to successfully communicate the problem and solution to a potential client. Advertising and marketing are the keys to conveying this message.

HstrongART/Shutterstock.comMarketing and sales are closely related, and advertisements are an integral part of sales. Advertisements typically convey solutions to identified problems. Consider television ads for soft drinks. They largely focus on people relaxing, quenching their thirst, and cooling off with an ice-cold drink. The problem is thirst and the solution is the soft drink. If an ad for a soft drink stated, "You're going to be thirsty sometime, and when you are, buy our drink," the advertisement would not have much impact. However, if the advertisement clearly demonstrates how the product can fix a problem, the impact is much greater. When attempting to convey that a product solves a problem, the fitness professional should be mindful to not only highlight the obvious solution but also focus on the reasons why the problem exists in the first place.

Sales Strategy Questions for Solving the Problem

What are three reasons, or subproblems, why your target market's problem exists?

What is a solution for each of the three subproblems identified?

Construct a paragraph of sales copy that conveys the overall problem, subproblems, and solution.

Sales copyWriting with the specific goal of guiding a consumer through a sale.

Emotional Factors in Purchasing

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingEmotional Factors in PurchasingConsumers buy products and services for a variety of reasons. The Consumer Emotional Intelligence Scale (Kidwell et al., 2008) was designed to investigate the role that emotional factors play in consumer's purchasing decisions. The three emotional factors examined include self-concept connection, emotional attachment, and brand love. This study found focusing on emotional connections with consumers, rather than traditional features and benefits, resulted in greater brand loyalty. For the fitness entrepreneur, this should be the main focus of the sales strategy. When attempting to build an emotional connection with customers, authenticity is essential, with 81% of consumers stating they must be able to trust a brand (Edelman, 2019).

With a solid understanding of the problems their programs and services solve, the virtual fitness professional can put themselves in their clients' and prospective clients' shoes and imagine the emotions that they may feel about the problems they are experiencing. Selling based on emotions is not an attempt to take advantage of the negative emotions people feel due to a certain problem but to highlight the positive emotions a person will feel when they realize the fitness entrepreneur's product solves the problem.

Sales Plan Questions for Emotional Factors in Purchasing

What is one negative emotion a consumer feels for each of the subproblems identified in the previous section?

What are two possible positive emotions for each subproblem once solved?

How does the client feel prior to utilizing the service? What positive emotions will be revealed once the services are delivered? (Write a detailed paragraph.)

Prices and Packages

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingPrices and PackagesWhen pricing a core product, a fitness professional must ensure their pricing aligns with the target market being served. A very low-priced service being offered to high-income earners will have a difficult time finding clients who value the service. A service whose target market is seniors on a fixed income may not find clients if the service is priced too high. The pricing level of a product should not be confused with the quality or value of a product. A product can be economically priced but of high quality and value, and conversely, a luxury priced product can be of very poor quality and not offer much value.

Pricing StrategiesThe business plan should define the target market and provide a pricing analysis of competitors in the market. The virtual fitness professional should set the base price of the service in the range of market analysis. Once the base price of a product is set, the fitness professional can then use different pricing strategies to aid in the sales process. The four pricing strategies discussed in Chapter 2: Building a Business include economy, skimming, penetration, and premium pricing. Additionally, the fitness professional may also consider using promotional pricing and bundle pricing strategies (Figure: Pricing Strategies).

Penetration pricing is used to build interest in a new product. With this method, the standard price of the product is initially reduced as an introductory offering. However, this pricing strategy may result in a price so low the business cannot sustain selling at this rate for long periods of time. When penetration pricing is used, a clear objective, or cut-off, must be noted. Penetration pricing objectives may include initially obtaining a specific number of clients, converting those clients to higher-priced programs or services, increasing client referrals, or having a specific and publicly announced end date for the promotion.

FigurePricing StrategiesVectorpocket/Shutterstock.comPromotional pricing is similar to penetration pricing but with a few distinct differences. First, promotional pricing is offered to an existing product or service. Second, the discount should not be as low as a penetration pricing discount. With an existing and established product, offering a very large discount runs the risk of upsetting existing customers, along with devaluing the services that are provided. If a product or service is regularly on sale, most customers will wait until promotional pricing is offered again, rather than purchase at the standard price.

Bundle pricing is a strategy that offers discounts for buying in bulk. This can either be buying one product in bulk or purchasing multiple products together for a discounted price. For example, different bundle discounts could be offered on monthly coaching if a client pre-pays for 3, 6, or 12 months of coaching when compared to paying monthly. A bundle discount for clients who purchase multiple products would cover clients who purchased fitness training and nutrition coaching together instead of purchasing fitness training or nutrition coaching alone.

Training Packages

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and PackagingTraining PackagesThe fitness professional does not need to have a one-size-fits-all approach to their packages. While a price point for the business is set in the business plan (economy, midgrade, or luxury), programs and services offered can still fall within a range of those price points. Providing different options to target the different needs of clients will allow a business to offer more personalized solutions to clients' specific needs and desires.

For each product developed, the entrepreneur can easily create and establish three price levels for that program or service, with each price level offering more or fewer features.

Online Fitness Coaching PackagesLevel/Cost Per Month

Monthly Training Program

Bi-Weekly E-Mail Check-Ins With Coach

Weekly E-Mail Check-Ins With Coach

Monthly 30-Minute Video Check-In

Good / $149

X

X

Better / $199

X

X

Best / $250

X

X

X

The example provided in Table: Online Fitness Coaching Packages illustrates that simply changing from a coaching check-in every other week to every week, results in a $50 a month upgrade, or a 20% increase in price. On the other hand, eliminating monthly video check-ins results in a 25% decrease in price. These options allow the consumer the freedom to pick a package that best fits their needs. It also allows for additional future upgrades for clients and may aid in increasing client retention by offering a lower-priced option that clients can downgrade to.

Sales Goals

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationSales GoalsAs with most areas in life, goals are critical to creating a strong sales strategy. There are many different methods to set and track sales goals. This section will examine three different approaches to setting and tracking sales goals and provide reasonable recommendations for ensuring that goals are attainable and achieved. These approaches are defining sales goals, tracking sales, and prospecting clients.

Defining Sales GoalsOverall, a sales goal is an established revenue target or objective generated by program and service sales. Sales goals can be broken down into a virtually infinite number of subcategories to fit any business structure. However, the two most basic subcategories for defining sales goals are timeframe and sales stage. Sales goals can be broken down and tracked in three simple timeframes, including daily, weekly, and monthly.

FigureSales GoalsThree basic sales stages to be tracked include new prospects, leads, and customers (Figure: Sales Goals). These goals represent the three different stages a customer enters during the sales cycle and will be expanded on later in this chapter. Using the timeline and sales stage method, the fitness professional now has three simple goals to track (Table: Sales Goals Tracking).

Sales Goals TrackingSales Goals

Daily

Weekly

Monthly

Prospects

Leads

Customers

ProspectA person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

LeadsProspects who have shown interest in a company and have provided identifying information, such as an email address.

CustomersLeads who have purchased a product or service from a company; may also be used interchangeably with the term clients.

Content

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationSales goals should be adjusted, at a minimum, on a quarterly basis to ensure the target numbers are not only realistic but are bringing in enough new clients to fulfill the fitness professional's vision for the business and financial need. The fitness professional can define the goals and timeframes that work best for their business; however, in this chapter, the above sales goals will be referenced and utilized for working examples.

DGLimages/Shutterstock.comThe sales goal tracking process can also be used for existing clients. For example, a fitness professional may create a goal to contact new clients after 30 days to see if they are interested in upgrading their virtual coaching package from training only to both nutrition and training. While these are existing clients in their respective categories of virtual coaching, they are leads for upgrading to a higher-priced service. It is always easier to sell to an existing

client than it is to sell to a new client. Existing clients are already familiar with the business and less time and effort is needed to build trust and establish rapport compared to a potential customer.

Table: Sample Virtual Fitness Sales Goals illustrates how a simple sales goal process can potentially generate large amounts of consistent, predictable revenue for a business.

Sample Virtual Fitness Sales GoalsSales Goals

Daily

Weekly

Monthly

Prospects

200

1,400

5,600

Leads

10

70

280

Customers

.4

3.4

14

Before the fitness professional has historical data to use for creating sales goals, all projections are educated guesses. For this example, it is assumed that 200 people per day will become prospects of the business. These prospects come from viewing the business's website, blogs, social media posts, etc. The example assumes that 5% of these prospects will turn into leads. The conversion from prospects to leads will change over time as leads do not go away after only 1 week. For example, in e-mail marketing, a lead may stay on a company's mailing list for months or years before becoming a customer. From these leads, the assumption is made that 5% will convert to paid customers every month. Again, this number will change over time. It is the fitness professional's job to gradually improve the percentages of prospects, leads, and customer conversions. Incremental improvements add up over time.

This example used simple numbers and educated guesses for conversion rates. Sales and conversion goals must be updated regularly to align with financial need and provide the entrepreneur with the most realistic targets possible.

Tracking Sales

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationTracking SalesWith sales goals established, the fitness professional must continually track their sales data to ensure realistic goals have been set. Using the metrics of daily, weekly, and monthly prospects, leads, and customers, the fitness entrepreneur has a powerful dataset for tracking sales and revenue. Each metric will have unique data points and places to source this data. To obtain sales data, the source of each metric being tracked must be clearly defined.

Each business should have personalized definitions of prospects, leads, and customers, but, in general, they will be similar to the following parameters for tracking. Prospects include unique views on the company website, comments on social media, podcast downloads, and video views. Prospects should be tracked daily. Leads include inbound e-mails and contact form submissions from the company website, direct messages on social media, inbound phone calls, downloading free ebooks in exchange for the lead's email address, and receiving any contact information from other means. Lead data will be tracked daily but recorded in the sales tracker weekly. Customers include anyone who has made their first purchase from the company or a client who returns after previously ending their services. For sales goals tracking, this number generally does not include those on recurring subscriptions. Customer data will be tracked daily but only recorded in the sales goal tracker monthly.

Eviart/Shutterstock.comEach sales stage category should be updated weekly with the previous week's data. This allows the fitness entrepreneur to track and stay on top of sales metrics and identify if they start to trend down, stay consistent, or trend upward. While nothing may need to be modified, it allows for visibility and tracking of revenue goals, and the fitness professional can determine how they may average out over time.

Helpful HintJust as declining sales are something the entrepreneur should be on alert for, explosive sales are also something to be aware of. Growth is vital for a business, but explosive growth is not sustainable for most small businesses and can have several negative consequences.

Content

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationTracking sales numbers should not be an overly complicated process and should not take more than a few minutes each day. The fitness professional may consider using the first 15 minutes of each day to record the previous day's numbers. A simple spreadsheet is all that is needed to accurately track sales goals. Table: Example Virtual Sales Tracking Sheet illustrates this process.

Example Virtual Sales Tracking SheetDay

Prospects

Leads

New Customers

1

1184

12

1

2

988

69

1

3

1132

91

6

4

1074

32

2

5

925

74

2

6

1231

12

0

7

1129

56

2

8

1080

22

2

9

800

48

4

10

1111
67
1
11
855
86
1
12
1164
93
8
13
919
28
1
14
942
75
2
15
814
8
1
16
937
84
3
17
1045
63
3
18
1086
109
4
19
995
100
4
20
966
58
5
21

856

9

0

22

924

37

3

23

1166

117

1

24

1151

104

4

25

1287

116

8

26

1221

37

3

27

1157

104

10

28

908

73

2

29

809

16

0

30

878

44

4

TOTALS

30734

1841

88

Averages

1024

61

3

Once data is gathered, it can be used to compare actual metric to projections. Using the data from the example provided, the business is surpassing the sales goals established in the previous section. This data can be used to readjust goals on a quarterly basis to ensure that trends are continuing in the right direction and that sales goals are realistic and achievable.

Prospecting for New Clients

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationProspecting for New Clients Prospecting is the act of searching for new clients. Prospects turn into leads and leads turn into clients. Finding prospects can often be a challenging and intimidating aspect of sales for small business owners, typically with outbound sales or outbound prospecting. The method of cold-calling prospects from a purchased sales list, such as telemarketing, is typically no longer used. There are many ways to find prospects for leads and, ultimately, new clients. This section will focus on how to utilize the business's target audience, as defined in the business plan, and marketing plan to automate the prospecting process.

FigureCommon Sales TypesThere are two types of sales: business to consumer sales (B2C) and business to business sales (B2B) (Figure: Common Sales Types). Fitness professionals who target the B2B market might be focused on services such as corporate wellness programs. In B2B marketing, the target customer is a business. Most virtual fitness professional's sales will fall into the B2C category, in which the target customer is an individual consumer. This section will focus primarily on the B2C category.

Prospecting, just like sales and marketing, can be broken down into inbound prospecting and outbound prospecting. Inbound prospecting builds on the marketing processes developed and will allow the prospecting process to become largely automated. An inbound prospect finds the company's content through various channels and content types defined in the marketing plan. These channels and content can include social media, search engines, pay-per-click (PPC) advertising, email marketing, videos, infographics, newsletters, etc. The goal is to convert the prospect who viewed or consumed the marketing content into a lead, and that lead in turn will provide the business with their contact information. This process will be discussed in greater detail later in this chapter. Outbound prospecting is when the target customer audience is first identified by the business and then, the business reaches out to the target customer and initiates contact. Outbound prospecting is an effective prospecting technique, but it is time-consuming and limits the ability to automate the prospecting process.

Prospecting must be continually performed, as businesses generally always need new customers. Prospecting can be developed and simplified into a repeatable and scalable process by focusing on three areas (Figure: Prospecting Process). First, clearly define the target market. Second, identify a clear prospecting strategy of how and where prospects will be found. Finally, establish a clear new prospecting strategy to ensure new prospects continue to become aware of the company.

FigureProspecting ProcessProspectingIdentifying potential customers.

Business to consumer sales (B2C)Sales from a business directly to a person.

Business to business sales (B2B)Sales from a business directly to another business.

Inbound prospectingThe process of a consumer discovering a business from passive content released by the business.

Outbound prospectingThe process of a business contacting a consumer via direct marketing.

Define Target Market

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationDefine Target MarketThe first step in automating the prospecting process is to ensure the target market, or target audience, is well-defined. This should be clearly outlined in the business plan, as the target market is used for many different areas of the business, including but not limited to sales and marketing. When defining or refining the target market for use in sales prospecting, the virtual fitness professional should ask three questions. Please note: This is not an all-inclusive list of questions, but it is a great starting point.

Sentavio/Shutterstock.comSales Strategy Questions for Define Target Market

What is the ideal client's goal?

How old is the ideal client?

How long is the average client enrolled in coaching?

Building on these three questions, the fitness professional can then focus their prospecting efforts on a narrower demographic.

Prospecting Strategy

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationProspecting StrategyThe second step in automating the prospecting process is developing a strategy for how the business will find new prospects. An example outbound prospecting strategy would be to purchase a list of consumers who fit the target audience and then, either call or e-mail them. This is a time consuming and expensive process, which typically yields poor results.

Utilizing an inbound prospecting approach, the virtual fitness entrepreneur can take advantage of the marketing plan and capitalize on existing content to attract prospective clients. For example, utilizing blog posts that have followed a strategic search engine optimization (SEO) approach, as defined by the marketing strategy, will bring in consumers who are in the business's target audience directly to the company's website. These prospects are very high quality because they

qualified themselves into the target audience by searching for a question the business can, and already has, answered in their blog post content.

Sales Strategy Questions for Prospecting StrategyThe fitness professional can define how the business will obtain new prospects by answering three questions.

Based on the marketing strategy, what are the top three content types that will be utilized by the business to attract prospects (videos, infographics, blogs, podcasts, etc.)?

For each of the content marketing types identified, what incentive will be created and offered for the consumer to share their contact information with the business and become a lead?

For each incentive, how will the fitness business entrepreneur follow up with the newly created lead? How can this process be automated?

Coach's CornerThe prospecting strategy must focus on refining the content marketing strategy to ensure content developed is directed toward the target audience.

For example, if a fitness professional's target audience is older adults, they may write blog posts about protein intake for seniors. The prospecting strategy should ensure that the blog is optimized for commonly used terms the prospects will type into a search engine.

If the business is utilizing videos in their marketing, the prospecting strategy should ensure the videos offer an incentive for prospects to provide their contact information and become leads.

A well-rounded business needs to have prospects and, consequently, sales coming from more than one place. Having multiple sales pipelines will ensure the business has enough diversity and a strong foundation of prospects that can withstand market changes over time.

New Prospects Strategy

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationNew Prospects StrategyThe third step in developing and automating the prospecting process is reading a new prospecting strategy. This ensures there is a constant flow of new prospects into the sales pipeline. While content creation is an integral part of the marketing strategy, it is equally, if not more important, for the prospecting strategy. To ensure a steady stream of prospects, content must be created on a regular and consistent basis and focus on topics the target audience is actively seeking knowledge on. For example, a blog post that covers how to design home workouts may appeal perfectly to the target audience. However, if the blog content is three years old and does not consider the latest home fitness equipment, the previous impact the blog may have had is lost and fewer leads will be generated from the outdated content. On the other hand, publishing and promoting monthly blog posts reviewing the latest home exercise equipment will produce new and different prospects regularly.

Pixel-Shot/Shutterstock.comSales Plan Questions for New Prospects Strategy

Referring to the three types of content marketing identified previously, how often will content be created for each type of content?

How often will incentives offered to the prospect be updated?

How can prospects, leads, and clients be incentivized to bring new prospects into the business? (List at least one idea for each.)

Now that the entrepreneur has a well-defined prospecting strategy, they can start building a repeatable and scalable process that can be automated using e-mail marketing and content creation and building a referral network from potential, existing, and former clients.

Getting TechnicalMarketing automation is essential to a growing business. Consider searching for and reviewing articles for additional information about various marketing automation tools on the market.

23 Marketing Automation Tools You Need to Use (Patel, 2020)

The Best Email Marketing Software for 2020 (McLaughlin & Sevilla, 2020)

Customizing the Sales Process

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationCustomizing the Sales Process With an automated prospecting process, the fitness professional can provide a highly customized sales process designed to appeal to different subsets of their target market. The process of subdividing target markets is called market segmentation. Segmenting a marketing or sales list will allow the fitness professional to deliver highly customized and personalized sales messaging directly to leads.

Email list segmentation can be implemented starting at the prospect level. Specific marketing content can be created for different segments of the target audience. For example, a blog post about resistance training for busy mothers will attract a different segment of the same target audience when compared to a blog post about endurance training for busy mothers. The target audience is the same, but the segments, those interested in resistance training versus those interested in endurance training, are different.

Segmenting the target audience can be automated for the sales process when the prospect becomes a lead by providing their email address in exchange for an offer. The lead is then segmented into an appropriate email marketing list that contains the same basic information as other email workflows but will have more personalized sales copy that conveys an understanding and solution to the segment's problems.

Red Deer/Shutterstock.com

Educating Prospective Clients

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 2Sales Goals and Process CustomizationEducating Prospective ClientsThe purpose of the marketing strategy is to educate prospective clients about the existence of the company and its programs and services. The sales process continues educating leads about the solutions the fitness professional provides to the problems they are facing. This education should be customized to a lead's segment as much as possible. Every lead will prefer to be educated on the aspects of the programs or services that directly apply to their individual needs. Two education techniques include offering a unique selling proposition and value proposition.

Offering a Unique Selling PropositionA unique selling proposition (USP) is a specific benefit a product or service provides the target market that separates a business from its competitors. It is important to highlight the true uniqueness of the programs and services offered. Mentioning features of a business or its services is simply not enough. There was a time when responding to an e-mail within 24 hours or offering text messaging to a client was unique and rare. However, at a time when more online coaching businesses are appearing, these features have now become the standard. The fitness business entrepreneur needs a USP that only they are able to bring to their clients. While the USP can be the same for different lead segments, it should be positioned differently to address the unique concerns of a particular segment.

Providing ValueThe value proposition is simply the value of the programs and services that are offered. This can describe the price of the service, service quality, and value trade-off, which is the lead saving money by choosing the service offered instead of spending more money on another option. Value propositions should educate leads on the value of the programs or services and be utilized to support the USP.

Customer Onboarding Process

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessCustomer Onboarding Process Developing a systematic process around the customer sales cycle or sales strategy allows for tracking, refinement, directional pivots, reproducibility/scale, and efficiency in client acquisition. Prior to becoming paid clients, consumers will enter different stages based on where they are in the sales process. As mentioned previously, these sales stages are prospects, leads, and clients.

Prospects are potential customers who are just finding out about the service. This could be by reading a blog, watching a video, or simply browsing the fitness professional's website. Prospects are starting to show interest in the business's services; however, they have shown no interest beyond that.

Leads are prospects who have shown a greater-than-normal interest in the business's product or service. Typically, a lead has reached out to the fitness professional in some form and has provided some type of personal information to initiate interaction and conversation. This contact information can come from filling out a form on the fitness professional's website, entering an e-mail address in exchange for a free ebook, or interacting with the fitness professional on social media.

Customers or clients are leads who have become paid customers of the business. Once a person becomes a client, they do not simply stay at this stage. Existing clients can also re-enter a sales funnel and become a lead for service or product upgrades and add-ons. Clients need to be nurtured as much, if not more, than prospects and leads to ensure their retention.

Please note: Both prospects and leads can become clients—they do not have to follow the specific order or progression outlined to become a client. The prospect, lead, and customer path is simply the most common progression from consumer to paid customer.

ProspectA person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

LeadsProspects who have shown interest in a company and have provided identifying information, such as an email address.

CustomersLeads who have purchased a product or service from a company; may also be used interchangeably with the term clients.

Customer Journey

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessCustomer Journey The fitness business entrepreneur should develop an understanding of what their client's customer journey will be as they progress from prospect to client. This journey or process can also be referred to as the sales funnel. Mapping the customer journey will allow the fitness professional to develop a repeatable process that can be modified based on real-world results and feedback. The customer journey will tie in closely with marketing efforts. The sales aspect of the customer journey will essentially be an expanded and more detailed outline derived from the fitness professional's marketing strategy.

An important aspect of the customer journey process is dividing potential customers into different subcategories. Separating prospects into groups based on certain predetermined characteristics is called market segmentation. Market segmentation allows the fitness professional to build more effective sales strategies based on consumer characteristics and where a prospect is in their customer journey. A potential client who visits one blog on a company's website needs a different marketing strategy than a potential client who follows a call to action and provides their e-mail address in exchange for a free ebook.

Using a fictitious company, here is an example of a possible customer journey map (Figure: Customer Journey Map):

FigureCustomer Journey Map

A consumer reads a blog article the fitness professional posted and becomes a prospect.

How the prospect found the blog article is detailed in the marketing strategy and may include paid search engine advertising, social media sharing, and organic search results.

Other content examples that may be used to drive prospect engagement include blogs, videos, infographics, social media posts, and podcasts.

The prospect provides their contact information to the business and is turned into a lead.

The incentive for the prospect to provide this information is a detail from the marketing strategy by following a call to action.

Content that can be used to turn a prospect into a lead include free digital content offers (training template, webinars, ebooks, etc.), filling out a contact form, or interacting with the business on social media.

The lead is nurtured and turned into a client.

Lead nurturing is a tie-in between marketing and sales. Details about how leads will be nurtured are provided from the marketing strategy. No matter the lead nurturing strategy, the sales goal is the same.

Examples of lead nurturing include automated e-mail marketing campaigns, phone calls, and text messaging.

Customer journey processThe guided path, designed by the business, that a consumer will follow to turn into a customer.

Market segmentationDividing prospects and leads to more well-defined categories.

Call to actionA prompt from a business for a consumer to take an action.

Sales Plan Questions for Customer Journey Process

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessWhile this is a basic example of the journey from prospect to client, not all prospects will become leads and not all leads will become clients. If a prospect does not provide a business with contact information, that does not automatically mean they cannot become a lead at some point in the future. A lead can be subdivided into two categories: warm and hot lead. A warm lead does not provide the business with contact information. However, the business can use paid advertising to initiate a retargeting campaign and subsequent sales funnel.

A hot lead is a client who has provided the business with their contact information in exchange for an offer from the company, as mentioned in previous examples. When a hot lead drops off and stops responding, they can be placed into yet another sales funnel that perhaps offers a discount on the program or service or even a free trial to further incentivize the lead into accepting a call to action. In this situation, the additional offer helps to continue building trust and rapport with the lead.

Sales Plan Questions for Customer Journey Process

What are three types of content that can be used to attract prospects? How can the content be created and managed?

What are two types of free, high-quality content that can be used to turn prospects into leads? What offer will be presented to the prospect in exchange for their contact information.

What are two methods in which leads will be nurtured into clients? What is your lead nurturing process?

Warm leadA lead that is interested but has not provided the business with contact information.

Retargeting campaignA marketing campaign that targets specific segments of prospects or leads that have not yet become customers.

Hot leadA lead that is interested and has provided the business with contact information.

From Client to Brand Champion

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessFrom Client to Brand ChampionFor many businesses, once a prospect becomes a client, the sales process is over. The customer journey process has achieved its goal and the business has a new client. However, for the fitness professional entrepreneur, the process has only just begun. Because it is easier and more cost-effective to sell to existing customers compared to acquiring new customers, the fitness professional should focus on maximizing a customer's lifetime value (CLV). This can be done through delivering exceptional service, product add-ons, and upgrades. Upgrading a client who enrolled in online fitness training to online training plus nutrition coaching will result in a more profitable customer while also providing the customer with more tools to achieve their goals and overall success.

Food for ThoughtImagine that a client pays $200 per month for virtual fitness coaching. Assuming that the client has an average membership length of 4 months, the lifetime value of this client is $800. If this client upgrades to a package that includes virtual fitness and nutrition coaching at $250 per month, after their first month, the client has a lifetime value of $950. This is a 16% increase in revenue from the client’s original lifetime value. Over the course of a year, if 100 clients purchase the same upgrade, this would result in an extra $15,000 in revenue for the business.

Upgrading an existing client's services is yet another customer journey process. The previous customer journey examined turning a prospect into a client; however, turning an existing client into a brand champion client requires a different process. A champion is a client who has a higher than average CLV. The brand champion client is a champion of your business and your brand. They are a long-term client who purchases service upgrades and raves about the business to everyone they know. Not every client will become a brand champion, but the virtual fitness entrepreneur must have processes in place to be able to take clients to the champion level.

Customer lifetime value (CLV)The amount that a customer will spend with business over a lifetime.

Content

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessA referral program can be a great way to turn clients into champions. A referral program is a relatively easy sales process to automate. A referral program can be as simple as sending an automated e-mail to all clients every 30 days informing them that for every three clients they refer to the business, they will receive 1 month of virtual coaching free. This simple method can turn successful clients into salespeople for

the business. For example, if the business has 100 clients at an average CLV of $800 each, obtaining three referrals from just 5% of existing clients would potentially result in an $11,000 per year profit, simply by sending an e-mail.

The final customer journey that will be illustrated is that of the former client. Every business should target former clients. Former clients are already familiar with the business and can be considered a warm lead because they have already provided their contact information and paid for programs or services previously. Again, basic e-mail automation can simplify this process for the already busy virtual fitness professional. Re-engaging former clients can be as simple as sending them an e-mail every 60 days to check-in, see how they are doing, and offer a 10% discount if they return to virtual training or coaching. As an example, if just 5% of a list of 500 former clients re-enroll in coaching per year, assuming an average CLV of $800 ($200 per month x 4 months), the business will have increased its annual revenue by $20,000 simply by sending an e-mail.

elenabsl/Shutterstock.comThe customer journey is not just one process but many depending on where the customer, client, or former client are currently in their lifetime cycle with the fitness professional. The fitness professional entrepreneur who establishes processes that cover every aspect possible of a customer's journey has set up their business for steady growth and long-term success.

Sales Process

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessSales ProcessThe sales process is what happens after a prospect becomes a lead. The sales process is the journey that leads take to become paying clients. During the previous phase of prospecting for new clients, the consumer turned into a lead. At that point, the marketing process ended, and the sale process began.

The lead-to-client sales process is one that will illustrate to qualified leads that the fitness professional understands their needs, help build rapport, and show the potential client their concerns and desires are being heard. This allows the fitness professional to demonstrate their expertise in the area the lead is struggling with. This process is commonly referred to as lead nurturing. In an automated sales process, lead nurturing can easily be done via e-mail marketing.

With e-mail marketing automation, the fitness professional has the equivalent of highly personalized ads sent directly to their target audience who has already shown specific interest in their products or services. E-mail automation provides the fitness professional with an opportunity to perform market segmentation and provide highly personalized e-mails. E-mail automation should always be as segmented as possible to ensure the most personalized messaging possible is being delivered to the lead.

Eny Setiyowati/Shutterstock.comNot everyone on a fitness professional's e-mail marketing list is a lead. When someone is first added to an e-mail list, they are a lead. This means the marketing strategy used by the fitness professional worked and a prospect was turned into a lead. The prospect showed interest, accepted an offer, and opted-in to an e-mail list and became a lead. The lead is then placed into e-mail automation software and enters into a specific e-mail automation workflow for new leads. This workflow is designed to provide e-mails that will build rapport and increase trust with leads. This is typically done over several days or weeks. By the time the workflow is complete, one of three things will happen:

The lead becomes a client. The workflow was successful. Once the lead becomes a client, the new lead workflow ends immediately.

The lead unsubscribes from the workflow. This can happen for any number of reasons. Please note: If the unsubscribe rate is more than .3% on the initial e-mail, then the content of the e-mails in the workflow should be assessed/re-examined for relevancy. Any of the following can influence open and unsubscribe rates and should be examined: the subject line copy, e-mail body copy, frequency or quantity of e-mails, day and/or time sent, and content design reassessed.

The workflow ends and the lead does not become a client. The sales process did not work and the lead did not initiate a purchase.

In the outcome where the lead did not become a client, they are no longer a lead but are once again a prospect. They will still receive general marketing e-mails as part of the marketing strategy; however, they would no longer receive personalized lead nurturing e-mails. At this point, the prospect will need to be remarketed to until they are placed into another sales funnel or workflow.

Sales processThe journey of turning a lead into a client.

Lead nurturingThe process of educating, displaying empathy, understanding, and listening to a lead to turn the lead into a customer.

WorkflowA systematic and repeatable process.

Sales Process Example

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessSales Process ExampleImagine a prospect has entered the sales process after providing their e-mail address on the company's website in exchange for a free ebook. Instantly, the newly created lead receives this email in their inbox.

Email 1

Subject: No Frustration Home Workouts

Body:

Hi, Joe,

Many people think that working out at home requires expensive equipment, a lot of room, and time that they just don't have. You're about to find out that none of that is true. As requested, this email contains your free access to an at-home fitness guide that will show you how to design easy home workouts without expensive equipment in any sized space and in time increments that you can manage.

Download Self-Guided Home Workouts here.

Please reach out to me at any time with any questions that you have.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

P.S. I will send you an email tomorrow covering the most common questions that I receive about the ebook.

The email containing the ebook download was sent immediately to the new lead, helping build trust by delivering on the promise made. The email addresses the lead by name, reminds the lead about how the offer (ebook download) can help solve a problem, and then delivers the solution by providing the ebook. At the bottom of the email are the next steps, which indicate they will receive an email the following day that contains answers to some of the most common questions regarding the ebook topics.

This initial e-mail accomplishes the following goals:

Builds trust

Shows an understanding of the problem the client wants to solve

Provides a solution and evidence of expertise in the problem area (e-book)

Outlines expectations for next steps

Demonstrates a genuine interest in the lead with the follow-up Q & A email

Exactly 24 hours later, the next email is sent.

Email 2

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessEmail 2

Subject: Answers to Your Questions, as Promised

Body:

Hi, Joe,

"Working out is difficult and time consuming." This is the most common issue that I hear as a virtual fitness coach. Many people don't feel like they have the time or skill to work out effectively from home. However, the truth is that anyone can work out effectively from home and achieve the results they want. As I mentioned in yesterday's e-mail, here are the most common questions I receive:

Q: What if I'm not strong enough to do some of the exercises like a pushup?

A: Eventually, you will be. With consistency, patience, and practice, you'll be able to do a push-up in no time. Until you can, you can modify any exercise so that you're able to perform it (more on how to modify exercises shortly).

Q: How long should these home workouts take?

A: There is no set amount of time to work out. If you're able to work out for 45 minutes at once, perfect. If you're only able to work out in two 5-minute intervals per day, then that is perfect too.

Q: How long will it take for me to see results?

A: That will vary by person. However, there are ways to get noticeable results much faster than others. In fact, that's why I offer online fitness coaching with completely custom designed exercise and nutrition coaching to get you the results that you want and need. If you're interested in learning more about teaming up with me for online coaching, click this link to schedule a free 20-minute phone consultation.

If the ebook yesterday made you feel a little overwhelmed with designing your own home workout, that's fine! Here is an example of a home workout that I designed for a client. This workout lists the modifications for exercises in case you have some difficulty with them at first. Give this workout a try tomorrow and I will check-in in 2 days to see how it went.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

P.S. I'll also be sending you my free nutrition guide in the next email. So, make sure you keep an eye out for the email!

The second email was delivered exactly when promised, as indicated in the subject line. It begins with an objection that is broad, but one that people genuinely have about fitness training. The email then proceeds to present the lead with an additional offer to accept/opt-into a free workout to try at home. Finally, the email ends again with a clearly defined next step. The fitness professional will check-in two days after the lead completed the workout. The email also incentivizes the lead to open the follow-up email because there is another free guide coming, only this time focused on nutrition, as well as a surprise bonus.

Two days later, the lead receives the next email.

Email 3

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessEmail 3

Subject: How Did Everything Go?

Body:

Hi, Joe,

How was your workout?

If you thought the workouts were too hard, you can modify the example by performing 1/2 of the workout one day and the other half the next day. Over the next week, attempt to complete the entire workout in one session. Alternatively, you can still take me up on that offer for a free consultation by scheduling here.

If you felt the workouts were too easy or not challenging enough, you can perform the workout twice in one session and increase the number of rounds you complete per training session.

As promised, here is the free nutrition guide. Give it a read tonight (it's only 10 pages), perform the workout routine again, and I will check-in tomorrow.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The third email is again, delivered as promised. This email starts out with a question of concern, such as "How was your workout?" and immediately provides the two most common answers, easy or difficult, followed by a solution for each of those answers. The solution for those answers is the sales offer, which is located toward the beginning of the email. Finally, the next step is clearly laid out. The lead will hear from the fitness professional tomorrow after they have had an opportunity to read the nutrition guide as well as perform the bonus workout they just received.

The next day, the lead receives another email.

Email 4

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessEmail 4

Subject: You Have the Tools. Do You Need A Guide?

Body:

Joe,

Over the past few days, your fitness toolbox has grown. First, you received a book that showed you how to design your own personalized home workouts. Then, we covered the most common questions and went over an example workout that you performed. Finally, we covered the basics of nutrition yesterday with your free nutrition guide. (If you have questions on that, please reply to this email and let's cover them!) So, what's next?

If you're still slightly confused, nervous, or unsure, I'd like to offer you 20% off of my online fitness coaching. I only make this offer one time to all customers and only for 48 hours. Why, you ask? To help motivate you! Now is the time to make the changes you want to make. There is no reason to wait longer. If you're serious about change, I want to help you out as much as possible.

You can click here to view all of the options I offer and to enroll in coaching. When you're checking out, use the promo code JOE123 and you'll receive your 20% off.

Don't wait, Joe! Remember that this offer expires in 48 hours. I won't e-mail you until after the offer expires, so make sure you enroll now if you're interested.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The fourth email starts off by reminding the lead of what they have already received and then offers a 20% discount on their first month of coaching. Finally, there is a sales opportunity, which is reasonable and not forceful. There is a limited amount of time to accept the offer and an explanation of why the offer expiration exists. The final line of the email states they will not hear from the fitness professional again until the offer expires.

Twenty-four hours after the promotional offer expires, the lead receives the final email in the sales workflow.

Email 5

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessEmail 5

Subject: What Are Your Plans?

Body:

Joe,

It's been 3 days since I emailed you about enrolling in coaching and you haven't enrolled. Please tell me about your concerns or fears in enrolling. I understand that enrolling is a big step, but I'd love to help you make that step towards investing in your health. I'd like to make one final offer, and, after this, I promise I'll stop sending these almost daily emails to you.

If you're really interested in making a change in your life and achieving your goals, talk to me. Call me, text me, email me. My number is 312-867-5309. Contact me anytime. If I'm unable to answer, leave a voicemail and I'll call you back. I promise that I will get back to you as soon as possible. We're in this together and I'm on your team. There is no reason to go at it alone. Just send a simple text that says "Hi" and we'll start from there.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The final email begins by reminding the client that they missed the offer. They are then asked clearly what their concerns are for investing in coaching. This is followed by a call to action asking for their input which demonstrates the fitness professional is listening and wants to understand the lead's perspective.

After the final email in the workflow, if the lead has not become a client, they return to being categorized as a prospect.

Content

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessA quality e-mail automation software will provide significant analytics for the fitness business entrepreneur to analyze and use to improve each section of their e-mail communications, from subject lines, to copy, to images used, and the design of the e-mail (Zote, 2020).

Table: Common E-Mail Marketing Statistics outlines common e-mail marketing statistics across all industries (Mailchimp, n.d.).

Common Email Marketing StatisticsAverage Open Rate

Average Click Rate

Unsubscribe Rate

21.33%

2.62%

0.26%

Using these industry average stats as a starting point, the fitness professional can adjust each e-mail in their workflow to improve open, average click, and unsubscribe rates. Please note: It is normal for open rates to decline further into the workflow. The following example sales workflow contains five e-mails, provides the lead with ample opportunities to ask questions, and contains numerous trust- and rapport-building qualities.

FigureSample Email Sales Workflow

Sales Email Techniques

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessSales Email TechniquesThere are many ways to structure and draft sales e-mails. The following sections will provide additional recommendations for sales e-mails, including uncovering needs, building rapport, and listening. Each of these techniques will help the fitness professional establish themselves as a credible expert in the virtual coaching arena.

Uncovering NeedsEach client has different needs. When marketing to a wide range of people in an automated process, the need being addressed must be comprehensive. The best need for sales e-mails to address can be uncovered through surveys and feedback from those leads that end up turning into clients. Existing clients are invaluable sales tools. Initially, the fitness professional will be using their knowledge of the industry and target market to develop their sales e-mails. However, after a successful client leaves their virtual coaching program, the fitness professional entrepreneur can survey former clients about what they found the most helpful about coaching. This feedback can be used to build a more accurate list of common needs virtual coaching can fulfill for clients. These needs can then be addressed in sales e-mails to demonstrate that the fitness professional understands the lead's pain points.

To begin uncovering leads' needs, the fitness professional can ask the following questions:

What are the three most common goals training clients start with?

What challenges did the client face that lead them to desire those goals?

What is one way to demonstrate empathy for each of the challenges the client faced?

These questions can also be reworded and asked to former clients in an exit survey.

Building Rapport

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 3The Onboarding ProcessBuilding Rapport Building rapport with consumers is not an easy task. Consumers largely distrust marketing, and this puts the fitness professional in a more difficult position as they attempt to build a long and meaningful relationship with their clients. The fitness professional will need to be positioned not only as an authority in the eyes of the consumer but also be perceived as genuine and authentic. Being genuine, honest, and truthful in the marketing content will build rapport with the consumer before they even contact the fitness professional or business.

The rapport a business builds with a consumer begins the instant the consumer becomes aware of the business. This awareness can come from many sources, including advertising, blogs, social media posts, and even word of mouth. Prior to obtaining a client's e-mail address, a business must start to build a positive rapport with a prospect. This positive rapport can be established relatively easily by providing free, high-quality content used in marketing and then presenting an offer to the prospect in exchange for their e-mail address. Because of the rapport established during the marketing process, a prospect should have little objection to providing their contact information in exchange for higher-quality, higher-value content. The offer that is immediately presented to the newly created lead fulfills the promise made and further enhances positive rapport.

Throughout the entire sales email workflow, the fitness professional needs to demonstrate that they are an authority, genuine, and authentic throughout the sales email workflow. In addition, it should be obvious that they understand the issues the lead is facing and that the information being provided will start to solve those issues.

Sales Strategy Questions for Building Rapport

How will the business position themselves as an authority by the second sales e-mail?

How will authenticity be demonstrated and maintained throughout the sales process?

What is one example of how a genuine concern for the lead's issues will be demonstrated?

ListeningWith in-person training, the client and fitness professional have face-to-face interactions that allow for more opportunities to listen to a client's needs, desires, and concerns. This face-to-face interaction is largely lost with virtual training. Interaction through e-mail, texting, and, to a lesser-extent, video conferencing do not provide the same opportunities for conversation that exist with in-person training. However, a fitness professional can overcome this obstacle in marketing and sales e-mails by preemptively addressing common objections, asking specific questions of the leads, as well as asking leads to reach out with any questions of their own.

Sales Strategy Questions for Listening

What are three common objections to virtual coaching? What response could be given to those objections.

What are three creative ways that leads can be encouraged to ask questions about coaching?

What are the three most common questions leads and new clients ask?

Billing and Collecting Payment

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 4Billing and Collecting PaymentBilling and Collecting PaymentAs with almost all aspects of a business, an efficient billing and payment processing system must aim to simplify things for the customer. A fitness business entrepreneur should strive for automation and repeatable processes and avoid needless redundancy. Billing and payment processing systems can seem overwhelming to those with non-technical backgrounds, but there are many affordable and less-technical options available on the market. This section will cover several points to consider when selecting a billing and payment processing system.

Selecting a Merchant ProcessorCompanies that provide billing services to businesses are called merchant processors or payment processors. These processors provide the business with simple solutions for accepting credit card payments on their website. Prior to a processor accepting a new business, the business will need at least three key items: a business license, an employer identification number, and a business checking account (Figure: Procure Processor).

Items Needed to Procure a Merchant or Billing ProcessorFigureProcure Processor

Business license for the state in which the business was formed

Federal Employer Identification Number (EIN)

The EIN functions much like a social security number for a business. An EIN can be applied for at no cost on the IRS website.

Many companies offer to obtain an EIN number for a business for a fee, but this can easily be completed by the fitness professional.

Business checking account

The fitness professional must have a business checking account and not a consumer bank account in the business owner's name. Depending on the type of business formed, this can have different tax consequences.

Note that not all of these are related to sales, but they are important items that every business needs.

Merchant processorsBusinesses that process credit card payments for another business.

Key Things to Look for and Consider When Searching for a Payment Processor

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 4Billing and Collecting PaymentWhen comparing merchant processors, several different options should be evaluated. The one that provides features and services that best meet the needs of the fitness professional should be chosen. If the fitness professional is less technologically savvy, then a processor that offers simplicity when integrating with a website may be best. If the fitness professional requires advanced analytics, then they will need to ensure that they have a processor that offers integrations with various software applications and that exports sufficient types and quantities of data. Processors typically charge a small percentage of the sale that the business pays. These fees vary slightly depending on the processor or plan selected, but typically range from 2.6% to 3.2% + 30¢ per transaction.

Helpful HintUnless the business is generating millions of dollars in sales per year, price should not be a large consideration when looking for a processor. If a business performed $1 million in business over 5,000 transactions per year, the difference is $6,000 and may not be worth the time put into price shopping payment processors.

Key Things to Look for and Consider When Searching for a Payment Processor

Fees ranging from 2.6% to 3.2% + 30¢ per transaction

The ability to setup subscriptions and recurring client payments

Daily deposits of funds

Well-known and established company

Ease of access to customer service

Once the payment processor is properly set up, the fitness professional entrepreneur can focus on setting up an automated billing and payment system for clients.

E-Commerce SystemWith a virtual coaching business, the business's store is the company website. There is no physical location for a client to come into and ask questions. A business's website is not only its marketing home but is also the company's sales desk. A virtual coaching business needs to allow clients to purchase and immediately enroll in coaching, without face-to-face interaction with the fitness professional. A website that requires a potential client to wait for the fitness professional to contact them in order to enroll in coaching is increasing the steps and, subsequently, barriers to purchase. An e-commerce website should provide a clear path to virtual coaching, from basic information all the way to registration and payment.

Collecting Online PaymentsWith recurring payments, the business must collect payments monthly and on time. If payment is collected too early, a client's budget may not allow the payment to process. If payment is collected too late, a client may be receiving free coaching, even if they do not intend to continue. Having consistent, automated billing also allows for the fitness professional to have predictable and consistent revenue coming into the business. Allowing a client to enter their own billing information into a website and subscribe to coaching via an online e-commerce platform integrated with the business's merchant processor will allow payments and subscription fees to be automated. Sending out individual invoices to clients every month is time consuming and allows for potential errors in amounts billed and consistency in payments. Automated billing and payment processing take stress away from the fitness professional, allowing them to focus on more impactful activities such as content development, programming, and coaching.

Summary

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 4Billing and Collecting PaymentSummaryLike any small business owner, a fitness professional who owns a virtual coaching business has roles and responsibilities that extend beyond developing programs and coaching clients, such as marketing their services and generating sales. Sales are vital to a company's success. Without sales, there is no revenue and without revenue, there is no company. While focusing on sales is often viewed with a negative connotation, it does not have to be. Ethical sales strategies and techniques are rooted in educating and helping others. It, ultimately, comes down to identifying potential clients' needs, offering solutions to those needs, and then asking them to make a financial commitment for those solutions. The aspects of running a business that can be automated should be, as automation frees up time to focus on areas of the business that cannot be and are vital to establishing authority, credibility, and authenticity in the market, such as content development, programming, and coaching and serving clients.

Marketing and sales processes can largely be automated and when combined with proper market segmentation, allows for personalized messaging delivered directly into the hands, and eyes, of the business's target audience. Automated sales workflows leveraging e-mail can be customized to not only deliver highly impactful content to potential clients but can also be used to contact existing customers about service add-ons and upgrades and re-engage former clients in an attempt to build another meaningful relationship. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH800:07:03Chapter 8 ReferencesEdelman. (2019, June). Edelman Trust Barometer Special Report: In Brands We Trust? Retrieved from https://www.edelman.com/research/trust-barometer-special-report-in-brands-we-trust

Mailchimp. (n.d.). Email Marketing Benchmarks and Statistics by Industry. Retrieved from https://mailchimp.com/resources/email-marketing-benchmarks/

McLaughlin, M. & Sevilla, G. (2020, September 2). The Best Email Marketing Software for 2020. Retrieved from https://www.pcmag.com/picks/the-best-email-marketing-software

Kidwell, B., Hardesty, D. M., & Childers, T. L. (2008). Consumer emotional intelligence: Conceptualization, measurement, and the prediction of consumer decision making. Journal of Consumer Research, 35(1), 154-166. https://doi.org/10.1086/524417

Patel, N. (2020, September 2). 23 Marketing Automation Tools You Need to Use. Retrieved from https://neilpatel.com/blog/marketing-automation-tools/

Prater, M. (2020, June). The Sales Cycle: The Backbone of a Successful Sales Effort. Retrieved from https://blog.hubspot.com/sales/sales-cycle

Zote, J. (2020, August). 11 Free Email Marketing Tools to Save You Time and Money. Retrieved from https://sproutsocial.com/insights/free-email-marketing-tools/

Chapter 9: Marketing Virtual Coaching

Summary

Chapter 8Selling Virtual CoachingLesson 4Billing and Collecting PaymentSummaryLike any small business owner, a fitness professional who owns a virtual coaching business has roles and responsibilities that extend beyond developing programs and coaching clients, such as marketing their services and generating sales. Sales are vital to a company's success. Without sales, there is no revenue and without revenue, there is no company. While focusing on sales is often viewed with a negative connotation, it does not have to be. Ethical sales strategies and techniques are rooted in educating and helping others. It, ultimately, comes down to identifying potential clients' needs, offering solutions to those needs, and then asking them to make a financial commitment for those solutions. The aspects of running a business that can be automated should be, as automation frees up time to focus on areas of the business that cannot be and are vital to establishing authority, credibility, and authenticity in the market, such as content development, programming, and coaching and serving clients.

Marketing and sales processes can largely be automated and when combined with proper market segmentation, allows for personalized messaging delivered directly into the hands, and eyes, of the business's target audience. Automated sales workflows leveraging e-mail can be customized to not only deliver highly impactful content to potential clients but can also be used to contact existing customers about service add-ons and upgrades and re-engage former clients in an attempt to build another meaningful relationship. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH800:07:03Chapter 8 ReferencesEdelman. (2019, June). Edelman Trust Barometer Special Report: In Brands We Trust? Retrieved from https://www.edelman.com/research/trust-barometer-special-report-in-brands-we-trust

Mailchimp. (n.d.). Email Marketing Benchmarks and Statistics by Industry. Retrieved from https://mailchimp.com/resources/email-marketing-benchmarks/

McLaughlin, M. & Sevilla, G. (2020, September 2). The Best Email Marketing Software for 2020. Retrieved from https://www.pcmag.com/picks/the-best-email-marketing-software

Kidwell, B., Hardesty, D. M., & Childers, T. L. (2008). Consumer emotional intelligence: Conceptualization, measurement, and the prediction of consumer decision making. Journal of Consumer Research, 35(1), 154-166. https://doi.org/10.1086/524417

Patel, N. (2020, September 2). 23 Marketing Automation Tools You Need to Use. Retrieved from https://neilpatel.com/blog/marketing-automation-tools/

Prater, M. (2020, June). The Sales Cycle: The Backbone of a Successful Sales Effort. Retrieved from https://blog.hubspot.com/sales/sales-cycle

Zote, J. (2020, August). 11 Free Email Marketing Tools to Save You Time and Money. Retrieved from https://sproutsocial.com/insights/free-email-marketing-tools/

Online Marketing Vehicles

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesOnline Marketing Vehicles After defining the customer avatar, the fitness professional is ready to determine the best online marketing vehicle for their business. Using information from the customer avatar can guide the fitness professional to the best marketing vehicle to reach the maximum number of potential clients. Online marketing vehicles include social media, email, and websites.

13_Phunkod/Shutterstock.com

Social Media

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesSocial Media According to the Pew Research Center (2019), nearly 72% of all Americans use at least some form of social media (Figure: Social Media). With the volume of potential clients using social media, it is an integral part of marketing and should not be underestimated. Social media can be a great way to bring awareness to a fitness professional's services and even serve to drive business.

FigureSocial Media

Variation Among Social Media Platforms

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesVariation Among Social Media PlatformsNote that not all social media platforms serve the same audience. There are many social media options available for consumers and, as a result, it can be difficult to know where to start in order to reach the target audience. This is where knowing the customer avatar is critical. Different social media platforms tend to have different populations as their most frequent users.

According to recent statistics, the number one demographic for Facebook users worldwide are men and women ages 25 to 34 (Clement, 2020). Contrast that to the younger demographic, the top three social media platforms for users ages 13 to 17 are YouTube, Instagram, and Snapchat (Figure: Social Media Users). Knowing this information will inform fitness professionals about where to find their target audience and how to vary the messages accordingly.

FigureSocial Media Users

Email

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesEmail Email marketing is a proven form of digital marketing. Potential clients who provide fitness professionals with their email have demonstrated some form of interest in the product or service. Some common opt-ins may include newsletter subscriptions, instructional e-books, or PDFs. The email content that is offered must be compelling enough for someone to provide their email address. This can prove to be difficult, as individuals are increasingly more protective over their personal information.

WebsiteLike a storefront, a website is often one of the first impressions potential customers receive about an online business. Many consumers make their purchasing decisions based on the clarity and structure of a business's website. There are numerous services available when deciding how to host a website. WordPress, Squarespace, and Wix are some of the more popular options. Here a couple of things to remember when potential customers go to a website:

Is the website easy to navigate?

Is it clear what the company is selling?

Is there an evergreen or deadline offer clearly being displayed?

Are next steps to purchasing clear (i.e., scheduling an assessment or buying a program)?

Online Advertising for Small Businesses

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesOnline Advertising for Small BusinessesOnline advertising can be an effective way to boost traffic to a website and increase the potential for conversion of prospects into paid customers. When it comes to online advertising, there are multiple digital platforms that can be used successfully.

Social Media PlatformsSocial media platforms such as Instagram and Facebook offer paid advertising to small businesses. Using these platforms for advertising allows a fitness professional to target the demographic they are marketing to. For example, a paid advertisement can target Facebook users by geographic location, age, and even other Facebook pages liked.

Search and Review PlatformsAnother way to advertise for a small business is by utilizing search platforms such as Google or user review sites like Yelp. These platforms are commonly used by consumers who are searching for a specific service or product. These platforms typically utilize a pay-per-click model of paid advertising. An advantage to using platforms of this type is that the user searching for the service is already at least somewhat interested.

ProspectA person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

Pay-per-click modelA model of digital marketing in which the advertiser pays a fee every time their ad is clicked.

Online Marketing Best Practices and Professionalism

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesOnline Marketing Best Practices and ProfessionalismTo truly be a successful online marketer, a fitness professional must know more than the various digital marketing platforms. They must also have a strong knowledge of which methods are most effective. The following section will discuss and review those methods and provide specific examples of implementation strategies.

Search Engine OptimizationOn any given day, there are over 2 million searches conducted on Google alone (Patel, 2019). This is why search engine optimization, or SEO, has become an important factor in marketing and searchability. SEO is a method of improving a website's ranking during organic, unpaid searches. Research shows the first five results on Google get 67% of the clicks (Patel, 2019). In such a noisy, online world, ranking high on the list of these searches is paramount. One of the best and most effective ways to increase SEO is by producing quality content. Items such as blog posts and e-books can organically drive people to the site, which will, in turn, increase overall ranking in the eyes of the search engine.

Engagement Methods for Digital MarketingTo produce engaging content, a fitness professional should view their actions strategically, rather than use a one-size-fits-all approach. When thinking about posting a piece of content, a marketer needs a system to determine the effectiveness of their post. The fitness professional must set clear metrics of success for their digital marketing efforts and campaigns. These metrics should align with their business goals. Fitness professionals can use analytics tools such as Google Analytics and Sprout Social to monitor what is and what is not working and know how to adjust accordingly.

Bloomicon/Shutterstock.comSearch engine optimizationA method of improving a website's ranking during organic, unpaid searches.

OrganicTraffic to a website or account that is not paid for.

Content

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesThere are many methods for delivering online messages but most fall into one of the four quadrants of digital marketing. These quadrants include building authority, social proof, connection, and attention (Figure: Four Quadrants of Digital Marketing).

FigureFour Quadrants of Digital Market

Webinars

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesWebinarsWebinars are one of the fastest-growing digital marketing methods. Webinars are live or prerecorded virtual conferences or presentations. Webinars can help establish fitness professionals as an authority in a specific topic or niche. For example, if a nutrition coach is well-versed in weight loss, he or she could host a webinar on the topic of intermittent fasting.

Webinar StructureThere are typically two types of webinars that can be run—paid and free. Although a paid webinar can make money, it can also potentially limit the number of people who are able to attend. On the other hand, hosting a webinar may aid in lead qualification as only the most serious potential clients will be interested in attending. One possible strategy when hosting webinars is to host it for a small fee and then reveal a back-end offer near the end of the webinar. That offer could be a bit more exclusive for clients who are interested in learning more about the topic or possibly purchasing a higher-end service. Using that same example of the nutrition coach, a potential strategy could be to offer a nutrition consultation or a meal plan to anyone who attended the webinar. Web-based services like Zoom and Webinar Ninja allow any fitness professional to easily host a webinar.

fizkes/Shutterstock.comBack-end offerAn additional offer to a customer who has already purchased a product or service from the business, also referred to as an upsell.

Social Media Posts

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesSocial Media Posts Because each social media platform caters to a different audience, it is wise to post on multiple platforms rather than posting on just one. Posting on multiple platforms has been shown to have a positive impact on brand loyalty (Çiçek & Erdoğmuş, 2012). Considering this, the question then becomes, “What to post?” Fitness professionals should consider the four digital marketing quadrants when determining what type of content to post (Figure: Examples of Four Quadrants).

FigureExamples of Four QuadrantsIt is best practice to use messaging in each quadrant from time to time so that social media marketing efforts are well-rounded and, therefore, more effective.

Social Media Schedule

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesSocial Media Schedule Developing a social media schedule is critical to maintaining consistency with posting. Posting consistently is difficult but it becomes more so when there is no plan in place. Software like Later or Sprout Social can also aid in developing a social media schedule. These resources can provide analytics, such as peak engagement times for various social media platforms, that will help the fitness professional develop a deeper understanding of their audience.

When developing a social media plan, there are several factors to consider:

Which days receive the highest engagement?

What type of content resonates most with the audience?

What events or deadlines are being marketed toward?

Sammby/Shutterstock.comGetting TechnicalThere are many ways for fitness professionals to drive organic traffic to their social media pages.

On Instagram, post stories of clients' successes (text message, videos, pics, etc.) and encourage them to share the post. In this scenario, the fitness professional not only reaches their audience but their client’s network/audience as well.

On Facebook, Twitter, or Instagram, the fitness professional can tag larger fitness accounts in the posts. If the larger accounts repost it, the fitness professional’s organic reach will increase.

Facebook Live and Instagram Live are popular tools used by fitness professionals. For example, collaborating with other fitness professionals in live Q&A sessions is a great way to drive traffic to social media pages or websites.

Email Campaigns

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesEmail Campaigns An email list is crucial for marketing to an already interested audience. Remember, a person who has willingly given their e-mail is already interested in a service, at least on some level, which makes them more likely to convert into clients. When considering which email service to use, the fitness professional should find one that is reliable and supports them in executing their marketing plan. Some of the most popular email marketing options include Mailchimp, Constant Contact, and ConvertKit.

stscheb/Shutterstock.comCreating an Email Opt-InFigureEmail Opt-InIt is one thing to have an e-mail list, but it is another to actually grow it. This is where an opt-in email becomes useful. An opt-in is when a consumer provides their e-mail address, usually in exchange for some sort of free content. These opt-ins are often in the form of pop-ups that appear when a person navigates through a website. Some common opt-in offers include newsletter subscriptions, instructional e-books, PDFs, or free training programs.

The quality of the opt-in should be high. The key is to provide enough value for the potential customer, while also giving them some insight into what purchasing a service might be like. Here is an example of a potential e-mail opt-in (Figure: Email Opt-In). Once that person's email is collected, they become a subscriber and a welcome email is typically sent confirming their subscription and delivering the promised content. From that point on, the fitness professional should continue to deliver valuable information to their subscribers so that they feel connected and part of the online community.

Newsletters Newsletters are a great way to keep an audience engaged. Think of a newsletter as an online newspaper for a business. It keeps customers, subscribers, and potential customers up to date with current business events. Newsletters are where many fitness professionals highlight clients and tell their subscribers about any upcoming specials or events. Typically, newsletters fall into the Connection category of the four quadrants of virtual marketing.

This Is Me/Shutterstock.comOpt-in emailAn option to join an e-mail list.

YouTube

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesYouTubeWith over 2 billion users worldwide, YouTube is one of the most popular forms of media for consumer video consumption. Many online fitness professionals have gained popularity by dedicating their time to developing a YouTube platform. Creating a YouTube channel is a great way for a fitness professional to build authority in their respective field. A study examining student engagement while watching videos showed that shorter videos are more engaging than longer videos (Guo et al., 2014, p. 49). The study recommended video segments shorter than 6 minutes. As people have access to more content, holding viewer attention becomes an ever-present challenge. One method is to select or create an engaging thumbnail for all YouTube videos. An engaging thumbnail helps a video stand out as people scroll through the numerous YouTube fitness videos available.

ART PAL/Shutterstock.comBlogsBlogs are one of the best ways to create authoritative content and drive traffic to a website. Additionally, traffic created from blogs helps improve website visibility, search engine ranking, and ultimately SEO.

Methods for Increasing Blog Visibility In the early inception of blogging, visibility was a relatively easy thing to obtain. However, as more people have started blogging, visibility has become much harder to achieve. By some estimates, there are over 600 million blogs on the Internet today (Petrov, 2020). With the large number of blogs available, the question then becomes, “How does the fitness professional’s blog stand out?”

Vasyl Nagernyak/Shutterstock.comHere are a few methods to gain greater visibility through blogging:

Consistency – To gain a loyal audience, a blogger must post consistently. Try setting a blog-release schedule.

Timing – Publish blog posts on high-traffic social media days. For example, releasing a blog on a Tuesday, normally a high-traffic day, will likely yield greater engagement than a blog posted on a Saturday.

Naming a Post – All digital marketing vies for consumer attention. The title of a blog post is the first thing someone sees and will often determine whether they choose to read on. Titles that begin with the phrases “How to…” and “Here are 5 ways to” tend to get more traffic over other more general titles.

Collaborations – Collaborating with other fitness professionals is a great way to increase the reach of a blog post. Interviews and guest posts are all methods that increase the shareability of a blog post. The post then gains exposure for not only the fitness professional’s followers but also to the followers of the other collaborator.

Proper Messaging

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesProper MessagingMessaging varies depending on the social media platform and on the message being delivered. Generally, it is important to keep messaging concise and direct. Whenever posting digital content, proper messaging and professionalism is crucial. This is true for both professional and personal social media accounts as a fitness professional is ultimately a direct representation of their business. Proper grammar, spelling, and punctuation should be used in all posts. Additionally, most posts should be done in an authoritative tone to convey the expertise of the fitness professional.

Proper Use of Visuals As the use of social media and digital marketing has grown, it is more important now than ever for the fitness professional to incorporate quality visuals into their social media marketing. The standard has been raised as more people become adept at visuals and social media. Camera phones have made this easier. With most phones now equipped with high-quality cameras, it is often unnecessary to hire a photographer to take professional photos. In the past, the creation of graphics required expensive software with a steep learning curve. However, now there are many graphic software products available, such as Canva or PicMonkey that make it easier and more cost-effective (and in many cases free) to design and edit high-quality marketing material.

Tero Vesalainen/Shutterstock.comIn addition to the quality of the visuals, the formatting of video and pictures is also important. For example, consider recording an exercise video with the intent of posting it on multiple video media platforms. Shooting the video in portrait mode (vertical orientation) is great for posting on an Instagram feed but it is not the ideal camera orientation for posting videos on YouTube. Landscape mode (horizontal orientation) is the preferred method for posting videos on YouTube and Facebook (Figure: Video Format). Videos shot in portrait mode leave extra space in the margins of the video when viewed on a widescreen, which can be distracting to the viewer.

FigureVideo Format

Word-of-Mouth Marketing

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesWord-of-Mouth Marketing Despite the advancements in technology and digital platforms, word-of-mouth marketing continues to be an incredibly effective form of marketing. According to research, 67% of consumers are based on word of mouth (Karlíček et al., 2010). As a fitness professional, developing trust and a strong referral network from current clients is a good way to grow a sustainable online business.

Referrals Offering existing members some type of incentive may encourage referrals. Ideally, clients will refer potential customers regardless of an incentive, but offering one can certainly help. One way to incentivize referrals is to offer a gift card or credit to clients who refer new clients to a business. A potential benefit of offering gift cards, as opposed to discounting an existing client's service, is that money spent on gift cards could potentially be written off for tax purposes, depending on the business situation. Additionally, gift cards do not devalue the price of training options.

CoCoArt_Ua/Shutterstock.com

Testimonials

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 2Online Marketing Vehicles and StrategiesTestimonialsTestimonials tap into a powerful, scientific marketing principle—the principle of social proof. The principle of social proof suggests that individuals observe and assume the behaviors and actions of others to determine what is correct or to find out what other people think is correct (Cialdini, 2006). If a potential customer sees that someone like them has had good results and a positive experience, they are more likely to choose that same service over another one.

Obtaining TestimonialsBoth written and video testimonials are excellent pieces of marketing material. There is some debate over which method is more effective. Luckily, with transcription services readily available, obtaining both is easy and relatively inexpensive. One way to obtain both types is to record a video testimonial of a client's experience and then send the audio file to a transcription service to have it converted into written format.

When gathering testimonials from clients, fitness professionals should provide a guide to follow so results come out clean and succinct. This guide may include recommendations for talking points and sample questions. The following are examples of questions that may yield a strong testimonial:

What was your experience when you first started working with (insert name of fitness professional and business)?

What was the biggest challenge you faced?

What is your experience like now?

What is your favorite thing about training with (insert name of business)?

Questions like these create a story or a hero's arch for the client testimonial. These questions relate their struggles and connect their story to others and potential clients who will likely share some of the same challenges.

Helpful HintNot sure whether to have a client do a written or a video testimonial? Why not do both?

With online transcription services, fitness professionals can record the video and then send it to a transcription company to have it converted into text. Typically, these companies charge a per-minute fee, and, for a short video, it is a valuable time saver. Once the fitness professional has the transcription and video, they can easily post and share them on various platforms.

MerchandiseMerchandise is often an underrated marketing tool. Merchandise is anything that clients can use or wear that represents a brand. Merchandise transforms the client into a walking billboard. Examples of effective merchandise for fitness businesses include t-shirts, stickers, and protein shaker bottles. The key to any sort of merchandise is to make sure the brand is clear and visible. Merchandise can also be an effective way to increase client retention. For example, if a client reaches a certain weight-loss goal, a great strategy would be to send them a t-shirt for their success and have them post a picture of themselves wearing it. This not only increases client retention but also helps build social proof for the brand.

Calculating Marketing ROI

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 3Evaluating Marketing EffortsCalculating Marketing ROI Calculating marketing Return On Investment (ROI) is a method for determining the effectiveness of a marketing campaign. The simplest equation to calculating ROI is as follows (Figure: Return on Investment):

FigureReturn on InvestmentReturn on investment (ROI)A performance measure used to evaluate the efficiency of an investment or compare the efficiency of a number of different investments.

Content

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 3Evaluating Marketing EffortsFor example, imagine a nutrition coach is running a marketing campaign to promote their one-on-one meal planning service. The marketing campaign costs $200 and they have seen a $1,000 increase in revenue for that service. To calculate the return on the campaign investment, the fitness professional would subtract the cost from the sales growth and then divide that number by the costs associated with their marketing campaign (Figure: Example Return on Investment).

FigureExample Return on InvestmentA positive return on investment signifies the returns were greater than the cost. A negative return on investment signifies the total costs associated with the marketing effort were greater than the returns.

Limitations of ROI

Chapter 9Marketing Virtual Coaching Lesson 3Evaluating Marketing EffortsLimitations of ROI Not all marketing efforts are afforded an immediate return on investment. A fitness professional may host a webinar in June and then be contacted by a potential client in November for online training. It can often be difficult to pinpoint if that person came in because of a particular marketing effort. Always expecting immediate ROI from a marketing effort can also be problematic. Some marketing efforts need time to take effect. In general, while it is important to understand a campaign's ROI, it may be more ideal to have a long-term mindset when it comes to determining the true value and success of marketing efforts.

SummaryMarketing a virtual coaching business can seem like a complex and even daunting task. However, as a fitness professional, it is necessary to ensure the growth and success of an online business. This is especially true in the current landscape with demand for fitness services increasing and consumer desires and purchasing habits evolving. With proper marketing planning, knowledge of the various marketing vehicles, and an understanding of the best methods to increase visibility and engagement, a thriving and sustainable online fitness business is within reach. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.

NASM VCS Lecture CH900:07:15Chapter 9 ReferencesCialdini, R. B. (2006). Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion (Revised ed.). New York, NY: Harper Collins Business.

Clement, J. (2020, July). Facebook: Distribution of Global Audiences 2020, by Age and Gender. Retrieved from https://www.statista.com/statistics/376128/facebook-global-user-age-distribution/#:%7E:text=Facebook%3A%20distribution%20of%20global%20audiences%202020%2C%20by%20age%20and%20gender&text=As%20of%20July%

Çiçek, M. & Erdoğmuş, İ. E. (2012, Oct.). The Impact of Social Media Marketing on Brand Loyalty. Procedia – Social and Behavioral Sciences, 58: 1353–1360. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sbspro.2012.09.1119

Guo, P. J., Kim, J., & Rubin, R. (2014, March). How video production affects student engagement: an empirical study of MOOC videos. Proceedings of the First ACM Conference on Learning @ Scale Conference. 41–50. https://doi.org/10.1145/2556325.2566239

Karlíček, M., Tomek, I., & Křížek, M. (2010). Word-of-Mouth Marketing: An Integrated Model. Ekonomika a Management, 2010(3).

Kelly, K. (2008, March). 1,000 True Fans. Retrieved from https://kk.org/thetechnium/1000-true-fans/

Patel, N. (2019, Dec.). SEO Made Simple: A Step-by-Step Guide for 2020. Retrieved from https://neilpatel.com/what-is-seo/

Petrov, C (2020, July). How Many Blogs Are There and Do They Make Money in 2020? TechJury. Retrieved from https://techjury.net/blog/how-many-blogs-are-there

Pew Research Center. (2019, June). Social Media Fact Sheet. Retrieved from https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/fact-sheet/social-media/

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. (2020, September 1). Occupational Outlook Handbook: Fitness Trainers and Instructors. Retrieved from https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/fitness-trainers-and-instructors.htm#tab-6